

German, Step by Step, Root by Root

An etymology-driven curriculum, built one word at a time

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This edition compiled incrementally — new chapters added as they
are written.

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Preface

This book teaches German one word at a time, and it teaches each word by taking it apart. It is written for someone starting from zero, whose only shared language is English. The method is the same as its companion volumes — one word per lesson, gone deep — but the etymology flows through a different channel. Spanish and French are Latin’s children; *German is English’s sibling*. Both are Germanic languages, so German words are most often *direct cousins* of English words, with no Latin middleman: *gut* is English *good*, *Tag* is *day*, *Nacht* is *night*. The gaps between them are not random — they follow the **High German Consonant Shift** ($d \rightarrow t$, $t \rightarrow s$, $k \rightarrow ch$), a single sound-law you can learn once and then use to guess the English cousin on sight (the Romance languages have their own such laws — Latin *-ct-* became Spanish *-ch-*).

Where it lights something up, the book sets German beside its cousins — English always, and Spanish and French as Latin’s side of the family, each form supplied in full so no prior knowledge of them is needed. The richest moment is *Nacht*, where German *Nacht*, English *night*, Spanish *noche*, and French *nuit* turn out to be the same Indo-European word, split four ways.

How to use this book

Every numbered section is one word, or one small phrase, and takes a few minutes — the length of a queue, an errand, or the walk to the bus. Read them in order the first time through: each section stands on the ones before it, and nothing is used before it has been taught. After that the book becomes reference, and you can open it anywhere.

Say the German out loud wherever you can. The prompts under *Your turn* are written to be spoken, and saying a word is most of what makes it stay. The questions under *Before you move on* carry their own answers in brackets: cover them, answer from memory, then look.

Nothing here is gated behind pronunciation. Each lesson names the one

or two sounds its own word needs, exactly where they are needed. The whole system is gathered in a reference at the back of the book — somewhere to look things up when you are curious, never a chapter to sit through first.

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Chapter 1

Greetings

Modes: 🗣️ voice (12) ✍️ pen (2) 🗣️ Hands-free start: first 1 of 14 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can greet someone in German, recognize the reply, and choose an appropriate response.

The German greetings, built from their pieces — a word for “good,” the day-parts, and the three-gender article system. Because German and English are siblings, most words here are direct cousins, reshaped by the High German Consonant Shift; where it helps, Spanish and French stand alongside for contrast. Writing begins with the same familiar cousin: follow one visible Hallo, then copy it once while the model stays in sight — no hidden spelling and no second word are due. GE-C01-practice closes the chapter by running the whole arc, casual to bedtime.

1.1 hallo — “hello,” and this time it *is* a cousin

Your first German word — and a reassuring one, because German and English are close cousins: *both are Germanic languages*. That kinship will help you all through this book, and *hallo* is the first proof.

Sounds you’ll need

- German **h** is pronounced (not silent like Spanish/French): *HA-lo*.
- German **a** is a clean, open *ah*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

hallo — informal “hello / hi.” Unlike Spanish *hola* (which only *looks* like “hello” by coincidence — a false friend), German **hallo** and English **hello** are the real thing: both grew from the same old Germanic hailing call (*hala*, a shout to get attention or hail a ferryman), the same family as English *holla*, *hollo*, and *hail*. Nineteenth-century English “hello” was even shaped partly by German *hallo*.

The pattern to carry through this whole book: because English is a Germanic language, German words are often **direct cousins** of English words — same family, no Latin middleman. (The Romance languages like Spanish and French reach English mostly *through* Latin; German reaches it directly.)

Why it’s said this way

hallo is informal-to-neutral — fine among friends, and increasingly common generally. Polite or first meetings often use a daytime greeting instead. You will build that greeting one familiar piece at a time over the next few lessons.

Writing — follow one word you can see

Keep **Hallo** visible. Trace directly over it, then copy it once in large, slow letters. Say *HA-lo* while your hand moves. Stop there.

This is not spelling from memory and not free writing. Your eye and hand are only following a word whose meaning and sound are already on the page.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “hallo” — *HA-lo*, with a real *h*
- “hallo” then English “hail”, “holler” — the true hailing family

Before you move on

Is German *hallo* a real cousin of English *hello*, or a coincidence like Spanish *hola*? (A real cousin — same Germanic hailing root.)

1.2 Hallo — copy one greeting with help

Point to **Hallo** and say it once: *HA-lo*. The model stays on the page.

Writing — one guided copy

Copy **Hallo** once on the line below it. Begin with the tall capital **H**, then follow with **allo**. Look back at the model whenever you want.

Say the word as you finish. Then draw one small line under the **H** that German and English inherited in the same old hailing family.

Before you move on

Compare your copy with the model. If one letter differs, repair only that letter. No hiding, no spelling test, and no second word today.

1.3 gut — “good,” and the sound-law that reshapes German

This word starts most German greetings. It’s a direct twin of English “good” — and the *tiny* difference between them (*good* vs *gut*) opens the single most useful decoding rule in the language.

Sounds you’ll need

- German **u** = *oo* as in *food* or English *boot*: *goot*. The final **t** stays crisp — never softened. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

gut — “good.” Root: Proto-Germanic ***gōdaz** — and English **good** comes from the *exact same* word. No Latin in sight; German and English just inherited it from their shared Germanic parent. So why *gut* and not *good*? One sound-law:

The High German Consonant Shift. Long ago, German (but not English) pushed a whole set of consonants forward. One of its rules: **d** → **t**. So every English *d* tends to show up as *t* in German:

English	German
good	gut
day	Tag
bed	Bett
do	tun

It's a single regular sound-law — the same kind of trick that reshaped the Romance languages (Latin *-ct-* became Spanish *-ch-*, *noche*). Learn the shift once, and you can guess the English cousin behind a German word (and vice-versa) on sight. More rules of the shift as we go.

Grammar Lens: German merges “good” and “well”

English splits *good* (adjective) from *well* (adverb); Spanish splits *bueno* from *bien*; French splits *bon* from *bien*. **German does not** — *gut* is *both*. “A good day” is *ein guter Tag* — and the very same *gut* is how you say you are doing well, which is what the wellbeing exchange is built on. One word covers the whole job, so the Romance *bien/bueno* pair collapses back into a single German word.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “gut” — *goot*
- “gut” then “good” — the d→t shift
- “Tag” then “day”; “gut” then “good” — same shift, twice

Before you move on

English *d* becomes which letter in German? (*t* — *good*→*gut*, *day*→*Tag*.) Does German split “good” and “well” like English? (No — *gut* is both.)

1.4 der, die, das — “the,” and the gender English *and* the Romance languages lost

Before your first noun: German’s words for “the.” Many European languages tag every noun with a grammatical *gender* — Spanish and French each run two — and German has it too, but with a twist neither of them kept.

Sounds you’ll need

- **der** = *dair*, **die** = *dee*, **das** = *dahss*. The **r** of *der* is barely a vowel-like murmur at the back of the mouth, not an English *r*; *die* rhymes with English *see*; the final **s** of *das* is a sharp *ss*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

der — “the” (masculine). **die** — “the” (feminine). **das** — “the” (neuter). Roots: the old Germanic demonstratives ***sa** / ***sō** / ***pat** (“that one”) — the *same* family as English **the** and **that**:

- **das** ↔ English **that** (the High German shift again: English *t* → German *s*, so *that* → *das*).
- **die** ↔ the *-y* of English **the**/**they**.

Unlike Spanish *el/la* and French *le/la* (both from Latin *ille/illa*), German’s articles are cousins of English’s own “the” — Germanic all the way.

Grammar Lens: German kept THREE genders

Here’s the twist. Latin had three genders (masculine, feminine, neuter); Spanish and French **collapsed to two**, folding neuter into masculine. German **kept all three**: *der* (masc.), *die* (fem.), *das* (neut.). So a German noun is one of *three* classes, not two — and, as everywhere, the gender is unpredictable and must be learned *with* the noun and its article. English, meanwhile, threw gender out entirely and kept a single “the” — the opposite extreme. Your next nouns will let you practise that pairing.

One more thing coming later: German articles also change by **case** (their job in the sentence), so *der* has other forms (*den*, *dem*, *des*).

Ignore that for now; learn *der* / *die* / *das* as the three “the”s and leave it there.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “der”, “die”, “das”
- “das” then English “that” — the t→s shift
- “der” for masculine, “die” for feminine, “das” for neuter

Before you move on

How many genders does German keep, vs Spanish/French? (Three vs two — German kept the neuter, *das*.) What English word is *das* a cousin of? (*That*.)

1.5 Tag — “day,” a straight cousin of English *day*

Your first German noun. In Spanish “day” was *día* (via Latin); in French, *jour* (via a longer Latin detour). In German it’s *Tag* — and it’s English “day” with one consonant shifted, and nothing else.

What to know first

- der / die / das — gender; *Tag* is masculine, *der Tag*.

Sounds you’ll need

- **Tag** = *tahk* — a long open *a*, the vowel of English *father*; Germans harden a final *-g* to a *k* (**final devoicing**), so *Tag* rhymes with English *tock*, not with English *tag*. German nouns are always **Capitalized** (every noun, not only names).

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

der Tag — “the day” (masculine). Root: Proto-Germanic ***dagaz** — and English **day** is the same word. The only difference is the High

German Consonant Shift from the *gut* lesson (**d** → **t**): *dagaz* → English *day*, German *Tag*.

So the three Romance-and-Germanic “day” words line up by ancestry:

- Spanish *día*, French *jour* ← Latin *dies* / *diurnum*
- German **Tag** ↔ English **day** ← Germanic **dagaz*

Two entirely different roots for “day” (Latin *dies* vs Germanic *dagaz*) — which is why *día* and *Tag* look nothing alike, even though both languages are cousins far enough back.

Grammar Lens

Tag is **masculine** (*der Tag*) — learn it with its article, as always. Also note the capital *T*: German writes **every** noun with a capital letter, a spelling rule no other language here shares.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “der Tag” — *dair tahk*
- “Tag” then “day” — hear the d→t shift

Before you move on

Tag and English *day* share a Germanic root; the shift is which consonant change? (*d*→*t*.) What’s odd about how German writes *Tag*? (Capitalized — all German nouns are.)

1.6 Guten Tag — assembled, and a first taste of German endings

Snap *gut* and *Tag* together for the standard polite greeting. But notice — *gut* shows up as *guten*, and that extra *-en* is your first glimpse of how German adjectives work.

What to know first

- gut · Tag

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Guten Tag = **gut** (“good”) + **Tag** (“day”) = “good day,” the neutral polite “hello” for daytime. Said *GOO-ten tahk*.

Grammar Lens: why *guten*, not *gut*?

Like every Germanic and Romance adjective, German *gut* **agrees** with its noun — but German adjectives agree in *more* dimensions than Spanish or French: not only gender and number, but **case** (the noun’s job in the sentence). *Guten Tag* is a frozen piece of a longer wish — “I wish you a good day” — and in that fuller thought, “a good day” is the *object* of the wishing (the accusative case). For a masculine noun in that role, *gut* takes the ending **-en**: *guten*. The rest of the wish fell away and left the ending behind.

Don’t try to master German’s ending system now — it’s a later chapter. Just bank two things: (1) German adjectives take endings that shift with gender, number, *and* case; (2) the greeting is really “(I wish you a) good day,” which is why it’s *guten*. A later bedtime greeting will give you a gentle contrast with a feminine noun and a different ending.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “Guten Tag” — *GOO-ten tahk*
- “Hallo” (casual) then “Guten Tag” (polite) — the register gap

Before you move on

Guten Tag literally shortens from what fuller phrase? (“[I wish you a] good day.”) Why the *-en* on *gut*? (Adjective agreement — masculine, accusative.)

1.7 Morgen — “morning,” hiding in your English *tomorrow*

The morning word — and a straight English cousin again, once you spot it.

What to know first

- Tag — same build ahead: *guten* + this noun.

Sounds you’ll need

- **Morgen** = *MOR-gun* — stress the first syllable; the *g* is a hard *g*; the German *r* is soft and guttural; the unstressed *-en* sinks to a soft *-un*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

der Morgen — “the morning” (masculine). Root: Proto-Germanic ***murganaz** — the same root as English **morning**, **morn**, and the *-morrow* in **tomorrow** (“to-morrow” = “at [the] morning [to come]”). No Latin detour; German *Morgen* and English *morning* are the same Germanic word, barely changed.

A small false-friend warning for later: German *Morgen* can also mean “**tomorrow**.” A later farewell will reuse it with that meaning. Context tells the two senses apart; English keeps them in separate words (*morning* vs *tomorrow*), while German lets *Morgen* do both jobs.

Grammar Lens

Morgen is **masculine** (*der Morgen*) — so, like *Tag*, it will take *guten* in the greeting.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “der Morgen” — *dair MOR-gen*
- “Morgen” then English “morning”, “tomorrow” — the same root

Before you move on

What English words share *Morgen*'s root? (*morning*, *morn*, *to-morrow*.) *Morgen* is masculine — so “good morning” will use *gut* with which ending? (*guten* — like *guten Tag*.)

1.8 Guten Morgen — good morning

Same assembly as *Guten Tag*, one noun swapped. Nearly free.

What to know first

- Guten Tag · Morgen

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Guten Morgen = **gut** (“good”) + **Morgen** (“morning”) = “good morning.” *Morgen* is masculine, exactly like *Tag*, so *gut* takes the same **-en**: *guten* — no new agreement to learn. Said *GOO-ten MOR-gen*. Used in the morning (roughly until midday); after that, German switches to *Guten Tag*. You will build the evening greeting next, from the same familiar pattern.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “Guten Morgen” — *GOO-ten MOR-gen*
- “Guten Morgen” then “Guten Tag” — morning, then midday

Before you move on

Why is it *guten* Morgen (same ending as *Guten Tag*)? (*Morgen* is masculine too.)

1.9 Abend — “evening,” cousin of English *eve*

The evening word — a quieter English cousin than the others, but a real one.

What to know first

- Tag — the same *guten* + noun build.

Sounds you'll need

- **Abend** = *AH-bent* — stress the first syllable; a long open *a*; the final *d* hardens to a *t* sound (German de-voices final consonants, exactly as it did to the *-g* of *Tag*).

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

der Abend — “the evening” (masculine). Root: Proto-Germanic ***ābanþs** — the same root as English **eve** and **even(ing)** (as in *Christmas Eve*, “the eve of...”). English wore it down to *eve*; German kept more of it as *Abend*. Same Germanic word for “the close of the day.”

Contrast worth banking across all four languages:
 “evening” has a *different* root in each branch — Germanic *ābanþs* (German *Abend*, English *eve*), vs Latin *sērus* “late” (French *soir*) and Latin *tardus* “late” (Spanish *tarde*). The Romance pair named it after *lateness*; the Germanic pair named it after the *evening-down* of the day.

Grammar Lens

Abend is **masculine** (*der Abend*) — so, again, *guten* in the greeting. Three masculine day-parts in a row (*Tag*, *Morgen*, *Abend*) all take *guten*. The next day-part is feminine, so it will gently show you a different ending without adding a new rule to memorize now.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “der Abend” — *dair AH-bent*
- “Abend” then English “eve”, “evening”

Before you move on

Abend is a cousin of which English words? (*eve, evening.*) Is it masculine or feminine? (Masculine — *der Abend*, takes *guten.*)

1.10 Guten Abend — good evening

The evening member of the set. Same *guten*, one more masculine noun.

What to know first

- Guten Tag · Abend

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Guten Abend = **gut** + **Abend** (masculine) = “good evening,” *GOO-ten AH-bent. guten* again — the third masculine day-part in a row.

You now have the daytime arc: **Guten Morgen** (morning) → **Guten Tag** (midday/afternoon) → **Guten Abend** (evening). All *guten*, all masculine. Only bedtime is left — and it breaks the pattern.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “Guten Abend” — *GOO-ten AH-bent*
- the arc — “Guten Morgen, Guten Tag, Guten Abend”

Before you move on

All three day-greetings use *guten* — because their nouns are all which gender? (Masculine.)

1.11 Nacht — “night,” where all four of your languages meet

This is the best cross-language word in the whole chapter. German *Nacht*, English *night*, Spanish *noche*, French *nuit* — all

four are the same word, traced back far enough. Here’s the family reunion.

What to know first

- der / die / das — *Nacht* is feminine, *die Nacht*.

Sounds you’ll need

- **Nacht** = *nahkht* — the **ch** is the guttural *loch* sound: a scrape at the back of the mouth, after the open *a*, and **not** an English *ch*. It is the same throat-scrape as Spanish *j* (*jamón*) and Arabic *kh*. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

die Nacht — “the night” (feminine). Root: it goes all the way back to **Proto-Indo-European *nókʷts** (“night”) — the deep ancestor of *every* one of your night-words:

Branch	Word
German (Germanic)	Nacht
English (Germanic)	night
Spanish (Latin)	noche
French (Latin)	nuit
(the Latin itself)	<i>noctem</i>

They split apart by each branch’s own sound-laws — Germanic turned the *kt* into *ht* (**Nacht**, **night**; that’s Grimm’s Law), while Latin kept *ct* (*noctem*), which Spanish then softened to *-ch-* (**noche**) and French to *-it-* (**nuit**). Four languages, four rules, one PIE word. When you say *Nacht*, you’re saying the same ancient syllable as *noche* and *nuit*.

Grammar Lens

Nacht is **feminine** — *die Nacht* — inherited from its Germanic gender (and it matches feminine *noche/nuit/noctem*, all feminine too). Its gender matters immediately: it’s why “good night” is *gute Nacht*, not *guten*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “die Nacht” — *dee nahkht*, guttural *ch*
- the family — “Nacht, night, noche, nuit”

Before you move on

Nacht, *night*, *noche*, *nuit* all descend from one PIE word — roughly what? (**nók^wts*, “night.”) Is *Nacht* masculine or feminine? (Feminine — *die Nacht*.)

1.12 Gute Nacht — good night, and the ending that finally changes

The greeting that breaks the *guten* streak — and shows you exactly what German’s endings are tracking.

What to know first

- gut · Nacht

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Gute Nacht = **gut** (“good”) + **Nacht** (“night”) = “good night,”
GOO-te nahkht.

Grammar Lens: *gute*, not *guten*

Three greetings in a row were *guten* (Tag, Morgen, Abend — all masculine). This one is *gute*. The reason is the one you set up: *Nacht* is **feminine**, and a feminine noun in the “(I wish you a) good _____” accusative takes the ending **-e**, not **-en**. So the endings line up:

- *guten* Tag / Morgen / Abend — masculine → **-en**
- *gute* Nacht — feminine → **-e**

That single vowel is German’s adjective quietly reporting the noun’s gender — exactly the job *bueno/buena* and *bon/bonne* did in Spanish and French, just with German’s own endings.

Why it's said this way

Like Spanish *buenas noches* and French *bonne nuit*, *Gute Nacht* is the **bedtime** farewell — “sleep well,” said on parting for the night, not an evening hello (that’s *Guten Abend*). Same split French makes; German keeps the greeting (*Abend*) and the send-off (*Nacht*) apart.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “Gute Nacht” — *GOO-te nahkht*
- “Guten Tag” then “Gute Nacht” — hear *-en* vs *-e*, and say why

Before you move on

Why *gute* Nacht but *guten* Tag? (*Nacht* is feminine, *Tag* masculine — the ending agrees.) Is *Gute Nacht* a greeting or a bedtime farewell? (Bedtime farewell.)

1.13 die — one article for every plural

You have learned three words for “the,” one per gender. Here is the relief: in the plural there is only ever **one**.

You'll want to know: *die* for every plural

Singular: **der** Tag · **der** Morgen · **der** Abend · **die** Nacht

Plural: **die** Tage · **die** Morgen · **die** Abende · **die** Nächte

Whatever the noun’s gender, the plural article is **die**. *der* → *die*, *das* → *die*, *die* → *die*. Three genders in the singular collapse to one form in the plural — German, like French with *les*, spends a single article on every plural noun there is.

Sounds you'll need

Many German plurals bend the vowel as well as adding an ending. *Nacht* → *Nächte*: the open *a* of *nahkht* is fronted to **ä**, the vowel of English *bed*, so *Nächte* is *NEKH-tuh*. That two-dot mark is called an

umlaut, and the vowel change it writes down is one of German’s regular plural signals.

Grammar Lens: the four day-parts in the plural

singular	plural	what changed
der Tag	die Tage	article, plus <i>-e</i>
der Morgen	die Morgen	article only — the noun is unchanged
der Abend	die Abende	article, plus <i>-e</i>
die Nacht	die Nächte	article, plus <i>-e</i> , plus the umlaut <i>a</i> → <i>ä</i>

German plurals are not built from one rule the way English adds *-s*. Each noun carries its own plural, which is why a German noun is worth learning as a set of three: *der Tag*, *die Tage*. The one thing that never varies is the article.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “der Tag, die Tage” — singular, then plural
- “der Abend, die Abende”
- “die Nacht, die Nächte” — hear the *a* bend to *ä*
- “der Morgen, die Morgen” — only the article moved

Before you move on

Which article do German plurals take? (**die** — always, whatever the gender.) Which of the four day-parts looks the same in the plural? (*Morgen* — *der Morgen*, *die Morgen*.) What changed in *Nächte* besides the ending? (The vowel — *a* took an umlaut and became *ä*.)

1.14 Practice — the German greetings

No new words — only the day’s arc, until the endings are automatic.

What you've built

- **hallo** — casual “hi” (a *real* cousin of English “hello”).
- **gut** — “good” and “well” (← Germanic **gōdaz* = English *good*; the d→t shift).
- **der / die / das** — “the,” and German’s *three* genders (kept the neuter).
- **Guten Morgen** → **Guten Tag** → **Guten Abend** — the daytime arc, all *guten* (masculine nouns).
- **Gute Nacht** — bedtime farewell, *gute* because *Nacht* is feminine.

Two threads: **register** (*hallo* vs *Guten Tag*) and **agreement** (*guten* for masculine day-parts, *gute* for feminine *Nacht*). And one big idea: German words are **direct Germanic cousins of English**, reshaped by the High German Consonant Shift (*good*→*gut*, *day*→*Tag*, *that*→*das*).

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- greet a friend casually, then politely — *hallo* / *Guten Tag*
- the right greeting for right now — morning/day/evening
- “Guten Tag” then “Gute Nacht” — and say why the ending changes
- three shift-cousins — *gut*/good, *Tag*/day, *das*/that

Twice through: Run *Guten Morgen* → *Guten Tag* → *Guten Abend* → *Gute Nacht* without hesitating on *guten/gute*.

Before you move on

Which German greeting uses *gute*, not *guten*, and why? (*Gute Nacht* — *Nacht* is feminine.) Next chapter, you will learn to introduce yourself and then build the friendly and respectful ways to address someone.

Chapter 2

Introducing Yourself

Modes: 🗣️ voice (10) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 10 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can introduce myself in German, give my name, and understand the other person's name.

Now a first real exchange — giving your name, asking for someone else's, and saying you are glad to meet them: Ich heie Mira. — Wie heien Sie? — Ich heie Arun. — Freut mich. It is built the way the greetings were: each piece taken apart first, then assembled — and, because German is English's sibling, most of those pieces are direct English cousins. GE-C02-practice puts the four lines back together at the end.

2.1 ich — “I,” the same ancient word as Latin *ego*

To introduce yourself, first “I.” German's is a three-letter word hiding a very deep root.

Sounds you'll need

- **ich** = *ikh* — the *ch* here is **soft**: a light hiss at the front of the mouth (the “ich-sound”), *not* the throat-scrape of *Nacht*. German has both; after *i* and *e* it's the soft one.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

ich — “I.” Root: Proto-Germanic ***ik**, from Proto-Indo-European ***eǵ** — the *same* deep root that became:

- Latin **ego** (and English **ego**), Greek *egō*,
- and, worn down hardest of all, English **I**.

So German *ich*, Latin *ego*, and English *I* are three survivals of **one** ancient word for “I” — English filed it down to a single letter, German kept a bit more.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ich” (*ikh*, soft *ch*)
- the three cousins — *ich* / *ego* / *I*

Before you move on

What PIE root gave **ich**, and what Latin and English words are its cousins? (**eǵ* — Latin *ego*, English *I*.) Which *ch* sound does *ich* use — soft or the *Nacht* scrape? (The soft “ich-sound.”)

2.2 du / Sie — “you,” familiar and formal

To ask someone’s name you need “you” — and German’s formal one is the strangest of all the languages here.

Sounds you’ll need

- **du** = *doo* (long *u*, as in *boot*). **Sie** = *zee* (the *s* is a *z*-sound at the start).

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

du (familiar “you”) ← Proto-Germanic ***þū**, from PIE ***tū** — the *same* root as:

- English archaic **thou**, Latin **tū**, French **tu**.

English kept *thou* only in old prayers and some dialects; German uses *du* every day.

Grammar Lens: two “you”s — and German’s is the odd one out

- **du** — friends, family, children, peers. Intimate, equal.
- **Sie** — the respectful “you,” for strangers and elders.

Here’s the twist: **Sie** is really the word for “**they**” (*sie*), promoted to a polite “you” and always **Capitalized** (*Sie*) to tell it apart from *sie* = “they/she.” So German is polite by addressing you in the **third person plural** — as if saying “might *they*...” about you to your face. Three languages, three escapes from the blunt “you”:

- Spanish coined **usted** (“your grace”),
- French uses the **2nd-person plural** *vous* (“you all”),
- German borrows the **3rd-person plural** *Sie* (“they”).

When unsure, use **Sie**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “du” (*doo*), “Sie” (*zee*)
- who gets *du* (friends), who gets *Sie* (strangers, elders)
- what *Sie* literally is (capitalized “they,” used as polite “you”)

Before you move on

What is the formal **Sie** literally, and why capitalized? (It’s “they,” *sie*, promoted to polite “you”; capitalized to distinguish it.) What old English word was the lost *du*? (*thou*.)

2.3 heißen — “to be called,” the verb English almost lost

German gives its name with one plain verb — *heißen*, “to be called.” No “myself” needed, unlike the Romance languages.

Sounds you'll need

- **heißen** = *HY-ssen*. The **ß** (*Eszett*) is a sharp “ss.” **ei** is the vowel of English *eye*. So **heiße** = *HY-ssuh*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

heißen — “to be called / to be named.” Root: Proto-Germanic ***haitana**. English *had* this verb:

- **hight**, “named” — now archaic (“a knight *hight* Gawain”), and
- **behest**, “a command” — literally something *called for*.

So German kept as an everyday word a verb English let fade to poetry. And where Spanish and French say “I call *myself*” (a reflexive), German uses *heißen* as a plain verb of **being** called — no “myself” at all.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “heißen” (*HY-ssen*)
- the English fossil — *hight* (“named”), *behest*

Before you move on

What does **heißen** mean, and what archaic English word is its cousin? (“To be called”; *hight*.) How is German’s way of giving a name different from Spanish/French? (A plain verb “to be called,” no reflexive “myself.”)

2.4 heißen with a person on the front — one verb, three endings

You have the verb and you have the people. *heißen* is the form a dictionary prints; it is not the form you say. Put a person in front of it and the tail of the word moves.

Grammar Lens: one verb, changing its ending

heißen is the dictionary (infinitive) form. German swaps the ending for each person:

- **ich heiße** — I am called
- **du heißt** — you (familiar) are called
- **Sie heißen** — you (formal) are called

That ending-swap is the same machine on every German verb. You'll use *ich heiße* and *Sie heißen* in the next lessons.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the three forms — *ich heiße* / *du heißt* / *Sie heißen*
- the infinitive, then the *ich* form — *heißen*, *ich heiße*
- the tails alone — *-e*, *-t*, *-en*

Before you move on

Which ending goes with *ich*? (*-e* — *ich heiße*.) With formal *Sie*? (*-en* — *Sie heißen*, the same as the dictionary form.) Is this ending machine special to *heißen*? (No — every German verb runs it.)

2.5 **ich heiße... — “my name is...,” literally “I am called”**

Assemble the two pieces — *ich* and *heißen* — into the sentence you need for meeting anyone.

You'll want to know: **ich heiße...**

- **ich** (I) + **heiße** (am called).

ich heiße... = word for word “I am called...” = “**my name is...**”

Ich heie Arun. → “My name is Arun.” *Ich heie Mira.* → “My name is Mira.”

Why it’s said this way

German also has the literal “my name is”:

- **mein Name ist...** — where **Name** ← Proto-Germanic ***namō**, the *same* root as English **name** and Latin **nōmen** (→ English **noun**, **nominate**). It’s correct and common.

But **ich heie** is warmer and more idiomatic — German prefers the **verb** (“I am called”) over the **noun** phrase (“my name is”). (Note **Name** is Capitalized: German capitalizes *every* noun — you’ll see it on every naming word.)

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ich heie...” then your own name
- what it literally says (“I am called”)
- the literal alternative — “mein Name ist...”

Before you move on

What does **ich heie** literally mean? (“I am called.”) What’s the more literal “my name is,” and what English words is *Name* cousin to? (*mein Name ist*; *name*, *noun*.)

2.6 wie — “how,” cousin of English *how*

German asks “what’s your name?” as “**how** are you called?” — so first, “how.”

Sounds you’ll need

- **wie** = *vee*. Two traps: German **w** is an English *v*, and **ie** is a long *ee*. So *wie* sounds like English “vee,” never “wy.”

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

wie — “how.” Root: Proto-Germanic ***hwī**, from the PIE interrogative root ***k^wo-** — the very root behind the English **wh**-words:

- **how, what, who, why** — and, through Latin, the **qu-** of *question, quantity*, and the *quo modo* that became French *comment*.

German *wie* and English *how* are the same question-word, lightly reshaped.

Grammar Lens: German counts names as a matter of “how”

Like French, German asks a name with “**how**,” not “what”: *wie heißen Sie?* is literally “*how* are you called?” — about the *manner* of your being called. Don’t translate word for word; learn the logic: the name-question runs on **wie**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “wie” (*vee* — *w* is *v*, *ie* is *ee*)
- the English *wh*-cousins — how, what, who, why
- “how are you called?” is the German for “what’s your name?”

Before you move on

How is **wie** pronounced, and what English question-words share its root? (*vee*; how / what / who / why.) English asks “what is your name?” — what does German literally ask? (“*How* are you called?”)

2.7 wie heißen Sie? — “what’s your name?”

Assemble it: “how” + “are you called” = the polite question that opens the introduction.

You'll want to know: wie heißen Sie?

- **wie** (how) + **heißen Sie** (“are you [formal] called”).
wie heißen Sie? = literally “**how are you called?**” = the polite “**what’s your name?**”

Grammar Lens: verb in second place

German likes the verb in the **second** slot of a sentence:

Wie (1) heißen (2) Sie?

The **informal** version swaps in *du* and its ending:

Wie heißt du?

So the one verb *heißen* runs the whole exchange: *ich heiße...* to give your name, *wie heißen Sie?* to ask for someone else’s. (Reply to *wie heißen Sie?* with *Ich heiße...*)

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “wie heißen Sie?” (formal)
- the informal — “wie heißt du?”
- the pair — ask, then answer: “wie heißen Sie?” / “ich heiße...”

Before you move on

What does **wie heißen Sie?** literally say? (“How are you called?”)
 What’s the informal version, and where does German put the verb?
 (*Wie heißt du?*; the verb goes second.)

2.8 mich — “me,” the same word as *ich*, doing a different job

English does not say “gladdens I.” It says “gladdens **me**.” German makes the same move, and the next phrase you learn needs it.

You'll want to know: mich

mich — “me,” the object form of *ich*.

Said *mikh*: the final **ch** is the soft ich-sound you already met in *ich*, not the throat-scrape of *Nacht*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

mich (“me,” the object form) ← Proto-Germanic ***mek**, from PIE ***me-** — the *same* first-person root as English **me**, **my**, **mine** (and the French *me* in *je m'appelle*). So German *mich*, English *me*, and French *me* are three cousins of one ancient word for “me.” And just as English shifts **I** (subject) → **me** (object), German shifts **ich** → **mich**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ich” then “mich” — subject, then object
- the three cousins — *mich* / *me* / *me*
- “mich” (*mikh*, soft *ch* — not the *Nacht* scrape)

Before you move on

What is *mich*, and what is its subject form? (“Me”; *ich*.) Which English pair does *ich* → *mich* match? (*I* → *me*.) Which *ch* does *mich* use? (The soft ich-sound.)

2.9 freut mich — “pleased to meet you,” i.e. “it gladdens me”

The warm close to an introduction — and it literally says the meeting makes you glad.

Sounds you'll need

- **freut mich** = *froyt mikh*. **eu** is the vowel of English *boy*; the final **ch** is the soft ich-sound again (from *ich*).

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

freut mich is short for **es freut mich (Sie kennenzulernen)** — “it gladdens me (to get to know you).” The verb **freuen** (“to gladden”) sits on **froh** (“glad, joyful”):

- the same **froh** in **Frohe Weihnachten** (“Merry Christmas”), and a cousin of English **frolic** (via Dutch *vrolijk*, “merry”).

So *freut mich* says, warmly, “this makes me glad.”

Grammar Lens: “it gladdens *me*”

German literally says “[it] gladdens **me**” — the *meeting* is what does the gladdening, and you (**mich**) are on the receiving end. Two common variants: **sehr erfreut** (“much pleased”) and the plain **angenehm** (“pleasant / agreeable”), both usable as “pleased to meet you.”

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “freut mich” (*froyt mikh*)
- the root — *froh* (“glad”), as in *Frohe Weihnachten*
- a variant — “sehr erfreut” or “angenehm”

Before you move on

What does **freut mich** literally mean, and on what word is *freuen* built? (“It gladdens me”; *froh*, “glad.”) What does *mich* mean in it? (“Me” — the meeting gladdens *me*.)

2.10 Chapter 2 — the introduction, whole

Every piece is built. Here’s the exchange it was all for.

The exchange

German	English
<i>Ich heie Mira.</i>	My name is Mira.
<i>Wie heien Sie?</i>	What’s your name?
<i>Ich heie Arun.</i>	My name is Arun.
<i>Freut mich.</i>	Pleased to meet you.

Every piece a Germanic cousin of English:

- **ich** ← **ik* (English *I*, Latin *ego*)
- **mich** ← **mek* (English *me*, *my*, *mine*)
- **heien** ← **haitanq* (English *hight*, *behest*)
- **wie** ← **hwī* (English *how*, *what*, *who*)
- **freuen** ← *froh* (glad; English *frolic*)

And two habits of German to keep: it names with a **plain verb of being called** (“I am called,” no “myself”), and it is polite by the **third person** (*Sie* = “they”).

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the whole exchange, both voices
- your own introduction — “ich heie ..., freut mich”
- ask it back — “wie heien Sie?”

Before you move on

Give your name in German, ask someone else’s, and say you’re pleased to meet them. (*Ich heie... / Wie heien Sie? / Freut mich.*) What two German habits does this show? (Naming with a plain “to be called” verb; politeness by the third person, *Sie*.) Next chapter: *Wie geht’s?* (“how’s it going?”) and answering with *gut* again — the responding cycle.

Chapter 3

How Are You?

Modes: 🗣️ voice (17) 👁️ eyes (1) 🖱️ Hands-free start: first 5 of 18 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can ask how someone is in German, answer naturally, and return the question.

German asks after someone with a verb of motion — Wie geht es dir?, “how goes it to you?” — so this chapter builds that question one word at a time and then answers it across a full ladder, from Sehr gut! down through Es geht and So lala to Nicht so gut. Around it sit the two courtesies that hold every German conversation together, danke and bitte, each an English word in disguise. GE-C03-formal-practice runs the finished exchange in the formal register, where only the listener word changes.

3.1 danke — “thank you,” which is really “I think of you”

You can introduce yourself in German. Next comes *how are you?* — and every answer to it leans on one word. It hides a secret that English shares and hides too: **to thank is to think**.

You’ll want to know: danke

danke — “thank you.”

Sounds you'll need

- **vowel-a-german** — *DAHN-kuh*: a pure open *ah*, the vowel of English *father*, and a final *-e* that sinks to a soft *uh* rather than disappearing. Stress the front: *DAHN-kuh*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

danke comes from **denken**, “to think.” The old idea: to thank someone is to **keep them in mind** — “I think of you,” “you are in my thoughts.” German *Dank* (“thanks”) and *Gedanke* (“a thought”) are the same root wearing two coats.

And here is the payoff for an English speaker: **English “thank” and “think” are the same word too.** Old English *þancian* (“thank”) and *þencan* (“think”) split from one root — to thank was to *hold in thought*. So *danke* is not foreign at all; it is English **thank** with the **think** still visible inside it.

Three different pictures of gratitude, worth holding side by side:

Language	“Thanks”	Literal idea
German	<i>danke</i>	“I think of you”
French	<i>merci</i>	a reward , a mercy
Spanish	<i>gracias</i>	grace , favour

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “danke” — *DAHN-kuh*, stress the front
- “danke” then “denken” — thanks, and the thinking inside it
- English “thank” then “think” — one root, two coats

Before you move on

What everyday verb is *danke* built from? (*Denken*, “to think.”)

What two English words share that same split? (*Thank* and *think*.)

Where does the stress fall? (On the front: *DAHN-kuh*.)

3.2 schön — “beautiful,” and your first umlaut with rounded lips

Danke on its own is complete and polite. But German has a one-word upgrade, and the upgrading word is worth having on its own — it is one of the commonest adjectives in the language.

You’ll want to know: schön

schön — “beautiful, lovely, nice.”

Sounds you’ll need

- **umlaut-oe** — **ö** is made by saying **ay** and then *rounding your lips* as if to whistle, without moving your tongue. English has no such vowel, so build it from two things you can already do: hold the *e* of *bed*, then push your lips forward into an *o* shape. That is **ö**.
- **sch-sh** — **sch** is simply English **sh**. So *schön* is *shurn* — with no *r* actually sounded, the way a Southern English speaker says *fern*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

schön is English **sheen**. Both come from a Germanic root meaning *bright, shining* — so the oldest sense of *schön* is not “pretty” but “gleaming,” and English kept the shine while German took the beauty. Now snap it onto the word you already have:

danke schön — “thank you nicely” → “thank you very much.”

Literally you are thanking someone *beautifully*. English has no equivalent move; the nearest is the tone of voice in “thanks *so* much.”

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ay” then round your lips — “ö”
- “schön” (*shurn*)
- “danke schön” — thank you very much

Before you move on

What does *schön* mean, and which English word is it? (“Beautiful”; *sheen*.) How do you make *ö*? (Say *ay*, then round the lips.) Upgrade a thank-you. (*Danke schön*.)

3.3 vielen Dank — “many thanks,” with the noun stepping forward

Danke is a verb form — “I thank.” But English also has a *noun*, **thanks**, and so does German. Meet it, and a second upgrade opens up.

You’ll want to know: der Dank

der Dank — “the thanks, the gratitude” (masculine).

Capital **D**, because every German noun is capitalised — the rule from *Tag*. Said *dahnk*, with the final **k** crisp.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

viel means “much,” and it is English **full** — a full measure of something. Put it in front of *Dank* and you get the phrase Germans reach for when *danke* alone feels too thin:

vielen Dank — “many thanks.”

The **-en** on *vielen* is the same kind of adjective ending you met on *guten Tag*: German adjectives dress to match their noun. You do not have to build it yet — learn *vielen Dank* whole, the way you learned *guten Tag* whole.

So the family now reads: *danke* (I thank) · *der Dank* (the thanks) · *Gedanke* (a thought) — all from *denken*, “to think.”

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “der Dank” — the noun, capital D

- “vielen Dank” — many thanks
- the family — “danke”, “Dank”, “denken”

Before you move on

What is the noun behind *danke*? (*Der Dank*.) What English word is *viel*? (*Full* — a full measure.) Say “many thanks.” (*Vielen Dank*.)

3.4 bitte — the Swiss-army word: “please” *and* “you’re welcome”

Every *danke* wants an answer. German’s answer is a word that also means “please” — and three other things besides, all from one idea.

You’ll want to know: bitte

bitte — “please,” and “you’re welcome.”

Sounds you’ll need

- **i-short** — *BIT-tuh*: a short crisp *i* as in English *bit*, a clearly doubled *t*, and the soft *-uh* ending you already met on *danke*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

bitte is the asking-form of **bitten**, “to ask, to request, to pray.” When you say *bitte* you are, at root, **making a request** — “I ask this of you.”

That verb is a close cousin of two English words:

- **bid** — as in “I *bid* you welcome,” “do as you are *bidden*”: to ask or command.
- **bead** — astonishingly, yes. A *bead* was originally a **prayer**. People counted their prayers (Old English *gebed*) on a string, and the name of the prayer slid onto the little ball it was counted on. A rosary **bead** is a frozen request — exactly what *bitte* still is.

That single idea, *I ask*, is what lets one word cover so much ground:

You say <i>bitte</i> when...	It means	Why it is all “I ask”
making a request	please	“I ask you...”
answering <i>danke</i>	you’re welcome	“I ask nothing back”
handing something over	here you go	“I offer, at your request”
you did not hear	pardon?	“I ask you to repeat”
Tone does the sorting. The word never changes.		

Why it’s said this way

The courtesy loop closes every small favour in German: **Danke.** — **Bitte.** It is the twin of Spanish *de nada* and French *de rien*, and leaving off the *bitte* sounds curt in a way English “no problem” does not.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “bitte” — *BIT-tuh*, doubled *t*
- the loop — “danke” ... “bitte”
- “bitte” as *please*, then as *you’re welcome* — same word, new tone

Before you move on

What verb is *bitte* from? (*Bitten*, “to ask, to pray.”) What two English words are its cousins? (*Bid*, and *bead* — a bead was a prayer.) Name two jobs *bitte* does. (Please; you’re welcome; here you go; pardon?) What answers *danke*? (*Bitte.*)

3.5 gehen — “to go,” and it is just English *go*

German asks “how are you?” with a verb of **motion**. You already own that verb without having studied it, because it *is* English *go*.

You'll want to know: gehen

gehen — “to go.” The form you will need most is **geht**, “goes.”

That **-t** is the ending you already met on *heißt*: third person, one person, one *t*.

Sounds you'll need

- **h-silent-lengthening** — in *gehen* the **h** is **not** breathed. It is a silent letter whose whole job is to **stretch the vowel before it**: *GAY-en*, not *ge-HEN*. So **geht** is simply *gayt*.

This is worth banking now, because German uses the trick everywhere — *sehr*, *Ihnen*, *Jahr* all hide a lengthening *h*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

gehen and English **go** descend from the *same* Germanic verb — no Latin detour, no false friend, a straight cognate. When you say *geht*, you are saying *goes*.

And that is the whole idea behind German's “how are you?": wellbeing is not something you *are*, it is something that **goes**.

Language	The verb it asks with	The picture
German	<i>gehen</i> , “to go”	how does it go ?
French	<i>aller</i> , “to go”	how does it go ?
Spanish	<i>estar</i> , “to stand”	how are you standing ?

Two of the three put wellbeing in motion; Spanish puts it on its feet.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “gehen” (*GAY-en*) — the *h* only stretches
- “geht” (*gayt*) — “goes”
- German *gehen* and English *go* — the same word

Before you move on

What English word is *gehen*? (*Go* — a straight cognate.) What does the *h* do in *gehen*? (Nothing but lengthen the vowel.) Which two of the three languages ask “how are you?” with “to go”? (German and French; Spanish uses “to stand.”)

3.6 es — “it,” the small word German leans on

You have the verb: *geht*, “goes.” But goes *what*? German needs a subject, and for a state — the weather, your day — it reaches for one tiny word.

You’ll want to know: es

es — “it.”

Said *ess*: a short clean *e*, the vowel of English *bet*, and a crisp *s*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

es is English **it**. The two look unlike only because of the same swap you already met in *das* / *that*: where English keeps a **t**, German often shows an **s**. Line them up and the pattern is one column wide:

English	German
that	das
it	es
what	was

Same word, one consonant apart — and *das*, the neuter “the,” is *es*’s close relative, which is why both point at things rather than people.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “es” (*ess*) — “it”
- “it” then “es”; “that” then “das” — the same t/s swap, twice
- “es geht” — “it goes”

Before you move on

What is *es*? (“It.”) Which English consonant turns up as *s* in German? (*T* — *it/es*, *that/das*, *what/was*.) Say “it goes.” (*Es geht*.)

3.7 mir — “to me,” the third coat that *ich* wears

You have *ich* (“I,” the doer) and *mich* (“me,” the done-to). German keeps a **third** form for a different job — and English keeps the same job without a special word for it.

You’ll want to know: mir

mir — “to me, for me.”

Said *meer*: a long *ee*, and a soft German **r** at the end that is barely more than a vowel — closer to *mee-uh* than to an English *meer*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

German marks *the person something happens to* with a form of its own. It is called the **dative** — the “to-whom” form.

Job	German	English
the doer	<i>ich</i>	I
the done-to	<i>mich</i>	me
the to-whom	<i>mir</i>	to me

English merged the last two into one word, *me*, and now signals the difference by **word order** instead: “she gave **me** the book” — *me* is the to-whom there, even though it looks identical to the done-to *me* in “she saw me.” German never merged them, so it can put the to-whom anywhere and still be clear.

That is why wellbeing works the way it does: something *goes*, and it goes **to a person**. The person is in the dative.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the three coats — “ich”, “mich”, “mir”

- “mir” (*meer*) — “to me”
- “es geht mir” — “it goes to me”

Before you move on

What does *mir* mean? (“To me, for me.”) Which of *ich* / *mich* / *mir* is the to-whom form? (*Mir*.) How does English show that job instead? (By word order — “gave *me* the book.”)

3.8 dir — “to you,” and English used to have it too

Mir is “to me.” To ask how someone else is doing, you need the same form pointed the other way.

You’ll want to know: dir

dir — “to you,” the to-whom form of *du*.

Said *deer*, with the same soft trailing **r** as *mir*. The two rhyme, which is the easiest way to remember they are a pair.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

dir is English **thee** — the old to-you form, from the same Germanic root, with the *th* hardened to *d* exactly as *das* answers *that*. English has not lost it entirely. It is fossilised in old phrases: “I give **thee** thanks,” “woe is **thee**.” Those are datives — *thee* was never the doer, always the to-whom, which is precisely *dir*’s job. So the pattern completes itself:

doer	to-whom
<i>ich</i>	<i>mir</i>
<i>du</i>	<i>dir</i>

Remember: *dir* belongs to *du*, so it is for friends and family. A stranger gets a different word, and that is the next lesson.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “mir” then “dir” — they rhyme
- “du” then “dir” — doer, then to-whom
- “dir” and English “thee” — the same word

Before you move on

What does *dir* mean? (“To you.”) Which English word is it? (*Thee*.) Whom do you say *dir* to? (Someone you call *du* — a friend or family.)

3.9 Wie geht es dir? — “how are you?”

Nothing new is coming. You have all four words — *wie*, *geht*, *es*, *dir*. This lesson only puts them in order.

You’ll want to know: Wie geht es dir?

Wie geht es dir? — “How are you?”

Word for word: “How goes it to you?”

German	English
<i>wie</i>	how
<i>geht</i>	goes
<i>es</i>	it
<i>dir</i>	to you

Said *vee gayt es deer* — remember German **w** says *v*, and *ie* is a long *ee*.

Every piece has been earned: *wie* from asking someone’s name, *geht* from *gehen*, *es* and *dir* from the last two lessons. This is what the book has been building toward — a real question assembled from parts, not memorised whole.

You’ll want to know: Wie geht’s?

In speech, *geht es* crushes together into **geht’s**:

Wie geht’s? — the form you will actually hear.

It drops the *dir* entirely, which makes it neutral: no need to decide between friend and stranger. When in doubt, this is the safe one.

And you can already answer it:

Wie geht's? — Danke, gut!

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “Wie geht es dir?” — *vee gayt es deer*
- the four pieces — “wie”, “geht”, “es”, “dir”
- the short form — “Wie geht's?”
- the whole exchange — “Wie geht's?” ... “Danke, gut!”

Before you move on

What does *Wie geht es dir?* say word for word? (“How goes it to you?”) What contracts into *geht's?* (*Geht es.*) Why is *Wie geht's?* the safe form? (It drops *dir*, so it needs no friend-or-stranger choice.)

3.10 Ihnen — “to you,” said at a respectful distance

Dir is for a friend. But you already know German splits its “you” in two, and the polite half needs its own to-whom form.

You'll want to know: Ihnen

Ihnen — “to you,” formal.

Said *EE-nen*: the **h** is silent and merely stretches the *i* into a long *ee*, the same trick as in *gehen*. Stress the front.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Ihnen is, underneath, “to **them**.” German’s polite “you” is the third-person plural borrowed wholesale: rather than address you directly, the language speaks of you as though you were a group —

distance as respect. *Sie* is “they” used as “you”; *Ihnen* is “to them” used as “to you.”

The capital letter is doing real work. Written small, *ihnen* means “to them” about actual other people. Written **Ihnen**, it is aimed at the person you are speaking to. Same sound, and only the page can tell them apart.

to whom	informal	formal
you	<i>dir</i>	<i>Ihnen</i>

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “Ihnen” (*EE-nen*) — long *ee*, silent *h*
- “dir” then “Ihnen” — friend, then stranger
- “Sie” and “Ihnen” — the polite pair

Before you move on

What does *Ihnen* mean? (“To you,” formally.) What does it literally say? (“To them.”) What does the capital **I** tell you? (It is aimed at the listener, not at other people.)

3.11 Wie geht es Ihnen? — the same question, at a distance

You have the question for a friend, and you have the formal to-whom word. Putting them together needs no new grammar at all — just a swap.

You’ll want to know: **Wie geht es Ihnen?**

Wie geht es Ihnen? — “How are you?”, to a stranger or an elder.

Listener	Question
friend, family	<i>Wie geht es dir?</i>
stranger, elder	<i>Wie geht es Ihnen?</i>

Three of the four words never move. Only the last one changes.

Grammar Lens: politeness lives in the pronoun

This is a rule worth generalising: **German carries politeness in the pronoun, not in the sentence.** English reaches for extra words to be polite — “I was wondering whether you might...” — and stacks them in front. German usually leaves the sentence exactly as it is and changes *who you are calling the person*.

You saw the same move with *du* and *Sie*. Here it reaches the dative: *dir* becomes *Ihnen*, and the politeness is done.

And when you would rather not choose at all, the contraction sidesteps it: **Wie geht's?** names no listener, so it commits to nothing.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- to a friend — “Wie geht es dir?”
- to a stranger — “Wie geht es Ihnen?”
- the pair back to back, hearing only the last word change
- the neutral escape — “Wie geht's?”

Before you move on

What is the formal “how are you?” (*Wie geht es Ihnen?*) How many words change from the informal? (One — *dir* to *Ihnen*.) Where does German keep its politeness? (In the pronoun, not in extra words.)

3.12 sehr — “very,” and it used to mean “sorely”

Gut answers “how are you?” perfectly well. One small word in front of it turns a polite answer into a warm one.

You'll want to know: *sehr*

sehr — “very.”

Said *zair*: German **s** before a vowel buzzes like English **z**, the **h** is silent and stretches the vowel, and the **r** softens almost to *ah*.

Sehr gut! — “Very well!”

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

sehr is English **sore**. In Middle High German it meant *painfully*, *grievously* — and intensifiers very often start life as words for pain, then fade into pure degree. English did exactly the same thing and then half forgot: “**sorely** missed,” “**sore** afraid” both mean *very*, not *painful*.

So *sehr gut* is, at the root, “sorely good” — and English *very* went the same road from a different start, having once meant *truly* (French *vrai*).

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*sehr*” (*zair*) — buzzing **z**, silent **h**
- “*sehr gut*” — very well
- “*danke sehr*” — thanks very much

Before you move on

What does *sehr* mean? (“Very.”) Which English word is it? (*Sore* — as in “sorely missed.”) Answer warmly. (*Sehr gut!*)

3.13 nicht — “not,” the same word as English *naught*

Not every day is a good one. To say so, you need the one word that turns any German sentence around.

You'll want to know: nicht

nicht — “not.”

Said *nikht*: the **ch** is the soft ich-sound from *ich* and *mich*, not the throat-scrape of *Nacht*. The vowel before it is short.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

nicht and English **not** are one word. Both come from a Germanic phrase meaning *no thing at all* — literally “not a whit.” English shows the longer form still: **naught** (and **nought**, the zero) is the undressed version, and *not* is what happens when centuries of fast speech wear it down.

So the pair lines up with the *ch* rule you already have:

English	German
naught	nicht
night	Nacht

That English *gh* is a fossil: it once *was* the German *ch* sound, and English stopped pronouncing it while keeping the letters.

Now the answer ladder reaches downward:

Nicht so gut. — “Not so good.”

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “nicht” (*nikht*) — soft *ch*
- “naught” then “nicht”; “night” then “Nacht”
- “nicht so gut” — not so good

Before you move on

What does *nicht* mean? (“Not.”) Which English word is it, undressed? (*Naught*.) What does English *gh* used to be? (The German *ch* sound.)

3.14 so lala — “so-so,” and the tune carries it

You can now say *gut* and *nicht so gut*. Between them sits the honest middle, and German fills it with a word that means nothing whatsoever.

You’ll want to know: so lala

so lala — “so-so, middling, could be worse.”

Said *zo LAH-lah*, with the voice rising and falling across the *lala* — a shrug set to music. Say it flat and it lands wrong; the tune is most of the meaning.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

There is nothing to take apart, and that is the point. **so** is English **so**. **lala** is not a word at all — it is the same *lalala* you hum when you do not know the lyrics, pressed into service as a meaning. This is not a German quirk. Reach for “so-so” in almost any language and you find a small repeated noise doing the work, because a shrug is easier to sing than to say.

Why it’s said this way

The shrug collection, four deep across the books in this series:

Language	The shrug	Literally
German	<i>so lala</i>	“so la-la”
French	<i>comme ci, comme ça</i>	“like this, like that”
Spanish	<i>más o menos</i>	“more or less”
Italian	<i>così così</i>	“so so”

Three of the four work by **repetition** — say a small thing twice and it comes out meaning *neither one nor the other*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “so lala” with the tune — up, then down
- the ladder — “sehr gut”, “gut”, “so lala”, “nicht so gut”

- the four shrugs — *so lala*, *comme ci comme ça*, *más o menos*, *così così*

Before you move on

What does *so lala* mean? (“So-so.”) What does *lala* mean on its own? (Nothing — it is pure sing-song.) What do three of the four shrugs have in common? (They repeat a small word.)

3.15 *es geht* — the German shrug: “it goes”

Someone asks *Wie geht’s?* You are neither great nor terrible. German has an answer for exactly that, and it is made of two words you already own.

You’ll want to know: *es geht*

es geht — “it goes.” → “So-so. I’m getting by.”

Nothing has been added. That is the whole trick.

Es geht mir gut says it goes **well**. Take the *gut* away and German does not become vague — it becomes *pointed*. The listener was waiting for a *gut* or a *schlecht*, and you gave neither. The **absence** is the meaning.

English does this too, with tone rather than deletion: “It’s... going.”

Grammar Lens: the answer ladder

You now hold the whole range, top to bottom, with no word left unexplained:

Answer	Sense
<i>Sehr gut!</i>	very well
<i>Gut, danke.</i>	well, thanks
<i>Es geht.</i>	so-so, getting by
<i>So lala.</i>	so-so, sung with a shrug
<i>Nicht so gut.</i>	not so well

Es geht and *so lala* sit on the same rung and differ only in mood: *es geht* is dry and a little stoic, *so lala* is light and musical. Choose by the face you want to make.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “es geht” — flat, unhurried
- “es geht mir gut”, then just “es geht” — hear the *gut* go missing
- the ladder top to bottom — “Sehr gut”, “Gut danke”, “Es geht”, “So lala”, “Nicht so gut”

Before you move on

What does *es geht* mean literally, and in use? (“It goes”; “so-so.”)
 What makes it mean so-so? (The missing *gut* — the absence is the message.) Which answer sits at the top of the ladder? (*Sehr gut.*)
 At the bottom? (*Nicht so gut.*)

3.16 und — “and,” and how to hand the question back

Someone asks how you are; you answer. A conversation only starts when you ask back — and German returns the question in two words.

You’ll want to know: und

und — “and.”

It is English **and** with the vowel darkened, and it has barely changed in a thousand years — one of the oldest words either language still uses daily.

Sounds you’ll need

- **d-t-final** — say *oont*, not *oond*. German hardens a **d** at the end of a word into a **t**. It is the same rule that makes *Tag* come out as *tock* rather than *tahg*: whatever the spelling, a final consonant goes voiceless. So *und* rhymes with English *hunt*, not with *shunned*.

Grammar Lens: returning the question

Hand the question back by naming the other person — in the **to-whom** form, because it is short for “and how goes it *to you?*”

To a friend**To a stranger***und dir?**und Ihnen?*

Not *und du* — the dative is doing real work here, and using the doer-form is the giveaway of a beginner. The same shape appears across the series: Spanish *¿y tú?*, French *et toi?*

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “und” (*oont*, hard *t*)
- “und dir?” — and you, to a friend
- “und Ihnen?” — and you, to a stranger

Before you move on

How is *und* pronounced, and why? (*Oont* — a final *d* hardens to *t*.) Return the question to a friend. (*Und dir?*) To a stranger? (*Und Ihnen?*) Why not *und du*? (It is short for “how goes it *to you*” — the to-whom form.)

3.17 Practice — *Wie geht's?*, casually

No new words. Everything below has had its own lesson; this is the first time they run together at speed.

The exchange**German****English***Hallo! Wie geht's?*

Hi! How are you?

Gut, danke, und dir?

Well, thanks — and you?

Es geht.

So-so.

Danke! — Bitte.

Thanks! — You're welcome.

Four moves: greet, ask, answer-and-return, close the courtesy loop.

Grammar Lens: why *dir*, and not *du*

Und dir? keeps the dative because it is short for the full question — “and how goes it **to you**?” Saying *und du* would be the one wrong note in the whole exchange, and it is the commonest beginner slip there is.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the whole exchange, both voices
- “Wie geht’s? — Gut, danke.”
- “Und dir? — Es geht.”

Twice through: “Wie geht’s? — Gut, danke, und dir?”

Before you move on

Run the casual exchange without looking. Which answer is the so-so one? (*Es geht.*) Which word answers *danke*? (*Bitte.*) Why *dir* and not *du*? (The question means “how goes it *to you*” — the to-whom form.)

3.18 Formal practice — *Wie geht es Ihnen?*

Same exchange, same order, same verb. One word changes throughout — and that is the chapter’s whole argument about German politeness.

The exchange

German	English
<i>Guten Tag. Wie geht es Ihnen?</i>	Good day. How are you?
<i>Danke, gut. Und Ihnen?</i>	Well, thanks. And you?
<i>Es geht.</i>	So-so.
<i>Danke! — Bitte.</i>	Thanks! — You’re welcome.

Set it beside the casual version and the difference is two words, both of them the listener:

	Casual	Formal
the question	<i>Wie geht's?</i>	<i>Wie geht es Ihnen?</i>
the return	<i>und dir?</i>	<i>und Ihnen?</i>

Danke, gut, es geht and *bitte* do not shift at all. German courtesy words are register-neutral; the politeness is carried entirely by the pronoun.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the formal exchange, both voices
- “Wie geht es Ihnen? — Danke, gut.”
- “Und Ihnen? — Es geht.”

Twice through: “Wie geht es Ihnen? — Danke, gut. Und Ihnen?”

Before you move on

Which greeting opens the formal exchange? (*Guten Tag.*) Which dative pronoun appears twice? (*Ihnen.*) What changes from the casual version? (*Dir* becomes *Ihnen* — nothing else.) Where does German keep its politeness? (In the pronoun.)

Chapter 4

Farewells

Modes: 🗣️ voice (12) 👁️ eyes (1) ✍️ pen (3) 🗣️ Hands-free start: first 7 of 16 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can end a German conversation politely, choose a farewell that fits the situation, and write German’s three distinctive marks — the eszett, the umlaut, and a capital on every noun.

German parts formally with a promise to see each other again, casually with a word that travelled from French through Walloon and Low German before it got here, and softly with bis — “until” — plus a word for time. This chapter takes auf Wiedersehen apart into the three words it is made of, then teaches bis as a recipe and fills its slot three times: bald, später, morgen. GE-C04-practice closes the arc with the first conversation that runs from hello to goodbye.

4.1 sehen — “to see,” and it is English see

The German goodbye is a promise to *see* each other again. Before you can say it, you need the verb — and you have met its spelling trick already.

You’ll want to know: sehen

sehen — “to see.”

The **-en** on the end is the infinitive ending you know from *gehen* and *heißen*: the dictionary form of every German verb wears it.

Sounds you'll need

- **h-silent-lengthening** — the same silent *h* as in *gehen*: it is not breathed, it only stretches the vowel. *ZAY-en*.
- **s-voiced** — a German *s* before a vowel buzzes like English **z**. So *sehen* opens with a *z*, not an *s*.

Put together: *ZAY-en*. Compare *gehen*, *GAY-en* — the two verbs rhyme, and they will keep rhyming through every form.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

sehen and English **see** are the same word, both from Germanic ***sehwan**. There is no Latin in this line at all — unlike Spanish *ver* and French *voir*, which both come from Latin *vidēre* (the *vid-* you can still see in English **video** and **evident**).

So the two families split the sense of sight between them:

Family	“To see”	Still visible in English
Germanic	German <i>sehen</i> , English <i>see</i>	<i>see</i> , <i>sight</i>
Latin	Spanish <i>ver</i> , French <i>voir</i>	<i>video</i> , <i>vision</i> , <i>evident</i>

English, as usual, ended up owning both halves.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “sehen” (*ZAY-en*) — buzzing *z*, silent *h*
- “gehen” then “sehen” — they rhyme
- “sehen” and English “see” — the same word

Before you move on

What does *sehen* mean, and which English word is it? (“To see”; *see*.) What does the *h* do? (Only lengthens the vowel.) Where does Spanish *ver* come from instead? (Latin *vidēre* — English *video*,

evident.)

4.2 wieder — “again,” and the *with* that means *back*

You have *sehen*, “to see.” The goodbye promises to see each other **again** — so the next piece is that “again.”

You’ll want to know: wieder

wieder — “again.”

Said *VEE-der*: the **w** says *v* and **ie** is a long *ee*, both rules you already met in *wie*. The final **-er** softens almost to *-uh*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

The obvious guess is that *wieder* is English **with**er. It is not. Its real cousin is the **with-** of **withdraw**, **withstand** and **withhold** — and that *with-* is not the ordinary English *with* meaning “alongside.” It is an older word meaning **back** or **against**:

- to **with**draw is to draw **back**
- to **with**stand is to stand **against**
- to **with**hold is to hold **back**

That older sense is exactly what *wieder* still carries: **back, again**. So when a German says *wieder*, they are saying the *with-* of *withdraw*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “wieder” (*VEE-der*) — *v*, then a long *ee*
- “withdraw”, “withstand” — the *with-* that means *back*
- “wieder sehen” — to see again

Before you move on

What does *wieder* mean? (“Again.”) Which English word is it hiding in? (The *with-* of *withdraw*.) What does that *with-* mean there? (“Back” or “against” — not “alongside.”)

4.3 auf — “on, upon,” and it is English *up*

Two pieces down, one to go. The formal goodbye opens with a three-letter word that turns out to be one you say constantly in English.

You’ll want to know: auf

auf — “on, upon.”

Sounds you’ll need

- **au-diphthong** — German **au** is the *ow* of English *house*, never the *aw* of *caught*. So *auf* rhymes with English **owf**, not with *oaf*.
- **f-final** — the **f** is crisp and unvoiced at the end.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

auf is English **up**. The vowel drifted — German widened it to *au*, English kept it short — but it is one word, and the meanings still overlap almost exactly:

German	English
<i>auf</i>	up, upon, on
<i>aufstehen</i>	to stand up
<i>aufmachen</i>	to make up , to open

English **upon** is literally *up* + *on*, which is the same doubling German gets from *auf* alone. That is why *auf* translates sometimes as “up” and sometimes as “on”: English split the job into two words and German never did.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “auf” (*owf*) — the *ow* of *house*
- “auf” and English “up” — the same word
- “auf wieder sehen” — on the seeing-again

Before you move on

What does *auf* mean? (“On, upon.”) Which English word is it? (*Up*.) How is **au** pronounced? (Like the *ow* in *house*.)

4.4 auf Wiedersehen — “goodbye,” i.e. “till we see again”

Three lessons, three words. Now snap them together — nothing here is new.

You’ll want to know: auf Wiedersehen

auf Wiedersehen — “goodbye,” to a stranger, an elder, or on the telephone.

Said *owf VEE-der-zay-en*. Piece by piece:

German	English
<i>auf</i>	on, upon
<i>wieder</i>	again
<i>sehen</i>	to see

So it reads “**on the seeing-again**” → “until we see each other again.” Note the capital **W**: welded together the three words became a *noun*, and German capitalises every noun. *Ein Wiedersehen* on its own is “a reunion.”

Why it’s said this way

Set the three goodbyes side by side and each language shows what it thinks parting is:

Language	Goodbye	The metaphor
German	<i>auf Wiedersehen</i>	“till we see again”
French	<i>au revoir</i>	“till the re-seeing ”
Spanish	<i>adiós</i>	“to God ”

German and French shake hands on a re-seeing; Spanish commends you to God. The German and the French are not merely similar — they are the same sentence built from each language’s own parts.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “auf Wiedersehen” — *owf VEE-der-zay-en*
- pull it apart — “auf”, “wieder”, “sehen”
- “auf Wiedersehen” then “au revoir” — the same sentence, twice

Before you move on

What does *auf Wiedersehen* literally say? (“On the seeing-again.”)
 What are its three pieces? (*Auf, wieder, sehen.*) Why the capital **W**? (The welded word is a noun, and German capitalises nouns.)

4.5 tschüss — the casual “bye” that used to say “to God”

Between friends, Germans almost never say the full *auf Wiedersehen*. They say one clipped syllable — which hides the best secret in this chapter.

You’ll want to know: tschüss

tschüss — “bye.”

Sounds you’ll need

- **tsch-ch** — **tsch** is the *ch* of English **church**. So the word starts *chü-*, not *tsh-oo*.
- **umlaut-ue** — **ü** is made the way you made **ö**, but starting from *ee* instead of *ay*: say **ee**, then round your lips without moving your tongue.

Together: *chüss*, short and clipped, rhyming roughly with a rounded

chuess.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

tschüss looks purely German. Trace it back and it leaves the country entirely:

Step	Form	Language
1	<i>adieu</i> — “to God”	French
2	<i>adjûs</i>	Walloon (southern Belgium)
3	<i>atschüs</i>	Low German
4	<i>tschüss</i>	modern German

And since French *adieu* is à *Dieu*, “to God,” the breeziest German goodbye is a far-travelled cousin of French **adieu** and Spanish **adiós** — all three the same small blessing, just worn down further at each step. The friendliest, most throwaway German goodbye is secretly the most solemn one.

Grammar Lens: which goodbye, to whom

This is **register** — the same split you have drilled since *du* and *Sie*. Pick the parting to match the relationship:

Say	To
<i>tschüss</i>	friends, family, peers, casual shops
<i>auf Wiedersehen</i>	strangers, elders, officials, the telephone

If you would say *Sie* to them, say *auf Wiedersehen*.

Why it’s said this way

You will also hear **tschau**. That one is Italian *ciao*, borrowed straight and respect to German spelling rules — so German ended up with two casual goodbyes imported from two different Romance languages.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ee” then round your lips — “ü”

- “tschüss” — *chüss*, short and clipped
- the chain — “adieu”, “adjûs”, “atschüs”, “tschüss”

Before you move on

What does *tschüss* secretly mean? (“To God” — it is *adieu*.) Which Spanish word is its cousin? (*Adiós*.) Whom do you say it to? (Anyone you would call *du*.)

4.6 bis — “until,” and the shape of every soft goodbye

You have the formal goodbye and the casual one. Between them sits a whole family of softer partings, and every one of them starts with the same small word.

You’ll want to know: bis

bis — “until, up to.”

Said *biss*: a short *i* as in English *bit*, and a crisp unvoiced *s* at the end — this one does *not* buzz, because the buzzing rule only applies before a vowel.

Grammar Lens: bis plus a time word

bis is a **recipe**, not a phrase. Put a word for time after it and you have a goodbye:

bis + *a time* → “see you *then*”

The other two languages in this book build their soft goodbyes exactly the same way, which means once you own the recipe you own three languages’ worth of it:

Language	The preposition	Example
German	<i>bis</i>	<i>bis ...</i>
Spanish	<i>hasta</i>	<i>hasta ...</i>
French	<i>à</i>	<i>à ...</i>

The next three lessons each supply one time word to pour into the slot.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “bis” (*biss*) — short *i*, crisp *s*
- the three prepositions — “bis”, “hasta”, “à”
- “bis ...” and leave the slot open

Before you move on

What does *bis* mean? (“Until, up to.”) What has to follow it to make a goodbye? (A word for time.) Which Spanish and French words do the same job? (*Hasta* and *à*.)

4.7 bald — “soon,” which is English *bold*

Bis is waiting for a time word. Here is the first one — and it is an English word you would never have guessed.

You’ll want to know: bald

bald — “soon.”

Said *balt*, not *bald*: the final **d** hardens to **t** by **final devoicing**, the rule you met on *und* and on *Tag*. It has nothing to do with English *bald* (hairless) — that is a pure coincidence of spelling.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

bald is English **bold**.

Old High German *bald* meant “bold, brave, quick.” Then the sense drifted along a line that is easy to walk: what is done **boldly** is done **without hesitating** → done **quickly** → happening **soon**.

German followed the speed. English followed the courage. One word, two destinations — and English still keeps a trace of the German path in the archaic “**full boldly**” meaning *promptly*, and in the way *bold* can still mean *sudden* in older writing.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “bald” (*balt*, hard *t*)
- “bald” and English “bold” — one word, two senses
- “bis bald” — until soon

Before you move on

What does *bald* mean? (“Soon.”) Which English word is it? (*Bold* — not *bald*.) How did “brave” become “soon”? (What is done boldly is done quickly.)

4.8 bis bald — “see you soon”

The recipe and the first ingredient are both yours. Pour one into the other.

You’ll want to know: bis bald

bis bald — “until soon” → “see you soon.”

Said *biss BALT*, with the stress on the second word and that final **d** hardening to **t**.

Use it when you genuinely expect to see the person before long — it carries a small promise the way English “see you soon” does, and it sounds odd to someone you are unlikely to meet again.

Its twins: Spanish *hasta pronto*, French *à bientôt*. All three are the same two-word recipe — preposition plus “soon.”

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “bis bald” — *biss BALT*
- the three twins — “bis bald”, “hasta pronto”, “à bientôt”
- “Tschüss, bis bald!”

Before you move on

What does *bis bald* mean, word for word? (“Until soon.”) When would you not use it? (When you do not expect to see the person before long.) What is the recipe? (*Bis* plus a time word.)

4.9 spät — “late,” and *später*, your first comparative

Bis bald is for soon. For a vaguer “see you around,” German needs “later” — and it builds that from “late” exactly the way English does.

You’ll want to know: spät

spät — “late.”

The **ä** is the vowel you met in *Nächte*: roughly the *e* of English *bed*, held a little longer.

Sounds you’ll need

- **st-initial-scht** — a German **st** at the *start* of a word is said **sht**. So *spät* opens like English *shp*, not *sp*: **shpayt**.

The same rule gives *Stadt* as *shtat* and *Straße* as *shtrahsse*. It is one of the fastest ways to stop sounding like a beginner, and it costs one rule.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Add **-er** and you have the comparative:

German	English
<i>spät</i>	late
<i>später</i>	later

That **-er** is not a coincidence and not a borrowing — English and German inherited the same comparative ending from the same ancestor. *Late/later*, *spät/später*: one pattern, two languages. So the second goodbye in the family is **bis später**, “until later” — the twin of Spanish *hasta luego* and French *à plus tard*, and the one to reach for when you have no idea when you will actually meet again.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “spät” (*shpayt*) — *sht*, not *st*
- “spät” then “später” — late, then later
- “bis später” — until later

Before you move on

What does *spät* mean, and *später*? (“Late”; “later.”) How is an initial **st** pronounced? (*Sht* — *shpayt*.) Which ending makes the comparative, in both languages? (**-er**.)

4.10 bis später — “see you later”

Second ingredient into the same slot — and this one commits to nothing at all, which is exactly why it is the most used.

You’ll want to know: bis später

bis später — “until later” → “see you later.”

Said *biss SHPAY-ter* — remember the initial **st** is *sht*.

Where *bis bald* promises “before long,” *bis später* promises nothing: it is the German equivalent of a wave. That vagueness makes it the safe default when you have no idea when you will meet again.

German	Spanish	French
<i>bis später</i>	<i>hasta luego</i>	<i>à plus tard</i>

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “bis später” — *biss SHPAY-ter*
- “bis bald” then “bis später” — soon, then vaguely
- the twins — “hasta luego”, “à plus tard”

Before you move on

What does *bis später* mean? (“Until later.”) How does it differ from *bis bald*? (*Bald* promises soon; *später* promises nothing.) How do you say the initial **st**? (*Sht.*)

4.11 morgen — “tomorrow,” the same word doing a second job

No new word this time — a word you have had since chapter one, doing something you have not seen it do.

You’ll want to know: morgen

morgen — “tomorrow.”

Same spelling as the *Morgen* of *Guten Morgen*, same sound: *MOR-gen*, with the German **r** made at the back of the throat.

Grammar Lens: the capital letter splits the sense

German capitalises every noun. That rule usually just makes text look busy — here it does real work:

Written	Part of speech	Means
<i>der Morgen</i>	noun	the morning
morgen	adverb	tomorrow

Guten Morgen! is “good **morning**.” *Bis morgen* is “until **tomorrow**.” The capital is the only thing telling them apart on the page — and once you know that, German’s noun-capitalisation stops being decoration and starts being punctuation you can read.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

This morning-becomes-tomorrow move is not a German quirk. All three languages make “tomorrow” out of “morning”:

Language	Morning	Tomorrow
German	<i>Morgen</i>	<i>morgen</i>
Spanish	<i>mañana</i>	<i>mañana</i>
French	<i>matin</i>	<i>demain</i>

And English did it too, then half forgot: **morrow** meant *morning*, and **tomorrow** is literally *to (the) morrow*. So *bis morgen* is “see you on the morrow,” almost word for word.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “Guten Morgen” — good morning, capital M
- “bis morgen” — until tomorrow, small m
- “morrow” then “morgen” — the same old word

Before you move on

What are the two meanings of *morgen*? (“Morning” and “tomorrow.”) What tells them apart in writing? (The capital letter — nouns take one.) Which English word is the old “morning”? (*Morrow*, still inside *tomorrow*.)

4.12 bis morgen — “see you tomorrow”

Third ingredient, and the most definite of the three: a goodbye with an actual date on it.

You’ll want to know: bis morgen

bis morgen — “until tomorrow” → “see you tomorrow.”

Said *biss MOR-gen*. Small **m**: here *morgen* is the adverb “tomorrow,” not the noun *der Morgen*, “the morning.”

This is the one you say leaving work, or leaving a class you both attend again the next day. Unlike *bis bald* and *bis später*, it makes a claim that can be checked.

Grammar Lens: the bis... family, complete

One preposition, three time words, three goodbyes — and the same three in Spanish and French, built the same way:

German	Means	Spanish / French twin
<i>bis bald</i>	soon	<i>hasta pronto / à bientôt</i>
<i>bis später</i>	later	<i>hasta luego / à plus tard</i>
<i>bis morgen</i>	tomorrow	<i>hasta mañana / à demain</i>

You now hold German's whole farewell set: the formal *auf Wiedersehen*, the casual *tschüss*, and these three soft partings.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “bis morgen” — *biss MOR-gen*, small *m*
- all three — “bis bald”, “bis später”, “bis morgen”
- “Tschüss, bis morgen!”

Before you move on

What does *bis morgen* mean? (“Until tomorrow.”) Why the small **m**? (It is the adverb “tomorrow,” not the noun “morning.”) Name all three *bis...* goodbyes. (*Bald*, *später*, *morgen*.)

4.13 ß — the letter that is two s's in a coat

German has one letter no other Latin alphabet uses. You have already written it without being told what it was: *heißen*.

You'll want to know: ß

ß — the *eszett*, or *scharfes S*, “sharp S.”

It is not a capital *B*, and it is not exotic. It is **ss** wearing a single character, and it always sounds like a plain sharp *s* — never a *z*, never a *b*.

It is a **ligature**: two letters fused into one shape. Its name says which two. *Es-zett* is literally “s-z” — in the old German hand the **long s** (a tall *s* drawn like an *f* without its crossbar) was joined to a following *s* or *z*, and the join hardened into **ß**.

Grammar Lens: ß after long, ss after short

Modern spelling gives it one clean job, and it is a genuinely useful one — the letter tells you how long to hold the vowel *before* it.

ß — long vowel

Straße (long *a*)

Fuß (long *u*)

weiß (diphthong *ei*)

groß (long *o*)

ss — short vowel

Fluss (short *u*)

muss (short *u*)

Kuss (short *u*)

Schloss (short *o*)

So seeing **ß** means “the vowel before me is long.” *Straße* stretches its *a*; *Fluss* clips its *u*. One letter, two pieces of information.

Writing — drawing the eszett

Draw it as a tall loop joined to a descending tail — the long-s curve, then the s/z finish. Copy **weiß** once with the model in view, then **Straße**.

Say each word as you finish it, and stretch the vowel the **ß** is telling you to stretch.

Why it’s said this way

Two things worth knowing about where you will and will not see it:

- **It has no everyday capital.** No German word begins with *ß*, so in ALL-CAPS you traditionally write **SS**: *STRASSE*. A capital eszett was finally made official in 2017, but *SS* is still what you will see.
- **Switzerland dropped it entirely.** Swiss German always writes *ss* — *Strasse*. So *ß* on a sign is a Germany-and-Austria marker.

Before you move on

What two letters is **ß** made of, and what does its name say? (*s* and *z* — *es-zett*.) What does it tell you about the vowel before it? (That it is long.) How is it written in all-caps, and where is it not used at all? (*SS*; Switzerland.)

4.14 ä ö ü — the two dots that used to be an *e*

You have already made two of these sounds — the **ö** of *schön* and the **ü** of *tschüss*. Now meet the mark itself, and what it is doing there.

You'll want to know: the umlaut

Umlaut — the two dots on **ä ö ü**, which shift the vowel *forward* in the mouth.

Um-laut is “around-sound” (*um*, around + *Laut*, sound). Say the plain vowel, then brighten it toward *ee*:

Plain	Umlauted	How
a → ä	<i>Mann</i> → <i>Männer</i>	<i>ah</i> becomes the <i>e</i> of <i>bed</i>
o → ö	<i>schon</i> → <i>schön</i>	<i>oh</i> becomes a rounded <i>eh</i>
u → ü	<i>Mutter</i> → <i>Mütter</i>	<i>oo</i> becomes <i>ee</i> with rounded lips

They look like the French tréma and do the opposite job: a tréma **splits** two vowels, an umlaut **changes** one.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

The dots are a fossil. The fronting was originally caused by an **e** in the *next* syllable, and scribes marked it by writing a tiny **e above the vowel**. In the old German hand that *e* was two little vertical strokes — which, shrunk and simplified, became two dots.

So an umlaut is a **flattened e sitting on top of the vowel**, and that is exactly why the ASCII fallbacks put it back on the line:

With dots	Ghost <i>e</i> restored
<i>Müller</i>	Mueller
<i>schön</i>	schoen
<i>Bär</i>	Baer

Grammar Lens: the umlaut does real work

Umlauts are not decoration. Fronting a vowel is how German marks whole grammatical changes, so learn to *expect* it:

Base	Umlauted	What changed
<i>Mann</i> (man)	<i>Männer</i>	plural
<i>Buch</i> (book)	<i>Bücher</i>	plural
<i>groß</i> (big)	<i>größer</i>	comparative
<i>Hund</i> (dog)	<i>Hündchen</i>	diminutive

When a German word brightens its vowel, something grammatical happened to it — usually *more than one*, *more*, or *smaller*.

Writing — the two dots

Two dots, side by side, sitting squarely **above** the vowel — not slanted, and not joined. Copy **schön** once with the model in view, then **Mütter**.

Say each word as you finish it, and let the vowel brighten as you write the dots.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “Mann” then “Männer” — hear the vowel brighten for the plural
- “Mutter” then “Mütter” — *ee* with rounded lips
- “schön” then “schoen” — put the ghost *e* back down

Before you move on

What does *Umlaut* literally mean? (“Around-sound.”) What are the dots, historically? (A shrunk *e* that migrated on top.) What is the fallback spelling for *ü*? (*ue*.) Name one grammar job the umlaut

does. (Plural, comparative, or diminutive.)

4.15 Großschreibung — why German capitalises every noun

You met this rule with *der Tag*, and you used it to tell *Morgen* from *morgen*. Now here it is in full — and it turns out to be doing more work than it looks.

You'll want to know: Großschreibung

Großschreibung — “capital-writing.” Every noun takes a capital, anywhere in the sentence.

Not just names or sentence starts — *every* noun:

Der Hund frisst das Essen in der Küche. — “The dog eats the food in the kitchen.”

Three nouns, three capitals, two of them mid-sentence. Also capitalised: the polite *Sie*, and any word *used as a noun* (*das Gute*, “the good”).

(The word itself shows off two things you now know: the **ß**, and the initial **st** said *sht* — *GROHSS-shry-boong*.)

Grammar Lens: the capital is a part-of-speech signal

The capital carries **meaning**. It separates words spelt alike that do different jobs:

Lower-case	Capital, so a noun
<i>essen</i> — to eat	<i>das Essen</i> — the food
<i>jung</i> — young	<i>der Junge</i> — the boy
<i>laut</i> — loud	<i>der Laut</i> — the sound

This is the same machinery that split *morgen* from *Morgen*. With *der/die/das* in front as well, German flags its nouns **twice** — which is why long German sentences are easier to parse, not harder.

Why it's said this way

English used to do this too: read a page of 1700s English and the Nouns are Capitalised. English dropped the habit in the eighteenth century; German kept it and wrote it into the rules. It is a living fossil of older European printing.

Writing — applying the rule

Capitalise the first letter of every noun, wherever it sits. Two tests if you are unsure: is there a *der/die/das* in front, or does it end in *-ung*, *-heit* or *-schaft*? Those are noun factories — *Zeitung*, *Freiheit*, *Freundschaft*.

Copy **Der Hund frisst das Essen** once, then write *Guten Morgen* and *bis morgen* one under the other and check every capital.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “Der Hund frisst das Essen” — every noun capitalised
- “essen” then “das Essen” — the capital flips it from doing to thing
- “Guten Morgen” then “bis morgen” — the same flip, in a word you own

Before you move on

Which words does German capitalise? (Every noun, anywhere — plus *Sie*.) What does the capital tell you? (That the word is a noun: *essen* versus *das Essen*.) Which language used to do this and stopped? (English, in the 1700s.)

4.16 Practice — hello to goodbye, in one conversation

No new words. This is the first conversation you can run from the first word to the last — everything in it has had its own lesson.

Grammar Lens: which farewell, when

You are...	Say
formal, to a stranger	<i>Auf Wiedersehen.</i>
casual, to a friend	<i>Tschüss.</i>
meeting again soon	<i>Bis bald.</i>
making no promises	<i>Bis später.</i>
leaving for the day	<i>Bis morgen.</i>

The exchange

Everything from your first greeting to here, in one conversation:

German	English
<i>Hallo! Ich heie Anna. Wie heien Sie?</i>	Hello! My name is Anna. What is your name?
<i>Ich heie Peter. Freut mich.</i>	My name is Peter. Pleased to meet you.
<i>Wie geht es Ihnen?</i>	How are you?
<i>Danke, gut. Und Ihnen?</i>	Well, thanks. And you?
<i>Sehr gut. Bis morgen, Peter.</i>	Very well. See you tomorrow, Peter.
<i>Bis morgen, Anna. Auf Wiedersehen!</i>	See you tomorrow, Anna. Goodbye!

Between friends, that last line becomes *Tschüss, bis morgen!* — and note that the whole exchange stayed formal because it opened formally with *Sie*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the whole exchange, both voices
- the closing pair — “Bis morgen.” ... “Auf Wiedersehen!”
- the casual version of that close — “Tschüss, bis morgen!”

Twice through: “Wie geht es Ihnen? — Danke, gut. Und Ihnen?”

Before you move on

Run the whole conversation without looking. Which goodbye promises a re-seeing? (*Auf Wiedersehen.*) Which one is secretly “to God”? (*Tschüss.*) Which would you use leaving a class you both attend tomorrow? (*Bis morgen.*)

Chapter 5

The First Verbs

Modes: ⇄ voice (15) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 15 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can conjugate any regular German verb, ask where someone lives and what they are doing, and build my own present-tense sentences instead of reciting them.

Until now the book handed over fixed phrases. This chapter hands over the machine: take the -en off a German verb and the stem that is left accepts six endings, learned once and applied to thousands of words. Three verbs run through it — wohnen, machen, lernen — along with the pronouns the paradigm needs and the question words wo and was. It ends with Ich lerne Deutsch, the first sentence in the book assembled from parts nobody handed over whole, and with the reason German keeps its pronoun when Spanish drops it.

5.1 wohnen — “to live,” and your first regular verb

Until now you have assembled fixed phrases. This chapter hands you the machine itself — and the first verb to run through it.

You’ll want to know: wohnen

wohnen — “to live, to dwell.”

Not *to be alive* — that is a different verb. *Wohnen* is where your bed is.

Sounds you'll need

- **w-as-v** — the **w** is an English *v*.
- **h-silent-lengthening** — the **h** only stretches the *o*, exactly as in *gehen* and *sehen*.

So: *VOH-nen*, with a long open *oh*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

wohnen comes from Old High German *wonēn*, “to dwell, to be accustomed, to be content” — because dwelling somewhere and *being used to* it were the same idea.

That root survives in English, just barely, in **wont**: “as is his *wont*” means “as he is accustomed.” It is also kin to **win** and **wish** — all from one root about striving for something, or being content with it. So *wohnen* is not a stranger. It is the word behind *wont*, still doing the older job.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “wohnen” (*VOH-nen*) — *v*, then a long *oh*
- “wohnen” and English “wont” — accustomed, at home
- “wohnen”, “gehen”, “sehen” — three verbs, one silent *h*

Before you move on

What does *wohnen* mean? (“To live, to dwell.”) Which English word is it? (*Wont* — accustomed.) What does the *h* do? (Only lengthens the *o*.)

5.2 der Stamm — drop the *-en*, and you have the machine

You met the ending-swap on *heißen*. Here is the piece underneath it, and it is the reason the swap works on every verb.

You'll want to know: the stem

The **stem** is what is left when you take **-en** off the dictionary form.

wohnen minus *-en* leaves **wohn-**. That is the part that never changes. The endings attach to it, and the dictionary form you look up is simply the stem already wearing one of them.

Grammar Lens: the three singular endings

Take *wohn-* and add:

Person	Ending	Form
<i>ich</i>	-e	<i>ich wohne</i>
<i>du</i>	-st	<i>du wohnst</i>

You saw *-e* on *ich heie*. The *-st* was hiding: *heien* ends in ****, and **** + *st* collapses to *heit*, so *du heit* never showed you the *s*. On a normal stem it is plain — *du wohnst*.

This is not special to *wohnen*. Every regular verb in German runs exactly this, which is why learning one is learning thousands.

Grammars call these **weak** verbs — “weak” because they take their endings meekly instead of changing their vowel the way *strong* verbs do. You will meet a strong one soon enough.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “wohnen” then the stem — “wohn-”
- “ich wohne”, “du wohnst”
- the endings alone — *-e*, *-st*

Before you move on

How do you get the stem? (Drop *-en*.) What is the stem of *wohnen*? (*Wohn-*.) Which endings go with *ich* and *du*? (*-e* and *-st*.) Why did *du heit* not show the *s*? (**** and *st* collapse together.)

5.3 er · sie · es — “he,” “she,” “it,” and one ending for all three

You can talk about yourself and to one other person. To talk *about* someone you need three more pronouns — and you already own one of them.

You’ll want to know: er, sie, es

er — “he.” Said *air*, with the soft German *r*.

It pairs with the article you already know: **der** things are *er* things.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

sie — “she.” Said *zee*.

Yes: the same sound and spelling as the polite *Sie*, and as the *sie* meaning “they.” German really does run three jobs through one word, and only the capital and the verb ending tell them apart. You will meet that properly later; for now, small **sie** with a *-t* ending means **she**. The three pronouns line up with the three articles, which is the whole reason German bothers with genders:

Article	Pronoun	English
<i>der</i>	<i>er</i>	he
<i>die</i>	<i>sie</i>	she
<i>das</i>	<i>es</i>	it

Grammar Lens: all three take -t

One ending covers all three — attach **-t** to the stem:

er wohnt · sie wohnt · es wohnt

English does the same thing with *-s* (*he lives, she lives, it lives*) and nowhere else in the paradigm. German’s *-t* is that same odd little marker.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “er”, “sie”, “es” — he, she, it
- “der/er”, “die/sie”, “das/es” — article, then pronoun
- “er wohnt”, “sie wohnt”, “es wohnt” — one ending, three people

Before you move on

Which pronoun goes with *der*? (*Er*.) With *die*? (*Sie*.) What ending do all three take? (*-t* — *er wohnt*.) Which English ending does the same job? (*-s*, as in *he lives*.)

5.4 wir — “we,” and an ending you have already been saying

Three singular people down. Now the plural — and the first one is nearly free.

You’ll want to know: wir

wir — “we.” Said *veer*, with the **w** as a *v* and the soft trailing *r*, so it rhymes with *mir* and *dir*.

It is English **we**, wearing German pronunciation. Nothing else to learn.

Grammar Lens: wir takes -en

Attach **-en** to the stem:

wir wohnen

Which is the dictionary form, unchanged. German’s infinitive and its *wir* form are identical, for every regular verb — so half of this ending was already in your head before you met it.

You have seen this once: *Sie heißen*, the polite form, is the same *-en*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “wir” (*veer*) — it rhymes with “mir” and “dir”

- “wohnen” then “wir wohnen” — the same word twice
- “ich wohne”, “du wohnst”, “er wohnt”, “wir wohnen”

Before you move on

What does *wir* mean, and what does it rhyme with? (“We”; *mir* and *dir*.) Which ending does it take? (-*en*.) What else looks exactly like *wir wohnen*? (The dictionary form, *wohnen*.)

5.5 ihr — “you all,” the plural English threw away

Du is one friend. What if there are several? English has no clean answer any more. German does.

You’ll want to know: ihr

ihr — “you all,” the plural of *du*.

Said *eer*: the **h** is silent and lengthens the *i*, the same trick as in *Ihnen*.

Use it for a group you would each call *du* — friends, family, a team. For a group of strangers you still use *Sie*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

English used to have this exact system and lost half of it. *Thou* was the singular and *ye/you* the plural — then *thou* faded, *you* took over both jobs, and English was left unable to say “you all” without inventing something: *y’all*, *you guys*, *yous*, *you lot*.

German never lost the distinction, so it needs no invention:

	Informal	Formal
one person	<i>du</i>	<i>Sie</i>
several people	<i>ihr</i>	<i>Sie</i>

Grammar Lens: ihr takes -t

Attach **-t** to the stem:

ihr wohnt

The same *-t* as *er wohnt*. Two different people, one ending — so context, not the verb, tells you which is meant. That is the only place the German present tense is ever ambiguous, and the pronoun clears it up instantly.

The paradigm is now complete: **-e · -st · -t · -en · -t · -en.**

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ihr” (*eer*) — you all
- “du wohnst” then “ihr wohnt” — one friend, then several
- the whole six — *wohne, wohnst, wohnt, wohnen, wohnt, wohnen*

Before you move on

What does *ihr* mean? (“You all.”) Which English word did the same job before it was lost? (*Ye* — leaving *y’all* to fill the gap.) Which ending does *ihr* share, and with whom? (*-t*, with *er/sie/es*.)

5.6 The endings you can actually hear

You have all six endings. Before moving on, one fact about them that makes German easier than it looks.

Grammar Lens: German endings are audible

Say them aloud and they genuinely differ:

wohne · wohnst · wohnt · wohnen

French writes just as many endings and pronounces almost none of them — *parle, parles, parlent* are three spellings of one sound. A French listener gets the person from the pronoun alone, because the verb tells them nothing.

German is the opposite. The verb carries real information, and you could very nearly tell who is speaking from the ending by itself.

That is worth knowing for two reasons. It makes listening easier than reading at first, and it makes the *next* question interesting: if German

endings say who the subject is, why does German still insist on the pronoun? That is the end of this chapter.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*wohne*”, “*ohnst*”, “*ohnt*” — three different sounds
- them again with your eyes closed, and hear the person change
- the full six in order

Before you move on

Are German verb endings audible? (Yes — *wohne*, *ohnst*, *ohnt* all differ.) And French ones? (Largely silent.) What does that let a German listener do? (Hear the person from the verb, not only the pronoun.)

5.7 in — the word that did not change

Ich wohne — I live. Live *where*? One more word and you have said something true about yourself.

You'll want to know: in

in — “in.”

Same spelling, same meaning, near enough the same sound: a short *i* as in English *bit*. This is one of the small handful of words German and English never bothered to change.

You have already met its neighbour *auf* (“on”). Between them they cover most of what English does with *in* and *on*.

You'll want to know: Ich wohne in ...

Put a place after it and the sentence is finished:

Ich wohne in Berlin. — “I live in Berlin.”

Swap the city for your own and the sentence is yours. This is the first thing in this book you can say about your actual life without being handed the whole line.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “in” — short *i*, exactly as in English
- “Ich wohne in Berlin.”
- the same sentence with the town you actually live in

Before you move on

What does *in* mean? (“In” — unchanged.) Say where you live. (*Ich wohne in ...*) Which word covers “on”? (*Auf*.)

5.8 wo — “where,” and the German w-questions

You can say where you live. To *ask* it, you need the question word — and it belongs to a family you have already started.

You’ll want to know: wo

wo — “where.” Said *voh*, a long *oh*.

Wo wohnst du? — “Where do you live?”

Note there is no extra “do” in German. English needs *do* to ask a question; German simply puts the question word first and the verb straight after it.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

wo is English **where** with the *-re* worn away. And it is not alone — German’s question words are the English ones with **wh-** flattened to **w-**:

German	English
<i>wo</i>	where
<i>wie</i>	how
<i>wer</i>	who
<i>wann</i>	when
English spells them <i>wh</i> - and mostly says them <i>w</i> -; German just spells what it says. Once you spot the family, each new one costs almost nothing.	

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “wo” (*voh*) — where
- “Wo wohnst du?” — no “do” needed
- the family — “wo”, “wie”, “wer”, “wann”

Before you move on

What does *wo* mean? (“Where.”) Ask someone where they live. (*Wo wohnst du?*) What happened to English *wh*- in German? (It flattened to *w*-.)

5.9 machen — “to make,” and it is exactly English *make*

Second verb — and it needs no new grammar at all. The stem-plus-ending machine you built on *wohnen* runs it unchanged.

You’ll want to know: machen

machen — “to make,” and also “to do.” German uses one verb for both.

Stem: **mach-**. So *ich mache*, *du machst*, *er macht*, *wir machen*, *ihr macht*, *sie machen*. Nothing new — that is the payoff of a regular pattern.

Sounds you'll need

- **ch-ach** — the **ch** after *a* is the raspy throat sound you met in *Nacht*, the *ch* of Scottish *loch*. Not the soft *ich* sound.

So: *MAKH-en*, with a clean open *ah*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

machen is English **make**, from Germanic *makōn*, “to shape, to fit together.” The *k* became the *ch* rasp on the way, by the same High German consonant shift that gave you *gut* from *good*:

English	German
make	machen
ik (old <i>I</i>)	ich
book	Buch

So *machen* is *make*, wearing German pronunciation.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “machen” (*MAKH-en*) — the *loch* rasp
- “make” then “machen”; “book” then “Buch”
- “ich mache”, “du machst”, “er macht”

Before you move on

What does *machen* mean? (“To make,” and “to do.”) Which English word is it? (*Make*.) Which *ch* does it use? (The raspy *ach*, not the soft *ich*.)

5.10 was — “what,” and the t-to-s swap one last time

You have *wo*. Here is its most useful sibling, and you can already predict how it is spelt.

You'll want to know: was

was — “what.” Said *vass*, short *a*, crisp *s*.

You met the rule that makes it: where English keeps a final **t**, German shows an **s**.

English	German
what	was
that	das
it	es

Third time you have seen this pair, and the last new word it gives you.

You'll want to know: Was machst du?

Was machst du? — “What are you doing?”

Question word first, verb second, subject third — the same shape as *Wo wohnst du?*. And note again that German needs no “do”: *machst* carries the whole question.

There is also no separate “am ...-ing” form in German. *Was machst du?* covers both “what do you do?” and “what are you doing?” — context decides.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “was” (*vass*) — what
- “what/was”, “that/das”, “it/es” — the swap three times
- “Was machst du?” then “Wo wohnst du?” — the same shape

Before you move on

What does *was* mean? (“What.”) Which swap explains its spelling? (English *t* shows up as German *s*.) Ask what someone is doing. (*Was machst du?*)

5.11 lernen — “to learn,” and its noun is *lore*

Third verb, same machine — and this is the one you are going to need to describe what you are doing right now.

You'll want to know: lernen

lernen — “to learn.”

Stem **lern-**: *ich lerne, du lernst, er lernt*. Three verbs now, one pattern.

Sounds you'll need

- **r-uvular-german** — the German **r** is a soft scrape at the back of the throat, nothing like the English *r* made with the tongue tip.

So: *LER-nen*, with a short *e* as in English *bed*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

lernen is English **learn** — the same Germanic root, barely disguised. Its relatives are the good part. The German noun is **die Lehre**, “the teaching, the body of what is taught” — and that word is English **lore**. Folklore is the *Lehre* of a folk; the lore of a craft is what its learners have accumulated.

So German kept the verb and the noun in the same family, and English kept both too — it just stopped noticing that *learn* and *lore* were relatives.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “lernen” (*LER-nen*) — scrape the *r* at the back
- “lernen” and English “learn”
- “die Lehre” and English “lore” — folklore

Before you move on

What does *lernen* mean? (“To learn.”) What is its noun, and which English word is that? (*Die Lehre*; *lore*.) Give the *ich* form. (*Ich lerne*.)

5.12 Deutsch — the language, and it means “of the people”

One noun stands between you and a sentence about what you are doing right now — the name of the language itself.

You’ll want to know: Deutsch

Deutsch — “German,” the language.

Capital **D**, because a language name is a noun and German capitalises every noun.

Sounds you’ll need

- **eu-diphthong** — German **eu** is the *oy* of English *boy*.
- **tsch-ch** — **tsch** is the *tch* of English *match*, the same cluster that opens *tschüss*.

So: *DOYTCH*, one syllable.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Deutsch comes from Old High German **diutisc**, “of the people, of the folk.” The Germanic tribes simply called their own tongue *the people’s language* — as opposed to Latin, the language of church and administration.

That root travelled a long way:

Word	Language	Route
<i>Deutsch</i>	German	<i>diutisc</i> , “of the people”
Dutch	English	the same word, later narrowed to the Netherlands
Teutonic	English	via Latin <i>Teutonicus</i>
<i>Tedesco</i>	Italian	its own echo of <i>diutisc</i>

So English **Dutch** and German **Deutsch** are not lookalikes — they are one word that drifted apart, and English simply pointed it at a smaller country.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “Deutsch” (*DOYTCH*) — one syllable
- “Deutsch” then “Dutch” — the same old word
- what it meant — “of the people”

Before you move on

What does *Deutsch* literally mean? (“Of the people.”) Which English word is the same word? (*Dutch*.) Why the capital **D**? (It is a noun.)

5.13 Ich lerne Deutsch — your first real sentence

Nothing new is coming. Every piece of the next line has had its own lesson — and that is exactly the point.

You’ll want to know: Ich lerne Deutsch

Ich lerne Deutsch. — “I am learning German.”

Piece	Where it came from
<i>ich</i>	the introductions chapter
<i>lern-</i>	the stem of <i>lernen</i>
<i>-e</i>	the <i>ich</i> ending
<i>Deutsch</i>	the last lesson

This is the first sentence in the book that was **not handed to you**. You built it: a pronoun, a stem, an ending, a noun. Change any piece and it still works.

Remember there is no separate “am ...-ing” in German. *Ich lerne* covers both “I learn” and “I am learning,” so this one line does the work of two English tenses.

Grammar Lens: swap the pieces

The same slots take other words, and you already have all of them:

Ich wohne in Berlin. · *Was machst du?* · *Ich lerne*

Deutsch.

Three sentences, one machine. From here the language is combinations, not memorised lines.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “Ich lerne Deutsch.” — *ikh LER-neh DOYTCH*
- it in pieces — “ich”, “lern-”, “-e”, “Deutsch”
- all three sentences in a row

Before you move on

Say “I am learning German.” (*Ich lerne Deutsch.*) Which four pieces is it made of? (*Ich*, the stem *lern-*, the ending *-e*, and *Deutsch.*) How does German say “I am learning” as opposed to “I learn”? (It does not — *ich lerne* is both.)

5.14 Why German keeps the pronoun

Here is the puzzle left open earlier. German endings *do* say who the subject is. So why say *ich* at all?

Grammar Lens: three languages, three reasons

Spanish, French and German each decide differently, and for different reasons:

Language	The pronoun	Why
Spanish	dropped	<i>hablo</i> already says “I”
French	kept	its endings are silent, so the pronoun is the only clue
German	kept	its grammar demands an overt subject

The German reason is the interesting one, because it is *not* about sound. German endings are perfectly audible — you proved that a few

lessons ago. The pronoun stays because a German sentence is built around the **verb in second position**, with something standing in front of it. Drop *ich* and there is nothing to hold that first slot. So German keeps the pronoun for **structure**, French for **sound**, and Spanish keeps neither because it needs neither. Three answers, and only one of them is about being understood.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “Ich lerne Deutsch.” — with the pronoun, always
- the three reasons — Spanish drops, French keeps for sound, German keeps for structure
- “ich wohne”, “ich mache”, “ich lerne” — never without the *ich*

Before you move on

Why does German keep the pronoun? (Its grammar needs an overt subject — the verb sits second, so something must come first.) Why does French? (Its endings are silent.) Why does Spanish not need to? (*Hablo* already says “I.”)

5.15 Practice — building sentences, not reciting them

For the first time you are *building* German rather than repeating it. Run each verb through the three singular persons.

Grammar Lens: three verbs, one pattern

Verb	<i>ich · du · er</i>
<i>wohnen</i>	<i>wohne · wohnst · wohnt</i>
<i>machen</i>	<i>mache · machst · macht</i>
<i>lernen</i>	<i>lerne · lernst · lernt</i>
The same endings every time — -e , -st , -t — and, unlike French, you can hear all three. You still keep the pronoun, because German needs	

an overt subject.

The exchange

German	English
<i>Wo wohnst du?</i>	Where do you live?
<i>Ich wohne in Berlin. Und du?</i>	I live in Berlin. And you?
<i>Ich wohne in Wien. Was machst du?</i>	I live in Vienna. What are you doing?
<i>Ich lerne Deutsch!</i>	I'm learning German!
<i>Sehr gut!</i>	Very good!
<i>Danke! — Bitte.</i>	Thanks! — You're welcome.

Every line is assembled from pieces you own. Nothing here was memorised whole.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the whole exchange, both voices
- each verb through *ich* / *du* / *er*
- the exchange again with your own city

Twice through: “Wo wohnst du? — Ich wohne in ...”

Before you move on

What are the three singular endings, and can you hear them? (-e, -st, -t; yes — unlike French.) Give the *ich* form of all three verbs. (*Ich wohne, ich mache, ich lerne.*) Why keep the pronoun? (German needs an overt subject.)

Chapter 6

One, Two, Three

Modes: 🗣️ voice (4) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can count one, two, three in German and say why each is the English number's twin rather than a Latin borrowing.

The first three numbers, one per lesson, and then the sound law that explains every difference between them and their English twins.

German's numbers were never borrowed from Latin; this chapter is where that stops being a claim and becomes something the reader can hear.

6.1 eins — “one,” and the German *ei*

Here is where German is closer to English than any Romance language gets. Its numbers are not borrowed from Latin — they are German's own, and they are the near-twins of the English ones. Start with the first.

You'll want to know: eins

eins — “one,” the number you say when you are counting.

Sounds you'll need

- diphthong-**ei** — German **ei** is the English word **eye**. Always, in every word, with no exceptions to remember.

So *eins* is *eyns*. You already own this one: *heißen* is *HY-ssen*, and

Wiedersehen has an *ie*, which is the other way round and says *ee*. **ei** says *eye*; **ie** says *ee*. The second letter tells you which.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

eins is English **one**. Not borrowed from it, not similar to it — the same inherited word, which is why it needs no story to make it stick. English hides the relationship in its spelling. *One* is written as though it rhymed with *bone*, and it did once; the *w*-sound at the front (*wun*) crept in later. Strip that off and *one* and *ein* are the same shape. The same word is also sitting inside English **a** and **an** — *an apple* is *one apple*, worn down. German does exactly the same thing with *eins*, and once the first five are learned there is a lesson on it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “eins” — *eyns*, with the English word *eye* inside it
- “eins” then “one” — the same old word
- “ei” as *eye*, “ie” as *ee* — the second letter decides

Before you move on

What is “one” in German? (*Eins*.) How is **ei** said? (Like the English word *eye*.) And **ie**? (*Ee*.) Which English word is *eins*? (*One* — and *a/an* underneath it.)

6.2 **zwei** — “two,” and the *z* that is a *ts*

One down. The second number has the same *ei* you met a moment ago, and one letter that does not say what an English reader expects.

You’ll want to know: **zwei**

zwei — “two.”

Said *tsvy*. The **z** is the *ts* of English *cats* — never the buzz of English *zoo*. That is the whole of the German **z**: it has one job and it never does anything else.

The other two letters you already own. The **w** is a *v*, as in *wohnen*, and the **ei** is *eye*, as in *eins*. So *zwei* is three rules you have and one that is new.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

zwei is English **two**, with the *tw*- opening turned into *zw*-.

English still says the *tw*- out loud in the words *two* grew from — **twin** (two born together), **between** (in the space of two), **twice**, **twenty**.

It only lost the *w* in the number itself, which is why *two* is spelt with a letter nobody pronounces. German kept the pair and shifted the *t* to *ts*:

tw- → *zw*:- **two** / *zwei*, **twin** / *Zwilling*, **twelve** / *zwölf*

So the silent *w* in English **two** is not a spelling accident. It is the *w* that German still says.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “zwei” — *tsvy*, the *z* like the end of *cats*
- “eins, zwei”
- “two”, “twin”, “between” — then “zwei”, and hear the *w* come back

Before you move on

What is “two”? (*Zwei*.) How is German **z** said? (*Ts*, as in *cats*.)

Which English words still say the *w* that *two* dropped? (*Twin*, *between*, *twice*.)

6.3 drei — “three,” and German’s missing *th*

Third number, third *ei*. And it shows you something that will keep paying: German has no **th** sound at all, and you can predict what it uses instead.

You'll want to know: drei

drei — “three.”

Said *dry*: the scraped *r* you met in *lernen*, and the *ei* saying *eye*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

drei is English **three**. German has no *th* at all, and where English says one, German says **d**. That is not a fact about numbers — it is a fact about the whole language, and you have been using it since your first *danke*:

English	German
three	drei
the	der, die, das
thank	danke
that	das

Five words, one swap. Whenever an English word starts with *th*, try a *d* and you will often land on the German.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “drei” — *dry*, scrape the *r*
- “eins, zwei, drei”
- the swap — “three/drei”, “the/der”, “thank/danke”

Before you move on

What is “three”? (*Drei*.) What does German use where English has **th**? (**D**.) Give three pairs. (*Three/drei, the/der, thank/danke*.)

6.4 Siblings, not borrowings

Drei, *three*, and Latin *tres* all mean three and all start with a different sound. Before the next seven numbers, it is worth knowing why — because the answer makes each of them cheaper to learn.

Grammar Lens: siblings and cousins

German and English are **siblings**. Latin is a **cousin**.

That is not a figure of speech. All three grew out of one older language, and Germanic — the parent of English and German — split off from the rest first. So *drei* did not come **from** *tres*, and English *three* did not either. All three are what one prehistoric word became along three different roads.

Which is why the German numbers are the easy ones and the Romance numbers are the hard ones, for an English speaker: *three* and *drei* are the same word two doors apart, while *tres* is the same word across the street.

Why it's said this way

The differences are not random. A **sound law** is a change that happened to *every* word in a language at once, so once you know one you can predict the rest.

You have already met one of these. *Gut* is *good* with the **d** turned to a **t**, and *machen* is *make* with the **k** turned to a **ch** — one shift, two words, and it caught every word in German that had those sounds. The shift that separates Germanic from Latin is older and works the same way. The two turns worth carrying into the next lessons are:

Older sound	Germanic sound	Seen in
t	th , and German d	Latin <i>tres</i> , English <i>three</i> , German <i>drei</i>
p	f	Latin <i>pes</i> “foot”, English <i>foot</i>

So when a Latin word and a German one sound nothing alike, try the first consonant before deciding they are unrelated. Often they are the same word, one law apart.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “tres”, “three”, “drei” — one word, three roads
- the two turns — “t becomes th”, “p becomes f”
- “good/gut”, “make/machen” — the shift you already knew

Before you move on

Is *drei* borrowed from Latin *tres*? (No — they are cousins, both from one older word.) What is a sound law? (A change that hit every word in the language at once, so it is predictable.) Which two turns should you carry forward? (Old **t** to **th/d**, old **p** to **f**.)

Chapter 7

Four, Five, and the Article Hiding in Eins

Modes: ⇄ voice (4) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can count to five in German, run the whole five as one motion, and use ein and eine for “a”.

Four and five complete the first run, which is then said as one motion rather than five remembered words. The chapter closes on ein / eine: the counting form eins with its -s taken off, exactly as English a and an are one worn down.

7.1 vier — “four,” written with a *v* and said with an *f*

The fourth number is the easiest one yet — as long as you do not trust the first letter.

You’ll want to know: vier

vier — “four.”

Sounds you’ll need

- **v-as-f** — German **v** is said as an **f**. It is not a *v* sound; that job belongs to **w**.
- **ie-long-ee** — **ie** is a long *ee*, the mirror of **ei**.

So *vier* is *feer*. Put the two vowel rules side by side and the pair is settled for good:

Spelling	Sound	Example
ei	<i>eye</i>	<i>eins, zwei, drei</i>
ie	<i>ee</i>	<i>vier, wieder</i>

Both times, **the second letter is the one you say**.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

vier is English **four**, and once you know the *v* is an *f* you can hear it: *feer, four*. Latin's cousin is *quattuor*, which is where Spanish *cuatro* and French *quatre* come from — so this is a number where English sides with German and not with the Romance languages at all.

The *v*-said-as-*f* is not special to this word. German writes **v** in a handful of its oldest words — *vier, Vater, von, voll* — and says every one of them with an *f*, which is exactly the letter English uses in *four, father, from, full*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “vier” — *feer*, the *v* said as an *f*
- “eins, zwei, drei, vier”
- the vowel pair — “ei” as *eye*, “ie” as *ee*

Before you move on

What is “four”? (*Vier*, said *feer*.) How is German **v** said? (As an *f*.) Which letter carries the *v* sound instead? (**W**.) And how do you tell **ei** from **ie**? (Say the second letter.)

7.2 fünf — “five,” and the law you can hear

The fifth number closes the first hand — and it is the clearest example of a sound law anywhere in the language.

You'll want to know: fünf

fünf — “five.”

Sounds you'll need

- **umlaut-ue** — **ü** is an *ee* said with your lips rounded for an *oo*. Say *ee*, hold the tongue exactly where it is, and push your lips forward.

So *fünf* is roughly *fewnf*, in one syllable. This is the umlaut doing what you learned it does: it takes the back vowel **u** and drags it to the front of the mouth.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

fünf is English **five**, and the two of them are the sound law from the last lesson caught in the act.

The older word for five began with a **p**. Latin kept it — *quinque* still has one in the middle — and Germanic turned every one of those **ps** into an **f**. So English got *five* and German got *fünf*, both starting with the letter that was once a *p*:

old **p** → Germanic **f**: five / fünf, against Latin's *quinque*

Say *fünf* and *five* one after the other. They are the same word, and the whole distance between them and the Latin one is that single turn.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “fünf” — say *ee*, then round your lips without moving your tongue
- “fünf” then “five” — one word, one law apart
- “eins, zwei, drei, vier, fünf”

Before you move on

What is “five”? (*Fünf*.) How do you make **ü**? (Say *ee* and round your lips.) Which sound turned into the **f** of *five* and *fünf*? (An older **p** — the one Latin kept.)

7.3 eins bis fünf — counting to five

Five words, one at a time. Counting is something else: it is the five of them running together without a pause to think. That is what this lesson is for, and nothing in it is new.

You'll want to know: the run

eins, zwei, drei, vier, fünf

Said straight through: *eyns, tsvy, dry, feer, fewnf*.

Every one is the English number with a German coat on:

German	English	What changed
<i>eins</i>	one	nothing — English hid it in the spelling
<i>zwei</i>	two	the <i>tw</i> - German still says
<i>drei</i>	three	th flattened to d
<i>vier</i>	four	the v is said as an f
<i>fünf</i>	five	an older p , now an f in both

Not one of them is borrowed from Latin. All five are what an English speaker already half knows.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “eins, zwei, drei, vier, fünf” — straight through, no gaps
- it again, faster
- it backwards — “fünf, vier, drei, zwei, eins”

Twice through: “eins, zwei, drei, vier, fünf”

Before you move on

Count to five. (*Eins, zwei, drei, vier, fünf*.) Now backwards. (*Fünf, vier, drei, zwei, eins*.) Which of the five is borrowed from Latin? (None of them.)

7.4 ein und eine — when “one” becomes “a”

Eins is what you say while counting. Put it in front of a naming word and it changes shape — and English does the very same trick, so this costs almost nothing.

You’ll want to know: ein / eine

ein / eine — “a,” “an,” and also “one” when it sits in front of a naming word.

Which of the two you use follows the same three-way split you already know from *der*, *die*, *das*:

The word takes	So “a” is
<i>der</i>	ein
<i>das</i>	ein
<i>die</i>	eine

Two of the three groups share one form, so there is really only one thing to remember: **die** words take the extra **-e**. On the two nouns inside *guten Tag* and *gute Nacht*:

der Tag → **ein Tag**, “a day” · *die Nacht* → **eine Nacht**, “a night”

Grammar Lens: the counting -s drops

Counting form: *eins*. In front of a naming word: *ein* / *eine*.

The -s belongs to counting and to nothing else.

English does the identical thing, and hides it every bit as well. *One* in front of a naming word wore down to **a** and **an** — *an apple* really is *one apple*, said quickly for a thousand years. So both languages have a special worn-down shape of “one”, and both use it as the word for “a”. The other numbers do not do this. *Zwei*, *drei*, *vier* and *fünf* look exactly the same whether you are counting or putting them in front of something. Only the first number has two shapes, in German as in English.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “eins” — then “ein”, dropping the *s*
- “der Tag / ein Tag”, “die Nacht / eine Nacht”
- “one apple”, then “an apple” — English doing the same thing

Before you move on

What happens to *eins* in front of a naming word? (It drops the *-s*: *ein*.) Which group takes *eine*? (The *die* group.) Which English words are the same worn-down “one”? (*A* and *an*.) Do the other numbers change? (No — only the first.)

Chapter 8

Six, Seven, Eight

Modes: ⇄ voice (3) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 3 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can count six, seven and eight in German, and hear the three sounds that make them hard to guess from the spelling.

*Three more numbers, each with the sound that makes it unguessable from the page: the **chs** of *sechs*, the buzzing *s* of *sieben*, and the throat sound in *acht* that English spells *gh*.*

8.1 sechs — “six,” where *chs* is a plain *x*

The second hand starts here. And the sixth number quietly settles the last thing German **ch** can do.

You’ll want to know: sechs

sechs — “six.”

Sounds you’ll need

- **ch-none** — in **chs**, the *ch* makes no throat sound at all. The pair is a plain **ks**, exactly the English letter *x*.

So *sechs* is *zeks*, and it rhymes with English *sex* — which is also, as it happens, the Latin word for six.

That completes the **ch**: raspy after *a* as in *machen*, and silent-into-*ks* when an *s* follows. Nothing else to learn about it.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

sechs is English **six**, and here the two languages have barely moved apart at all — *zeks* against *siks*. Even the Latin cousin *sex* is close enough to hear, because this is one of the few numbers no sound law rearranged much.

Which makes it the cheapest number in the chapter: if you can say *x*, you can say *sechs*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “sechs” — *zeks*, no throat rasp
- “machen” then “sechs” — the two jobs of *ch*
- “sechs” then “six” — barely a step apart

Before you move on

What is “six”? (*Sechs*, said *zeks*.) What does **ch** do in front of an *s*? (Nothing — the pair is a plain *ks*.) And after an *a*? (The raspy throat sound, as in *machen*.)

8.2 sieben — “seven,” and the buzzing *s*

You have been saying *sechs* as *zeks* without being told why. Here is the rule, on the number that needs it most.

You’ll want to know: sieben

sieben — “seven.” Two syllables: *ZEE-ben*.

Sounds you’ll need

- **s-voiced** — a German *s* in front of a vowel **buzzes**, like the English letter *z*. At the end of a word it goes back to a plain hiss.
- **ie-long-ee** — the long *ee* again, as in *vier*.

So *sieben* is *ZEE-ben*, not *SEE-ben*. And it explains the two numbers before it: *sechs* is *zeks* and not *seks* for the same reason.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

sieben is English **seven**, with the middle consonant softened from a *v* to a *b* — a swap those two letters make in each other’s direction constantly, because they are made with the same lips.

This is the one number where the Latin cousin is also unmistakable: *septem*, which English still uses in *September* and in *septet*. Seven is the number almost nobody’s language disguised.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “sieben” — *ZEE-ben*, buzz the *s*
- “sechs, sieben” — both start with the buzz
- “sieben” then “seven”

Before you move on

What is “seven”? (*Sieben*, said *ZEE-ben*.) What does a German **s** do in front of a vowel? (It buzzes, like *z*.) And at the end of a word? (It hisses.) Which English word is *sieben*? (*Seven* — the *v* softened to a *b*.)

8.3 acht — “eight,” on a rasp you already have

Nothing new in the mouth for this one. You met its sound on the very first *Gute Nacht*.

You’ll want to know: acht

acht — “eight.” Said *akht*.

The **ch** is the raspy back-of-the-throat sound from *Nacht* and *machen*: a clean open *ah*, then the scrape. One syllable, no vowel after it.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

acht is English **eight** — and the pairing is easier to believe once you notice that English still *writes* the missing sound.

Eight has a **gh** in it that nobody says. It is not decoration. English used to make a real throat scrape there, exactly the one German still makes, and the spelling is the fossil left behind after the sound fell out. So German **-cht-** answers English **-ght-**, and it does it every single time:

German	English
acht	eight
Nacht	night
Licht	light
recht	right

Nacht and *night* you already own. The pattern is worth more than the number: whenever you see a German word with **cht**, try the English one with **ght**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “acht” — *akht*, open *ah* then the scrape
- “Nacht” then “acht” — the same ending twice
- the pairs — “acht/eight”, “Nacht/night”, “Licht/light”

Before you move on

What is “eight”? (*Acht*.) What does German **-cht-** answer in English? (**-ght-**.) Why does *eight* have a silent **gh**? (English used to say the same scrape German still says.) Give another pair. (*Nacht/night*.)

Chapter 9

Nine, Ten, and the Months That Are Numbers

Modes: ⇄ voice (5) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can count all the way to ten in German, and say which words a language keeps and which it buys.

Nine and ten finish the count, and the chapter closes on the seam the whole sequence has been building toward: the numbers are homegrown and the month names are Latin imports, so one calendar carries both answers to the same question.

9.1 neun — “nine,” in the vowel of *Deutsch*

Ninth number, and again nothing new to learn in the mouth — you got this vowel from the name of the language itself.

You’ll want to know: neun

neun — “nine.” Said *noyn*.

The **eu** is the *oy* of English *boy*, which is exactly what it does in *Deutsch*. So *neun* rhymes with English *coin*, and it is one syllable with an *n* at each end.

Do not let the spelling talk you into *new-n*. German **eu** is never two separate vowels.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

neun is English **nine**, and the two have kept the same skeleton: *n*, a vowel, *n*. Only the vowel wandered — German to *oy*, English to *eye*. The Latin cousin is the odd one out here. *Novem* has a *v* where the Germanic words have nothing, which is why Spanish *nueve* and French *neuf* look like a different word. Between *neun* and *nine* there is nothing to explain.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “neun” — *noyn*, rhyming with *coin*
- “Deutsch” then “neun” — the same *eu*
- “sieben, acht, neun”

Before you move on

What is “nine”? (*Neun*, said *noyn*.) How is **eu** said? (Like the *oy* of *boy*, as in *Deutsch*.) What do *neun* and *nine* share? (*N*, a vowel, *n* — only the vowel moved.)

9.2 zehn — “ten,” and one consonant in three photographs

The last one. And it is the number that shows both of German’s sound laws working, one after the other, on the same letter.

You’ll want to know: zehn

zehn — “ten.” Said *tsayn*.

The **z** is the *ts* you met in *zwei*, and the **h** does what it did in *wohnen* and *gehen*: it says nothing and stretches the vowel in front of it. So: *ts*, a long *ay*, and an *n*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin *decem*, English **ten**, German **zehn**. One word, photographed at three moments of the same consonant walking:

Stage	Word	The sound
what Latin kept	<i>decem</i>	d
the first law	ten	d became t
the second law	<i>zehn</i>	t became ts

The first step is the law from the *drei* lesson, the one that separated Germanic from Latin. The second is the *later* shift you already know from *gut* and *machen* — the one that only German went through, which is why English stopped at *ten* and German carried on to *zehn*. So the distance between *ten* and *zehn* is not a different word. It is one extra step down a road English stopped walking.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “zehn” — *tsayn*, long vowel, silent *h*
- “decem, ten, zehn” — the same consonant, three times
- “acht, neun, zehn”

Before you move on

What is “ten”? (*Zehn*, said *tsayn*.) What does the **h** do? (Nothing — it lengthens the vowel.) Walk *decem* to *zehn*. (*D* became *t*, and German took the *t* on to *ts*.)

9.3 sechs bis zehn — finishing the count

Five more words learned one at a time. Same job as before: make them one run, then join the two runs together.

You’ll want to know: the second run

sechs, sieben, acht, neun, zehn

Said straight through: *zeks, ZEE-ben, akht, noyn, tsayn*.

And the second five are the same story as the first — English twins, Latin only a cousin:

German	English	What changed
<i>sechs</i>	six	almost nothing; <i>chs</i> is <i>x</i>
<i>sieben</i>	seven	the <i>v</i> softened to a <i>b</i>
<i>acht</i>	eight	German still says the scrape English writes as gh
<i>neun</i>	nine	only the vowel moved
<i>zehn</i>	ten	an old d to t , then t to ts

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “sechs, sieben, acht, neun, zehn” — straight through
- all ten from the start, in one breath if you can
- the ten backwards, from “zehn” down to “eins”

Twice through: “eins, zwei, drei, vier, fünf, sechs, sieben, acht, neun, zehn”

Before you move on

Count from six to ten. (*Sechs, sieben, acht, neun, zehn*.) Now all ten. Which of the ten is borrowed from Latin? (None — every one is the English number’s twin.)

9.4 Homegrown numbers, imported months

You have ten numbers and not one of them came from Latin. That is worth holding onto, because the very next thing German counts with **did** come from Latin — and you can hear the join.

Grammar Lens: a language keeps some words and buys others

A language does not import evenly. The words people use every hour of every day are the hardest to displace, and the words that arrive with an institution come in whole.

Numbers are the first kind. German counts with its own inherited words, and so does English. Month names are the second kind: they arrived with the Roman calendar, and both languages took them whole.

Why it's said this way

The Roman year began in **March**. Count from there and the last four months of the year land on the Latin words for seven, eight, nine and ten — which is why those four month names are numbers wearing a disguise, in German exactly as in English.

Say each Latin number and then the German one that means the same thing:

The Latin number inside	German counts it
<i>septem</i> — seven	<i>sieben</i>
<i>octo</i> — eight	<i>acht</i>
<i>novem</i> — nine	<i>neun</i>
<i>decem</i> — ten	<i>zehn</i>

Not one pair sounds like a pair. The month names came from one language and the counting words from another, and German never reconciled them — because there was never any reason to.

You will meet the German month names themselves in a later chapter.

What matters now is that when you get there, they will look Latin, and the numbers you have already learned will still be German.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “sieben, acht, neun, zehn” — the German four
- “septem, octo, novem, decem” — the Latin four
- which kind of word a language keeps, and which it buys

Before you move on

Did German borrow its numbers? (No — they are its own.) Did it borrow its month names? (Yes, from Latin, with the calendar.) Why do four of them carry the wrong number? (The Roman year began in March, so *septem* was the seventh month.)

9.5 Practice — counting, and asking for one

Ten numbers, one article, and one fact about which words a language keeps. Put them to work.

Grammar Lens: the ten, and what each one cost

German	Said	English twin
<i>eins</i>	<i>eyns</i>	one
<i>zwei</i>	<i>tsvy</i>	two
<i>drei</i>	<i>dry</i>	three
<i>vier</i>	<i>feer</i>	four
<i>fünf</i>	<i>fewnf</i>	five
<i>sechs</i>	<i>zeks</i>	six
<i>sieben</i>	<i>ZEE-ben</i>	seven
<i>acht</i>	<i>akht</i>	eight
<i>neun</i>	<i>noyn</i>	nine
<i>zehn</i>	<i>tsayn</i>	ten

Ten numbers and not one of them borrowed. Every one is the English word with a predictable coat on, which is the whole reason this chapter was cheap.

The exchange

German	English
<i>Eins, zwei, drei ...</i>	One, two, three...
<i>Und?</i>	And?
<i>... vier, fünf, sechs, sieben, acht, neun, zehn!</i>	...four, five, six, seven, eight, nine, ten!
<i>Sehr gut!</i>	Very good!
<i>Danke! — Bitte.</i>	Thanks! — You're welcome.

Every word in that exchange is one you already own, and seven of them you learned this chapter.

Then the article, on the two nouns *guten Tag* and *gute Nacht* are built from:

der Tag → **ein Tag** · *die Nacht* → **eine Nacht**

Eins on its own keeps its **-s**, because nothing follows it. The moment a naming word arrives, the *-s* comes off.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- all ten, straight through
- the exchange, both voices
- “eins” as a count, then “ein” as an article — the *-s* comes off

Twice through: “eins, zwei, drei, vier, fünf, sechs, sieben, acht, neun, zehn”

Before you move on

Count to ten. When does *eins* become *ein*? (In front of a naming word.) Are the German numbers borrowed from Latin? (No — they are the English numbers’ twins.) Which German words *were* borrowed from Latin? (The month names.)

Chapter 10

The Gods of the Week

Modes: 🗣️ voice (9) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 9 lessons.

***By the end of this chapter:** I can name the five German weekdays, say which god is in each, and explain why one of them has no god at all.*

The Romans named their weekdays for planet-gods and the Germanic peoples swapped in their own, one for one, which is why German and English line up here and Romance does not. Five days are a god's name plus Tag; this chapter meets them one at a time, with the nouns Mond and Donner taught before the days built on them, and ends on Mittwoch — the day the medieval Church took Wodan out of.

10.1 Gott plus Tag

You have now seen a language keep its numbers and buy its months. The weekdays are the same question asked again, and German answers it a third way.

Grammar Lens: a god, then Tag

A German weekday is a **god's name** with **Tag** on the end.

Tag you already own. What sits in front of it is the part worth knowing: the Romans named their weekdays for planet-gods — Mars, Mercury, Jupiter, Venus — and when those names reached the Germanic peoples, they did not translate them and they did not borrow them. They **swapped in their own gods**, one for one. That is why German and English line up here and Romance does not.

Both inherited the same substitutions, made once, long before either language was written down.
 Five of the seven days keep that shape. Two do not, and both were edited later for reasons you can name — which is the more interesting half of the chapter.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the shape — “a god, then Tag”
- what the Romans used — “planet-gods”
- what Germanic did — “swapped in its own, one for one”

Twice through: “Gott plus Tag.”

Before you move on

What shape does a German weekday have? (**A god’s name plus Tag.**) Whose gods did the Romans use? (**Their planet-gods.**) Did Germanic borrow those names or replace them? (**Replaced them,** one for one.) How many of the seven keep the shape? (**Five.**) Next: the first of them.

10.2 der Mond — “the moon”

Before the first weekday, the thing it is named after.

You’ll want to know: der Mond

der Mond — “the moon.”

A *der*-word, and the same inherited word as English **moon**. German rounded the vowel and added a *d* on the end; nothing else happened to it.

The moon was the first Germanic god-slot in the week, which is why it comes first here.

Sounds you'll need

- **long-o** — a long, round *o*, the vowel of English *moan*, not the *oo* of *moon*.
- **d-t-final** — the final *d* hardens to a *t* at the end of the word, the same hardening you met in *und*. So it comes out *mohnt*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “der Mond” — *mohnt*, with a hard ending
- the pair — “Mond, moon”
- the vowel warning — “not *moon*; *moan*”

Twice through: “der Mond.”

Before you move on

Say “the moon.” (**Der Mond.**) Which English word is it? (***Moon.***) How does the final *d* sound? (**Like a t.**) Next: the day named after it.

10.3 Montag — “Monday”

You have the moon and you have the day. Put them together before reading on.

You'll want to know: Montag

Montag — “Monday.”

Mon- is *Mond* with its hard ending worn off inside the compound, and *-tag* is the day. The pattern's first instance, and the easiest: English says the same two words in the same order — *moon* and *day*.

That is what an **inherited** name looks like. Nobody translated this; both languages were already saying it before they were separate languages.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “Montag”
- its two pieces — “Mond, Tag”
- the English beside it — “Montag, Monday”

Twice through: “Montag — Monday.”

Before you move on

Say “Monday.” (**Montag**.) What are its two pieces? (**Mond** and **Tag**.) Is the English name a translation of it? (**No** — both inherited it.) Next: a day named for a god you have never heard of.

10.4 Dienstag — “Tuesday”

The second day, and the first god in the week whose name you will not recognise — though you say it every Tuesday.

You’ll want to know: Dienstag

Dienstag — “Tuesday.”

Diens- plus *-tag*, and the *ie* is the long *ee* you met in *vier*: *DEENS-tahk*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

The god is **Tiw**, or **Ziu** in the older German — the Germanic war-god, put in where the Romans had **Mars**. English kept his name almost bare: **Tuesday** is *Tiw’s day*.

And his name is the oldest thing in this chapter. It comes from the Proto-Indo-European word for the **bright sky**, and the same word became Latin *deus* (“god”), Greek **Zeus**, and the *Ju-* of *Jupiter*. So the god in *Tuesday* and the god in *Jupiter* are the same ancient word, which the Germanic peoples had already demoted from sky-king to war-god long before the Romans arrived to be swapped out.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “Dienstag” — *DEENS-tahk*
- the god — “Tiw, Ziu”
- the family — “Tiw, deus, Zeus”

Twice through: “Dienstag — Tuesday.”

Before you move on

Say “Tuesday.” (**Dienstag.**) Which god is in it? (**Tiw**, or *Ziu*.) Which Roman god did he replace? (**Mars.**) Which Greek god shares his name’s root? (**Zeus.**) Next: the noun behind the loudest day of the week.

10.5 der Donner — “thunder”

Run the sound law backwards on this one before you read it. German has no *th*; what would English *thunder* look like in German?

You’ll want to know: der Donner

der Donner — “thunder.”

Th- becomes *d-*, exactly as it did in *drei*. Take the *th* off *thunder*, put a *d* there, and you have most of the German word already.

This is the second time that rule has paid, and it will keep paying: German *d* answers English *th* right across the vocabulary.

Sounds you’ll need

- **vowel-o** — short and open, the *o* of English *on*.
- **r-uvular-german** — the *-er* at the end is barely a consonant; it colours the vowel and stops. *DON-ah*, not *DON-err*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “der Donner”
- the rule that predicts it — “th becomes d: three, drei; thunder, Donner”
- the soft ending — “DON-ah”

Twice through: “der Donner — thunder.”

Before you move on

Say “thunder.” (**Der Donner.**) Which English sound does German *d* answer? (**Th.**) Name the other word you have that shows it. (**Drei** / *three*.) Next: the day this noun names, and the god who is both.

10.6 Donnerstag — “Thursday”

You have the thunder and you have the pattern. This one you can build.

You’ll want to know: Donnerstag

Donnerstag — “Thursday.”

Donner plus *-s-* plus *Tag*. The little *s* in the middle is a joining sound German drops between the halves of a long compound; it carries no meaning of its own.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

The thunder-god was **Donar** in the German-speaking south and **Thor** in the Norse north — one god, two names, and *Donner* is his name still doing duty as an ordinary weather word.

English named the day for the Norse form: **Thursday** is *Thor’s day*. He stood in for **Jupiter**, who was the Roman sky-and-thunder king. So this one slot has been filled three times over — Jupiter, Donar, Thor — and every version of it is the god who throws the lightning.

Say *Donnerstag* and *Thursday* back to back and the shift you already own does the rest: German *d* where English has *th*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “Donnerstag”
- its pieces — “Donner, s, Tag”
- the three names for one god — “Donar, Thor, Jupiter”

Twice through: “Donnerstag — Thursday.”

Before you move on

Say “Thursday.” (**Donnerstag**.) Which god is in it? (**Donar** — **Thor** in the north.) Which Roman god did he replace? (**Jupiter**.) What is the *s* in the middle doing? (**Joining the two halves**; it means nothing.) Next: the last of the weekdays, and a goddess.

10.7 Freitag — “Friday”

The last weekday, and the *ei* rule you learned with *eins* is all you need for the sound.

You’ll want to know: Freitag

Freitag — “Friday.”

Ei is the English word *eye*, always — so the first syllable rhymes with *fry*, never with *free*. *FRY-tahk*.

That one rule has now told you how to say *eins*, *zwei*, *drei* and this. It does not have exceptions to remember.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

The goddess is **Frija** — **Frigg** in the Norse — and she stood in for **Venus**. English named the day for her too: **Friday**.
This is the one day of the week named for a **goddess**, and it is a

goddess in both systems. The Germanic swap did not merely fill the slot; it matched the god in it. Whoever made these substitutions was paying attention to who the Roman deity was, not only to which day was which.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “Freitag” — *FRY-tahk*
- the goddess — “Frija, Frigg”
- who she replaced — “Venus”
- the four you own — “Montag, Dienstag, Donnerstag, Freitag”

Twice through: “Freitag — Friday.”

Before you move on

Say “Friday.” (**Freitag**.) How does *ei* sound? (**Like English *eye*.**) Which goddess is in it? (**Frija**, or *Frigg*.) Which Roman goddess did she replace? (**Venus**.) Next: the day that broke the pattern.

10.8 Mittwoch — the day with no god

Four days in and the shape has held every time. Here is the first one that breaks it, and you can hear the break before you know the reason: this word does not end in *Tag* at all.

You’ll want to know: Mittwoch

Mittwoch — “Wednesday,” and literally “**mid-week**.”

No god, no *Tag*. *Mitt-* is the middle, *Woche* is the week, and the day is named for its position rather than for anybody.

English did **not** do this. *Wednesday* is **Woden’s day** — the chief god, sitting exactly where the pattern says he should. So English kept the Germanic name and German threw it away, which is the opposite of what the rest of this chapter would lead you to expect.

Sounds you'll need

- **ch-ach** — the ending is the raspy back-of-the-throat sound you first met in *Nacht*. Same sound, same spelling, and it closes this word too: *MIT-vokh*.

The *w* in the middle is a German *w*, so it is a *v*.

Why it's said this way

The medieval Church disliked naming a day of its week for the chief pagan god. So German dropped Wodan and put a plain description in his place, and the replacement stuck.

That is a decision you can date and attribute, sitting inside an everyday word. Most of the etymology in this book is drift — sounds wearing down over centuries with nobody deciding anything. This one is somebody choosing, and the choice is still in the language a thousand years later.

English, further from that authority, kept its god.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “Mittwoch” — *MIT-vokh*, with the *Nacht* sound at the end
- what it means — “mid-week”
- the contrast — “Mittwoch, Wednesday: German dropped the god, English kept him”

Twice through: “Mittwoch — mid-week.”

Before you move on

Say “Wednesday.” (**Mittwoch**.) What does it literally mean? (**Mid-week**.) Does it end in *Tag*? (**No** — the only weekday that does not.) Which god does English keep there? (**Woden**.) Why did German drop him? (**The Church declined to name a day for the chief pagan god**.) Next: the five weekdays run together.

10.9 Practice — the working week

No new words. Five days, four gods, and one day where the god was taken out.

Grammar Lens: the five, assembled

German	who is in it
<i>Montag</i>	the moon
<i>Dienstag</i>	Tiw, the war-god
<i>Mittwoch</i>	nobody — “mid-week”
<i>Donnerstag</i>	Donar, the thunder-god
<i>Freitag</i>	Frija, the goddess
Four of the five carry a god and end in <i>Tag</i> . The one that does neither is the one the Church rewrote.	

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the five in order — “Montag, Dienstag, Mittwoch, Donnerstag, Freitag”
- them against the English — “Monday, Tuesday, Wednesday, Thursday, Friday”
- the gods — “the moon, Tiw, nobody, Donar, Frija”
- the two nouns you own underneath — “der Mond, der Donner”

Twice through: “Montag, Dienstag, Mittwoch, Donnerstag, Freitag.”

Before you move on

Run the five without prompting. Which one has no god in it? (*Mittwoch*.) Which has a goddess? (*Freitag* — Frija.) Which two are built on nouns you can say on their own? (*Montag* from *Mond*, *Donnerstag* from *Donner*.) Next: the weekend, where the pattern breaks a second time.

Chapter 11

The German Weekend

Modes: 🗣️ voice (6) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 6 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name both German words for Saturday and the word for Sunday, and say which of them German inherited and which it bought.

The weekend is where the weekday pattern breaks a second time. Samstag is not Saturn's day but the Sabbath — Hebrew shabbāt by way of Greek — while Sonntag is the sun's, a day the Church renamed in Romance and left alone here. It closes on Sonnabend, the northern Saturday, which is transparent the moment Sonne and Abend are both owned.

11.1 die Sonne — “the sun”

You have *der Mond*. Its opposite number comes with a surprise attached, and the surprise is the article.

You'll want to know: die Sonne

die Sonne — “the sun.”

Same word as English **sun**, with the German ending. But notice the pair you now own: **der Mond** and **die Sonne**. The moon is masculine and the sun is feminine.

Why it's said this way

That is the **reverse** of what the Romance languages do, where the sun is masculine and the moon feminine — French *le soleil* and *la lune*, Spanish *el sol* and *la luna*.

Neither is a statement about the sun. Grammatical gender is a filing system, not a description, and the two families filed the same two objects in opposite drawers. It is worth meeting early, because it is the clearest possible proof that a German noun's gender is not something you can reason out from the thing itself.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “die Sonne”
- the pair with their articles — “der Mond, die Sonne”
- the other way round — “le soleil, la lune”

Twice through: “der Mond, die Sonne.”

Before you move on

Say “the sun.” (**Die Sonne.**) Which article does the moon take? (**Der.**) Which way round is French? (**The opposite** — *le soleil, la lune.*) Can you work a German noun's gender out from the thing? (**No.**) Next: the day named for it.

11.2 Sonntag — “Sunday”

The pattern again, on the noun from a moment ago.

You'll want to know: Sonntag

Sonntag — “Sunday.”

Sonne plus *Tag*, with the *e* dropped in the compound. English says the same two words: *sun* and *day*.

Why it's said this way

Mittwoch showed the Church taking a god out of the week. This day shows where it did **not**.

Romance renamed Sunday completely, for the **Lord**: Spanish *domingo*, French *dimanche*, both from Latin *dies dominicus*. The sun was pushed out entirely. German and English kept the sun.

So the same institution rewrote one German day and left another alone, and the week records both decisions side by side. *Mittwoch* is where it intervened; *Sonntag* is where it did not.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “Sonntag”
- its pieces — “Sonne, Tag”
- what Romance did instead — “domingo, dimanche”
- the two decisions — “Mittwoch rewritten, Sonntag left alone”

Twice through: “Sonntag — Sunday.”

Before you move on

Say “Sunday.” (**Sonntag**.) What are its two pieces? (**Sonne and Tag**.) What did Spanish name the day for instead? (**The Lord** — *domingo*.) Which German day did the Church rewrite? (**Mittwoch**.) Next: a word that is not German at all.

11.3 der Sabbat — “the Sabbath”

Every word in this week so far has been Germanic. Here is the one that is not — and it did not come from Latin either.

You'll want to know: der Sabbat

der Sabbat — “the Sabbath,” the day of rest.

Hebrew *shabbāt* means “to rest.” Greek-speaking Christians took it as *sábbaton* and carried it north, and German has it as *Sabbat*.

Hold the word on its own for a moment before the next lesson does anything with it. Its road is the point: **Hebrew to Greek to German**, with no Germanic ancestor and no Latin one either. It is the only word in the German week that came from outside Europe.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “der Sabbat”
- the road — “shabbāt, sábbaton, Sabbat”
- what it means — “rest”

Twice through: “der Sabbat — the Sabbath.”

Before you move on

Say “the Sabbath.” (**Der Sabbat.**) What does the Hebrew root mean? (**To rest.**) Which language carried it north? (**Greek.**) Is it Germanic or Latin? (**Neither.**) Next: the day it became.

11.4 Samstag — the day that is not Saturn’s

The second break in the pattern, and a bigger one than *Mittwoch*. That day lost its god. This one was never Germanic at all.

You’ll want to know: Samstag

Samstag — “Saturday.”

It ends in *Tag*, so the shape looks intact. What sits in front of it is not a god: it is *Sabbat*, worn down. **Sam(s)- + Tag** — “the Sabbath day.”

English kept the Roman planet here. *Saturday* is **Saturn’s day**, the one Roman name the Germanic swap never replaced. German did replace it, but not with a god of its own.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

The road this word travelled is longer than any other in the chapter: Hebrew *shabbāt*, “to rest,” became Greek *sábbaton*, and Greek-speaking Christians carried it north into German as *Sabbat*. From there it wore down to the *Sams*- you say now.

So **German *Samstag* and Spanish *sábado* are the same word** — both are the Sabbath. And English, which usually stands beside German in this chapter, is the odd one out: it alone still points at a Roman planet.

Why it’s said this way

This is the distinction you were given with the months, arriving again on a different word.

The weekday names are the first kind of word: everyday, inherited, hard to displace — which is why six of them are still Germanic after fifteen hundred years. *Samstag* is the second kind. It came with an institution, and it came in whole, exactly as the month names did.

So one week contains both answers to the same question. Six days a language kept, and one it bought.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “Samstag”
- the road — “shabbāt, sábbaton, Sabbat, Samstag”
- the pair — “Samstag, sábado: the same Sabbath”
- the odd one — “Saturday still points at Saturn”

Twice through: “Samstag — the Sabbath, not Saturn.”

Before you move on

Say “Saturday.” (**Samstag**.) Is it Saturn’s day? (**No** — the Sabbath’s.) Which language did it reach German through? (**Greek**, from Hebrew.) Which Spanish day is the same word? (**Sábado**.) Which kind of word is it — kept or bought? (**Bought**, like the

month names.) Next: the day the Church left alone.

11.5 Sonnabend — Saturday, in the north

One more Saturday. This one you can read before you are told what it means, because both halves are already yours.

You'll want to know: Sonnabend

Sonnabend — “Saturday,” in northern Germany.

Sonn- is the sun and *-abend* is the evening, both of which you own. It is “**Sun-eve**”: the evening before Sunday, standing in for the whole day.

That is the same reckoning English keeps in *Christmas Eve* and *New Year's Eve* — the day taking its name from the night that runs up to it.

Why it's said this way

Both words are correct German and a speaker will use one or the other by where they are from: **Sonnabend** in the north, **Samstag** in the south and west, with *Samstag* the more widely used of the two. So Saturday has two names in German and neither is a mistake — which is worth knowing before you hear the one you did not learn and assume you misheard it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “Sonnabend”
- its two halves — “Sonne, Abend”
- both Saturdays — “Samstag, Sonnabend”

Twice through: “Sonnabend — Sun-eve.”

Before you move on

Say the northern word for Saturday. (**Sonnabend**.) What are its two halves? (***Sonne** and **Abend***.) What does it literally mean?

(**Sun-eve.**) Which word is used more widely? (***Samstag.***) Next: the whole week, said through.

11.6 Practice — all seven

No new words. Seven days, five gods, and two places where something else got in.

Grammar Lens: the whole week

German	what is in it
<i>Montag</i>	the moon
<i>Dienstag</i>	Tiw
<i>Mittwoch</i>	mid-week — the Church took the god out
<i>Donnerstag</i>	Donar
<i>Freitag</i>	Frija
<i>Samstag</i>	the Sabbath — bought, not inherited
<i>Sonntag</i>	the sun

Five gods, one edit, one import. Run them in order until the list is one motion rather than seven remembered words.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- all seven in order, from *Montag* to *Sonntag*
- the two Saturdays — “Samstag, Sonnabend”
- the two breaks — “Mittwoch: no god. Samstag: not Germanic.”
- the shape that holds for the other five — “a god, then Tag”

Twice through: “Montag, Dienstag, Mittwoch, Donnerstag, Freitag, Samstag, Sonntag.”

Before you move on

Run all seven without prompting. Which day has no god? (*Mittwoch*.) Which is not a Germanic word at all? (*Samstag* — the Sabbath.) Which day did the Church rename in Romance but leave alone here? (*Sonntag*.) Which day has two names? (**Saturday** — *Samstag* and *Sonnabend*.)

Chapter 12

Telling the Time

Modes: 🗣️ voice (10) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 10 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can ask for and tell the time in German.

The chapter's thesis is a division of labour. Uhr came from Latin hora with the clocks that needed it, and German already had Stunde for the span, so the loan took the clock-reading job and the native word kept the other. Mittag and Mitternacht are German's own compounds, Mitte with Tag and Nacht, the same thought French assembled out of Latin as midi. It closes on the two frames together: a number with Uhr, or a pivot standing alone.

12.1 die Uhr — “the clock”

Something changes here. The numbers were German's own and the weekdays were German's gods — this word is neither.

You'll want to know: die Uhr

die Uhr — “the clock,” and also “o'clock.”

A *die*-word, and one syllable. It does two jobs: the object on the wall, and the word you say when telling the time.

Sounds you'll need

- **u-long** — a long *u*, the vowel of English *moor*.
- **r-final** — and then a soft *r* that barely closes: German's final *r*

colours the vowel and stops rather than rolling.

Together: *oor*. One syllable, nothing more.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “die Uhr” — *oor*, long and soft
- its two jobs — “the clock; o’clock”
- it beside a word you own — “der Tag, die Uhr”

Twice through: “die Uhr.”

Before you move on

Say “the clock.” (**Die Uhr**.) Which article? (**Die**.) How many syllables? (**One** — *oor*.) What else does the word mean? (**O’clock**.) Next: where it came from, which is not where the rest of this book’s words come from.

12.2 Uhr, taken apart

You have twice met a language keeping some words and buying others. Here is the third time, and it completes a picture.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Uhr comes from Latin ***hōra***, “hour” — the same word that became French *heure*, Italian *ora* and English **hour**. It reached German through medieval Latin and Low German *ūr(e)*.

Timekeeping arrived with Roman and monastic clocks, and the word rode in with the machinery.

Why it’s said this way

Three layers of the German day, three different origins:

what	German	where it came from
the numbers	<i>eins, zwei, drei</i>	native Germanic
the weekdays	<i>Montag, Donnerstag</i>	Germanic gods
the clock	<i>Uhr</i>	Latin, from <i>hōra</i>

German kept its own counting and its own gods. For the **machine that measures hours** it reached for Rome. That is the same rule you were given with the months and again with *Samstag*: the words used every hour of every day are the hardest to displace, and the words that arrive with an institution come in whole. A clock is an institution arriving.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the family — “Uhr, hōra, heure, ora, hour”
- the three layers — “numbers native, weekdays gods, clock Latin”
- the reason — “the clock came in, and its word came with it”

Twice through: “Uhr — from hōra.”

Before you move on

Which Latin word is *Uhr*? (***Hōra***.) Which English word is its cousin? (***Hour***.) Which two layers of the German day are **not** borrowed? (**The numbers and the weekdays**.) Why did this one come in? (**It arrived with the clocks**.) Next: the German word that was there already.

12.3 die Stunde — “an hour”

A borrowed word usually arrives because a language needs one. This time German already had a perfectly good word, and took the Latin one anyway.

You'll want to know: die Stunde

die Stunde — “an hour,” in the sense of a **span of sixty minutes**.

Native Germanic, and older in the language than *Uhr*. It is the word for a duration: a lesson lasts *eine Stunde*.

Sounds you'll need

- **st-initial-scht** — a German *st-* at the start of a word is *sht-*, not *st-*. So this opens *SHTOON-*, which is the single most useful spelling rule in German after *ei* and *ie*.
- **u-long** — the same long *u* you met in *Uhr*.

Why it's said this way

The loan did **not** push the native word out. The two divided the work instead:

for	German uses
reading a clock — “o'clock”	<i>Uhr</i>
a length of time — “an hour”	<i>Stunde</i>

English has the same split and hides it: *hour* covers both, and *o'clock* is a worn-down phrase (*of the clock*) doing the first job.

This is worth holding on to, because it is what borrowing usually looks like. The loan rarely kills the native word; it takes a slice of the meaning and the two settle into different rooms.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “die Stunde” — *SHTOON-duh*
- the pair and their jobs — “Uhr for the clock, Stunde for the span”
- the spelling rule — “st- at the front is sht-”

Twice through: “die Uhr, die Stunde.”

Before you move on

Say “an hour,” meaning a span. (**Eine Stunde.**) Which word do you use to read a clock? (**Uhr.**) Which of the two is native German? (**Stunde.**) How is *st-* pronounced at the start of a word? (**Sht-**.) Next: putting *Uhr* into a sentence.

12.4 Es ist zwei Uhr — telling the time

You have the numbers and you have the word. The frame that joins them needs nothing new.

Grammar Lens: es ist, a number, Uhr

es ist + the number + **Uhr**

*Es ist **ein** Uhr.* — “It is one o’clock.” *Es ist **zwei** Uhr.* — “It is two o’clock.” *Es ist **zehn** Uhr.* — “It is ten o’clock.”

Word for word that is the English sentence with *o’clock* moved: *it is two o’clock*. Nothing about the order has to be relearned.

One thing to notice: at one o’clock it is **ein** Uhr, not *eins* — the counting form drops its *-s* here exactly as it does before a noun, which you met with *ein* and *eine*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the frame — “es ist ... Uhr”
- “Es ist zwei Uhr.” “Es ist zehn Uhr.”
- the odd one — “Es ist ein Uhr”, not *eins*
- the hour it is now, wherever you are

Twice through: “Es ist zwei Uhr.”

Before you move on

Say “it is ten o’clock.” (**Es ist zehn Uhr.**) What are the three pieces? (***Es ist*, the number, Uhr.**) What happens to *eins* at one o’clock? (**It drops the -s: ein Uhr.**) Next: the plural German does not use here.

12.5 zwei Uhr, not zwei Uhren

Every German noun you have met takes a plural. This one refuses — but only in one of its two jobs.

Grammar Lens: the clock-reading Uhr does not count

Telling the time, *Uhr* stays **singular** however many hours you name.

Zwei Uhr is “two o’clock.” Not *zwei Uhren* — that would be **two clocks**, the objects on the wall.

German	English
<i>zwei Uhr</i>	two o’clock
<i>zwei Uhren</i>	two clocks

English does the identical thing and hides it behind an apostrophe. You would never say “two o’clocks” either, because *o’clock* is not a noun being counted — it is a fossilised phrase, *of the clock*. German’s *Uhr* is doing that job with no apostrophe to warn you. So what you are watching is not really about *Uhr*. It is about a word that has stopped being a countable thing and become a **unit of time**, a job nouns take on in every language and mark differently in each.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the time — “zwei Uhr”
- the objects — “zwei Uhren”
- the English that hides it — “two o’clock, two clocks”

Twice through: “zwei Uhr; zwei Uhren.”

Before you move on

Say “two o’clock.” (**Zwei Uhr.**) Say “two clocks.” (**Zwei Uhren.**) Which of the two is the plural? (**Uhren.**) Why does the time not take one? (**It is a unit of time, not a thing being counted.**) Next: the two pivots of the day, and they are German’s own.

12.6 die Mitte — “the middle”

The clock-word was Latin. The two pivots of the German day swing straight back to German’s own vocabulary, and they share a piece.

You’ll want to know: die Mitte

die Mitte — “the middle.”

Two syllables, short *i*, and a crisp doubled *t*: *MIT-tuh*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Mitte is English **mid** and **middle** — the same inherited word, and you can hear it without being told.

Its Latin cousin is *medius*, “middle,” which English borrowed several times over: **medium**, **median**, **mediocre** (literally “middling”), and the *medi-* of *Mediterranean*, the sea in the middle of the land.

So the everyday Germanic word and the learned Latin one sit side by side in English, and German has the first of them. That is the pattern you have been watching all book: two doors into one root, one worn smooth by daily use and one carried in by scholars.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “die Mitte” — *MIT-tuh*
- the Germanic side — “Mitte, mid, middle”
- the Latin side — “medius, medium, median”

Twice through: “die Mitte — the middle.”

Before you move on

Say “the middle.” (**Die Mitte.**) Which two English words is it? (**Mid** and **middle.**) Which Latin word is its cousin? (**Medius.**) Name an English word from that side. (**Medium, median** or **mediocre.**) Next: the middle of the day.

12.7 der Mittag — “noon”

You have the middle and you have the day. Put them together before reading on — you will be right.

You’ll want to know: der Mittag

der Mittag — “noon,” and literally “**mid-day.**”

Mitt- from *Mitte*, *-tag* from *Tag*. Nothing is hidden and nothing had to be learned: this is the third compound in two chapters you could read on sight, after *Montag* and *Sonnabend*.

English has the identical compound — **midday** — built from the identical two inherited words. Neither language got it from the other; each still had the pieces and used them.

To say it is noon: *Es ist Mittag*. No number and no *Uhr*, because noon is not an hour you count to.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “der Mittag”
- its two pieces — “Mitte, Tag”
- the English twin — “Mittag, midday”
- “Es ist Mittag.”

Twice through: “der Mittag — midday.”

Before you move on

Say “noon.” (**Der Mittag.**) What are its two pieces? (**Mitte and Tag.**) Say “it is noon.” (**Es ist Mittag.**) Does it need a number? (**No.**) Next: what French does with the same idea, and why German did not.

12.8 Mittag and midi

French says *midi* for noon, and it means exactly what *Mittag* means. That is not a borrowing in either direction.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

French *midi* comes from Latin *medius diēs* — “middle day.” German *Mittag* is *Mitte* plus *Tag* — “middle day.”

The **same thought**, assembled **twice**, out of different material:

language	built from	result
Latin, then French	<i>medius</i> + <i>diēs</i>	<i>midi</i>
German	<i>Mitte</i> + <i>Tag</i>	<i>Mittag</i>

Both families looked at the sun overhead and named the moment for the middle of the day. Neither copied the other; the idea is obvious enough that two languages reached it independently, and each used the words it had.

Why it’s said this way

This is the counterweight to *Uhr*, and the two are worth holding together.

For the **clock** — a machine that arrived from outside — German took the foreign word whole. For **noon** — something anyone with a sky already has — German built its own out of pieces it owned.

A language borrows what arrives and builds what was always there. One chapter, both halves of that.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the pair — “Mittag, midi”

- what each is made of — “Mitte plus Tag; medius plus diēs”
- the chapter in one line — “borrow the clock, build the noon”

Twice through: “Mittag, midi — the same thought, built twice.”

Before you move on

What is French *midi* made of? (**Medius** + **diēs**, “middle day”.)
 And *Mittag*? (**Mitte** + **Tag**.) Did German borrow it? (**No** — it
 built its own.) Which word in this chapter **was** borrowed? (**Uhr**.)
 Next: the other pivot.

12.9 die Mitternacht — “midnight”

The day’s other pivot, and the second compound in this chapter
 you can assemble from words you already have.

You’ll want to know: die Mitternacht

die Mitternacht — “midnight,” literally “**mid-night**.”

Mitter- is *Mitte* with the linking form it takes inside a compound, and
-nacht is the night. English **midnight** is the same two words again.

To say it: *Es ist Mitternacht*. Like *Mittag*, no number and no *Uhr*.

Sounds you’ll need

- **ch-ach** — the raspy back-of-the-throat sound from *Nacht* itself,
 unchanged inside the longer word.

And that *-cht* is the correspondence you were given with the numbers:
 German *-cht*- answers English *-ght*- every time.

German	English
<i>acht</i>	eight
<i>Nacht</i>	night
<i>Licht</i>	light

You met the first pair counting to ten. Here it is again on a word you
 now need, which is what a sound correspondence is for — you learn it
 once and it keeps paying.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “die Mitternacht”
- its pieces — “Mitte, Nacht”
- the correspondence — “acht/eight, Nacht/night, Licht/light”
- “Es ist Mitternacht.”

Twice through: “Mittag, Mitternacht.”

Before you move on

Say “midnight.” (**Die Mitternacht.**) What are its pieces? (**Mitte and Nacht.**) What does German *-cht-* answer in English? (**-ght-**.) Give the pair you met with the numbers. (**Acht / eight.**) Next: the whole chapter, said through.

12.10 Practice — the clock and the two pivots

No new words. One borrowed word and two built ones, and the difference between them is the chapter. Start by saying the borrowed one, one long syllable — *Uhr* — and then the piece both pivots begin with, *Mitte*.

Grammar Lens: three ways to say when

when	German
one o'clock	<i>Es ist ein Uhr.</i>
ten o'clock	<i>Es ist zehn Uhr.</i>
noon	<i>Es ist Mittag.</i>
midnight	<i>Es ist Mitternacht.</i>

One frame, *es ist*, and then either a number with *Uhr* or a pivot on its own. The pivots take no number because they are not hours you count to.

Why it's said this way

Hold the two halves of the chapter side by side:

- ***Uhr*** came from Latin *hōra*, with the clocks. German had *Stunde* already, so the loan took the clock-reading job and the native word kept the span.
- ***Mittag*** and ***Mitternacht*** are German's own, built from *Mitte* with *Tag* and *Nacht* — the same thought French assembled out of Latin as *midi*.

A language borrows what arrives and builds what was always there. The sky was always there; the clock was delivered.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the four sentences above, in order
- the two hour-words and their jobs — “Uhr for the clock, Stunde for the span”
- the counted and the uncounted — “zwei Uhr; Mittag”
- the chapter in one line — “borrow the clock, build the noon”

Twice through: “Es ist zwei Uhr. Es ist Mittag. Es ist Mitternacht.”

Before you move on

Say “it is two o’clock.” (**Es ist zwei Uhr.**) Say “it is midnight.” (**Es ist Mitternacht.**) Which word here is Latin? (***Uhr***, from *hōra*.) Which two did German build itself? (***Mittag*** and ***Mitternacht***.) Why does *zwei Uhr* have no plural? (**It is a unit of time, not a thing being counted.**)

Chapter 13

The Roman Calendar

Modes: 🗣️ voice (9) 🗋️ Hands-free start: all 9 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name the first six German months and say why every one of the twelve came from Latin.

The unit is German's own – der Monat IS der Mond, one turn of it, exactly as English month is moon. The twelve names inside it are Latin, taken whole with the calendar that ordered them. The chapter walks the first six and stops on the one that arrived twice: Maerz is Mars by name, and Dienstag is the same god by translation, because German already had a week to map onto and no twelve-month calendar at all.

13.1 der Monat — “the month”

Twelve names are coming, and every one of them is Latin. The word that holds them is not.

You'll want to know: der Monat

der Monat — “the month.”

Say *Mond* and then *Monat* and you have heard the whole etymology. They are the same word: a month is a **moon**, one turn of it. English does this too — *moon* and *month* — and neither language got the idea from the other, because both inherited it.

The plural is *die Monate*, “the months,” and it is the form the chapter title uses.

Why it's said this way

Here is the shape of the next two chapters, in one sentence.

The **unit** is German's own, inherited, older than any calendar: a moon. The **names** for the twelve are borrowed whole from Rome, along with the calendar that ordered them.

You met that division in the numbers chapter, where the counting words stayed home and the month names came in. This is where you meet the month names.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the pair — “der Mond, der Monat”
- the English pair — “moon, month”
- singular and plural — “der Monat, die Monate”

Twice through: “der Mond, der Monat.”

Before you move on

Say “the month.” (**Der Monat.**) What German word is hiding in it? (**Mond**, the moon.) Is *Monat* borrowed? (**No** — it is inherited.) And the twelve names about to arrive? (**Latin**, all of them.) Next: the first one.

13.2 der Januar — “January”

The first of the twelve borrowed names, and it is a doorway.

You'll want to know: der Januar

der Januar — “January.”

Latin *Januarius*, the month of **Janus** — the Roman god of doors, gateways and beginnings, shown with two faces because a doorway looks both ways at once.

A first month is exactly that: the year behind you and the year ahead, seen from the same spot.

Sounds you'll need

- **j-as-y** — German *j* is English *y*. *Januar* begins **ya-**, not **ja-**.
- **vowel-a-long** — and the *a* that follows is long and open.

YA-nu-ar, with the weight on the first syllable.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “der Januar” — YA-nu-ar
- the god in it — “Janus”
- what a first month is — “a door that looks both ways”

Twice through: “der Januar.”

Before you move on

Say “January.” (**Der Januar.**) How does the *j* sound? (**Like an English *y*.**) Which god? (**Janus**, of doorways.) Why two faces? (**A doorway looks both ways.**) Next: a month named for a washing.

13.3 der Februar — “February”

The second month, and the odd one out among the twelve.

You'll want to know: der Februar

der Februar — “February.”

Latin *Februarius*, from the ***Februa*** — a purification festival the Romans held at that point in the year, a washing-clean before the new season.

Every other month you will meet is named for a **god**, an **emperor**, or a **number**. This one is named for something people *did*.

Sounds you'll need

- **vowel-e-german** — the *e* of *Fe-* is a clear short *e*, not the English *feb*'s flat vowel.
- **r-final** — and the ending is the same soft closing *r* you met on *Uhr*.

FAY-bru-ar, four beats, weight on the first.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “der Februar” — *FAY-bru-ar*
- the first two in order — “Januar, Februar”
- what it is named for — “a washing-clean”

Twice through: “Januar, Februar.”

Before you move on

Say “February.” (**Der Februar.**) Is it named for a god? (**No** — for a **festival**, the *Februa*.) Say the first two months together. (**Januar, Februar.**) Next: a god you have already met, arriving a second time.

13.4 der März — “March”

You already know something about this month from the numbers chapter, though not its name.

You'll want to know: der März

der März — “March.”

Latin *Martius*, the month of **Mars**, the war-god. Campaigning weather began here, and so did the Roman year.

That second fact is the one you have already been given: the Roman year opened here. Four of the twelve names still count from this month, and you will meet them in the next chapter.

Sounds you'll need

- **vowel-ae** — *ä* is a bright open *e*, close to English *bed*. Not the *ar* of English *March*.
- **tz-affricate** — and *-rz* ends on a **ts**, so the word closes *merts*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “der März” — merts
- the god — “Mars”
- three in order — “Januar, Februar, März”

Twice through: “der März.”

Before you move on

Say “March.” (**Der März.**) How does *-rz* end? (**On a ts.**) Which god? (**Mars.**) Where did the Roman year begin? (**Here, in March.**) Next: the same god, under a name you already own.

13.5 März and Dienstag

Two German words you now own. They come from the same god, and neither of them looks like the other.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Mars entered German **twice**, and by two different routes.

the route	what German got	result
his name , borrowed whole	Latin <i>Martius</i>	<i>März</i>
his job , given to Tiw	Germanic <i>Tiwaz</i>	<i>Dienstag</i>

When the Romans met the Germanic gods, they matched them up by what they did: the war-god here answers the war-god there. Tuesday was Mars’s day, so it became Tiw’s day, and it still is — in German *Dienstag*, in English **Tuesday**.

The month got no such treatment. Nobody translated *Martius*; German took it as it stood.

Why it's said this way

The difference is worth holding onto, because it is the whole chapter in one example.

The **week** was a thing Germanic speakers already had, so when the Roman scheme arrived they mapped it onto their own gods and kept their own words. The **calendar of twelve months** was not; it came in as an administrative object, name-plates and all, and German took the name-plates.

Same god, same century, two outcomes — decided by whether German already had something to put in the slot.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the pair — “März, Dienstag”
- what each did with the god — “took his name; took his job”
- the reason — “German had a week already; it had no twelve months”

Twice through: “März and Dienstag — one god, two doors.”

Before you move on

Which two German words carry Mars? (***März** and **Dienstag***.) Which took his name? (***März***.) Which took his job? (***Dienstag***, through **Tiw**.) Why did the week get translated and the calendar not? (***German already had a week***.) Next: a month that may be named for an opening.

13.6 der April — “April”

Three months in and every name has had an owner. This one does not.

You'll want to know: der April

der April — “April.”

Latin *Aprilis*. Where that came from is genuinely unsettled — the Romans of the classical period were already guessing. The oldest and best guess is *aperire*, “to open,” for the month when things do.

Say it aloud and notice where the weight sits: German puts it on the **second** syllable, *a-PRIL*, where English puts it on the first.

Sounds you'll need

- **r-uvular** — the *r* in *-pril* is made at the back of the throat, closer to a soft scrape than an English roll.
- **i-short** — and the *i* is short and bright: *pril*, not *preel*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “der April” — a-PRIL, weight at the back
- the guess — “aperire, to open”
- four in order — “Januar, Februar, März, April”

Twice through: “der April.”

Before you move on

Say “April.” (**Der April**.) Which syllable carries the weight? (**The second** — a-PRIL.) Who is it named for? (**Nobody knows** — perhaps *aperire*, “to open”.) Next: a goddess of growing things.

13.7 der Mai — “May”

One syllable, and its vowel is one you were given for a number.

You'll want to know: der Mai

der Mai — “May.”

Latin *Maius*, the month of **Maia** — a goddess of growth and increase, which is a reasonable thing to call the month when everything is putting on size.

Sounds you'll need

- **ai-as-eye** — *ai* is the vowel of English **eye**.

You already have that vowel under its commoner German spelling, *ei*, from the numbers. German writes the same sound two ways, and *Mai* is the rarer one: *ei* and *ai* both say **eye**. So *Mai* rhymes with English *my*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “der Mai” — rhymes with “my”
- the goddess — “Maia, of growing things”
- five in order — “Januar, Februar, März, April, Mai”

Twice through: “der Mai.”

Before you move on

Say “May.” (**Der Mai.**) What does *ai* sound like? (**English eye.**) Which other spelling gives that sound? (**Ei.**) Which goddess? (**Maia.**) Next: the queen of the gods.

13.8 der Juni — “June”

Its first letter behaves exactly as the first month's did.

You'll want to know: der Juni

der Juni — “June.”

Latin *Junius*, the month of **Juno** — Jupiter's queen, and the goddess Romans married under, which is why June weddings are a Roman habit that never stopped.

Sounds you'll need

- **j-as-y** — the same *j* as *Januar*: English *y*. *YOO-ni*, never *joon*.
- **ie-long-ee** — and the final *i* is a long *ee*.

Spoken German often lengthens this one to *Juno* when a date has to be clear over the phone, because the month after it sounds far too close. That is a real habit, not something you have to learn now.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “der Juni” — YOO-nee
- the goddess — “Juno”
- six in order — “Januar, Februar, März, April, Mai, Juni”

Twice through: “der Juni.”

Before you move on

Say “June.” (**Der Juni.**) How does the *j* sound? (**Like English y.**) Which other month opens the same way? (**Januar.**) Which goddess? (**Juno.**) Next: all six, said through.

13.9 Practice — half a Roman year

No new words. Six names and the container they sit in.

Grammar Lens: what German owns and what it bought

what	German	where from
the unit	<i>der Monat</i>	inherited — it is <i>der Mond</i>
the names	<i>Januar ... Juni</i>	Latin, taken whole

One line, and it is the chapter. German had a moon and needed no help naming the span. It had no twelve-month calendar, so when one arrived it took the labels that came with it.

Why it's said this way

Notice what the six names are *for*, because they are not one kind of thing:

Januar — a god, **Janus** of doorways. **Februar** — not a god at all, but a **festival**, the *Februa*. **März** — a god, **Mars**, who is also in *Dienstag* under another name. **April** — unknown, and unknown already in Rome. **Mai** — a goddess, **Maia** of growth. **Juni** — a goddess, **Juno**, queen of the gods.

Four deities, one ritual, one shrug. A calendar is not a designed object; it is a pile of things people happened to call months, kept because nobody stopped.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- all six in order — “Januar, Februar, März, April, Mai, Juni”
- the two that begin with an English y — “Januar, Juni”
- the one that ends on a ts — “März”
- the unit and its cousin — “der Monat, der Mond”

Twice through: “Januar, Februar, März, April, Mai, Juni.”

Before you move on

Say the first six months. (**Januar, Februar, März, April, Mai, Juni.**) Which word for the span is German's own? (**Der Monat**, from *Mond*.) Which month shares a god with *Dienstag*? (**März.**)

Which one is named for a festival? (***Februar***.) Which one nobody can explain? (***April***.)

Chapter 14

When the Calendar Stopped Naming

Modes: 🗣️ voice (7) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 7 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name the last six German months and say which of them are numbers rather than names.

Two months named for men who could order it – Julius Caesar, who rebuilt the calendar, and Augustus, who took the next one – and then the naming stops. September through Dezember are septem, octo, novem and decem, counted from Maerz where the Roman year began. German’s own seven, eight, nine and ten sound like none of them, and never had to.

14.1 der Juli — “July”

Six months named for gods, festivals and guesses. From here the calendar changes what it is doing.

You’ll want to know: der Juli

der Juli — “July.”

Latin *Julius*, and not a god: **Julius Caesar**. He rebuilt the Roman calendar into something that tracked the sun, and the month of his birth was renamed for him while he was alive to see it.

Juni and *Juli* differ by one letter and one sound. Take them slowly as a pair: YOO-nee, YOO-lee.

Sounds you'll need

- **j-as-y** — English *y* again, as in *Januar* and *Juni*.
- **ie-long-ee** — and a long *ee* at the end.

Because the two are so close, German speakers arranging a date will often say *Julei* for July, stretching it away from *Juni*. You will hear it; you do not have to say it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “der Juli” — YOO-lee
- the pair, slowly — “Juni, Juli”
- who it is — “Julius Caesar, not a god”

Twice through: “Juni, Juli.”

Before you move on

Say “July.” (**Der Juli.**) And “June”? (**Der Juni.**) Which one is a god? (***Juni* — *Juno.***) Which one is a man? (***Juli* — *Caesar.***)
Next: the man who took the hint.

14.2 der August — “August”

Caesar took a month. His heir noticed.

You'll want to know: der August

der August — “August.”

The emperor **Augustus**, Caesar’s adopted son, who had the next month renamed for himself. Two men in a row, side by side in the year, and then it stops: **no month after this one is named for anybody at all.**

The weight falls on the second syllable in German — *au-GUST* — where English puts it on the first.

Sounds you'll need

- **au-diphthong** — *au* is one gliding vowel, the *ow* of English *how*.
- **st-initial-scht** — the *st* here is **inside** the word, not at the start, so it stays a plain *st*. German's *sht* happens at the beginning of a word, and this is the contrast that shows you where the boundary is.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “der August” — au-GUST
- the two men, in order — “Juli, August”
- what happens next — “the naming stops”

Twice through: “Juli, August.”

Before you move on

Say “August.” (**Der August.**) Which syllable is stressed? (**The second** — au-GUST.) Who is it? (**The emperor Augustus.**) How many months are named for men? (**Two** — and they are next to each other.) Next: what the calendar does once it runs out of names.

14.3 der September — “September”

You have the Latin number for seven from a chapter about counting. Here it is again, wearing a month.

You'll want to know: der September

der September — “September.”

Latin *september*, from *septem* — **seven**. Count from *März*, where the Roman year started, and September lands seventh.

The year was later moved to start in January. The name was not moved with it, so a word meaning “seventh” now sits in the ninth slot, in German exactly as in English, and has done for two thousand years.

Sounds you’ll need

- **vowel-e-german** — three clear short *es*: *sep-TEM-ber*.
- **r-final** — closing on the soft *r*.

The stress is on the middle syllable, as in English.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “der September” — sep-TEM-ber
- the Latin number inside it — “septem, seven”
- the German seven beside it — “sieben”
- where the count starts — “März”

Twice through: “September — septem — sieben.”

Before you move on

Say “September.” (**Der September.**) What number is inside it? (**Septem** — **seven.**) Which position does it actually hold now? (**Ninth.**) Why the mismatch? (**The year used to start in März.**) What is German’s own seven? (**Sieben.**) Next: eight.

14.4 der Oktober — “October”

The same trick as September, one number along.

You’ll want to know: der Oktober

der Oktober — “October.”

Latin *october*, from **octo** — **eight**. Eighth from *März*, tenth on the calendar you use.

Notice the spelling. English writes *Oc*-, keeping the Latin *c*. German writes *Ok*-, because German spells that sound with a **k** and applies its own rule to a borrowed word. Same word, same origin, one letter of local habit.

Sounds you'll need

- **vowel-o-german** — a clean rounded *o*, held steady rather than gliding as English *oh* does.
- **r-final** — and the soft closing *r*.

ok-TOH-ber, weight in the middle.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “der Oktober” — ok-TOH-ber
- the Latin number — “octo, eight”
- the German eight — “acht”
- the pair so far — “September, Oktober”

Twice through: “Oktober — octo — acht.”

Before you move on

Say “October.” (**Der Oktober.**) Which letter does German use where English keeps a *c*? (**A k.**) What number is inside? (**Octo** — **eight.**) German’s own eight? (**Acht.**) Next: nine.

14.5 der November — “November”

Spelled exactly as in English. Said differently, on one letter.

You'll want to know: der November

der November — “November.”

Latin *november*, from **novem** — **nine**. Ninth from *März*, eleventh now.

German and English write this month with the same eleven letters. That is rarer than it looks, and it happens here because both took the word from Latin without touching it.

Sounds you'll need

- **v-as-f** — German *v* is an **f**. The month is *no-FEM-ber*.
- **r-final** — soft closing *r*, as on the two before it.

This is the one letter where the identical spelling stops being identical. A German reading *November* aloud produces something an English ear does not expect, and nothing about the page warns you.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “der November” — no-FEM-ber
- the Latin number — “novem, nine”
- the German nine — “neun”
- three in order — “September, Oktober, November”

Twice through: “November — no-FEM-ber.”

Before you move on

Say “November.” (**Der November** — no-FEM-ber.) How is German *v* said? (**As an f**.) What number is inside? (**Novem** — **nine**.) German’s own nine? (**Neun**.) Next: ten, and the end of the year.

14.6 der Dezember — “December”

The last month, and a letter whose sound you were given with a number.

You'll want to know: der Dezember

der Dezember — “December.”

Latin *december*, from **decem** — **ten**. Tenth from *März*, twelfth now, and the last of the four months that are nothing but numbers.

Where English writes *De-c-*, German writes *De-z-*.

Sounds you'll need

- **z-ts** — German *z* is **ts**, the sound you were given on *zehn*. So the month opens *de-TSEM-*, not *de-SEM-*.
- **r-final** — and it closes on the same soft *r* as the other three.

That is the whole difference between the German and English versions of one Latin word: *c* became *z*, because German already had a letter for that sound.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “der Dezember” — de-TSEM-ber
- the German ten, same opening sound — “zehn”
- the Latin number — “decem, ten”
- the four in order — “September, Oktober, November, Dezember”

Twice through: “Dezember — de-TSEM-ber.”

Before you move on

Say “December.” (**Der Dezember.**) How does German *z* sound? (**Ts.**) Which number gave you that? (**Zehn.**) What number is inside the month? (**Decem** — **ten.**) Next: the four of them together.

14.7 Practice — the second half of the year

No new words. Six names, of which four are not really names.

Grammar Lens: the four that count in Latin

the month	the Latin inside	German's own word
<i>September</i>	<i>septem</i>	<i>sieben</i>
<i>Oktober</i>	<i>octo</i>	<i>acht</i>
<i>November</i>	<i>novem</i>	<i>neun</i>
<i>Dezember</i>	<i>decem</i>	<i>zehn</i>

Read across each row and hear that nothing rhymes. German counts in one language and dates in another, and never reconciled the two — because there was never any occasion to.

Why it's said this way

The second half of the year is a record of a calendar running out of ideas.

Juli — *Julius Caesar*, who rebuilt the calendar and took a month.

August — *Augustus*, who took the next one. **September** to **Dezember** — *nobody at all. Seven, eight, nine, ten, counted from März, where the year used to begin.*

Two men who could order a month renamed did so, one after the other, and then the practice stopped. What was left was arithmetic, and the arithmetic stopped being true the moment the year moved to January — which nobody thought worth fixing, and so it stands.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- all six — “Juli, August, September, Oktober, November, Dezember”
- the two men — “Caesar, Augustus”
- each Latin number with its German twin — “septem, sieben; octo, acht; novem, neun; decem, zehn”
- the one that begins with a ts — “Dezember”
- the one whose v is an f — “November”

Twice through: “September, Oktober, November, Dezember.”

Before you move on

Say the last four months. (**September, Oktober, November, Dezember.**) What are they named for? (**Numbers — seven, eight, nine, ten.**) Counted from where? (**März.**) Which two are named for men? (**Juli and August.**) Do German's own numbers sound like the Latin ones inside the months? (**No — and they never had to.**)

Chapter 15

The Seasons Go Native

Modes: 🗣️ voice (11) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 11 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name the four German seasons and say which of them German built and which it inherited.

The months were bought; the year, the time and the seasons were not. Jahr is English year, Zeit is English tide, and Jahreszeit is the two of them stuck together – year-time – where English borrowed season from French. Frühling was built inside German out of früh, and Herbst is English harvest: one inherited word that English narrowed to the act of gathering before buying Latin autumn for the season German never stopped naming with it.

15.1 das Jahr — “the year”

Januar to Dezember. Twelve months. There is a word for the whole of that, and it is not from Latin.

You’ll want to know: das Jahr

das Jahr — “the year.”

Germanic *jēra*, the twin of English **year**.

Every one of the twelve names inside it was bought from Rome. The container was not, any more than *Monat* was. German bought the labels and kept the measurements.

Sounds you'll need

- **j-as-y** — the *j* is English *y*, as in *Januar* and *Juni*: *jaar*.
- **h-silent-lengthening** — the *h* is not pronounced. It **stretches** the *a* in front of it, which is the job that *h* does inside a German word.

So *Jahr* is two letters of sound and two letters of instruction. Written, it looks nothing like *year*; said, it is the same word.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “das Jahr” — *jaar*, long
- the English twin — “Jahr, year”
- what the *h* is doing — “stretching the *a*”

Twice through: “das Jahr.”

Before you move on

Say “the year.” (**Das Jahr**.) Is the *h* pronounced? (**No** — it lengthens the *a*.) What is its English twin? (**Year**.) Borrowed or inherited? (**Inherited** — like *Monat*, unlike every month name.) Next: the second half of a compound you are about to build.

15.2 die Zeit — “time”

You have a clock and you have an hour. This is the thing they measure.

You'll want to know: die Zeit

die Zeit — “time.”

Germanic, through and through, and the twin of an English word you would not guess: **tide**.

Tide once meant a stretch of time, and it still does in the leftovers — *Yuletide*, *eventide*, *in good time*. Then the sea took the word, and English had to borrow *time*’s job out to a different root. German never had that problem and kept *Zeit* for the whole idea.

Sounds you’ll need

- **z-ts** — German *z* is **ts**, as it was at the front of *Dezember*.
- **diphthong-ei** — and *ei* is the vowel of English **eye**.

Put them together: *tsite*, rhyming with English *sight*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “die Zeit” — tsite
- the English leftover — “Yuletide”
- the three together — “die Uhr, die Stunde, die Zeit”

Twice through: “die Zeit.”

Before you move on

Say “time.” (**Die Zeit**.) How does *z* sound? (**Ts**.) What is its English twin? (**Tide**.) Where does English still use it that way? (**Yuletide**.) Now hold *Jahr* and *Zeit* together — the next word is both of them.

15.3 die Jahreszeit — “season”

Year. Time. Put them together and say what you think it means before reading on.

You’ll want to know: die Jahreszeit

die Jahreszeit — “season,” and literally “**year-time**.”

Jahres- is *Jahr* with the linking *-es-* German puts between the halves of a compound, and *-zeit* is *Zeit*. Nothing is hidden. The plural is *die Jahreszeiten*, and it is the title of this chapter.

Why it's said this way

English does not do this. English has **season**, from French *saison*, from Latin *satio* — “the sowing.” A borrowed word, opaque unless somebody explains it, which is what the previous sentence had to do. German assembled its word out of two it already owned, and the result explains itself to anyone who has the halves. You had the halves two lessons ago.

That is the difference between the two halves of this chapter and the last one. The months arrived as labels. The year, the time and the seasons were already here, and German named them out of stock.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “die Jahreszeit”
- its two halves — “Jahr, Zeit”
- what it says — “year-time”
- the plural — “die Jahreszeiten”

Twice through: “Jahr, Zeit, Jahreszeit.”

Before you move on

Say “season.” (**Die Jahreszeit.**) What are its halves? (**Jahr and Zeit.**) What does it literally say? (**Year-time.**) Is English *season* built the same way? (**No** — it is borrowed from French.) Next: the first of the four.

15.4 früh — “early”

One small word first, because the first season is built out of it.

You'll want to know: früh

früh — “early.”

Not a noun and not capitalised: an adjective, and one you will meet constantly — *früh aufstehen*, to get up early.

Sounds you'll need

- **umlaut-ue** — *ü* is a sound English does not have. Say **ee**. Hold it. Now round your lips as if for **oo**, and do not let your tongue move. That is *ü*.
- **h-silent-lengthening** — and the *h* is silent again, stretching the vowel, as it did in *Jahr*.

fr-ü-h: one syllable, the middle held long.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the vowel alone — “ee, then round the lips”
- “früh”
- what the *h* is doing — “stretching, not sounding”
- it beside a word with the same trick — “Jahr, früh”

Twice through: “früh.”

Before you move on

Say “early.” (**Früh.**) How do you make *ü*? (**Say ee, then round the lips.**) Is the *h* sounded? (**No** — it lengthens.) Next: what German calls the early season.

15.5 der Frühling — “spring”

You have *früh*. Add three letters.

You'll want to know: der Frühling

der Frühling — “spring,” and literally “**the early one.**”

The ending **-ling** takes a quality and makes a thing that has it. *Früh* is early; a *Frühling* is the early one — the year's first *Jahreszeit*.

You will meet *-ling* again elsewhere, and it does the same job every time.

Sounds you'll need

- **umlaut-ue** — the same *ü* as in *früh*, unchanged by the ending.
- **ng-cluster** — and *-ling* ends on the *ng* of English *sing*, with no hard *g* after it.

Two syllables, and the weight sits on *früh*, the half that carries the meaning.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the small word — “früh”
- the season — “der Frühling”
- what it says — “the early one”
- it with its category — “der Frühling ist eine Jahreszeit”

Twice through: “früh, Frühling.”

Before you move on

Say “spring.” (**Der Frühling.**) What is it built from? (***Früh* plus *-ling*.**) What does *-ling* do? (**Makes “the one that is like that.”**) Borrowed or built? (**Built.**) Next: two seasons that need no explaining at all.

15.6 der Sommer — “summer”

After the built one, an inherited one. This is the easiest word in the chapter.

You'll want to know: der Sommer

der Sommer — “summer.”

One Germanic word, kept whole by both languages: *Sommer*, **summer**. The difference between them is the vowel letter and nothing else.

Words survive like this when nobody ever has a reason to replace them, and a hot season is one of those things every generation needs to talk about.

Sounds you'll need

- **vowel-o-german** — a short, rounded *o*, steadier than the English vowel.
- **r-final** — and the ending is the soft *r* you have on *Uhr* and *November*.

SOM-mer, weight on the first.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “der Sommer”
- the pair — “Sommer, summer”
- two seasons in order — “der Frühling, der Sommer”

Twice through: “der Frühling, der Sommer.”

Before you move on

Say “summer.” (**Der Sommer.**) Is it borrowed? (**No** — **inherited**, like English *summer*.) Say the first two seasons. (**Der Frühling, der Sommer.**) Next: the one with a surprise in it.

15.7 der Herbst — “autumn”

The third season, and the only one whose name you will not recognise at first hearing.

You'll want to know: der Herbst

der Herbst — “autumn,” or “fall.”

It is the **reaping** season: the stretch of the year when the crop comes in. That meaning is the whole of the word, and the next lesson is about where else you already have it.

Sounds you'll need

- **herz-short-e** — a short, open *e*, the vowel of English *bed*, with the German *r* colouring it from behind.
- **st-initial-scht** — the *-st* here is at the **end**, so it stays a plain *st*, exactly as it did inside *August*.

hairpst, one syllable, no vowel between the *b* and the *st*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “der Herbst” — one syllable
- what it means — “the reaping season”
- three in order — “der Frühling, der Sommer, der Herbst”

Twice through: “der Herbst.”

Before you move on

Say “autumn.” (**Der Herbst.**) How many syllables? (**One.**) What does the word mean underneath? (**The reaping season.**) Next: the English word that is the same word.

15.8 Herbst and harvest

Say *Herbst* once more and then say the English word **harvest**. Those are the same word.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Germanic *harbistaz*, “the reaping season,” went into both languages and then each did something different with it.

language	what it kept	what it did next
German	<i>Herbst</i> , the season	nothing — it was enough
English	<i>harvest</i> , the act	borrowed Latin <i>autumn</i> for the season

English narrowed the inherited word to the *gathering itself* — you harvest a field — and then found it had no word left for the time of year, so it took one from Latin. German never split the meaning and never needed the loan.

Why it’s said this way

This is the clearest example in the book of something worth knowing: two languages can inherit **the same word** and end up looking unrelated, without either of them doing anything strange.

Nobody replaced *harvest*. Its meaning drifted a little, a gap opened where the season used to be, and a Latin word was standing nearby. That is how most borrowing happens — not because a language lacks a word, but because one of its words moved.

And it is the last turn of this chapter’s argument. The months were bought outright. The seasons were not, and *Herbst* is the one place you can watch the English side buy what German kept.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the pair — “Herbst, harvest”
- what each language kept — “the season; the work”
- what English had to buy — “autumn, from Latin”

Twice through: “Herbst, harvest — one word, two jobs.”

Before you move on

What English word is *Herbst*? (**Harvest.**) What does English use it for now? (**The act of gathering.**) So what did English borrow, and from where? (**Autumn, from Latin.**) Did German need a loan? (**No.**) Next: the coldest one, and then a word most Germans never say.

15.9 der Winter — “winter”

The fourth season, spelled exactly as you would expect, and said exactly as you would not.

You’ll want to know: der Winter

der Winter — “winter.”

Same six letters as English, same inherited Germanic word, and like *Sommer* it was never worth replacing.

Sounds you’ll need

- **w-as-v** — German *w* is an English **v**. The season is *VIN-ter*.
- **i-short** — and the *i* is short and bright.

November had the mirror of this: a *v* that is said as an *f*. German’s *v* and *w* have swapped the jobs an English reader expects of them, and these two words put both halves of the swap on one page.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “der Winter” — VIN-ter
- the swap — “w is v, v is f”
- all four — “der Frühling, der Sommer, der Herbst, der Winter”

Twice through: “der Winter.”

Before you move on

Say “winter.” (**Der Winter** — VIN-ter.) How is German *w* said? (**As a v.**) And German *v*? (**As an f.**) How many *Jahreszeiten* have you now? (**Four.**) Next: a fifth name for a season you already have.

15.10 der Lenz — “spring,” the old word

German has a second word for spring. You will read it far more often than you will hear it.

You’ll want to know: der Lenz

der Lenz — “spring,” in poetry and in set phrases.

Frühling is the word you use. *Lenz* is the word that turns up in songs, in older writing, and in the odd fixed expression. Recognise it; reach for *Frühling*.

It is older than *Frühling*, and it is the twin of English **Lent** — which was the *spring* season before the Church attached a fast to it. Both go back to a root about the **lengthening** of the days, which is the one thing a northern spring reliably does.

Sounds you’ll need

- **z-ts** — the *z* is **ts**, as in *Zeit* and *Dezember*: *lents*.
- **herz-short-e** — with the short open *e* of *Herbst*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “der Lenz” — lents
- the everyday word beside it — “der Frühling”
- the English twin — “Lent”
- which one you use — “Frühling”

Twice through: “Frühling, Lenz.”

Before you move on

What does *Lenz* mean? (**Spring**.) Which word do you use in speech? (**Frühling**.) What is *Lenz*'s English twin? (**Lent**.) What did the root mean? (**The lengthening of the days**.) Next: the whole year, said through.

15.11 Practice — the four, and the seam

No new words. A year, a time, and the four things they make between them.

Grammar Lens: the four seasons

German	built from	English
<i>der Frühling</i>	<i>früh + -ling</i>	spring
<i>der Sommer</i>	inherited whole	summer
<i>der Herbst</i>	inherited whole	autumn
<i>der Winter</i>	inherited whole	winter

Three of the four are the plain twins of their English words. The fourth was built inside German out of a word you learned one lesson earlier. Not one of them was borrowed.

Why it's said this way

Hold the last three chapters together and the seam is exact.

The **months** came from Rome, all twelve, names and calendar together. The **year**, the **time**, and the **seasons** did not. *Jahr*, *Zeit*, *Jahreszeit*, and the four seasons are German's own, and *Frühling* was still being built out of German parts long after the month names had arrived.

Herbst is the sharpest place to see it, because there English went the other way: it kept the inherited word for the **work** and bought *autumn* for the **season**. Two languages, one starting word, opposite outcomes — and the German one is the one that needed no purchase.

And German kept a spare. *Lenz* is still there for spring, older than *Frühling*, unneeded and unretired.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- all four — “der Frühling, der Sommer, der Herbst, der Winter”
- the category — “die Jahreszeiten”
- the built one and its part — “Frühling, from früh”
- the compound and its halves — “Jahreszeit: Jahr, Zeit”
- the pair that split — “Herbst, harvest”

Twice through: “Frühling, Sommer, Herbst, Winter.”

Before you move on

Name the four seasons. (**Der Frühling, der Sommer, der Herbst, der Winter.**) Which one was built rather than inherited? (**Frühling**, from *früh*.) Which one is English *harvest*? (**Herbst.**) How many of the four did German borrow? (**None.**) And how many of the twelve month names? (**All of them.**)

Chapter 16

Family

Modes: ⇄ voice (2) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 2 lessons.

The months were Latin tourists. Family is the opposite story: German's words for father, mother, brother and sister were never borrowed — they are inherited, and they are blood cousins of the English ones. Along the way they put a famous sound-law on display.

16.1 *der Vater, die Mutter* — the pair that proves Grimm's law

Sounds you'll need

der Vater is said *FAH-ter*: note the spelling **V**, but it is pronounced **f**. **die Mutter** is said *MOO-ter*, with a short *u* as in English *put*.

Two words, with their articles:

German	English	from
<i>der Vater</i> (masculine)	father	PIE <i>*ph₂tér</i>
<i>die Mutter</i> (feminine)	mother	PIE <i>*méh₂tēr</i>

Grammar Lens

Grimm's law, on display. Grimm's law is the great sound-shift that split the **Germanic** languages (English, German, Dutch...) off from the rest of the family. Watch what it did to the *same* ancient words that Latin kept as *pater* and *māter*:

ph₂tér* → Latin *pater* (French *père*) vs. Germanic **father / **Vater**

méh₂tēr* → Latin *māter* (French *mère*) vs. Germanic **mother / **Mutter**

Etymology

p → **f**: Latin kept the *p* (*pater*); Germanic turned it into *f* — English **father**, German **V**ater (where the *V* is simply an old spelling of that *f* sound).

t → **th** → **d**: the middle consonant became English *th* (**mother**), and then, in German’s own later shift, *d/t* (**Mutter**).

Why it’s said this way

So German and English *agree* here — both start with *f*-, both with *m*- — precisely because they are **both Germanic**, while French and Latin sit on the other side of Grimm’s line. The month names were Latin tourists; *Vater* and *Mutter* are natives.

16.2 *der Bruder, die Schwester* — and the word for “siblings”

Sounds you’ll need

BROO-der; and **Schwester** is *SHVES*-ter — German *sch* spells an English *sh* sound, and the *w* that follows is said *v*, so *Schw*- = *shv*-.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

der Bruder (“brother”) ← PIE **b^hréh₂tēr* — the same root as Latin *frāter* (French *frère*), but here kept with a *b*- (Grimm’s law changed *b^h* → *b*), exactly like English **brother**.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

die Schwester (“sister”) ← PIE **swésōr*. The German *sch* spells an *sh* sound; strip it back and *Schwester* is English **sister** and Latin **soror** — all one root.

Morphology Spotlight

The collective — *die Geschwister*. German has a tidy word English lacks: **die Geschwister** = “**siblings**,” brothers-and-sisters together. It is built with the **ge-** prefix, an old **collective** marker (“a set of...”) attached to *Schwester* — the same *ge-* that bundles mountains into a **das Gebirge** (“a mountain range”), and that lets German gather a whole family into one word.

The four family words now stand as a Germanic set beside the Romance ones:

German	English	Romance
<i>Vater / Mutter</i>	father / mother	<i>père / mère</i>
<i>Bruder / Schwester</i>	brother / sister	<i>frère / sœur</i>

Why it's said this way

Why do these match English so closely? Because both languages are **Germanic**, drawing on the same ancient roots with no Grimm's-law gap between them. Months were *borrowed* from Latin; family is *inherited* Germanic.

Chapter 17

Bread, Water, Wine

Modes: ⇄ voice (2) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 2 lessons.

Three words from the table, and three different histories. Two of them German speakers have always had; one of them Rome carried north together with the plant it came from. On the way, the last of German's three genders finally appears.

17.1 *das Brot* — bread, and the third gender

Sounds you'll need

broht, with a long *o* as in English *boat*; the German *r* is made far back, in the throat.

Where the Romance sisters all say a version of Latin *pānis* (French *pain*, Italian *pane*), German goes its **own Germanic way**: *Brot*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

das Brot (“bread”) ← old Germanic **braudam* — the same word that became English **bread**. No Latin here: this is a **native** word, like *Vater* and *Wasser*, out of the Germanic core the two languages share.

Grammar Lens

The third gender — *das*. You have met **der** (masculine, *der Vater*) and **die** (feminine, *die Mutter*). German has a **third**: **das**, the **neuter** — and *Brot* is one of its nouns: **das Brot**. So the article set is now complete: **der / die / das**.

Why it's said this way

German nouns are also always **Capitalized** — *Brot*, *Vater*, *Wasser* — a rule no other language in this book follows.

17.2 *das Wasser, der Wein* — one word

Germans always had, one Rome brought

Two drinks, two very different histories. *Wasser* is a word Germanic speakers have **always had**; *Wein* is one Rome **carried north** with the grapevine. Side by side, they show the difference between an *inherited* word and an ancient *loan*.

Sounds you'll need

In German the letter **w** is pronounced **v**: *Wasser* = VAH-ser, *Wein* = vine. And **ei** is always said like English *eye*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

das Wasser (“water”) — the Grimm’s-law twin of English **water**: the same Germanic root **watar*, the same core meaning, both native. Like *Brot* and *Vater*, no Latin needed — and neuter, **das Wasser**.

Etymology

der Wein (“wine”) — here is the twist: *Wein* is **not** a native Germanic word. It was **borrowed from Latin *vīnum*** in Roman times, when the legions brought **viticulture** north of the Alps. The Germanic tribes took the drink *and its name* — which is exactly why English **wine**, German **Wein**, and Latin *vīnum* all match: they are one **loan**, not three cousins. (Masculine: *der Wein*.)

Why it's said this way

The lesson in one line: *Wasser* is a word Germans **always had**; *Wein* is a word Rome **gave** them — the vine came with a vocabulary.

German	English	history
<i>das Brot</i>	bread	inherited Germanic (<i>*braudam</i>)
<i>das Wasser</i>	water	inherited Germanic (<i>*watar</i>)
<i>der Wein</i>	wine	borrowed from Latin <i>vīnum</i>

Chapter 18

Numbers Eleven to Twenty

Modes: ⇐ voice (1) 👁 eyes (1) ⇐ Hands-free start: first 1 of 2 lessons.

Why are English *eleven* and *twelve* so strange? Why not “oneteen, twoteen”? German has the same oddity. Because the two languages are Germanic twins, learning one *explains* the other. At thirteen, both settle into a rule that never breaks.

18.1 *elf* und *zwölf* — “one left over,” “two left over”

Sounds you’ll need

elf is said as it looks. *zwölf* begins *tsv*- (German *z* = *ts*, *w* = *v*) and carries the rounded *ö*: shape your lips for *oh* and say *eh*.

Morphology Spotlight

elf (11) ← old Germanic *ainlif* = *ain* (“one”) + *lif*.

zwölf (12) ← *twalif* = *twa* (“two”) + *lif*.

And **-lif** means “**to leave, to remain**.” So *elf* = “**one left over**” and *zwölf* = “**two left over**.”

Left over from **what**? From **ten** — from your ten fingers. You count to ten, you run out of fingers, and you have **one left**. Eleven is literally the leftover.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

English says exactly the same thing: *eleven* ← *ain-lif*, *twelve* ← *twa-lif*. Not similar words — *the same words*, inherited side by side. The Germanic-twin pattern that turned up in *Vater/father* and *Wasser/water* reaches even the counting.

Grammar Lens

And then it stops. The leftover-trick covers only **two** numbers. From **13** on, German turns completely regular — and so does English.

18.2 *dreizehn* → *zwanzig* — the pattern that never breaks

After the two leftovers, German settles into a rule so regular you can generate every number without being taught it: **digit** + **zehn**. And English does the identical thing — because *-teen* **is** *ten*.

	German	English	build
13	<i>dreizehn</i>	thirteen	<i>drei</i> + <i>zehn</i>
14	<i>vierzehn</i>	fourteen	<i>vier</i> + <i>zehn</i>
15	<i>fünfzehn</i>	fifteen	<i>fünf</i> + <i>zehn</i>
16	<i>sechzehn</i>	sixteen	<i>sechs</i> + <i>zehn</i> (the <i>s</i> drops)
17	<i>siebzehn</i>	seventeen	<i>sieben</i> + <i>zehn</i> (shortened)
18	<i>achtzehn</i>	eighteen	<i>acht</i> + <i>zehn</i>
19	<i>neunzehn</i>	nineteen	<i>neun</i> + <i>zehn</i>
20	<i>zwanzig</i>	twenty	← <i>twaintig</i> , “two tens”

Sounds you’ll need

The *z* of *zehn* and *zwanzig* is *ts*: *TSAYN*, *TSVAHN-tsikh*. The final *-ig* of *zwanzig* is normally said like the soft *ich*-sound, *-ikh*.

Every one of them is a digit + *zehn* — and the English column is the same compound with *-teen*, which is just **ten** again (*thir-teen* = “three-ten”). Only two small wearings-down: *sech(s)zehn* and *sieb(en)zehn* clip a sound for easier speech, exactly as English *thir-* and *fif-* did to *three* and *five*.

Morphology Spotlight

zwanzig (20) ← *twaintig*, “**two tens**” — the *-zig* is another worn-down form of *ten*, matching English *twen-ty*, whose *-ty* is *ten* as well.

Why it’s said this way

The contrast worth noticing. The Romance sisters all **break** their pattern partway through the teens — Portuguese at 16, French and Italian at 17, swapping over to a “ten-and-six” style. **German never breaks.** Two leftovers, then one clean rule all the way to twenty — and English marches beside it the entire distance.

Chapter 19

Colours

Modes: ⇄ voice (2) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 2 lessons.

Four colours — *schwarz*, *weiß*, *rot*, *blau* — and a small surprise inside them. German’s colour words are all home-grown Germanic, with no Latin borrowed in; and two of them travelled the other way, out of Germanic and into the Romance languages.

19.1 *schwarz*, *weiß* — black and white, and the word German lent away

German’s colour words are **home-grown** — no Latin here. But one of them has a sibling that emigrated: a German word for “shining” became the word for **white** in French, Italian and Portuguese.

Sounds you’ll need

schwarz = *SHVARTS*: the *schw*- cluster is “sh” + “v,” and the final *z* is always “ts.”

weiß = *vice*: German *w* is English “v,” *ei* is the vowel of English *eye*, and the *ß* (*Eszett*) is a sharp “ss.”

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

schwarz (“black”) ← Proto-Germanic **swartaz*. Its English cousin survives in **swarthy** (“dark-complexioned”). Further back it is related to Latin *sordēs* (“dirt”) — the root of English **sordid**. Black and grubby, from one idea.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

weiß (“white”) ← Proto-Germanic **hwītaz* — *exactly* English **white**.
The same word in different spelling clothes.

Sounds you’ll need

The ß (*Eszett*) marks a sharp *s* after a long vowel. So *weiß* rhymes with English *vice*, not with the second half of *vice-versa*. In Switzerland you will see it written **weiss** — the letter is optional there.

The word that emigrated

German also has **blank** — “shiny, polished, bare.” That word, in its Frankish form *blank* (“shining”), was **borrowed into Romance**, where it pushed Latin’s own *albus* out and became:

Language	“white”
French	blanc
Italian	bianco
Portuguese	branco
German	<i>blank</i> — still just “ shiny ”

Why it’s said this way

This is the **reverse** of the usual flow. Latin normally lends *to* Germanic (*Fenster* ← *fenestra*, *Wein* ← *vīnum*). Here Germanic lent *to* Latin’s daughters — and German kept the original meaning while they turned it into a colour.

Practise them on something you can already name: *der Wein ist weiß* (“the wine is white”), and *weiß* · *white* said side by side, so you can hear that it is one word.

19.2 *rot, blau* — an ancient cousin and a second emigrant

Two more native German colours. One is related to the French word for red — genuinely, not by borrowing. The other is a **second** German word the Romance languages took.

Sounds you'll need

rot = *roht*, with a long “o” as in English *road*.

blau = *blow* (rhyming with *cow*): German *au* is the vowel of English *house*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

rot ← Proto-Germanic **raudaz* ← Proto-Indo-European **h₁rewdʰ-*. That root is one of the oldest colour words we can reconstruct, and it went everywhere:

Language	Word
German	rot
English	red , <i>rust</i> , <i>ruddy</i>
Latin	<i>ruber</i> , <i>rubeus</i> → French rouge , <i>ruby</i> , <i>rubric</i>

So *rot* and *rouge* are **cousins**, not borrowings — they split apart thousands of years before either language existed. Red is the colour humans name first, after black and white.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

blau ← Proto-Germanic **blēwaz*. Like *blank* in the last lesson, this word was **borrowed into Romance**.

Language	“blue”
German	blau
French	bleu
Italian	blu
English	blue — taken from French , not from German

Why it's said this way

English is the odd one here: it had Germanic *blāw* available but borrowed the French form instead. The word went Germanic → French → English, coming home in disguise. Portuguese went a different way entirely — its blue is **azul**, from **Arabic**.

The chapter in one table

German	Source	Did Romance borrow it?
<i>schwarz</i>	Germanic <i>*swartaz</i>	no
<i>weiß</i>	Germanic <i>*hwītaz</i>	no — but <i>blank</i> went instead
<i>rot</i>	Germanic <i>*raudaz</i>	no — Latin had its own cousin
<i>blau</i>	Germanic <i>*blēwaz</i>	yes — <i>bleu</i> , <i>blu</i>

Say all four together — *schwarz*, *weiß*, *rot*, *blau* — and then the cousins that prove the family: *rot* · *red* · *rouge*. Next chapter: putting these onto the things you already name.

Chapter 20

To Have

Modes:  voice (8)  Hands-free start: all 8 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can use every present form of German’s verb for “to have”, building the four the ending machine already gives me and knowing the two it gets wrong.

haben is the weak ending machine on the stem hab-, and the chapter is organised around where that machine fails: it predicts four of the six forms correctly, so those get one lesson that makes the reader build them rather than read them, and du hast and er hat get a lesson each because nothing generates them. The b-drop, the einen that Ich habe einen Bruder needs, and the habere false cognate follow; the grid is printed only in the practice lesson.

20.1 haben — “to have”

German’s workhorse verb, and the twin of a word you have said every day of your life.

You’ll want to know: haben

haben — “to have.”

Same word as English *have*, worn differently. Chop the *-en* the way you did with *machen* and the stem is *hab-*, which is where every form in this chapter starts.

Two syllables, and the first one carries the weight: *HAH-ben*.

Sounds you'll need

- **long-a** — the *a* of *haben* is long and open, the vowel of English *father*, not the clipped *a* of *hat*.
- **d-t-final** — that long *a* does **not** survive into every form. Two of them coming up are short and clipped, and both end in a crisp, fully released *t*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “haben” — long *a*, soft second syllable
- the stem on its own — “hab-”
- the twins — “haben, have”

Twice through: “haben, haben — to have.”

Before you move on

Say “to have.” (**Haben.**) What is its stem? (**Hab-**) Is the *a* long or short? (**Long** — as in *father*.) Which English verb is it? (**Have.**) Next: the stem through the ending machine you already own.

20.2 hab- through the machine

You own an ending machine: a stem, and *-e*, *-st*, *-t*, *-en*. Run *hab-* through it before reading on, and keep what you get.

Grammar Lens: four forms you already knew

On *hab-*, the machine is **right four times out of six**.

Ich takes *-e*, so *ich habe*. *Wir* takes *-en*, so *wir haben* — which is the infinitive over again, the way the *wir* form goes throughout German. *Ihr* takes *-t*, so *ihr habt*. And *sie* takes *-en* like *wir*, so *sie haben*. Nothing there is new. Those four are the rule from your first verbs applied to one more stem — so do not read them off the page. Take each ending, put it on *hab-*, and hear that you already knew the answer.

The chapter is about the other two.

Your turn

Build each one before you say it — take the ending first, then put it on *hab-*.

Say these aloud:

- the ending *ich* takes, then the form — “-e ... ich habe”
- the ending *wir* takes, then the form — “-en ... wir haben”
- the ending *ihr* takes, then the form — “-t ... ihr habt”
- *sie* borrows *wir*’s ending — “sie haben”
- now prove the machine is not about this verb — run *wohn-* through it: “ich wohne, wir wohnen, ihr wohnt”

Twice through: “ich habe, wir haben, ihr habt, sie haben.”

Before you move on

Build “we have” without being given it. (**Wir haben.**) Build “you all have.” (**Ihr habt.**) Which other form does *wir haben* match? (**The infinitive.**) Did you have to learn any of those four, or work them out? (**Work them out** — the endings were already yours.) How many of the six does the rule get right? (**Four.**) Next: the first one it gets wrong.

20.3 du hast — “you have”

The machine says *du* plus *-st* on the stem *hab-*. Say what that would give, and then hear what German actually says.

You’ll want to know: du hast

du hast — “you have,” to one person you are on familiar terms with.

The rule predicts *hab-st*. German says **hast**. The *b* is simply gone, and the long *a* goes with it: the vowel is short and clipped now, and the *-st* lands crisply on the end.

This is not a spelling convenience. It is one of exactly two places in the whole verb where the machine fails, and it is worth meeting on its own so that it is a form you know rather than a form you derive wrongly.

Sounds you'll need

- **vowel-a** — short and clipped, the *a* of English *hat*, not the long *a* of *haben*. The form is one syllable: *hast*, rhyming with English *mast*.
- **d-t-final** — the *-st* is fully released; German does not soften it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “du hast”
- the long against the short — “ich habe, du hast”
- what the rule wanted, then what German says — “hab-st ... hast”

Twice through: “du hast, du hast.”

Before you move on

Say “you have,” informally. (**Du hast.**) Which letter went missing? (**The b.**) What happened to the vowel? (**It shortened.**) What would the rule have predicted? (**Hab-st.**) Next: the second place the machine fails, and it fails the same way.

20.4 er hat — “he has”

One more break, and then the verb behaves for good. The machine says *-t* on *hab-*.

You'll want to know: er hat

er hat — “he has.” Also *sie hat*, “she has,” and *es hat*, “it has.”

The rule predicts *hab-t*. German says **hat**: the same *b* gone, the same vowel shortened. One syllable, rhyming with English *hut* rather than *hat* — the German *a* sits further back than the English one.

One form covers *er*, *sie* and *es*, exactly as the third-person *-t* always does. So the two breaks in this verb are neighbours: *du hast*, *er hat*, and every other form is the machine.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “er hat, sie hat, es hat”
- the two breaks together — “du hast, er hat”
- the whole shape — “habe ... hast ... hat ... haben”

Twice through: “du hast, er hat.”

Before you move on

Say “he has.” (**Er hat.**) Say “she has.” (**Sie hat.**) Which two forms of this verb break the rule? (**Hast and hat.**) What do both of them drop? (**The b.**) Next: why they drop it, and the English verb that does the identical thing.

20.5 The b that fell out

Hast and *hat* both lost a *b*. That is not two accidents.

Grammar Lens: one shortcut, in exactly two cells

Haben keeps its **b** everywhere except before a *-st* or a *-t* ending, where the *b* drops and the vowel shortens with it.

Say *hab-st* and *hab-t* at speed and you can feel why: a *b* squeezed between a vowel and a hard *t* is work, and centuries of speakers declined to do it. The consonant wore away and the two shortest forms are what is left.

Now listen to English, which is the same verb:

person	English	German
infinitive	<i>have</i>	<i>haben</i>
second person, older	<i>thou hast</i>	<i>du hast</i>
third person	<i>he has</i>	<i>er hat</i>

English lost the same consonant, in the same two cells, of the same verb — and kept the archaic *hast* long enough for us to see it. Two languages, one shortcut, inherited together rather than invented twice.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- where the *b* survives — “habe, haben, habt”
- where it does not — “hast, hat”
- the English echo — “thou hast, du hast; he has, er hat”

Twice through: “hast, hat — no *b*.”

Before you move on

In which two forms does the *b* drop? (***Hast* and *hat***.) What else changes with it? (**The vowel shortens.**) Which English form still shows the same loss? (***He has*** — or archaic ***thou hast***.) Next: something to actually have.

20.6 *einen* — “a,” when it is the thing you have

Ich habe ... wants something after it. The commonest thing to put there is “a something,” and German asks one small question first.

You’ll want to know: *einen*

einen — “a,” for a **der**-word that is the thing you have.

Ein is the number *one* doing a second job, which is exactly what English *a* is — a worn-down *one*. German keeps the resemblance visible: *ein*, *eins*.

The *-en* on the end is the part English threw away. German marks a *der*-word differently when it is the thing being had rather than the thing doing the having, and *einen* is that marked form:

Ich habe einen Bruder. — “I have a brother.”

Der Bruder is a *der*-word, and he is what you have, so *ein* becomes *einen*. Nothing else in the sentence moves.

Take this one as a word for now, not as a system. The system behind it — German’s cases — gets a chapter of its own later; this is the first place the book cannot avoid it, because a sentence with *haben* in it needs something to have.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “einen”
- “Ich habe einen Bruder.”
- it with the two broken forms — “du hast einen Bruder; er hat einen Bruder”

Twice through: “Ich habe einen Bruder.”

Before you move on

Say “I have a brother.” (**Ich habe einen Bruder.**) Which word did *ein* become? (**Einen.**) Why? (**Because *der Bruder* is the thing being had.**) Which English word is *ein* underneath? (**One.**) Next: the trap this verb is famous for.

20.7 haben is not habēre

German *haben*, Latin *habēre*. Same consonants, same meaning, and the best false cognate in the business.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Two verbs that look like one word:

language	verb	meaning
German	haben	to have
Latin	habēre	to have

They are not related. It is a coincidence, and one of the most famous in linguistics. Follow each one back and they go in opposite directions.

Haben comes from Germanic **habjaną*, from Proto-Indo-European **kap-*, “**to seize**.” That root’s Latin child is *capere* — which is where English gets **capture**, **captive**, **capable** and **accept**.

Habēre comes from a different root entirely, **g^hab^h-*, and its English descendant is ... **give**.

So German *haben* is a cousin of *capture*, and Latin *habēre* — the source of French *avoir* and Italian *avere* — is a cousin of *give*. Seizing and giving, which is about as far apart as two verbs get.

Why it’s said this way

This is worth carrying beyond one verb. Resemblance is not evidence. Two words can match in sound and sense and still have nothing to do with each other, and the only way to tell is to follow both back rather than to compare them where they stand.

Most of this book’s cousin pairs are real. This one is the control that proves the others were checked.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the pair that is not a pair — “haben, habēre”
- where German’s goes — “haben, kap-, capture”
- where Latin’s goes — “habēre, g^hab^h-, give”

Twice through: “haben is not habēre.”

Before you move on

Are *haben* and *habēre* related? (**No** — a coincidence.) Which English word is *haben*’s cousin? (**Capture**, from *capere*.) And *habēre*’s? (**Give**.) What did *haben*’s root originally mean? (“**To seize**.”) Next: the whole verb, said through.

20.8 Practice — the whole of haben

No new words. Four of the six forms below cost you nothing, and the other two have each had a lesson, so this is the first place

it is safe to set them out together.

Grammar Lens: the six, assembled

singular

ich **habe**

du **hast**

er/sie/es **hat**

plural

wir **haben**

ihr **habt**

sie/Sie **haben**

Run it aloud and hear where the *b* goes missing: *habe ... hast ... hat ... haben*. Four forms carry it, two do not, and the two that do not are the two shortest.

The exchange

German	English
<i>Hast du einen Bruder?</i>	Do you have a brother?
<i>Und du?</i>	And you?
<i>Ich habe eine Schwester.</i>	I have a sister.
<i>Wir haben Brot und Wein.</i>	We have bread and wine.
<i>Gut! Dann haben wir alles.</i>	Good! Then we have everything.

Two things slip in without lessons of their own, because the translation carries them: **eine**, which is what *ein* becomes for a *die*-word, and **alles** (“everything”). And notice *Hast du ...?* — a question puts the verb first, which is the one move German makes that English needs *do* for.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the six in order — “habe, hast, hat, haben, habt, haben”
- the two breaks alone — “hast, hat”
- “Ich habe einen Bruder.” “Wir haben Brot und Wein.”
- the whole exchange, both voices

Twice through: “habe, hast, hat, haben, habt, haben.”

Before you move on

Run the six without looking. Which two drop the *b*? (***Hast* and *hat***.) Say “I have a brother.” (***Ich habe einen Bruder***.) Is *haben* related to Latin *habēre*? (**No.**) Which English word is it related to? (***Capture***.) Next: the one everyday sentence where German refuses this verb altogether.

Chapter 21

The Wrapped Participle

Modes: ⇄ voice (8) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 8 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can turn any regular German verb I know into its past participle, and hear that the marking arrives at both ends of the word at once.

The weak participle is a circumfix, so it is met as one concrete word first — gesagt — and only then as the recipe behind it. Three more verbs run through that recipe one at a time, the ge- gets its own lesson because it is the half English threw away, and the infinitive-to-participle table appears only at the end, where it recaps six lessons instead of introducing four words.

21.1 sagen — “to say”

One more weak verb before the past tense starts, and it is the verb the whole chapter will be built on.

You’ll want to know: sagen

sagen — “to say.”

Two syllables, *ZAH-gen*. It behaves like *machen* and *lernen* in every respect: chop the *-en* and you have the stem *sag-*, and onto that stem go the endings you already own — *ich sage*, *du sagst*.

Nothing new is happening in those endings. *Sagen* is here so that when the past tense arrives in the next lesson, the only unfamiliar thing in it is the past.

Sounds you'll need

- **long-a** — the *a* of *sagen* is long and open, the vowel of English *father*, not the clipped *a* of *hat*.
- **ge-prefix** — the *-gen* at the end is unstressed and swallowed, a soft *gn* more than a full syllable. The same mumble will open every participle in this chapter, so it is worth getting comfortable now.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Sagen and English *say* are the same word. Germanic **sagjaną* went to both, and then English quietly dropped the *g* out of the middle:

German	English
sagen	say
Tag	day
Weg	way

Three pairs, one habit. Whenever a German *g* sits between vowels or at the end of a short word, English is likely to have thinned it to a *y* sound — so a German *g* you cannot place is often an English *y* in disguise.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “sagen” — long *a*, soft ending
- “ich sage, du sagst, wir sagen”
- the three pairs — “sagen–say, Tag–day, Weg–way”

Twice through: “sagen, sagen — to say.”

Before you move on

Say “to say.” (**Sagen.**) Say “I say.” (**Ich sage.**) Is the *a* long or short? (**Long** — as in *father*.) Which English word is *sagen*? (**Say.**) Next: what happens to this verb when the saying is already over.

21.2 gesagt — “said”

You have *sagen*. Now the form German uses when the saying is already finished — and it is longer at **both** ends than the word it came from.

You’ll want to know: gesagt

gesagt — “said.”

Hear where it grew. *Sag-* is still sitting in the middle, untouched. In front of it a *ge-* has appeared; behind it the *-en* has gone and a *-t* has taken its place:

sagen — **ge-sag-t**

That is the word English calls a **past participle**: the form that goes with *have* in *I have said*. German’s has a hat on as well as boots.

Sounds you’ll need

- **ge-prefix** — unstressed, almost swallowed: *guh*, never *gay*. The stress stays on *sagt*, exactly where it was in *sagen*.
- **final-t** — the closing *t* is crisp and fully released. The *g* in front of it hardens to a *k* on the way out, the same hardening you met when *und* came out as *unt*: say *guh-ZAHKT*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “gesagt” — soft opening, hard ending
- the pair — “sagen, gesagt”
- the three pieces — “ge, sag, t”

Twice through: “sagen, gesagt. Sagen, gesagt.”

Before you move on

Say “said.” (**Gesagt.**) Which part of *sagen* survives inside it? (**Sag-**, the stem.) What appeared in front? (**Ge-**.) What replaced the *-en*? (**-t.**) Next: the same two additions, on any weak verb you like.

21.3 ge...-t — the wrap that makes a participle

Sagen, gesagt. One verb did that; the recipe behind it works on every regular verb you own.

Grammar Lens: ge- in front, -t behind

Take a regular verb. Strip the *-en*. Put **ge-** in front of what is left and **-t** on the end.

That is the whole operation for the regular verbs — the ones grammarians call **weak**, because they build their past out of endings rather than by changing the vowel inside.

The thing worth noticing is that the ending has a beginning. English marks its participle in one place: *walk* becomes *walk-ed*, and the front of the word sits untouched. German marks it in two, one piece of grammar arriving at both ends of the stem at once.

Grammar has a name for a piece that wraps like that: a **circumfix**. It is not a prefix plus a suffix that happen to co-occur — neither half means anything without the other. **Gesag* is not a word, and **sagt* on its own is “he says.” Only both together make “said.”

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the recipe — “ge in front, t behind”
- the wrap on its own — “ge ... t”
- “sagen, gesagt” and hear both ends move

Twice through: “ge- in front, -t behind.”

Before you move on

Which two pieces make a weak participle? (**Ge-** in front, **-t** behind.)
 What is a piece of grammar that wraps a word called? (A **circumfix**.) Where does English put its own participle marker? (**Only at the end** — *walked*.) Build the participle of *sagen*. (**Gesagt**.) Next: the same wrap on a verb you met long before this one.

21.4 gemacht — “made,” “done”

You know the recipe. Run it on *machen* before reading on: strip the *-en*, wrap what is left.

You’ll want to know: gemacht

gemacht — “made,” and also “done.”

Machen gives up its *-en*, leaving *mach-*. The wrap goes round it and out comes *gemacht*. No stem was harmed: the *a* is the same *a*, and the *ch* is the same *ch*.

German uses this one participle where English chooses between two different words. *Ich habe das gemacht* is “I made that” and “I did that” alike; German never had to pick.

Sounds you’ll need

- **ch-ach** — after *a*, *o* or *u*, German *ch* is the scrape at the back of the throat, the sound in *Bach* and in *Nacht*. It sits in the middle of *gemacht* untouched.
- **final-t** — and the *t* on the end is crisp: *guh-MAHKHT*, three consonants landing together at the finish.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “machen, gemacht”
- both participles together — “gesagt, gemacht”

- one word for two English ones — “made, done — gemacht”

Twice through: “machen, gemacht.”

Before you move on

Build the participle of *machen*. (**Gemacht**.) Which two English words does it cover? (**Made** and **done**.) What happened to the *ch* on the way? (**Nothing** — the wrap only touches the edges.) Next: the verb you have been doing to German itself.

21.5 gelernt — “learned”

Third time through the recipe, and this one describes what you have been doing since page one.

You’ll want to know: gelernt

gelernt — “learned.”

Lernen loses its *-en*, leaving *lern-*; the wrap closes round it. The English cousin is doing the very same job with the very same stem — *learn*, *learned* — and differs only in where the marking sits. German puts a piece at each end; English puts both pieces at the back.

Sounds you’ll need

- **r-uvular-german** — the *r* inside *gelernt* is made at the back of the mouth and, before a consonant, is barely a consonant at all: it colours the vowel more than it rolls. *Guh-LEHRNT*, with the *r* almost swallowed.
- **final-t** — *-nt* at the end, both consonants sounded, the *t* released.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “lernen, gelernt”
- the English twin — “learn, learned; lernen, gelernt”

- all three so far — “gesagt, gemacht, gelernt”

Twice through: “lernen, gelernt.”

Before you move on

Build the participle of *lernen*. (**Gelernt.**) Which English verb is its twin? (**Learn.**) Where does English put its marking? (**All of it at the end.**) Next: the fourth verb, and the last one before the recipe is yours.

21.6 gewohnt — “lived”

Fourth and last of the four. Run the recipe on *wohnen* yourself first.

You’ll want to know: gewohnt

gewohnt — “lived,” in the sense of dwelt somewhere.

Wohn- takes the wrap and nothing else changes. Four verbs, four participles, one recipe: it has not bent once.

Sounds you’ll need

- **w-is-v** — the *w* buried in the middle is a German *w*, which is English *v*. *Guh-VOHNT*.
- **final-t** — *-nt* to close, exactly as in *gelernt*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Wohnen began by meaning something closer to “to be accustomed” than “to reside,” and *gewohnt* still carries that older sense alongside the newer one: in modern German it is also the ordinary word for *used to something*.

English kept the same word and only the old meaning:

word	meaning
German gewohnt	lived; accustomed
English wont	accustomed, as in <i>he was wont to sing</i>

Two languages split one word between them — Germany took the address and England took the habit.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “wohnen, gewohnt” — with a *v* in the middle
- the fossil — “gewohnt, wont”
- the whole set — “gesagt, gemacht, gelernt, gewohnt”

Twice through: “wohnen, gewohnt.”

Before you move on

Build the participle of *wohnen*. (**Gewohnt.**) How is the *w* sounded? (**Like English v.**) Which English word preserves its older sense? (**Wont** — accustomed.) Next: where that *ge-* came from, and the English word still hiding it.

21.7 The ge- that English lost

Four participles, four *ge-*s. That syllable is not decoration, and English used to have it too.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

German *ge-* comes from Germanic **ga-*, a prefix meaning “**together, completely.**” Its job was to mark an action as **finished** — what grammarians call *perfective* — which is exactly the work a past participle does. A finished saying is *gesagt*.

English inherited the same prefix and spelled it *y-*. Chaucer still wrote it. Then English let it go, and two fossils were left behind with the prefix welded on:

English word	what is hiding inside
enough	Old English <i>genōg</i> — “completely sufficient”
<i>yclept</i> (archaic, “named”)	<i>gecleopod</i> — “called,” finished and done
Say the German wrap out loud — <i>ge-sag-t</i> — and then the English fossil: <i>en-ough</i> , from <i>genōg</i> . It is the same syllable, worn down to a vowel and carried inside a word nobody thinks of as a participle at all. So English once wrapped its participles the same way German still does. German simply never stopped.	

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- what it meant — “together, completely”
- the fossil — “enough, from *genōg*”
- four finished actions — “gesagt, gemacht, gelernt, gewohnt”

Twice through: “ge- means completely.”

Before you move on

What did *ge-* originally mean? (“**Completely**,” marking an action finished.) How did English spell the same prefix? (**Y-**.) Which everyday English word still carries it? (**Enough**, from *genōg*.) And the archaic one? (**Yclept**.) Next: the four participles side by side, and then the verb that puts them to work.

21.8 Practice — four verbs, one wrap

No new words. Every participle here has had its own lesson, so this is the first place they are safe to put side by side — as a recap of work already done, not as a list to swallow.

Grammar Lens: the four, assembled

infinitive

sagen
machen
lernen
wohnen

participle

gesagt
gemacht
gelernt
gewohnt

Cover the right-hand side and rebuild it from the left. Then cover the left and work backwards: given *gemacht*, what was the infinitive? The recipe runs both ways, which is what makes it worth having.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the four in order — “gesagt, gemacht, gelernt, gewohnt”
- the four infinitives back — “sagen, machen, lernen, wohnen”
- the recipe out loud — “ge in front, t behind”
- the fossil — “enough, from genōg”

Twice through: “gesagt, gemacht, gelernt, gewohnt.”

Before you move on

Run the four participles without prompting. Which infinitive gives *gemacht*? (***Machen.***) What are the two pieces of the wrap? (**Ge-** and **-t.**) What did the front piece originally mean? (**“Completely.”**) Next: the verb that carries all four of these into a sentence.

Chapter 22

The Past Built From Have

Modes: 🗣️ voice (9) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 9 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say what I did in German — haben in second place, the participle waiting at the end of the clause — and read it as a plain past rather than as “have done”.

The Perfekt is haben plus a participle, and its cost is the four person slots rather than the recipe: ich habe, du hast, er hat, wir haben each get their own lesson before any of them share a page. The bracket that leaves the participle stranded at the end of the clause gets one of its own too, then gestern to fill the gap it opens, and finally the translation trap — ich habe gesagt is “I said”.

22.1 haben plus a participle — the everyday past

A participle on its own says nothing about who or when. It needs a partner, and German picks the same partner English does.

Grammar Lens: the recipe

haben, conjugated for whoever did it, plus the **participle**.

That two-part past has a name in German: the **Perfekt**. *Haben* carries everything that changes — the person, and the fact that this is a finished action — while the participle sits there in one shape for everybody. Only one of the two words has to agree with anything, which is why the *Perfekt* costs far less to learn than its size suggests. English assembled the identical machine out of the identical parts: a verb meaning “have,” plus a finished-action participle. *I have said* and

ich habe gesagt line up word for word. The next few lessons take *haben*'s forms one at a time and hang a participle off each.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the recipe — “haben, conjugated, plus the participle”
- the name — “das Perfekt”
- which half moves — “haben changes, the participle does not”

Twice through: “haben plus participle.”

Before you move on

Which two pieces make the *Perfekt*? (**Haben** plus the **participle**.)
 Which of the two changes for the person? (**Haben**.) Which English tense is built the same way? (**I have said** — *have* plus a participle.)
 Next: the first person, and the first whole sentence about the past.

22.2 ich habe gesagt — “I said”

The recipe, filled in for the person you talk about most.

You'll want to know: ich habe gesagt

ich habe gesagt — “I said.”

Three words, three jobs. *Ich* is who; *habe* is the form of *haben* that goes with *ich*; *gesagt* is what happened. Nothing here is new except the way the last two sit together.

Say it as one run rather than three separate words. The stress lands on *gesagt*, and *habe* shrinks in ordinary speech to something close to *hab*: *ich HAB gezahkt*. That contraction is not sloppy — it is how the sentence sounds when a German says it at speed.

Sounds you'll need

- **ich-laut** — *ich* still ends in the soft breathy sound from the very first chapter, not a *k*.
- **ge-prefix** — and the *ge-* that follows two words later is just as soft. The sentence has two unstressed mumbles in it and one loud syllable.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ich habe gesagt”
- it at speed — “ich hab gesagt”
- the English beside it — “I said; ich habe gesagt”

Twice through: “ich habe gesagt, ich habe gesagt.”

Before you move on

Say “I said.” (**Ich habe gesagt.**) Which word carries the person? (**Habe.**) Which syllable is stressed? (**Sagt.**) Next: the same sentence, aimed at the person in front of you.

22.3 du hast gesagt — “you said”

Same sentence, different person — and *haben* loses a letter on the way.

You'll want to know: du hast gesagt

du hast gesagt — “you said,” to one person you are on familiar terms with.

The *b* of *haben* has gone. Not worn away here and kept elsewhere — this is one of the two forms where German drops it, and you met both when you learned the verb.

English does exactly the same thing to exactly the same verb: *I have*, but *thou hast*, and still today *he has*. Two languages, one shortcut, inherited together rather than invented twice.

The participle has not moved. *Gesagt* is *gesagt* whoever did the saying, so half of every sentence in this chapter is already yours.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “du hast gesagt”
- the pair — “ich habe gesagt, du hast gesagt”
- the English echo — “du hast, thou hast”

Twice through: “du hast gesagt.”

Before you move on

Say “you said,” informally. (**Du hast gesagt.**) Which letter of *haben* disappeared? (**The b.**) Which English form does the same? (**Thou hast**, and *he has*.) Did the participle change? (**No.**) Next: the same sentence about somebody else.

22.4 er hat das gemacht — “he did that”

Third person, and the first sentence in this chapter with a word standing between *haben* and the participle.

You’ll want to know: er hat das gemacht

er hat das gemacht — “he did that.”

Hat is the second of *haben*’s two *b*-less forms, the twin of English *has*. And *das*, the little word you met as an article, doubles as “that” — the thing he did.

Notice where it went. *Das* did not follow *gemacht*; it slipped in **before** it. The participle stayed at the far end of the sentence and let the rest of the words file in ahead of it. That is not a quirk of this one sentence, and the next lesson but one is about it.

Sounds you'll need

- **ch-ach** — the throat scrape is back, in the middle of *gemacht*.
- **final-t** — three of the four words in this sentence end in a *t*. Release each one; German does not let a final *t* go soft.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “er hat das gemacht”
- the b-less pair — “du hast, er hat”
- with the other participle — “er hat das gesagt”

Twice through: “er hat das gemacht.”

Before you move on

Say “he did that.” (**Er hat das gemacht.**) Which two forms of *haben* have no *b*? (**Hast** and **hat.**) Where did *das* land — before or after the participle? (**Before.**) Next: the same past, said about a group.

22.5 wir haben gesagt — “we said”

The fourth person, and the easiest of the four, because its form is one you have been saying since the verb was introduced.

You'll want to know: wir haben gesagt

wir haben gesagt — “we said.”

The helper here is *haben* itself, unchanged from the dictionary form. German does that everywhere: the *wir* form of any verb is the infinitive over again, which is one of the few completely free pieces of the ending system.

So the sentence has *haben* in it twice over in a sense — as the recipe’s helper and as its own plain shape — and the participle at the back is still *gesagt*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “wir haben gesagt”
- the four helpers in order — “habe, hast, hat, haben”
- “wir haben das gemacht”

Twice through: “wir haben gesagt.”

Before you move on

Say “we said.” (**Wir haben gesagt.**) Which other form of the verb does *wir haben* match exactly? (**The infinitive, haben.**) Say “we did that.” (**Wir haben das gemacht.**) Next: why the participle keeps ending up at the back.

22.6 The participle waits at the back

Er hat das gemacht. Something happened in that sentence that has not been named yet, and it is the one thing about the *Perfekt* English cannot copy.

Grammar Lens: where the participle goes

The participle goes to the **end of the clause**, not next to *haben*.

You already know that the working verb takes the second position in a German sentence. The *Perfekt* splits the verb in two and puts the halves at opposite ends: *haben* in its usual second slot, the participle at the very back. Between them sits everything else the sentence has to say.

Grammarians call that shape a **bracket**, and once you hear it you cannot unhear it — a German sentence opens a verb and does not close it until the last word. It is also why German listeners wait: until the bracket shuts, you do not yet know what was done.

English refuses this outright. *I have German learned* is not a sentence, and no amount of context rescues it, because English keeps its two verb pieces welded together and pushes everything else behind them.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the shape — “haben second, participle last”
- “er hat das gemacht” and hear the bracket close
- “wir haben das gesagt”

Twice through: “The participle waits at the back.”

Before you move on

Where does the participle sit? (**At the end of the clause.**) Where does *haben* sit? (**Second**, as any working verb does.) What is between them? (**Everything else.**) Can English do this? (**No.**) Next: a word to put in that middle space.

22.7 gestern — “yesterday”

The bracket leaves a gap in the middle of every past sentence. Here is the first word worth putting in it.

You’ll want to know: gestern

gestern — “yesterday.”

It pairs with *morgen*, which you already have for “tomorrow.” One word each side of today, and both of them slide into the middle of a sentence rather than onto its end.

Now put it to work with a participle you own:

Ich habe gestern Deutsch gelernt. (*word for word: I have yesterday German learned.*)

Three things stacked between *habe* and *gelernt*, and the participle still waiting at the back. Read the English gloss aloud and hear how badly it fails as an English sentence; that failure is the shape of German.

Sounds you'll need

- **ge-prefix** — the opening *ge-* is the same unstressed mumble as in a participle, though here it is simply part of the word: *GES-tern*, stress on the first syllable.
- **r-uvular-german** — the *r* before *n* barely sounds; it colours the vowel and gets out of the way.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Gestern and *yesterday* are the same word. Germanic **gestra-* meant “the day before”; German kept it as it was, and English glued *day* onto the end of it, which is why the English word is two syllables longer for no extra meaning.

Latin took the same ancient root to *heri*, which is where French *hier* and Spanish *ayer* come from — so the word for yesterday is one of the oldest things in the room.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “gestern” — stress on the front
- the pair — “gestern, morgen”
- “Ich habe gestern Deutsch gelernt.”

Twice through: “Ich habe gestern Deutsch gelernt.”

Before you move on

Say “yesterday.” (**Gestern.**) Say “I learned German yesterday.” (**Ich habe gestern Deutsch gelernt.**) Which word comes last? (**Gelernt.**) Which English word is *gestern*? (**Yesterday.**) Next: what that sentence actually means in English, which is not what it looks like.

22.8 It means “I said,” not only “I have said”

The last thing about this tense is a translation trap, and it is the one that trips up English speakers hardest.

Grammar Lens: one German past for two English ones

Ich habe gesagt covers both “I said” and “I have said.”

English keeps those apart and makes the difference do work: *I said it yesterday* against *I have said it already*. Pick the wrong one and an English speaker hears something slightly off.

Spoken German mostly does not bother. The *Perfekt* took over the whole territory and answers both questions, so *ich habe gestern Deutsch gelernt* is “I learned German yesterday” — plain past, no “have” anywhere in the English.

That is the trap: the German sentence has a word that looks like *have* in it, and the English translation usually does not. Read the German for its meaning rather than its parts, and the sentence stops sounding stilted.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ich habe gesagt — I said”
- it the other way too — “ich habe gesagt — I have said”
- “Ich habe gestern Deutsch gelernt — I learned German yesterday”

Twice through: “ich habe gesagt — I said.”

Before you move on

Translate *ich habe gesagt* into plain English. (“**I said.**”) Does the English need the word “have”? (**Usually not.**) Which language keeps *I said* and *I have said* apart? (**English.**) Next: the whole chapter, said through.

22.9 Practice — the Perfekt, all four persons

No new words. Each of the four slots below has had a lesson of its own, so this is the first place it is safe to set them out together.

Grammar Lens: the four slots, assembled

German	English
ich habe gesagt	I said
du hast gesagt	you said
er hat gesagt	he said
wir haben gesagt	we said
One half of the sentence moves and the other does not. Run the four aloud and hear that <i>gesagt</i> never budes.	

The exchange

German	English
<i>Was hast du gestern gemacht?</i>	What did you do yesterday?
<i>Ich habe Deutsch gelernt.</i>	I learned German.
<i>Und du?</i>	And you?
<i>Wir haben das auch gemacht.</i>	We did that too.
<i>Gut gemacht!</i>	Well done!

Two joining words slip in without lessons of their own, because the translation carries them: **was** (“what”) and **auch** (“too”). And the last line is already an idiom — *gut gemacht* is exactly English *well done*, participle and all.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the four in order — “ich habe, du hast, er hat, wir haben — gesagt”
- the same four with the other participle — “...gemacht”
- “Ich habe gestern Deutsch gelernt.”
- the whole exchange, both voices

Twice through: “ich habe, du hast, er hat, wir haben.”

Before you move on

Run the four helpers without prompting. Say “we did that.” (**Wir haben das gemacht.**) Where is the participle in every one of those sentences? (**Last.**) Translate *ich habe gesagt* into plain English. (“**I said.**”) Next: the other past tense German has, and why you meet it mostly in books.

Chapter 23

The Simple Past

Modes: ⇄ voice (10) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 10 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can recognise the one-word past German uses in writing, produce the handful of its forms that people actually say out loud, and explain why the rest of it retreated.

German's second past means exactly what the first one means, so this chapter separates the two by register rather than by tense: produce the Perfekt, recognise the Präteritum, and learn the short list of forms that ignore the rule. It ends with the reason the tense retreated at all — the same change ran through French and Italian over the same centuries, because their speakers are neighbours.

23.1 -te — the one-word past

German has a second past tense. It needs no helper verb and no participle — just a stem and an ending.

Grammar Lens: add -te to the stem

Take a regular verb's stem and put **-te** on it.

The tense that ending builds is called the **Präteritum**. Where the *Perfekt* spends two words and a bracket, this one spends a single word: *sag-* plus *-te* and the sentence is done.

The two tenses report the same events. That is worth saying plainly, because a learner reasonably expects a language with two pasts to be drawing a distinction with them, the way English draws one between *I said* and *I have said*. German draws none. What separates its two

pasts is something else entirely, and it takes a few more lessons to arrive at.

The *-te* itself has a history reaching well beyond German, and that comes first.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the recipe — “stem plus *te*”
- the name — “das *Präteritum*”
- how many words it takes — “one”

Twice through: “stem plus *-te*.”

Before you move on

Which ending builds the *Präteritum* on a regular verb? (**-te**.) How many words does it need? (**One**.) How many does the *Perfekt* need? (**Two**.) Do the two tenses mean different things? (**No**.) Next: the first verb through the new ending.

23.2 *ich sagte* — “I said,” in one word

Run the new ending on the verb this chapter started from.

You’ll want to know: *ich sagte*

ich sagte — “I said.”

Stem *sag-*, ending *-te*. Two syllables and it is finished, where the *Perfekt* took three words to say the same thing:

ich sagte · *ich habe gesagt*

Both are “I said.” Neither is more past than the other, neither is more polite, and neither is wrong. Hold that in mind while the differences that do exist arrive.

Sounds you'll need

- **long-a** — the stem vowel is the same long *a* as in *sagen*; the new ending does not shorten it.
- **final-te** — the *-te* is a full unstressed syllable, *tuh*, not a bare *t*. Hear the difference against the participle: *ge-SAHKT* has one syllable at the end, *SAHK-tuh* has two.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ich sagte”
- the pair back to back — “ich sagte ... ich habe gesagt”
- the two endings apart — “gesagt, sagte”

Twice through: “ich sagte, ich habe gesagt.”

Before you move on

Say “I said” in one word. (**Ich sagte.**) And in three. (**Ich habe gesagt.**) Which of them is further in the past? (**Neither.**) How many syllables does *sagte* have? (**Two.**) Next: the same ending on the verb for doing.

23.3 ich machte — “I made,” “I did”

You have *gemacht*. Build the other past of the same verb before reading on.

You'll want to know: ich machte

ich machte — “I made,” “I did.”

Mach- plus *-te*. Notice what the two pasts of this verb have in common: the stem. *Gemacht* wrapped it and *machte* suffixed it, and neither touched a letter inside it.

That is the whole promise of a weak verb. Whatever German asks of it, the middle stays put — which is why the four participles of the last chapter

and the *-te* forms of this one can be built from any regular verb you meet, on the spot, without a list.

er machte das · er hat das gemacht

Same person, same event, two tenses.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ich machte”
- the pair — “er machte das ... er hat das gemacht”
- both new forms — “sagte, machte”

Twice through: “ich sagte, ich machte.”

Before you move on

Say “I did” in one word. (**Ich machte.**) What do *machte* and *gemacht* share? (**The stem mach-**) Does either change the stem? (**No.**) Say “he did that” both ways. (**Er machte das; er hat das gemacht.**) Next: where that *-te* came from, and the English ending that is the same thing.

23.4 The dental preterite — a Germanic invention

Say *sagte*, then say *walked*. Both endings are made with the tongue against the teeth, and that is not a coincidence.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

The German *-te* is what linguists call the **dental preterite**: a past tense made by bolting a *t* or *d* sound onto a stem. Dental, because those sounds are made at the teeth.

language	present	past
German	<i>sag-</i>	sagte
English	<i>walk</i>	walked
Dutch	<i>werk-</i>	werkte

Three languages, one device, inherited rather than borrowed — this is a **Germanic invention**, and it is one of the features that identifies the family. Everything with a *-t* or *-d* past in Germanic comes from the same ancestor.

Latin built nothing of the kind. Its past came from inherited perfect endings and from reduplication, and its descendants carried that on: French *parla*, Spanish *habló*. So *sagte* and *walked* are one machine, and *parla* and *habló* are a different one — which is why an English speaker recognises the German ending on sight and a Spanish speaker does not.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the three together — “sagte, walked, werkte”
- the name — “the dental preterite”
- the two machines — “sagte and walked; parla and habló”

Twice through: “sagte, walked — the same ending.”

Before you move on

What is the *-te* called? (**The dental preterite.**) Why *dental*? (**It is made at the teeth.**) Which English ending is the same thing? (**-ed.**) Did Latin have it? (**No** — Romance builds its past another way.) Next: the one verb whose *-te* form you will hear constantly.

23.5 ich hatte — “I had”

The dental ending on the verb you have been leaning on for two chapters.

You'll want to know: ich hatte

ich hatte — “I had.”

Haben drops its *b* — the same *b* that goes missing in *du hast* and *er hat* — and the dental ending lands on what is left, doubling the *t* in the spelling: *hat-te*. Two syllables, both short.

English did the identical thing to the identical verb and then wore the result down further: *have* lost its consonant and took a *-d*, giving *had*. So *hatte* and *had* are the same word doing the same job.

Haben has a *Perfekt* of its own as well — *ich habe gehabt*, “I have had” — built by the ordinary recipe, since *haben* is a perfectly ordinary verb when it is not busy helping another one.

Sounds you'll need

- **d-t-final** — the doubled *tt* is one sharp *t*, and the vowel in front of it is short and clipped. *HAT-tuh*, never *HAH-tuh*.
- **final-te** — the ending is still a full unstressed syllable.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ich hatte”
- the pair — “ich hatte ... ich habe gehabt”
- the English twin — “hatte, had”

Twice through: “ich hatte, ich hatte.”

Before you move on

Say “I had.” (**Ich hatte.**) Which letter of *haben* is missing? (**The b.**) Say the same thing in the *Perfekt*. (**Ich habe gehabt.**) Which English word is *hatte*? (**Had.**) Next: which of the two pasts a German actually reaches for, and where.

23.6 Which past, and where

Two tenses, one meaning. Time to answer the question that has been waiting since the *-te* arrived: when does a German say which?

Grammar Lens: speech takes one, writing takes the other

The *Perfekt* belongs to **speech**. The *Präteritum* belongs to **narrative writing**.

tense	where it lives
<i>Perfekt</i>	everyday conversation, and dominant there
<i>Präteritum</i>	novels, reports, anything told on the page

Open a German novel and the story runs in *Präteritum* from the first page to the last. Stand in a German kitchen and you will barely hear it. Neither audience thinks it is choosing a tense; each is simply doing what that setting does.

So the practical instruction for a speaker is lopsided and easy:

produce the *Perfekt*, **recognise** the *Präteritum*. You will read far more of it than you will ever need to say.

Why it's said this way

There is a second axis, and it is geographic. Spoken *Präteritum* has largely vanished from conversation in southern Germany, Austria and Switzerland; further north it survives noticeably better. A Hamburg speaker will use forms in conversation that a Munich speaker would find bookish.

That map is not decoration — the next lessons turn out to explain it — and it means the honest answer to “do Germans say *ich sagte?*” is: some of them, some of the time, and it depends where you are standing.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the split — “Perfekt for speech, Präteritum for writing”

- your own instruction — “produce the Perfekt, recognise the Präteritum”
- the map — “weaker in the south, stronger in the north”

Twice through: “Perfekt spoken, Präteritum written.”

Before you move on

Which past does a novel use? (**The Präteritum.**) Which does a conversation use? (**The Perfekt.**) Which should you produce? (**The Perfekt.**) Where is spoken *Präteritum* weakest? (**The south.**) Next: the forms that ignore all of this and stay spoken everywhere.

23.7 ich konnte — “I could”

The last new form of the chapter, and a *Präteritum* nobody thinks twice about saying out loud.

You’ll want to know: ich konnte

ich konnte — “I could,” “I was able to.”

The dental ending again, doubled in the spelling as it was in *hatte: konnte*. It belongs to a small family of verbs German calls *modal* — the ones that lean on another verb, the way English *can*, *must* and *may* do.

Those verbs are the *Präteritum*’s stronghold in ordinary speech. Nobody in Munich says *ich habe gekonnt* over dinner; they say *ich konnte*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Konnte and English *could* descend from one Germanic verb, **kunnana*, which meant “**to know how**” rather than “to be physically able.” Ability arrived later, out of knowledge.

That older sense is still visible in the English relatives: *know*, *cunning* (originally “knowing”), and *uncouth*, which began as “unknown.” The *l* that English wrote into *could* is pure accident — it was copied from *would* and *should* centuries after anyone stopped pronouncing it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ich konnte”
- the two doubled forms — “hatte, konnte”
- the old meaning — “konnte, could — knew how”

Twice through: “ich konnte, ich hatte.”

Before you move on

Say “I could.” (**Ich konnte.**) What did the verb behind it originally mean? (“**To know how.**”) Name an English cousin. (**Know**, *cunning*, or *uncouth*.) Is *konnte* bookish? (**No** — it is said out loud everywhere.) Next: why a handful of forms get that exemption.

23.8 The forms that stayed spoken

Hatte. Konnte. Both are *Präteritum*, and both come out of a German mouth without a second thought. So the writing-only rule has holes in it.

Grammar Lens: a short list of survivors

A handful of very common verbs keep their one-word past **in speech**, everywhere in the German-speaking world.

Three groups make up almost the whole list:

- **hatte** — the past of *haben*;
- **konnte** and its modal siblings — *musste*, *wollte*, *durfte*;
- the past of the verb for “to be,” which arrives two chapters from now and is the most-said of them all.

Everything else in the *Präteritum* obeys the split you learned last: written, not spoken.

Why these? Because they are the verbs said most often, and frequency protects a form the way it protects an irregularity. A shape you

produce fifty times a day is never up for replacement; a shape you produce once a month quietly gets swapped for the compound version and nobody notices the swap happening. So the practical list is genuinely short, and it is worth having by heart rather than by rule.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the survivors you own — “hatte, konnte”
- the modal siblings — “musste, wollte, durfte”
- the reason — “frequency protects a form”

Twice through: “hatte, konnte — spoken everywhere.”

Before you move on

Name two *Präteritum* forms a German says out loud. (***Hatte***, ***konnte***.) Which family does *konnte* belong to? (**The modals.**) Why did these survive? (**They are said most often.**) Next: why the rest of the tense retreated, and where the retreat came from.

23.9 The same retreat, three times over

German is not the only language that let a two-word past crowd out a one-word one. Two of its neighbours did the identical thing at the identical time.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

language	one-word past	what took it over in speech
German	<i>Präteritum</i>	<i>Perfekt</i>
French	<i>passé simple</i>	<i>passé composé</i>
Italian	<i>passato remoto</i>	<i>passato prossimo</i>

Two Romance languages and one Germanic one, doing the same thing over the same centuries — and not by coincidence. The dental *-te* and

the Romance endings came from completely different ancestors, so nothing inherited can account for three languages arriving at the same answer.

Geography can. Southern Germany, France and northern Italy are one connected block of territory, and the change spread through it by **contact**: speakers who live near each other borrow habits, and a habit of speech travels across a language boundary as easily as across a dialect one. Linguists call a change that spreads that way an *areal* change.

Why it's said this way

Two pieces of evidence make the contact story stick rather than merely sound good.

The first is what did **not** happen at the western edge. Spanish and Portuguese kept their one-word past far more fully in speech, and they are the two languages furthest from that connected block.

The second is the map inside German itself, which you already met: the *Präteritum* is weakest in the **south**, nearest the centre of the change, and strongest in the **north**, furthest from it. A change spreading outward from a region should thin as it goes, and that is exactly what German shows.

Geography did not dictate any single sentence. But it explains why a Germanic language and two Romance ones moved in step, and why one end of Germany sounds older than the other.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the three languages — “German, French, Italian: the same retreat”
- the name — “an areal change, spread by contact”
- the inside map — “south more Perfekt, north more Präteritum”

Twice through: “areal change — it spread by contact.”

Before you move on

Which two neighbours made the same change? (**French** and **Italian**.) Did German inherit it from Latin? (**No** — the two families build their pasts from different material.) What is a change that spreads by contact called? (An *areal* change.) Which two languages at the western edge kept their one-word past? (**Spanish** and **Portuguese**.) Next: the chapter run through end to end.

23.10 Practice — the two pasts, side by side

No new words. The point of this one is to hear, in your own voice, that two different-sounding sentences report the same event.

Grammar Lens: one meaning, two shapes

meaning	Präteritum	Perfekt
I said	<i>ich sagte</i>	<i>ich habe gesagt</i>
I made	<i>ich machte</i>	<i>ich habe gemacht</i>
I had	<i>ich hatte</i>	<i>ich habe gehabt</i>
Say each pair back to back — <i>ich sagte ... ich habe gesagt</i> — and then <i>er machte das ... er hat das gemacht</i> . Nothing about the meaning has moved. All that has changed is which room you are standing in.		

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the pair — “*ich sagte ... ich habe gesagt*”
- the other pair — “*er machte das ... er hat das gemacht*”
- the survivors — “*ich hatte, ich konnte*”
- your own instruction — “produce the Perfekt, recognise the Präteritum”

Twice through: “*ich sagte, ich habe gesagt.*”

Before you move on

Say “I made” both ways. (**Ich machte; ich habe gemacht.**) Which of the two would a novel use? (**The Präteritum.**) Which would you say out loud? (**The Perfekt** — except for the survivors.) What is the *-te* called? (**The dental preterite.**) What kind of change pushed the tense out of speech? (An *areal* one.) Next: the verb every one of these sentences has been waiting for.

Chapter 24

I Am, You Are

Modes:  voice (8)  eyes (1)  Hands-free start: first 8 of 9 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say what someone is in German, using any of the six present forms of the verb for “to be” — and say that I am tired.

sein is the one German verb whose forms cannot be guessed from its infinitive, so this chapter meets them one at a time — bin, bist, ist, sind, seid, sind — and only assembles the grid once every cell has had its own lesson. It closes with müde, the adjective that finishes ich bin, and a short exchange that runs on nothing but this verb.

24.1 sein — “to be”

You have met the German verb for *to have*. Here is its partner — the most irregular verb in German, and the one verb whose forms you will not be able to guess.

You’ll want to know: sein

sein — “to be.”

The **-en** on the end is the infinitive ending you already own from *gehen* and *sehen*: the dictionary form of a German verb wears it, and *sein* wears it too.

That is where the resemblance stops. *Gehen* and *sehen* keep their stem in every form — *ich gehe*, *ich sehe*. *Sein* keeps nothing. Not one of its present forms contains the letters *s-e-i-n* in that order.

This is the only verb in the book that has to be met one form at a time, and the next several lessons do exactly that: one form each, said until it is automatic, before any of them are ever seen side by side.

Sounds you'll need

- **s-voiced** — a German **s** before a vowel buzzes like English **z**, exactly as it does in *sehen*. So *sein* opens with a **z**.
- **diphthong-ei** — German **ei** is the vowel of English *eye*, never “ee”.
- **final-t** — worth having ready now, because two of the forms coming up end in a crisp, fully released **t**.

Put together, *sein* sounds like English **zine**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “sein” (*zine*) — buzzing **z**, *ei* as in *eye*
- “gehen, sehen, sein” — three infinitives, one ending
- “sein — to be”

Twice through: “sein, sein — *zine*.”

Before you move on

What does *sein* mean? (“**To be**.”) Which ending does it share with *gehen* and *sehen*? (**-en**, the infinitive.) How does the *s* sound? (Like English **z**.) And the *ei*? (Like English **eye**.) Next: the first form, and it looks nothing like the word you just learned.

24.2 ich bin — “I am”

You have *ich*, and you have the infinitive *sein*. Put them together and you get a form that shares no letters with either half of that sentence except the *i*.

You'll want to know: ich bin

ich bin — “I am.”

One syllable, short *i*, ordinary *b*, ordinary *n*. There is no rule behind it and nothing to derive it from: *bin* is simply the form that goes with *ich*, and it is learned the way you learned *hallo*.

It rhymes with English *bin*, and that rhyme is not an accident — see below.

Sounds you'll need

- **ich-laut** — *ich* still ends in the soft breathy sound you met when you first said “I”: tongue where it sits for *ee*, air pushed past it, no scrape.
- **i-short** — the *i* of *bin* is short and clipped, the vowel of English *bin*, not the long *ee* of *ihm*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Bin rhymes with English *be* for a reason, even though the vowels have drifted apart. Both come from Proto-Indo-European ***b^huH-** — “to grow, to become.”

So German kept that ancient root in the **present tense** and English kept it as the **infinitive**: *be* and *bin* are the same old word wearing different jobs. Hold on to that; two lessons from now it explains something about the whole verb.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ich bin” — short *i*, soft ending on *ich*
- “ich bin Anna.” “ich bin Peter.”
- “bin — be” — the same old root

Twice through: “ich bin, ich bin.”

Before you move on

Say “I am.” (**Ich bin.**) Is the *i* of *bin* long or short? (**Short** — English *bin.*) Which English word comes from the same root as *bin*? (**Be.**) Next: the same verb for the person you are talking to.

24.3 du bist — “you are”

Du is the familiar “you” — the one for a friend. Its verb ending is **-st**, and for once *sein* uses it.

You’ll want to know: du bist

du bist — “you are.”

Take *bin*, drop the *n*, add the familiar **-st**: *bi-* plus *-st* is *bist*. That is the same ending as *du gehst*, *du heißt*, *du siehst*.

Of the six present forms of *sein*, this is the only one that can be derived from another one. Enjoy it; it does not happen again.

Sounds you’ll need

- **u-long** — *du* has a long, rounded **oo**, the vowel of English *do*, held.
- **final-t** — German releases a final **t** fully and audibly. *Bist* ends with a small puff of air; English tends to swallow it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “du bist” — long *u*, crisp final *t*
- “ich bin ... du bist” — the pair
- “du bist Peter.”

Twice through: “ich bin, du bist.”

Before you move on

Say “you are,” to a friend. (**Du bist.**) Which ending is that? (**-st**, the familiar one.) Which form is *bist* built on? (***Bin.***) Is the final *t* released or swallowed? (**Released.**) Next: the form for everybody else.

24.4 er ist — “he is”

Bin and *bist* both start with *b*. The third form does not, and it is the one you will hear most.

You’ll want to know: er ist

er ist — “he is.”

er is “he.” The same **ist** serves three more subjects without changing at all: **sie ist** (“she is”), **es ist** (“it is”), and **das ist** (“that is”) — *es* and *das* both already yours.

So one two-letter word covers everything that is not *ich* and not *du*, in the singular. It is the workhorse of the whole verb.

Sounds you’ll need

- **r-final** — the *r* at the end of *er* is not a full English *r*. It softens towards a vowel, close to *air* said without the tongue curling.
- **final-t** — *ist* ends in the same released **t** as *bist*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Ist is the one form of *sein* whose relatives you can name on sight:

language	“is”
German	ist
English	is
Latin	<i>est</i>
French	<i>est</i>

All from Proto-Indo-European ***h₁es-**, “to be” — and the infinitive **sein** is built on that root too. So *sein* and *ist* really do belong to each

other; it is *bin* and *bist* that came from somewhere else.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “er ist, sie ist, es ist”
- “Das ist gut.” — “that is good”
- “ich bin, du bist, er ist”

Twice through: “Das ist gut.”

Before you move on

Say “he is.” (**Er ist.**) Which other subjects take the same form? (**Sie, es, das.**) Say “that is good.” (**Das ist gut.**) Which Latin word is *ist*? (**Est.**) Next: the form for more than one.

24.5 wir sind — “we are”

Three singular forms down. The plural starts here, and after *bin*, *bist*, *ist*, this one will finally look like the verb it belongs to.

You’ll want to know: wir sind

wir sind — “we are.”

wir is “we.” And **sind** shares its first two letters with the infinitive *sein*, which is the first visible family resemblance in this verb.

Its Latin twin is *sunt*, “they are” — same **s**, same **n**, same closing stop, the same root wearing a different vowel.

Sounds you’ll need

- **w-as-v** — German **w** is English **v**. *Wir* begins like *veer*.
- **ie-long-ee** — **ie** is a long **ee**. *Wir* is *veer*, not *wire*.
- **d-t-final** — the **d** at the end of *sind* is spoken as a **t**, the same final devoicing you met on *und*. Say *zint*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “wir sind” — *veer zint*, final *d* as *t*
- “wir sind gut.”
- “sein ... sind” — the family resemblance

Twice through: “wir sind, wir sind.”

Before you move on

Say “we are.” (**Wir sind.**) How is the final *d* pronounced? (As a **t**.) How does *wir* begin? (Like English **v**.) Which Latin word is *sind*? (**Sunt.**) Next: the plural “you.”

24.6 ihr seid — “you are,” to several people

Du is one friend. For two or more friends German has a separate word, and English used to have one as well.

You’ll want to know: ihr seid

ihr seid — “you are,” said to more than one person you would each call *du*.

ihr is the familiar plural “you” — a crowd of friends, a group of children, your own family. English once had *ye* here and let it go, which is why one English *you* now does the work of four German words.

seid opens exactly like the infinitive: *sei-* is *sein* without its *n*. Both the *s* and the *ei* behave as they did there.

Sounds you’ll need

- **ie-long-ee** — *ihr* is *eer*, one long vowel; the *h* only stretches it.
- **s-voiced** — *seid* opens with the buzzing **z** of *sein*.
- **diphthong-ei** — and carries the *eye* vowel through. Say *zite*.

Wir sind and *ihr seid* are the two plural forms, and they sound nothing alike, which makes them easy to keep apart.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ihr seid” — *eer zite*
- “wir sind ... ihr seid”
- “sein ... seid” — the same opening

Twice through: “ihr seid, ihr seid.”

Before you move on

Say “you are” to a group of friends. (**Ihr seid.**) Which English word did that job before English dropped it? (**Ye.**) Which part of *seid* comes straight out of *sein*? (**sei-**.) Next: the last form, and the one that does double duty.

24.7 sie sind / Sie sind — “they are,” and “you are,” politely

The polite **Sie** is literally the word for “they,” worn as a courtesy. Its verb form follows from that, and costs you nothing new.

You’ll want to know: sie sind and Sie sind

sie sind — “they are.” **Sie sind** — “you are,” to someone you would address formally.

The form is **sind**, the very same word you learned for *wir*. Nothing changes in the mouth at all: *wir sind*, *sie sind*, *Sie sind* are three subjects and one verb form.

Grammar Lens: the capital carries the politeness

On the page, *sie* and *Sie* differ by exactly one capital letter — and German already spends capitals on grammar rather than decoration. In speech there is no difference at all; the context tells you which one is meant.

written	means
<i>sie sind</i>	they are
<i>Sie sind</i>	you are, formally
That is the whole of it. Six subjects, and you have now met every present form of the verb.	

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “sie sind” — “they are”
- “Sie sind Herr Peter Schmidt?” — politely
- “wir sind, sie sind, Sie sind” — one form, three subjects

Twice through: “sie sind, Sie sind.”

Before you move on

Say “they are.” (**Sie sind.**) Say “you are” to a stranger. (**Sie sind** — same sound.) What separates the two on paper? (**The capital S.**) How many different present forms of this verb have you now met? (**Five** — *bin, bist, ist, sind, seid.*) Next: one adjective, so you can finally say something about yourself.

24.8 müde — “tired”

Ich bin is a sentence waiting for one more word. Here is the word that finishes it most often.

You’ll want to know: müde

müde — “tired.”

Ich bin müde. — “I am tired.”

Two syllables, stress on the first: *mü-duh*. It is an adjective, and after *sein* an adjective takes **no ending at all** — the same bare form serves every subject. *Ich bin müde, du bist müde, wir sind müde.*

That is worth noticing, because German adjectives are famous for their endings. They only take them in front of a noun. Standing after *sein*, they stand still.

Sounds you'll need

- **umlaut-ue** — **ü** is the vowel you make by rounding your lips for *oo* and then saying *ee* without moving them. The dots are the fronting mark you already know: the mouth shifts forward, the lips stay round.

The final **-e** is a soft *uh*, never silent. *mü-duh*, two beats, the weight on the first.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “müde” — round the lips, say *ee*
- “Ich bin müde.”
- “Er ist müde. Wir sind müde.” — the adjective never changes

Twice through: “Ich bin müde.”

Before you move on

Say “I am tired.” (**Ich bin müde.**) How do you make the **ü**? (**Round for oo, say ee.**) Does *müde* change after *sein*? (**No** — no ending.) Say “we are tired.” (**Wir sind müde.**) Next: everything at once, on purpose.

24.9 Practice — the whole present of sein

No new words. Every form below has had its own lesson, so this is the first time it is safe to put them all on one page — as a recap, not as something to memorise from cold.

Grammar Lens: the six forms, assembled

singular

ich **bin**
 du **bist**
 er/sie/es **ist**

plural

wir **sind**
 ihr **seid**
 sie/Sie **sind**

Six subjects, five different forms — *sind* does double duty. Look at that with fresh eyes now that you can say all of it: *bin* and *ist* do not look like forms of the same word, and the next chapter explains why they aren't.

The exchange

German

Hallo! Wie geht es dir?
Danke, ich bin müde.
Du bist müde? Ich auch.
Dann sind wir müde. Aber das ist gut.
Bis morgen!

English

Hello! How are you?
 Thanks — I am tired.
 You are tired? Me too.
 Then we are tired. But that is good.
 See you tomorrow!

Three small joining words slip in there without needing lessons of their own, because each can be read straight off the translation: **auch** (“too”), **dann** (“then”) and **aber** (“but”).

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the six in order — “ich bin, du bist, er ist, wir sind, ihr seid, sie sind”
- the same six backwards
- “Ich bin müde.” “Du bist müde.” “Wir sind müde.”
- the whole exchange, both voices

Twice through: “ich bin, du bist, er ist, wir sind, ihr seid, sie sind.”

Before you move on

Run the six forms without looking. Which one form covers *wir*, *sie* and *Sie*? (***Sind***.) Which is the only form built out of another one? (***Bist***, from *bin*.) Say “that is good.” (***Das ist gut***.) Say “you are tired” to a group. (***Ihr seid müde***.) Next: where these forms came from — three different verbs, none of them each other.

Chapter 25

Being Your Years

Modes: 🗣️ voice (7) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 7 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can ask how old somebody is and say my own age in German, using the verb German insists on for it.

This material was the second half of the hand-written haben chapter, and it could not stay there: ich bin zwanzig Jahre alt needs ich bin, and Wie alt bist du? needs du bist — both of which the chapter on sein teaches. It sits here instead, immediately after that chapter, where every word it needs is already owned, and it closes the haben chapter's open question by showing the one everyday sentence where German refuses that verb.

25.1 alt — “old”

You can say *ich bin müde*. Here is a second adjective to put in the same slot, and it opens a sentence you will be asked for constantly.

You'll want to know: alt

alt — “old.”

One syllable. It behaves exactly as *müde* did: after *sein* an adjective takes no ending at all, so *ich bin alt* needs nothing added.

It is the same word as English **old**, and you can nearly hear it — German kept the *a* where English rounded it.

Sounds you'll need

- **vowel-a** — short and clipped, the *a* of English *hat*.
- **d-t-final** — the *-lt* closes crisply, both consonants sounded.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “alt”
- the pair — “alt, old”
- with the verb — “ich bin alt”, “ich bin müde”

Twice through: “alt, alt — old.”

Before you move on

Say “old.” (**Alt.**) Does it take an ending after *bin*? (**No.**) Which English word is it? (**Old.**) Next: the noun that goes with it.

25.2 die Jahre — the form the age sentence uses

A noun you were given ten chapters ago. The age sentence wants it in a shape you have not used yet.

You'll want to know: die Jahre

die Jahre — the plural of *das Jahr*.

The plural adds *-e* and takes *die*, as plurals do, and it stays capitalised because German capitalises every noun in every number.

Here is why it matters. The age sentence counts, and a count takes a plural: you are so many *Jahre* old, never so many *Jahr*. From here on it is *Jahre* that does the work, and *das Jahr* that sits behind it.

Sounds you'll need

- **j-as-y** — German *j* is the *y* of English *yes*. So *Jahr* opens like *year*, not like *jar*.

- **h-silent-lengthening** — that *h* is not pronounced. It is the silent lengthening *h* you met inside *gehen*, and *Jahr* was named there as one of the three words that hide it, beside *sehr* and *Ihnen*. Here it is.
- **long-a** — so the vowel runs long: *YAAR*. Say it beside English *year* and the two are almost the same noise.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- singular and plural — “das Jahr, die Jahre”
- the plural alone, which is the one you need — “die Jahre”
- the two words the sentence will need — “Jahre, alt”

Twice through: “das Jahr, die Jahre.”

Before you move on

Say “the year.” (**Das Jahr.**) And the plural. (**Die Jahre.**) Which of the two does an age sentence use? (**The plural** — you are counted.) What does the plural add? (**An -e, and die.**) Next: where *Jahr* and *alt* both come from.

25.3 Jahr and alt, taken apart

Two words, both inherited rather than borrowed, and one of them has a Latin cousin you would never guess.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

German	from	English
Jahr	Germanic <i>*jēra</i>	year
alt	Germanic <i>*aldaz</i>	old

Neither line passes through Latin, which is worth noticing in a chapter about age: German borrowed its **month** names wholesale from Latin, and kept its own words for the year and for being old.

Now the cousin. The root behind **aldaz* also went into Latin, as *alere* — “to **nourish**, to grow.” From *alere* English took **adult**, which is literally “grown up.”

So *alt* and *adult* are the same idea taken down two roads: something that has been fed and has grown. Ageing as growth rather than as decay, which is a kinder picture than English usually admits to.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the two twins — “Jahr, year; alt, old”
- the Latin cousin — “alt, alere, adult”
- what the root meant — “to nourish, to grow”

Twice through: “Jahr, year. Alt, old.”

Before you move on

Which English word is *Jahr*? (**Year.**) And *alt*? (**Old.**) Which English word comes from *alt*’s Latin cousin? (**Adult.**) What did that cousin mean? (“**To nourish, to grow.**”) Next: the question you will be asked with these two words.

25.4 Wie alt bist du?

You have *wie*, you have *alt*, and you have *du bist*. That is the whole question.

You’ll want to know: Wie alt bist du?

Wie alt bist du? — “How old are you?”

Four words, and every one of them is already yours. Read it against the English and nothing has moved: *how* — *old* — *are* — *you*.

That is not a coincidence to be grateful for; it is inheritance. Neither language borrowed this question from the other. They have been asking it the same way since before either was called German or English.

The verb sits second, as it does in every German statement and question with a question word in front — *Wie* first, *bist* second, and the rest behind.

To someone you would address formally, it is *Wie alt sind Sie?* — the same question with the polite form of the verb.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “Wie alt bist du?”
- it against the English — “how old are you; wie alt bist du”
- the formal one — “Wie alt sind Sie?”

Twice through: “Wie alt bist du?”

Before you move on

Ask how old someone is, informally. (**Wie alt bist du?**) And formally. (**Wie alt sind Sie?**) Which word sits second? (**Bist.**) How many of the four words were new? (**None.**) Next: how to answer it.

25.5 ich bin zwanzig Jahre alt

The answer, and it is as English as the question was.

You’ll want to know: ich bin zwanzig Jahre alt

Ich bin zwanzig Jahre alt. — “I am twenty years old.”

Word for word, that is the English sentence: *I — am — twenty — years — old.* Put any number you own in the middle and the sentence is yours.

And German shortens it the same way English does. *Ich bin zwanzig* is complete and ordinary, exactly as “I’m twenty” is — the *Jahre alt* can go, and in speech usually does.

Notice which verb is doing the work: *bin*. Not *habe*. Hold on to that, because it is the whole point of the next lesson.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “Ich bin zwanzig Jahre alt.”
- the short form — “Ich bin zwanzig.”
- your own age, in both lengths
- the question and the answer together

Twice through: “Ich bin zwanzig Jahre alt.”

Before you move on

Say “I am twenty years old.” (**Ich bin zwanzig Jahre alt.**)
 Shorten it. (**Ich bin zwanzig.**) Which verb does it use? (**Bin.**)
 Which does it **not** use? (**Habe.**) Next: why that choice puts
 German and English on one side and every Romance language on
 the other.

25.6 sein, not haben

You spent a whole chapter on *haben*. Here is the everyday sentence where German refuses to let you use it.

Grammar Lens: you ARE your years

German states age with **sein**, never with *haben*.

**Ich habe zwanzig Jahre* is not German. It is not a clumsy way of putting it; it is not a sentence.

Look what happens when you line the languages up:

language	how age works	literally
German	<i>ich bin ... Jahre alt</i>	I am ...
English	<i>I am twenty</i>	I am ...
French	<i>j'ai vingt ans</i>	I have ...
Spanish	<i>tengo veinte años</i>	I have ...
Italian	<i>ho venti anni</i>	I have ...
Portuguese	<i>tenho vinte anos</i>	I have ...

Two on one side, four on the other, and the line falls exactly where the

families do.

Why it's said this way

Romance has its years; Germanic is its years. Age as something you carry against age as something you are — two pictures of the same fact, and each family committed to one of them long ago.

What makes German's choice worth pointing at is that German did *not* hold the Latin line out generally. Its month names are Latin borrowings wholesale; *Januar*, *Februar* and the rest came in and stayed. But on this sentence, said several times a week for a lifetime, German kept its own logic.

The words a language uses most are the ones it is least willing to trade — which is the same force that keeps its commonest verbs irregular.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the rule — “age takes sein, not haben”
- the two sides — “ich bin zwanzig; j'ai vingt ans”
- the picture — “Romance has its years, Germanic is its years”

Twice through: “Ich bin zwanzig Jahre alt — bin, not habe.”

Before you move on

Which verb does German use for age? (***Sein***.) Which does French use? (***Avoir*** — “to have”.) Which two languages sit together here? (**German and English**.) Did German borrow its month names from Latin? (**Yes** — which is what makes keeping this sentence its own worth noticing.) Next: the chapter said through.

25.7 Practice — asking and answering an age

No new words. One question, one answer, and one thing to keep hearing: which verb carries it.

The exchange

German	English
<i>Wie alt bist du?</i>	How old are you?
<i>Zwanzig Jahre alt. Und du?</i>	Twenty years old. And you?
<i>Ich bin achtzehn.</i>	I am eighteen.
<i>Und du bist müde.</i>	And you are tired.
<i>Aber nicht alt!</i>	But not old!

Every line runs on the same verb, and two of them drop it the way speech does — *zwanzig Jahre alt* answers the question on its own. Nothing here needs *haben*, and the last two lines put *müde* and *alt* side by side in the slot they share.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the question, then your own answer
- the answer short, then long
- the two sides — “ich bin zwanzig; j’ai vingt ans”
- the twins — “Jahr, year; alt, old; alt, adult”
- the whole exchange, both voices

Twice through: “Wie alt bist du? Ich bin zwanzig Jahre alt.”

Before you move on

Ask someone’s age. (**Wie alt bist du?**) Answer with your own, both long and short. Which verb does German use, and which does it refuse? (**Sein**; **not haben**.) Which English word shares a root with *alt*? (**Adult**.) Which four languages say “I have twenty years”? (**French, Spanish, Italian, Portuguese**.)

Chapter 26

Three Verbs Under One Roof

Modes: ⇄ voice (8) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 8 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can put the German verb for “to be” into the past, and say why its forms look like three unrelated words — because they are.

The past of sein is the tidy half of the verb: one stem war-, ordinary endings, and ich war identical to er war. The chapter teaches those four cells one at a time and then answers the question the present tense raised — bin, ist and war come from three different Proto-Indo-European verbs, which is called suppletion, and it survives because the words you never have to guess at are the words analogy never reaches.

26.1 ich war — “I was”

You know the simple past is mostly a written tense in German, and that a handful of very common verbs keep it in speech. This is the most common of them.

You’ll want to know: ich war

ich war — “I was.”

Nobody says *ich bin gewesen* in ordinary speech when *ich war* will do. This is the past-tense form Germans actually use, in every region, out loud.

And hear the shape of it. *Bin* has a *b*. *Ist* has an *s* and a *t*. *War* has a *w* and an *r*, and no sound in common with either. That is now three completely unlike stems inside one verb.

Sounds you'll need

- **w-as-v** — German **w** is English **v**, so *war* begins like *var*.
- **vowel-a-long** — the **a** is long and open, the *a* of English *father*.
- **r-final** — the final **r** softens towards a vowel rather than curling.

The result sounds close to English *var*, and nothing like English *war*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ich war” — *var*, long open *a*
- “ich bin ... ich war” — now and then
- “Ich war müde.”

Twice through: “ich bin, ich war.”

Before you move on

Say “I was.” (**Ich war.**) How does the *w* sound? (Like English **v**.) Is this form used in speech or only in writing? (**In speech, everywhere** — it is one of the survivors.) How many unlike stems does this verb now have? (**Three.**) Next: the same form for *du*.

26.2 du warst — “you were”

You have *ich war*. The familiar “you” wants the ending it always wants.

You'll want to know: du warst

du warst — “you were.”

War plus **-st**, with nothing else moved. The same ending that made *bist* out of *bin*, and *gehst* out of *gehen*.

So the past tense of this verb is better behaved than its present: you take one stem, *war-*, and add ordinary endings to it. Everything difficult about *sein* happens in the present.

Sounds you'll need

- **u-long** — *du* keeps its long rounded **oo**.
- **final-t** — and *warst* ends on the fully released **t** German always gives you, after the *s*. Say the *s* and the *t* both: *varst*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “du warst” — *varst*, both consonants released
- “ich war ... du warst”
- “du bist ... du warst” — now and then

Twice through: “ich war, du warst.”

Before you move on

Say “you were,” to a friend. (**Du warst.**) Which ending is that? (**-st.**) Which stem is it added to? (**War-**) Is the past of this verb regular or irregular in its endings? (**Regular** — one stem, ordinary endings.) Next: the form for everyone else, and a surprise.

26.3 er war — “he was”

In the present, *ich* and *er* took different words — *bin* against *ist*.
In the past they take the same one.

You'll want to know: er war

er war — “he was.”

Not a new form. It is *war*, unchanged, the very word you learned for *ich*. And as with *ist*, it covers **sie war** (“she was”), **es war** (“it was”) and **das war** (“that was”) as well.

This is a habit of the German simple past, not a quirk of this verb: the I-form and the he-form are always identical there. *Ich sagte* and *er sagte*. *Ich hatte* and *er hatte*. The present tense never does this; the past always does.

Sounds you'll need

- **r-final** — two softening *r* sounds in a row now, one closing *er* and one closing *war*. Neither curls.
- **vowel-a-long** — and the long open **a** between them carries the phrase.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “er war, sie war, es war”
- “Das war gut.”
- “ich war ... er war” — the same word twice

Twice through: “Das war gut.”

Before you move on

Say “he was.” (**Er war.**) How is it different from *ich war*? (**It isn't** — same word.) Does the present do that? (**No** — *bin* against *ist*.) Say “that was good.” (**Das war gut.**) Next: the plural.

26.4 wir waren — “we were”

One more form, and the verb is finished — present and past, all of it.

You'll want to know: wir waren

wir waren — “we were.”

War plus the plural ending **-en**, the one *wir* takes on every verb. And just as *sind* served three subjects at once, *waren* covers **sie waren** (“they were”) and **Sie waren** (“you were,” politely) with no change.

The one plural form left over is **ihr wart**, for a group of friends. It takes the plural-*you* **-t**, and it is the rarest form in the whole verb.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

English does the identical thing and nobody notices:

	German	English
singular	<i>war</i>	was
plural	<i>waren</i>	were

An **s** in the singular, an **r** in the plural, in both languages, inherited from the same ancestor. English *was/were* and German *war/waren* are the same pair of words.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “wir waren, sie waren, Sie waren”
- “ich war, du warst, er war, wir waren”
- “war — was; waren — were”

Twice through: “ich war, wir waren.”

Before you move on

Say “we were.” (**Wir waren.**) Which English pair matches *war/waren*? (**Was/were.**) What is the plural ending on it? (**-en.**) Say “they were.” (**Sie waren.**) Next: why one verb needed three different stems.

26.5 bin, ist, war — three verbs under one roof

Say *bin*, *ist*, *war* one after another. They do not look like forms of the same word — and they aren’t.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Three separate Proto-Indo-European verbs each handed German a slice of this paradigm, and each of them left cousins in languages you

can check:

forms	from	which also gave
ist, sind, seid, sein	* <i>h₁es-</i> — “to be”	Latin <i>est, sunt</i> ; French <i>est, sont</i>
bin, bist	* <i>b^huH-</i> — “to grow, become”	English be ; Latin <i>fuī</i>
war, waren	* <i>wes-</i> — “to dwell, remain”	English was, were

Read the middle row again. **b^huH-* did not mean “to be” at all. It meant “to grow” — and the reason English says *be* and German says *bin* is that a verb about growing got promoted into a verb about existing, in both languages, before either of them existed.

The bottom row is the same story with a different verb: **wes-* meant “to dwell, to remain.” Staying somewhere became having been.

Why it’s said this way

Bin has a cousin further afield than English. Latin *fuī*, “I was,” is from the same **b^huH-* — and *fuī* is the direct source of Spanish **fui**, “I was / I went.”

So German *bin* and Spanish *fui* are the same ancient word. One landed in the present tense, the other in the past, and the two languages now use it to mean opposite ends of time.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the three roots — “ist from **h₁es-*, bin from **b^huH-*, war from **wes-*”
- “ist — est — is”
- “war — was; waren — were”
- the cousin abroad — “German bin, Spanish fui, one root”

Before you move on

How many ancient roots is *sein* built from? (**Three.**) Which one gives *ist* — and which Latin word proves it? (**h₁es-*; Latin *est*.)

What did the root behind *bin* originally mean? (“**To grow, to become.**”) Which Spanish word shares it? (***Fui.***) Which root gives English *was* and *were*? (****wes-***, the same one as *war.*) Next: the name for what this verb is doing.

26.6 Suppletion — filling a verb in from another verb

Three roots, one verb. There is a name for that, and once you have it you will find the same thing in English.

Grammar Lens: what suppletion is

When one verb’s forms are filled in from a **different** verb, that is **suppletion**.

Sein has no forms of its own for “I am” or “I was.” It borrowed them, long ago, from two other verbs, and then all three grew together into a single paradigm that native speakers use without ever noticing the seam.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

English does the identical thing with its own commonest verbs, and you have never thought twice about it:

present	past	where the past came from
go	went	<i>wend</i> , a different verb entirely
am	was	the same * <i>wes-</i> that gave German <i>war</i>
good	better	a different word again

Went belonged to *wend* — “to make one’s way,” still alive in *wend your way*. English took it, gave it to *go*, and left *wend* with a regular past of its own. That is precisely what German did to build *sein*. Suppletion is not a German oddity, and it is not rare. It is simply what languages do to the words they use most — and every language you have looked at in this book has done it to its verb for “to be.”

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the definition — “one verb’s forms, filled in from another verb”
- “go, went” — English doing it
- “bin, war” — German doing it

Before you move on

What is suppletion? (**One verb’s forms filled in from another verb.**) Name the English example. (*Go* / *went*.) Which verb did *went* actually belong to? (*Wend*.) How many verbs are hiding inside *sein*? (**Three.**) Next: why this always happens to the commonest words.

26.7 Why “to be” is the messiest word in every language

Every language you have ever met has a broken verb for “to be.” That is too consistent to be an accident, and it isn’t one.

Grammar Lens: frequency protects irregularity

The most-used words are the most irregular.

Regularity spreads by **analogy**. You meet an unfamiliar verb, you do not know its forms, so you guess them from the pattern — the *-e*, *-st*, *-t*, *-en* machine you learned early. Guess often enough and the guess becomes the form: the odd old shape is sanded down and the verb joins the regular crowd.

But you never have to guess at “to be.” You hear it a hundred times a day, from the day you start speaking. Every one of those hearings reinforces the strange shape faster than analogy can wear it away. Rare words get regularised. Common words are protected fossils.

Why it's said this way

This also tells you where the irregularity will sit inside a verb, and *sein* proves it. Its present tense — the part you say constantly — is the wreckage: three roots, five unlike forms. Its past tense, which you say far less often, has quietly become well-behaved: one stem *war-*, ordinary endings, *warst* built exactly like *bist* was not.

So the mess is not spread evenly. It clusters where the traffic is.

The practical consequence is a comfort. There is no long list of verbs this strange, because a verb has to be *this* common to survive being this strange — and there are only a handful of words in any language that common.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the rule — “the most-used words are the most irregular”
- why — “you never have to guess at them”
- “bin, bist, ist” against “war, warst, waren” — mess, then order

Before you move on

State the rule. (**The most-used words are the most irregular.**)

What spreads regularity? (**Analogy** — guessing from the pattern.)

Why does analogy never reach “to be”? (**You never have to guess at it.**) Which half of *sein* is the tidy half? (**The past** — one stem, ordinary endings.) Next: the chapter together.

26.8 Practice — was, were, and why

No new words. Present and past, side by side, and then the account of how one verb ended up like this.

Grammar Lens: the past, assembled

Six forms, one stem, four endings, no surprises. Said in order:

- **ich war, du warst, er war** — and the first and third are the same word, which the present tense would never allow;

- **wir waren, ihr wart, sie waren.**

Compare that with the present, where five different shapes came from three different verbs. The past of *sein* is the part of the paradigm that behaved.

The exchange

German	English
<i>Wo warst du?</i>	Where were you?
<i>Ich war in Berlin.</i>	I was in Berlin.
<i>Wie war es?</i>	How was it?
<i>Es war gut. Aber ich bin müde.</i>	It was good. But I am tired.

Wo (“where”) and *in* are read straight off the English here; neither is asked of you yet.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ich war, du warst, er war, wir waren, ihr wart, sie waren”
- the pairs — “ich bin / ich war”, “wir sind / wir waren”
- the three roots — “ist, bin, war — three verbs”
- the whole exchange, both voices

Twice through: “Wie war es? Es war gut.”

Before you move on

Run the six past forms. Which two are identical? (*Ich war* and *er war*.) Name the three roots this verb is built from, by their German forms. (*Ist, bin, war*.) What is the technical name for that? (**Suppletion.**) Why has nothing tidied this verb up? (**It is too common — you never guess at it, so analogy never reaches it.**) Next: the past tense that is built on this verb rather than out of it.

Chapter 27

The Past That Takes To Be

Modes:  voice (8)  eyes (1)  Hands-free start: first 8 of 9 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can build the German past of verbs of motion and change with the verb for “to be” instead of the verb for “to have”, and say why the participle never changes.

Motion and change of state build their perfect on sein rather than haben — ich bin gegangen beside ich habe gelernt. The chapter teaches the rule, then the four verbs that follow it (kommen, fahren, werden, bleiben), then the short list that has to be learned outright, and finally the one place German is simpler than French: the participle in the perfect agrees with nothing at all.

27.1 ich bin gegangen — the perfect built on sein

You built the everyday past with *haben* — **ich habe gelernt**. A particular family of verbs refuses *haben* and takes this chapter’s verb instead.

Grammar Lens: which verbs take sein

Verbs of **motion** and **change of state** build their perfect with **sein**, not *haben*.

An action that leaves you somewhere else, or leaves you something else, takes *sein*. An ordinary activity that leaves you where you were keeps *haben*: *ich habe gearbeitet, ich habe getanzt*.

Gehen is the model, and because every present form of *sein* now belongs to you, the whole thing reads off without a single new word:

German	English
<i>ich bin gegangen</i>	I went / I have gone
<i>du bist gegangen</i>	you went
<i>er ist gegangen</i>	he went
<i>wir sind gegangen</i>	we went
The recipe is the one you already know, with the helper swapped: present form of sein + past participle, and the participle goes last	

Sounds you'll need

- **ge-prefix** — *gegangen* opens with the same unstressed **ge-** that wrapped *gelernt* and *gesagt*. It is never stressed; the weight falls on *-gang-*.
- **ich-laut** — and *ich* keeps its soft ending right before it, so the phrase runs *ich bin ge-GANG-en* without a break.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ich bin gegangen; du bist gegangen; er ist gegangen; wir sind gegangen”
- the contrast — “ich habe gelernt ... ich bin gegangen”
- the rule — “motion and change take sein”

Twice through: “ich bin gegangen.”

Before you move on

Which family of verbs takes *sein*? (**Motion and change of state.**) Say “I went.” (**Ich bin gegangen.**) Where does the participle sit? (**At the end.**) Which helper does *arbeiten* take? (**Haben** — it is an activity, not a change.) Next: the first of the family, and it is the one you say most.

27.2 kommen — “to come”

Motion takes *sein*. Here is the motion verb you will use as often as *gehen*, and it is an English word you already own.

You’ll want to know: kommen

kommen — “to come.”

ich bin gekommen — “I came.”

The infinitive wears the **-en** you know. The participle is **gekommen**: the *ge-* wrap in front, and *-en* rather than *-t* at the back, because this is one of the old strong verbs rather than a regular one.

Coming is arriving somewhere you were not. That is motion with a result, so it takes *sein*, exactly as *gehen* does.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

kommen and English **come** are the same word, both from Germanic **kwemanq*. No Latin anywhere in the line — French *venir* and Spanish *venir* come from Latin *venīre* instead, which is where English gets *advent*, *convene* and *venue*.

So English, as usual, owns both halves: the everyday **come** from the Germanic side, the formal **convene** from the Latin.

Sounds you’ll need

- **vowel-o** — the **o** is short and open, the vowel of English *cot*, not the *uh* English puts in *come*.
- **ge-prefix** — *gekommen* keeps the unstressed **ge-**; the stress is on **-KOMM-**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “kommen” — short open *o*
- “ich bin gekommen”
- “ich bin gegangen ... ich bin gekommen”

Twice through: “ich bin gekommen.”

Before you move on

What does *kommen* mean? (“**To come.**”) Say “I came.” (**Ich bin gekommen.**) Which helper, and why? (**Sein** — it is motion.) Which English word is it? (**Come.**) Next: the verb that covers everything with a vehicle under it.

27.3 fahren — “to travel, to drive”

Gehen is going on your feet. When there is a vehicle under you, German changes the verb.

You’ll want to know: fahren

fahren — “to travel, to go by vehicle, to drive.”

ich bin gefahren — “I travelled, I drove.”

German keeps two verbs where English makes do with *go*. You **gehen** on foot and you **fahren** in anything with wheels — a car, a bus, a train, a bicycle. Getting that pair right is one of the first things that makes a learner sound German rather than translated.

It is motion, so the helper is *sein*.

Sounds you’ll need

- **vowel-a-long** — the **a** is long and open, as in *war*.
- **h-silent-lengthening** — and the **h** after it is the silent stretcher you met in *gehen* and *sehen*: it is not breathed, it only holds the vowel. *FAH-ren* rhymes with the way *gehen* and *sehen* are built.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

fahren is English **fare** — the old verb meaning “to travel,” which English demoted to a noun and then almost forgot. It is still there in:

English word	what it is really saying
farewell	travel well
thoroughfare	a way you can travel through
seafaring	sea-travelling
the fare you pay	what the travelling costs
So <i>auf Wiedersehen</i> and <i>farewell</i> are built the same way: both are a wish handed over at the door, one about seeing again, one about travelling well.	

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “fahren” — long *a*, silent *h*
- “ich bin gefahren”
- the pair — “gehen on foot, fahren with wheels”
- “fahren — fare — farewell”

Twice through: “Ich bin gefahren.”

Before you move on

What does *fahren* mean? (“**To travel, to go by vehicle.**”) Which verb would you use walking to the shop? (***Gehen.***) Say “I drove.” (***Ich bin gefahren.***) Which English word is *fahren*? (**Fare** — as in *farewell*.) Next: the verb for becoming something else.

27.4 werden — “to become”

The rule has two halves. *Gehen, kommen* and *fahren* are the motion half. This one word is the whole of the other half.

You’ll want to know: werden

werden — “to become.”

ich bin geworden — “I became.”

Sein says what you are. *Werden* says what you turn into. Where *sein* sits still, *werden* moves — and that is exactly why it takes *sein* as its helper: becoming is change of state in its purest form.

Ich bin müde geworden. — “I got tired.”

Notice what that sentence does. The adjective you learned with *sein* now describes an arrival rather than a condition. German makes the difference with the verb; English does it with *be* against *get*.

Sounds you’ll need

- **w-as-v** — the **w** is English **v**, as in *war* and *wir*.
- **d-t-final** — and in **wird** (“he becomes”) the final **d** devoices to a **t**, the same rule that turned *sind* into *zint*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

werden is a lost English verb — *weorthan*, “to turn, to come to be” — and its bones are still in the language:

English	the buried meaning
toward	turning to
backward	turning back
worth	what a thing turns out to be

So *werden* means “to turn into,” and every time you say *toward* you are using the same root without knowing it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “werden” — *VAIR-den*
- “ich bin geworden”
- “Ich bin müde geworden.” — “I got tired”
- “werden — toward — worth”

Twice through: “Ich bin müde geworden.”

Before you move on

What does *werden* mean? (“**To become.**”) Why does it take *sein*? (**It is change of state** — the other half of the rule.) Say “I became.” (**Ich bin geworden.**) Which English words hide the same root? (***Toward, backward, worth.***) Next: the two verbs that break the rule by standing still.

27.5 bleiben — “to stay”

Werden takes *sein* because it is pure change. This verb takes *sein* too — and it means staying exactly where you are.

You’ll want to know: bleiben

bleiben — “to stay, to remain.”

ich bin geblieben — “I stayed.”

By the rule as stated, this verb should take *haben*. Staying is not motion and it is not change; it is the absence of both. It takes *sein* anyway, and every German learner meets it as a fact rather than a consequence.

The honest way to hold it: *bleiben* is on the *sein* list because it is about **where you are** rather than **what you do**, and that is the deeper thing the motion rule was pointing at all along.

Sounds you’ll need

- **diphthong-ei** — **ei** is the *eye* vowel again, exactly as in *sein*. So *bleiben* is *BLY-ben*, never *blee-ben*. The two verbs of this chapter that break the rule both carry that vowel.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

bleiben is **be-** plus an old Germanic verb *liba-*, “to remain.” English lost the verb and kept its leavings — literally: what **remains** after everything else has gone is what English calls the **leftovers**, and *leave* in the sense of *what is left* belongs to the same family.

German still uses the verb every day; English kept only the residue of it, which is a fitting fate for a word meaning “to be left over.”

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “bleiben” — *BLY-ben*, the *eye* vowel
- “ich bin geblieben”
- the odd pair — “ich bin geworden ... ich bin geblieben”

Twice through: “Ich bin geblieben.”

Before you move on

What does *bleiben* mean? (“**To stay.**”) Say “I stayed.” (**Ich bin geblieben.**) Does the motion rule predict its helper? (**No** — it has to be learned.) How is *ei* pronounced? (Like English **eye**.) Next: the rest of the verbs that have to be learned, including this chapter’s own verb.

27.6 ich bin gewesen — and the rest of the learned list

Bleiben was the first verb the rule failed to predict. Here is the whole of the rest of that list, and it is short.

Grammar Lens: the verbs you simply learn

Besides motion and change, a small fixed set of verbs takes *sein* and has to be **learned**.

verb	perfect	meaning
<i>sein</i>	<i>ich bin gewesen</i>	I have been
<i>bleiben</i>	<i>ich bin geblieben</i>	I stayed
<i>gelingen</i>	<i>es ist gelingen</i>	it succeeded
<i>geschehen</i>	<i>es ist geschehen</i>	it happened
<i>passieren</i>	<i>es ist passiert</i>	it happened
<i>begegnen</i>	<i>ich bin begegnet</i>	I met

Sein and *bleiben* head the list because they are the two that most clearly contradict the rule: one says a thing simply is, the other says it stays. The rest are events that arrive of their own accord —

succeeding, happening, running into somebody — and German treats an arrival as a change.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Look closely at **gewesen**. Strip the *ge-* wrap and the *-en* ending and what is left is **wes-** — the third of the three roots inside this verb, the one that gave *war* and English *was*.

So *sein* reaches for that root twice: once for its past tense, once for its participle. The infinitive comes from one root, the present from two, the past and participle from a third. There is no part of this verb that belongs to all of it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ich bin gewesen; ich bin geblieben”
- “es ist passiert” — “it happened”
- “war ... gewesen” — the same root twice

Twice through: “ich bin gewesen.”

Before you move on

Name the two verbs at the head of the learned list. (***Sein*** and ***bleiben***.) Say “I have been.” (**Ich bin gewesen**.) Say “it happened.” (**Es ist passiert** — or *es ist geschehen*.) Which root is hiding inside *gewesen*? (***wes-**, the one behind *war*.) Next: the ending German does not put on any of these.

27.7 gegangen — the participle that never changes

French draws the same *have*-against-*be* line German does. Here is the place the two languages part company, and German comes out easier.

Grammar Lens: German agrees with nothing here

Inside the perfect, the German participle takes **no ending at all**. *Gegangen* is *gegangen* for every person, number and gender.

	French	German
he went	<i>il est allé</i>	<i>er ist gegangen</i>
she went	<i>elle est allée</i>	<i>sie ist gegangen</i>
they went	<i>ils sont allés</i>	<i>sie sind gegangen</i>

French makes the participle agree with its subject and spells the agreement out three different ways. German changes the helper — *ist*, *sind* — and leaves the participle exactly where it found it.

Old High German did inflect it here, at least some of the time. Modern German lost that, along with most of its other adjective-like endings in this position. So the simplicity is not a design; it is an erosion, and German happens to have come out ahead.

Why it's said this way

It would be easy to assume German copied this split from Latin, the way it borrowed so much else. It did not.

The *haben*-perfect and the *sein*-perfect are **native Germanic developments**. They grew up alongside the Romance ones rather than out of them: neighbouring languages drifting the same way over centuries of contact, the same areal spread that pushed the simple past out of everyday speech in French, German and Italian together.

Two things to carry forward, and they point in opposite directions:

- the **split** between the two helpers is shared with French;
- the **agreement** is not.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “er ist gegangen; sie ist gegangen; sie sind gegangen”
- the participle, unchanged, three times — “gegangen, gegangen, gegangen”

- the comparison — “elle est allée ... sie ist gegangen”

Twice through: “sie ist gegangen; sie sind gegangen.”

Before you move on

Does the German participle agree with its subject in the perfect? (**No** — never.) What changes instead? (**The helper** — *ist, sind*.) Does French agree? (**Yes**.) Did German take this split from Latin? (**No** — it grew in parallel.) Next: the one place a German participle does take an ending.

27.8 der angekommene Zug — where the ending comes back

The participle takes no ending in the perfect. That is a fact about the perfect, not about participles — and the difference matters.

Grammar Lens: in front of a noun, it inflects

A German participle standing **in front of a noun** is working as an adjective, and it takes the endings adjectives take there.

German	English
<i>ein geschriebener Brief</i>	a written letter
<i>der angekommene Zug</i>	the arrived train
<i>die eingeschlafene Katze</i>	the fallen-asleep cat

Each noun keeps its capital, and each participle now carries a small ending chosen by the article in front of it. That is the ordinary German adjective machine, applied to a participle. (*Katze*, “cat”, gets a lesson of its own later; here it is only carrying the ending.) So German did not lose participle endings everywhere. It lost them in exactly one construction: the perfect.

Sounds you’ll need

- **ge-prefix** — all three participles above still carry their **ge-** wrap, and it is still unstressed. In *angekommen* it has slid into

the middle of the word, behind *an-*, which is where German puts it when a prefix comes first.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “der angekommene Zug”
- “die eingeschlafene Katze”
- the contrast — “sie ist gegangen” (no ending) ... “die eingeschlafene Katze” (ending)
- “die müde Mutter” — an ordinary adjective doing the same thing

Before you move on

Where does a German participle still take an ending? (**In front of a noun**, as an adjective.) Where does it never take one? (**In the perfect**.) Say “the arrived train.” (**Der angekommene Zug**.) What is the participle behaving as, in that phrase? (**An adjective**.) Next: choosing between the two helpers, on the spot.

27.9 Practice — haben or sein?

No new words. The only skill left in this chapter is picking the right helper without stopping to think, and that is drill.

Grammar Lens: the whole family in one place

verb	perfect	why
<i>gehen</i>	<i>ich bin gegangen</i>	motion
<i>kommen</i>	<i>ich bin gekommen</i>	motion
<i>fahren</i>	<i>ich bin gefahren</i>	motion
<i>werden</i>	<i>ich bin geworden</i>	change of state
<i>bleiben</i>	<i>ich bin geblieben</i>	learned
<i>sein</i>	<i>ich bin gewesen</i>	learned
<i>lernen</i>	<i>ich habe gelernt</i>	ordinary activity
<i>machen</i>	<i>ich habe gemacht</i>	ordinary activity

Read the right-hand column and you can see how much of the work the motion rule does on its own: only two rows have to be memorised outright.

The exchange

German	English
<i>Wo bist du gewesen?</i>	Where have you been?
<i>Ich bin nach Berlin gefahren.</i>	I travelled to Berlin.
<i>Und Anna? Ist sie gekommen?</i>	And Anna? Did she come?
<i>Anna ist zu Hause geblieben.</i>	Anna stayed at home.
<i>Ich habe viel gelernt. Jetzt bin ich müde.</i>	I learned a lot. Now I am tired.

Note the third and fourth lines: *ist sie gekommen*, *Anna ist geblieben* — a feminine subject both times, and not one letter added to either participle.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the contrast pair — “*ich habe gelernt ... ich bin gegangen*”
- the family — “*bin gekommen, bin gefahren, bin geworden, bin geblieben, bin gewesen*”
- the French comparison — “*elle est allée ... sie ist gegangen*”, no ending at all
- the one place the ending returns — “*der angekommene Zug*”

- the whole exchange, both voices

Twice through: “ich habe gelernt ... ich bin gegangen.”

What you’ve built — where this volume pauses

You have gone from *guten Tag* to two working past tenses, and the method has not changed once: take the word apart, find the English cousin sleeping inside it, and let the family tree do the memorising for you.

The next volume picks the thread back up with describing what you see.

Before you move on

Which helper for *tanzen*, “to dance”? (**Haben** — an activity.)

Which for *fahren*? (**Sein** — motion.) Which two verbs on the *sein* list mean the opposite of change? (**Sein** and **bleiben**.) Say “she stayed.” (**Sie ist geblieben** — no ending on the participle.)

Chapter 28

Head and Hand

Modes: ⇄ voice (3) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 3 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name the head and the hand in German, devolve the final *d* of Hand, and say where the Germanic and Latin families stop matching.

Say die Hand with its final d spoken as t, bring the d back in die Hände, run the Germanic body set Hand/Arm/Finger/Fuß/Herz, and name the gap: main, mano, mão — but Hand.

28.1 Der Kopf — “the head”

Learn the first body part with its article and its characteristic final sound.

You’ll want to know: der Kopf

der Kopf — the head

It is masculine and capitalised because every German noun begins with a capital letter.

Sounds you’ll need

At the end of **Kopf**, close for *p* and release directly into *f*. English has no identical native ending, so practise it slowly:

Ko-p-f → **Kopf**

Grammar Lens: Kopf + Schmerzen

A useful phrase is:

Ich habe Kopfschmerzen. — I have a headache.

German compounds simply place nouns together: **Kopf** (head) + **Schmerzen** (pains).

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Kopf originally meant a **cup or bowl**. It is related to English **cup**; both were early borrowings of Late Latin *cuppa*. A container word became slang for the skull and eventually took over the everyday job. German's older inherited head-word did not disappear completely. The next micro-lesson follows it into compounds and compares the same container metaphor in French.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “der Kopf” — release *p* into *f*
- “Ich habe Kopfschmerzen.”
- “Kopf — cup or bowl”

Twice through: “Der Kopf — masculine, capitalised.”

Before you move on

Say “the head.” (**Der Kopf**.) Give its gender. (**Masculine**.) Why the capital? (It is a **noun**.) What did *Kopf* first mean? (A **cup or bowl**.) Name the related English word. (**Cup**.) Next: find the inherited word *Haupt*.

28.2 Kopf / Haupt — two head-words

Kopf began as “cup.” German's inherited word for “head” is **Haupt**, a cousin of English *head* and Latin *caput*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

language	inherited form
Latin	<i>caput</i>
German	Haupt
English	head

The initial $k \rightarrow h$ relationship reflects Grimm's law, the same systematic Germanic sound shift seen in Latin *pater* beside English *father*. The later consonants have their own history; use the initial pair as the clear signal.

Haupt survives in compounds and formal vocabulary:

- **Hauptstadt** — capital, literally “head city”;
- **Hauptbahnhof** — main station;
- **Hauptsache** — main thing.

Why it's said this way

language	everyday word	older picture
German	Kopf	<i>cuppa</i> , cup
French	<i>tête</i>	<i>testa</i> , pot

Both languages independently promoted a vessel-word to “head,” while keeping the older head-root in words for chiefs, capitals, or main things. The vocabulary sources are both Latin loans, but the **metaphor** was applied separately: heads look like bowls in many languages.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “Kopf — everyday cup-word”
- “Haupt — inherited head-word”
- “Hauptstadt, Hauptbahnhof”

Twice through: “Kopf took the job; Haupt stayed in compounds.”

Before you move on

Which word is everyday “head”? (**Kopf**.) Which inherited word survives in compounds? (**Haupt**.) Name two compounds. (**Hauptstadt, Hauptbahnhof**.) What parallel metaphor did French use? (**Tête**, originally a pot.) Next: the hand.

28.3 die Hand — “the hand”

After the tangle of *Kopf* and *Haupt*, here is the easiest word in the chapter — and a useful lesson about when languages **don’t** match.

You’ll want to know: die Hand

die Hand — the hand. **Feminine**, and spelled exactly like English.

Sounds you’ll need

One pronunciation note: the final **d** is said as a **t**. German devoices a consonant at the end of a word, so *Hand* **ends** like English *hunt* — but with the open *ah* of *Tag*, not *hunt*’s vowel. Add an ending and the *d* comes back: *die Hände* (“the hands”).

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Hand is Germanic **handuz*, and English inherited it directly. Same word, same meaning, two thousand years apart. German and English are close relatives, and body parts are where you feel it most:

German	English
Hand	hand
Arm	arm
Finger	finger
Fuß	foot
Herz	heart

Why it's said this way

Now the interesting part. Every Romance language builds “hand” on Latin *manus*:

French	<i>la main</i>
Italian	<i>la mano</i>
Portuguese	<i>a mão</i>
Spanish	<i>la mano</i>

And Germanic — German, English — has **handuz*, which is **not related to *manus* at all**. The two families simply have different words here.

That is worth noticing, because these connections keep turning up, and it can start to feel as though everything must connect. It doesn't. Indo-European languages share a great deal, and then diverge, and “hand” is one of the places where they diverged early and completely. The Latin word did reach German — but only as **borrowed vocabulary**: *Manuskript*, *Maniküre*, *manuell*. Learned imports, sitting beside the native word without displacing it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “die Hand” — final **d** said as **t**
- the plural, and hear the *d* return — “die Hände”
- the Germanic set — “Hand, Arm, Finger, Fuß, Herz”
- the gap — “*main*, *mano*, *mão* ... but **Hand**”

Before you move on

Say “the hand.” (*Die Hand* — **feminine**.) How is the final **d** pronounced, and why? (As a **t** — German **devoices** final consonants; the *d* returns in *Hände*.) Is *Hand* related to French *main*? (**No** — Germanic **handuz* against Latin *manus*; the families differ here.) How did *manus* reach German anyway? (As **borrowed** learned words — *Manuskript*, *manuell*.) Next: the rest of the body.

Chapter 29

Yes and No

Modes: 🗣️ voice (2) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 2 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can answer yes or no in German and take nein apart into ni + ein, the same 'not one' English froze into none.

*Say nein to rhyme with nine, split it into ni + ein and match it to English none, then run the PIE *ne chain — nōn, non, nein, nahīm.*

29.1 ja — yes

The easiest German word to say, and one English almost shares.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

ja = **yes**. Said *yah* — remember German **j** is pronounced like English **y**, never the English “j.”

It's an ancient **Germanic** word, and English kept the very same root in the one word that still clearly shows it:

- **yea** — the old, formal “yes” (*the yeas and the nays* in a vote) — this is *ja*'s direct cousin, same Proto-Germanic root.
- **aye** — the sailor's and parliament's “yes” (*Aye, aye, captain*) — *sounds* like a cousin, but its origin is actually **uncertain**; it may come from a different word entirely, so don't bank on it.

So German *ja* and English *yea* are the same little word, split between two cousin languages. (English's everyday *yes* is a compound of that

same *yea* with an old “be it so.”)

Grammar Lens: A German habit to file away

German also has a **third** answer-word, **doch**, for one special job: contradicting a **negative** — exactly like French *si*. If someone says something *isn't* so and you insist it *is*, you say **doch**, not *ja*:

Du kommst nicht? (“You’re not coming?”) — **Doch!**
 (“Yes I am!”)

You’ll drill *doch* on its own later; for now, keep *ja* for a plain yes and know *doch* is waiting for the contradictions.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ja” — *yah*, the j like English y
- the English cousin — “yea... ja” (and maybe *aye*)
- the contradiction preview — “Du kommst nicht? — Doch!”

Before you move on

How do you say yes in German? (**ja**, *yah*.) How is the **j** pronounced? (Like English **y**.) Which English word is *ja*’s firm direct cousin? (**yea** — *aye* only looks like one; its origin is uncertain.) What German word answers *yes* specifically to contradict a **negative**? (**doch**.)

29.2 nein — no

German’s “no” is a tiny sentence with a number hidden inside it.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

nein = **no**. Said to rhyme with English *nine* (the **ei** in German is always *eye*).

Take it apart and it's two words fused: **ni** + **ein** — literally “**not one**.” English did the *exact same trick*: **ne** + **one** → **none**. So German *nein* and English *none* are the same idea — “not a single one” — hardened into a bare “no.”

Why it's said this way

That **n-** at the front is not a coincidence. A single ancient sound — linguists write it **PIE *ne** — is the negator behind an astonishing sweep of languages you're learning:

from PIE **ne*

Latin	<i>nōn</i> → Spanish no , French non
German	nein (<i>ni</i> -ein)
Hindi	nahīm (from <i>na</i>)
English	no , not , none

Learn *nein* and you've really met the same “n-of-no” that will greet you again in Hindi, and that also sits inside Spanish and French. One negative, half the world.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “nein” — rhymes with *nine*
- taken apart — “ni + ein = not one”, like English *none*
- the family — “nōn... non... nein... nahīm” — all the PIE *ne*

Before you move on

How do you say no in German? (**nein**, rhymes with *nine*.) What two words is it fused from, and what do they mean? (**ni** + **ein** — “not one.”) Which English word is built the same way? (**none** = *ne* + *one*.) What ancient sound links German *nein*, Latin *nōn* and Hindi *nahīm*? (**PIE *ne**, the negator.)

Chapter 30

Please

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🖱️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

***By the end of this chapter:** I can ask politely for something in German by putting **bitte** after the thing I want — **Wasser, bitte**.*

*Assemble a complete polite request out of two words already learned — **Wasser, bitte** — and hear the request still living inside **bitte** via **bitten**, English **bid** and **bead**. The chapter's only lesson, so the payoff covers everything it introduces.*

30.1 **bitte** — turn a known word into a polite request

You already use **bitte** after **danke** to mean “you’re welcome.” Now give that same small word its other everyday job: **please**.

You’ll want to know: A complete small request

Wasser, bitte. — Water, please.

Nothing here is new except the job **bitte** is doing. You learned **Wasser** with the food. Put **bitte** after the thing you want and the two known words become a complete, polite small request. The comma marks the little pause you will naturally hear before **bitte**.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Bitte is the request form of **bitten**, “to ask, request, pray.” Its English cousins are **bid**—as in “I bid you welcome”—and **bead**, whose oldest meaning was a prayer. A prayer bead was first the object used to count those requests.

So when you add **bitte**, the word itself is already doing the asking.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “Wasser.” — water
- “Wasser, bitte.” — water, please
- the root family — “bitten, bitte, bid, bead”

Before you move on

Ask politely for water. (**Wasser, bitte.**) What older lesson supplied both words? (**Bitte** came from the courtesy loop; **Wasser** came from the food chapter.) Which verb is **bitte** built from? (**Bitten**, “to ask or request.”) Name its two English cousins. (**Bid** and **bead.**)

Chapter 31

Sorry

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can apologise or excuse myself in German with *Entschuldigung*, and reach for *es tut mir leid* when I mean it more.

Say Schuld, then Entschuldigung as the 'un-guiling' built on it, and switch to es tut mir leid for real regret rather than a bump in the hallway. The chapter's only lesson, so the payoff covers everything it introduces.

31.1 Entschuldigung — “sorry” / “excuse me”

You already know **bitte** does triple duty for “please,” “you’re welcome,” and “here you go.” German’s word for **sorry** is just as hard-working: **Entschuldigung** covers both “**excuse me**” and “**I’m sorry**.”

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

- **ent-** = a “removal / undoing” prefix — the same shape as in **entdecken** (“un-cover” → discover) or **entfernen** (“un-distance” → remove).
- **Schuld** = “**guilt, fault, blame**” (also, separately, “debt” — a *Schuld* can be money owed or wrong done).
- **-igung** = a noun-forming suffix, roughly “-ing/-ation.”

So **Entschuldigung** is literally “**an un-guiling**” — the act of

removing blame. Saying it hands the guilt back: *I release you from any fault* (when getting someone's attention or brushing past) or *I ask you to release me from mine* (when apologizing).

Schuld has a striking cousin: it traces to the same ancient Germanic root as English **shall** and **should** — a verb that originally meant “**to owe.**” *Schuld* (what is owed, guilt) and *shall* (what one is obliged to do) are, at root, the same idea of an obligation outstanding.

Why it's said this way

For **deeper regret** — real sorrow, not a bump in the hallway — German often reaches for **es tut mir leid**, literally “**it does to-me sorrow**”:

- **es** = “it,” **tut** = “does” (from **tun**, “to do”), **mir** = “to me,” **Leid** = “sorrow, suffering” (a cousin of English **loath**, both from a root meaning “hateful, painful”).

Use **Entschuldigung** for the everyday sorry/excuse-me (stepping on a foot, interrupting), and **es tut mir leid** when you mean it more — condolences, a real regret. The two overlap; native speakers move between them by feel.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “Schuld” — guilt/fault — then “Entschuldigung,” sorry / excuse me
- the deeper phrase — “es tut mir leid,” it pains me / I’m so sorry

Before you move on

What does **Entschuldigung** literally mean, piece by piece? (“**Un-guiling**” — *ent-* “away” + *Schuld* “guilt/fault.”) What English word shares Schuld’s ancient root? (**Shall/should** — both from a root meaning “to owe.”) What’s the deeper phrase for real regret? (**Es tut mir leid**, “it does to me sorrow.”)

Chapter 32

Weather

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🖱️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can talk about the weather in German — das Wetter, es ist heiß, es ist kalt, es regnet.

Say das Wetter as English weather's own cousin, build hot and cold with sein rather than a Romance 'make', and say es regnet on the same root as English rain. The chapter's only lesson, so the payoff covers everything it introduces.

32.1 das Wetter, es regnet — German's own native words, English's own cousins

Every Romance language you've met so far shares the exact same Latin word for “weather” (*tempus*). German breaks completely from that family — with a word that's actually a much closer cousin of English.

The two words: das Wetter and weather

das Wetter = “**weather**” — from Proto-Germanic *wedraq* — the **exact same word** as English **weather** itself (both descend from the same Germanic ancestor, not one borrowed from the other). Unlike Spanish's *tiempo*, French's *temps*, or Latin's own *tempus*-family, German's weather word has **no connection to Latin at all** — it's a native Germanic inheritance, cousin to English rather than to Romance.

Grammar Lens: Es ist heiß / Es ist kalt

Es ist heiß. — “It’s hot.” — literally “it **is** hot.” **Es ist kalt.** — “It’s cold.” — literally “it **is** cold.”

German uses **sein** (“to be”) here — matching the same “**be**” pattern you already met in German’s own AGE lesson (*ich bin zwanzig*), not the Romance “make” periphrasis (*hacer/faire*).

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Es regnet. — “It’s raining.” — from **regnen** ← Proto-Germanic *regnōnq* — the **same root** as English **rain**. Just like *Wetter*/ “weather,” this is a genuine Germanic cousin-pair, not a shared Latin borrowing the way Spanish’s *llueve* and French’s *pleut* are.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “Wetter” — weather, the same word as English “weather”
- “Es ist heiß. Es ist kalt.” — it’s hot/cold
- “Es regnet” — it’s raining, same root as English “rain”

Before you move on

Does **Wetter** come from Latin, like the Romance languages’ weather words? (**No** — it’s native Germanic, the same word as English “weather.”) What verb does German use for “it’s hot/cold” — *sein* (“be”) or a *hacer*-style “make”? (**Sein**, “to be” — matching German’s own AGE pattern.) What English word is **regnet** related to? (**Rain** — same Proto-Germanic root, *regnōnq*.)

Chapter 33

Dog and Cat

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can name a dog and a cat in German and say which of the two words German inherited and which one it borrowed.

Say Hund beside English hound and the unexplained dog that displaced it, then say Katze and admit it is the borrowed Late Latin cattus — widespread, but not universal: Romanian pisică and Serbian mačka went their own way. The chapter's only lesson, so the payoff covers everything it introduces.

33.1 Hund, Katze — one native word, one surprising loan

Here's a real surprise to end this comparison on: German's word for “dog” is native and expected — but its word for “cat” secretly isn't native at all.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Hund (“**dog**”) is native Germanic, from **Proto-Indo-European** **kwon-* — and it has a direct cousin sitting inside English itself: **hound**. Old English **hund** was the ordinary, everyday word for “dog” for centuries — until, for reasons nobody fully understands, **dog** (Old English *docga*) pushed it out by the 16th century, leaving *hound* to narrow down to just hunting dogs. English's *dog* is, honestly, its **own** unexplained mystery word, with no confirmed cognates in any other

language — the exact same *shape* of story as Spanish’s *perro* displacing *can*, just in a completely different language family.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Here’s the twist: **Katze** (“cat”) looks like it should be native Germanic too, sitting right next to native *Hund* — but it isn’t. **Katze** descends from Proto-Germanic ***kattuz**, which is itself a borrowing of the **same Late Latin cattus** you already met with French’s *chat* and Spanish’s *gato* — most likely ultimately **Afro-Asiatic**, traveling out of Egypt along Roman trade routes. Every Germanic language shows this **same** borrowing (Dutch *kat*, Swedish *katt*, Icelandic *köttur*) — so unlike “dog” words, which go their own separate ways in nearly every language, “cat” words are remarkably **widespread** across both Germanic and Romance, because the word traveled **with the animal itself**. Be honest that this isn’t a universal rule, though: **Romanian** (*pisică*) and much of **South Slavic** (Serbian/Croatian *mačka*) built their own onomatopoeic cat-words instead, imitating the sound of a cat’s call rather than inheriting *cattus* — so the spread is wide, but not without real exceptions.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “Hund” — dog, native Germanic, cousin of English “hound”
- the parallel — English replaced “hound” with the still-mysterious “dog,” the same shape as Spanish’s *perro*/*can*
- “Katze” — cat, surprisingly a Latin loanword, not native at all

Before you move on

Is **Hund** native Germanic, and what’s its English cousin? (**Yes** — cousin of English **hound**.) What word did English replace *hound* with, and is that word’s origin known? (**Dog** — genuinely **unexplained**, no confirmed cognates anywhere.) Is **Katze** native Germanic? (**No** — surprisingly, it’s the same borrowed Late Latin *cattus* behind French’s *chat* and Spanish’s *gato*.)

Chapter 34

Green and Yellow

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can name green and yellow in German, and say why grün is English green’s own cousin while gelb’s link to French jaune is only probable.

Say grün as the direct cousin of English green from a root unrelated to Latin viridis, say gelb, and state the gelb / jaune cousinhood as probable rather than airtight. The chapter’s only lesson, so the payoff covers everything it introduces.

34.1 grün, gelb — English’s own cousin, and a secret cousin of French

German’s green word is a direct cousin of English’s own word. Its yellow word has a cousin too — but a much more surprising one, sitting inside French.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

grün (“green”) is native Germanic, from Proto-Germanic **grōniz*, ultimately from **Proto-Indo-European** **ǵʰreh₁-*, “to grow, to become green” — the **exact same root** as English’s own **green**. Be careful, though: this is a **completely different** root from Latin’s **viridis** (source of Spanish’s *verde*, French’s *vert*), which traces to its own, separate “to grow/flourish” root, **weis-*. Two unrelated language families each independently built a “green” word out of a verb meaning “to grow” — a real coincidence of logic, not a shared word.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

gelb (“yellow”) is native too, from Proto-Germanic **gelwaz* — and the same word as English’s **yellow**. Trace it back far enough, to **Proto-Indo-European** **ghel-* (“to shine,” with derivatives covering yellow, green, and gold), and it is usually said to land on the **same ancient root** behind Latin’s **galbus/galbinus** — the source of **French’s jaune**. Honesty check, though: that particular link is **less secure** than it looks — some modern Latin scholarship treats *galbus*’s origin as genuinely unknown rather than confirming the **ghel-* connection. So *gelb* and *jaune* are **probably** PIE-level cousins, despite belonging to completely different language families and reaching German and French by entirely separate paths — just don’t treat the link as airtight.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “grün” — green, direct cousin of English’s own “green”
- “gelb” — yellow, probable hidden cousin of French’s *jaune*
- the contrast — grün’s root is unrelated to Latin’s *viridis*, but *gelb*’s root is **PROBABLY** shared with French’s *jaune*

Before you move on

Is **grün** related to Latin’s *viridis*? (**No** — a completely different root, though both independently mean “grow” → “green”; *grün* IS a direct cousin of English’s own “green.”) What French word is **gelb**’s probable PIE cousin, and how solid is that link? (**Jaune** — both usually traced to PIE **ghel-*, “to shine,” though modern Latin scholarship treats *galbus*’s origin as genuinely unknown, so the connection is probable, not certain.)

Chapter 35

Verbs of the Mind

Modes:  voice (4)  Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say I think, I understand, I read and I write in German, break a strong verb’s vowel in the du and er forms, and say which of the four German borrowed rather than inherited.

The chapter closes on schreiben, the one loan among four inherited verbs: the reader produces all four ich forms and all four er forms, names liest as the only vowel-breaker, and takes Manuskript apart into the Latin hand German never inherited plus the Latin verb it did. It reaches back past its own chapter to reassess Chapter 17’s Hand, the Hand/manus gap, and Grimm’s law.

35.1 denken — the verb that was inside *danke* all along

You learned early on that **danke** is built on a verb meaning “to think.” Here is that verb, with its own forms at last.

Sounds you’ll need

- **vowel-e-german** — a short, open *e*.
- **ng-cluster** — *n* before *k* is the *ng* of *sing*: **denken** = *DENG-ken*.

You'll want to know: denken

denken means “**to think**,” with the same audible endings you drilled on *wohnen*, *machen* and *lernen*:

- **ich denke** — I think · **wir denken** — we think
- **du denkst** — you think · **ihr denkt** — you all think
- **er denkt** — he thinks · **sie denken** — they think

Ich denke, also bin ich. — “I think, therefore I am.”

It also carries the weather straight into a new sentence:

Ich denke, es ist kalt. — “I think it is cold.”

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

denken is Proto-Germanic **þankijanaþ*. English **think** is that same inherited word — a loan in neither direction.

One consonant separates them, and you have been taught how to read it. With **Haupt** beside *head* you met **Grimm’s law**, which turned Proto-Indo-European **k* into Germanic *h*. The same law turned PIE **t* into Germanic **þ*, the *th* sound. English kept it and spells it **th**: *think*. German later softened it to **d**.

Germanic **þankō* meant both “a thought” and “gratitude” — hence German **Dank** and **Gedanke**, and English **thank** beside **think**. To thank was to hold someone in thought. German also kept a sibling verb, **dünken**, “to seem”; English had that one too and let it collapse into *think*.

Grammar Lens: also does not mean “also”

In *Ich denke, also bin ich*, the word **also** means “**therefore**.” English *also* is *eall swā*, “all so,” meaning *likewise*; German *also* is *al + so*, meaning *thus*. Same bricks, different building. A German saying **also** is drawing a conclusion, not adding to a list.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ich denke, du denkst, er denkt”

- “wir denken, ihr denkt, sie denken”
- “Ich denke, also bin ich.”
- “Ich denke, es ist kalt. Das Wetter ist gut.”
- the family — “denken, danke, Dank, Gedanke”
- the shift — PIE *t*, Germanic *th*, German *d*: think, denken

Before you move on

Which chapter-3 word is built on **denken**? (**Danke**.) Is English *think* a borrowing? (**No** — both inherited **þankijaną*.) Which law turned PIE **t* into the Germanic *th* German made a *d*? (**Grimm’s law**, as in *Haupt* and *head*.) What does German **also** mean? (**Therefore**.)

35.2 verstehen — standing around a thing until you see it

You can say **ich denke**. Thinking happens in the **Kopf**; this is the verb for when it lands — and English built its own word from the same picture, separately.

Sounds you’ll need

- **v-as-f** — German **v** is said *f*, so *ver-* is *fair-*.
- **h-silent-lengthening** — the **h** is silent; it marks the vowel before it as long. **verstehen** = *fair-SHTAY-en*.

You’ll want to know: verstehen

verstehen means “to understand,” with the ordinary endings:

- **ich verstehe · wir verstehen**
- **du verstehst · ihr versteht**
- **er versteht · sie verstehen**

Ich verstehe. — said on its own, constantly. **Ich verstehe Deutsch**. — “I understand German.”

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Break it in two: **ver-** plus **stehen**, “to stand.” *Stehen* is English **stand**, the same inherited word, Proto-Germanic **standanq*. The prefix **ver-** is old and worn, and here it carries its ancient sense “around, about.” So *verstehen* is literally “**to stand around**” a thing. Now English. **Understand** is *under* + *stand* — and that *under* is not “underneath.” The usual explanation is that Old English *under* also carried the sense “among, between,” a cousin of Latin *inter*; so *understand* is “to stand **among**” a thing. That reading is standard but not certain, and no honest account will claim otherwise.

Either way the important fact holds: **each language welded a prefix onto its own inherited verb “to stand” and got a word for comprehension.** Neither borrowed the compound. The green-and-yellow lesson showed the same move with **grün**: Germanic and Latin each built “green” from a verb for “grow,” independently. This is that coincidence one family closer in.

The verb underneath is one of the family’s biggest roots, PIE **steh₂-*: German **der Verstand** (“reason”), English **stand, stead, stall**, and — from Latin’s *stāre* — **state, station, stable, constant**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ich verstehe, du verstehst, er versteht”
- “Ich verstehe Deutsch.”
- both verbs — “Ich denke. Ich verstehe.”
- the pieces — “ver- + stehen” beside “under + stand”
- the parallel — like *grün* beside *viridis*, built, not shared
- where it happens — “der Kopf” — and what stands in it, “der Verstand”

Before you move on

What are the two pieces of **verstehen**? (**Ver-** + **stehen**.) Which English verb is *stehen*? (**Stand**.) Did English borrow *understand*

from German? (**No** — each built its own compound.) How solid is the “under = among” account? (**Standard, but not certain.**) Say “I think” and “I understand.” (*Ich denke. Ich verstehe.*)

35.3 lesen — gathering, and the first verb that changes its vowel

Every German verb so far has kept its vowel in every form. This one does not — and its older meaning is **gathering**.

Sounds you'll need

- long-e — a long *e*, English *ay* without the glide.
- s-voiced — a single *s* between vowels buzzes like *z*: *LAY-zen*.

You'll want to know: lesen

lesen means “to read.”

- **ich lese** — I read · **wir lesen** — we read
- **du liest** — you read · **ihr lest** — you all read
- **er liest** — he reads · **sie lesen** — they read

Ich lese Deutsch. — “I read German.”

Grammar Lens: the vowel that breaks in the middle

Four forms keep the *e* of *lesen*. Two swap it for a long *ie*: *du liest*, *er liest*.

That is the mark of a **strong verb**: the vowel changes inside the word, in exactly two present-tense forms — **du** and **er/sie/es**. Nothing else moves; the endings stay the familiar *-e* / *-st* / *-t*. It is a rule about a whole class of verbs, not about *lesen*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

lesen is Proto-Germanic **lesaną*, “to gather.” That sense still lives in **die Weinlese**, the grape harvest — the *wine-gathering*, built on the

Wein you already have. Reading came second: you pick the letters up, one after another.

Now the trap. Latin **legere** also meant “to gather,” also came to mean “to read,” and stands behind **legible**, **lecture**, **lesson** and **collect**. It looks like one shared word. It probably is **not**: the sounds do not correspond as they should, and the standard account ties *lesen* to a separate root, whose clearest cousin is Lithuanian *lèsti*, “to peck up grain.” Treat it as you treated **grün** beside *viridis*.

English **read** is a third story: Old English *rædan*, “to advise,” which is German **raten** and **das Rätsel** (“riddle”). *Lesen* and *read* are no relation.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ich lese, du liest, er liest” — hear the vowel break
- “wir lesen, ihr lest, sie lesen” — and back
- “Ich lese Deutsch. Ich verstehe Deutsch.”
- the old meaning — “die Weinlese”
- the three so far — “denken, verstehen, lesen”
- why *lesen* is not *legere* — the reason *grün* is not *viridis*

Before you move on

Which two forms of a strong verb break their vowel, and what are they here? (**Du** and **er/sie/es** — **du liest, er liest**.) What did *lesen* mean first? (**To gather** — *die Weinlese*.) Is it Latin *legere*? (**Probably not** — the sounds do not correspond.) And English *read*? (**No relation** — it meant “to advise,” and is German *raten*.)

35.4 schreiben — the one borrowed verb

Three verbs in, all three English’s own blood relatives. The fourth breaks the run: **German borrowed it; English did not.**

Sounds you'll need

- sch-sh — **sch** is one sound, English *sh*.
- diphthong-ei — **ei** is said *eye*: **schreiben** = *SHRY-ben*.

You'll want to know: schreiben

schreiben means “to write.”

- **ich schreibe** — I write · **wir schreiben** — we write
- **du schreibst** — you write · **ihr schreibt** — you all write
- **er schreibt** — he writes · **sie schreiben** — they write

Ich schreibe Deutsch. · **Die Hand schreibt.**

Grammar Lens: strong, but not here

Lesen taught you to watch **du** and **er**. Here: *du schreibst*, *er schreibt* — **the vowel does not move**. *Schreiben* is strong (its past is *schrieb*), but its present is smooth. So the rule is exact: a strong verb may break its vowel there. Hold the pair: *du liest*, but *du schreibst*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

schreiben is Latin *scribere*, and before that “to scratch.” German took it in with the writing itself, and early: the loan passed through German sound changes — *sc-* became *sch-* — and joined the native strong verbs, its past becoming *schrieb*. A late loan would have done neither.

English refused it. **Write** is Old English *writan*, also “to scratch,” because runes were cut; German **reißen** and **ritzen** are its relatives. Two languages, two writing-words, both meaning *scratch*. Latin’s verb reached English anyway: **scribe**, **script**, **describe**, **transcript**. And one closes a circle back to **die Hand**. German **Hand** has **no Latin cousin** — Latin says *manus* — yet *manus* reached German as a loan: **Manuskript**. *Manu-* is *manus*, the hand; *-skript* is *scriptum*, this verb. A **Manuskript** is written *by hand*: the Latin hand-word German never inherited, bolted to the Latin writing-verb it did.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “Die Hand schreibt. Ich schreibe Deutsch.”
- the four “I” forms — “ich denke, ich verstehe, ich lese, ich schreibe”
- the four “he” forms — “er denkt, er versteht, er liest, er schreibt” — only *liest* broke
- three inherited, one borrowed — “denken/think, verstehen/stand, lesen/gather”, then “schreiben/scribere”
- denken’s *d* — PIE *t*, Germanic *th*: Grimm’s law
- “Ich denke, also bin ich.” — and what *also* does
- *Manuskript* — *manus* plus *scriptum*

Before you move on

Say all four “I” forms. (*Ich denke, ich verstehe, ich lese, ich schreibe*.) Which is the loan? (*Schreiben*, from *scribere*, “to scratch” — as English *write* also meant.) Which “he” form breaks its vowel? (Only *liest*.) Which half of *Manuskript* did German never inherit? (*Manus*, its own **Hand**.) And German *also*? (**Therefore**.)

Chapter 36

Taking, Asking, Helping, Liking

Modes: 🗣️ voice (4) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say I take, I ask, I help and I like in German, sort all eight verbs of these two chapters into the three present-tense patterns, and use gern to say I like doing something.

The chapter closes on mögen, lieben and gern: the reader produces all eight ich forms of Chapters 24 and 25, sorts them into vowel-stays, vowel-breaks and the old third pattern, hangs gern on four verbs already learned, and runs the nine-word cousin roll-call. It reaches back to every atom of Chapter 24 and to Chapters 21 and 22 — Ich mag das Wetter, Ich mag die Katze, Der Hund mag Wasser.

36.1 nehmen — the verb English threw away

Four verbs about doing rather than thinking. **Schreiben** was a Latin word German took and English refused; this one is the reverse — a Germanic word English threw away and German kept.

Sounds you'll need

- long-e — a long *e*: **nehmen** = *NAY-men*.
- h-silent-lengthening — the **h** is silent, marking the long vowel.

You'll want to know: nehmen

nehmen means “to take.” It is what a **Hand** does.

- **ich nehme** — I take · **wir nehmen** — we take
- **du nimmst** — you take · **ihr nehmt** — you all take
- **er nimmt** — he takes · **sie nehmen** — they take

Grammar Lens: the rule again, and harder

You know where to look: **du** and **er**. Long *e* becomes short **i** — *du nimmst*, *er nimmt* — while *wir*, *ihr* and *sie* keep the *e*.

This goes further than *lesen* did: once the vowel shortens the silent *h* has no job, so it drops and the **m** doubles: *nehmen* but *nimmt*. Say them back to back — *NAY-men*, *NIMT*.

Three shapes now: *du liest* breaks its vowel; *du nimmst* breaks it and respells the word; *du schreibst* does not break at all.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

nehmen is Proto-Germanic **nemaną*, “to take.” English had it — Old English *niman* — and then **lost it**, because Norse settlers brought *taka* and English took **take** instead.

A lost word leaves fossils, and English carries two. **Numb** is the old past participle of *nim*: a hand *taken* by the cold. **Nimble** is “quick to take hold.”

Beyond Germanic the root **nem-* meant “to assign, to allot,” and Greek’s version is unexpectedly familiar: *némein*, “to distribute,” gives **nomad**, **economy** and **nemesis**.

Why it’s said this way

German **bekommen** means “to receive, to get” — not “to become.” Both are built from the same prefix and the same verb of motion, and then the meanings walked off in opposite directions. A German saying **Ich bekomme...** in a café is being served, not transformed.

Recognise *bekommen*; **say** *nehmen*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ich nehme, du nimmst, er nimmt” — *NAY-me, NIMST, NIMT*
- “wir nehmen, ihr nehmt, sie nehmen” — the long *e* is back
- “Die Hand nimmt. Die Hand schreibt.”
- the three shapes — “du liest, du nimmst, du schreibst”
- the fossils — “nehmen, numb, nimble”
- borrowed against lost — “schreiben came in from Latin; niman went out”
- the trap — “bekommen is *receive*”

Before you move on

Give the *du* and *er* forms. (***Du nimmst, er nimmt*** — the *h* drops, the *m* doubles.) Which verb replaced the English cousin of *nehmen*? (**Take**, from Norse.) Name the two fossils it left. (**Numb** and **nimble**.) What does **bekommen** mean? (**To receive**.) And say “the hand takes.” (***Die Hand nimmt.***)

36.2 fragen — asking, and the three answers German gives back

After two vowel-breaking verbs, a rest: this one keeps its vowel everywhere. And you already own its answers — all **three** of them.

Sounds you’ll need

- vowel-a-german — a pure open *ah*: **fragen** = *FRAH-gen*.
- r-uvular-german — the soft guttural *r* you first met in *lernen*.

You’ll want to know: fragen

fragen means “to ask.”

- **ich frage · wir fragen**
- **du fragst · ihr fragt**

- **er fragt** · **sie fragen**

The noun sits beside it: **die Frage**, “the question.”

Grammar Lens: the vowel that stays

Check the two forms that break in a strong verb. *Du fragst. Er fragt.* The *a* has not moved.

fragen is a **weak** verb — the ordinary kind, built like *lernen* and *machen*: endings only, stem untouched. That matters, because after *lesen* and *nehmen* it is easy to start breaking vowels everywhere. Most German verbs are weak; the strong ones are a closed club, learned one at a time. Hold the pair: **du nimmst**, but **du fragst**.

Why it's said this way

An asked question wants an answer, and you have the whole German set already. English has two. German has **three**:

- **ja** — yes.
- **nein** — no.
- **doch** — the one English has no word for: *yes, against what you just said*. It exists to contradict a negative.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

fragen goes back to Proto-Indo-European ***prek-**, “to ask.” Germanic turned that opening *p* into an *f* — the Grimm’s-law step that puts *father* beside Latin *pater*.

English once had the cousin, Old English *frignan*, and dropped it, just as it dropped the cousin of *nehmen*. The word it uses instead, **ask**, is a different Germanic word and no relation.

So English gets the root back only the long way round. Latin *precārī*, “to beg, to pray,” is the same verb, and gives **pray**, **prayer** and **precarious** — literally “held only by asking for it.”

One caution: Latin *rogāre*, “to ask,” behind *interrogate*, looks like a candidate and is **not** related — it belongs with *rēx* and *right*, a root about straightening and ruling.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ich frage, du fragst, er fragt” — the *a* never moves
- “die Frage” — the question
- the contrast — “du liest, du nimmst”, then “du fragst”
- the three answers — “ja, nein, doch”
- the Latin cousins — “pray, prayer, precarious”
- the two verbs English dropped — “nehmen, fragen”

Before you move on

Is **fragen** strong or weak, and how do you know? (**Weak** — *du fragst*, the vowel never breaks.) Name German’s three answers. (**Ja**, **nein**, **doch** — the last contradicts a negative.) Is English *ask* a relative? (**No**.) Which English words carry the root instead? (**Pray**, **precarious**, through Latin *precārī*.) Say “I ask” and “I take.” (*Ich frage*. *Ich nehme*.)

36.3 helfen — one word, one sound law, two languages

Almost nothing sits between the two words: **helfen** *is* **help**. The lesson is the single sound that separates them — and it is not the law you already know.

Sounds you’ll need

- **h-pronounced** — a real, breathed *h*, unlike the silent one in *nehmen*.
- **f-final** — a clean *f*: **helfen** = *HEL-fen*.

You'll want to know: helfen

helfen means “to help,” and it is strong, so you know where to look:

- ich helfe · wir helfen
- du hilfst · ihr helft
- er hilft · sie helfen

The *e* becomes **i** in *du* and *er*, exactly as in *nehmen* — the third verb to do it, so by now you can predict it.

One honest limit: when German names the person helped, that person's word takes a noun form this book has not taught. Keep to **Ich helfe** on its own.

Why it's said this way

The noun is **die Hilfe**, “help” — the same *e* to *i* change, frozen. And **bitte** gave you the shape for asking politely: name the thing, then say **bitte**.

Hilfe, bitte. — “Help, please.”

A whole request, from one new noun and one old word.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

helfen is Proto-Germanic **helpaną*, and English **help** is the same inherited word.

The only difference is **p** against **f**, from a different law than the one behind **Haupt**. That was **Grimm's law**, the *first* shift, PIE sounds into Germanic ones — seen again in *fragen's* *p* becoming *f*. This is the **second**, High German shift, much later, and the event that split German from English. After a vowel, Germanic **p** became German **f**: *helpan* → **helfen**; *ship* → **Schiff**; *open* → **offen**; *sharp* → **scharf**; *deep* → **tief**.

Outside Germanic, be honest: *helfen* has **no secure cousins** — a proposed link to Lithuanian *šelpiti* is disputed.

English keeps a fossil, though. *Helfen* is still strong — *helfen*, *half*, *geholffen* — and *help* was too: its old **holp** and **holpen** survive in old Bibles and dialect. English let the shape go within recorded memory.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ich helfe, du hilfst, er hilft” — the *e* breaks to *i*
- “Hilfe, bitte.”
- the strong pair — “du nimmst, du hilfst” — then the weak “du fragst”
- the second shift five times — “helfen/help, Schiff/ship, offen/open, scharf/sharp, tief/deep”
- which law was which — Grimm’s law gave *Haupt*; the second shift gave *helfen*

Before you move on

Give the *du* and *er* forms. (***Du hilfst, er hilft.***) Which shift separates *helfen* from *help*, and is it the one behind *Haupt* and *head*? (The **second**, High German shift — **no**, *Haupt* was **Grimm’s law**.) Name two more pairs from it. (**Schiff/ship, offen/open, scharf/sharp.**) Cousins outside Germanic? (**None secure.**) Ask for help politely. (***Hilfe, bitte.***)

36.4 mögen, lieben, gern — German’s three ways of liking

English says “I like.” German has **three** ways, and the commonest is not a verb.

You’ll want to know: mögen and lieben

mögen (“to like”, *MER-gen* — **ö** is *ay* with rounded lips) is a **third** pattern, an old verb whose *ich* and *er* forms take no ending:

- **ich mag · wir mögen**
- **du magst · ihr mögt**
- **er mag · sie mögen**

lieben (“to love”, *LEE-ben* — **ie** is a long *ee*) is weak: *ich liebe, du liebst, er liebt*.

Ich mag die Katze. · Der Hund mag Wasser. · Ich mag das Wetter. · Ich liebe Deutsch.

A masculine **der** noun changes its article after *mögen* — untaught here, so these use **die** and **das** words.

Grammar Lens: gern hangs on any verb

gern is an adverb, “gladly,” dropped in after a verb:

Ich lese gern. — “I read gladly”: **I like reading.** **Ich schreibe gern. · Ich helfe gern.**

English must rebuild the sentence, with *like* plus a verb in *-ing*; German changes nothing. So: **mögen** for a thing, **gern** for an activity, **lieben** for love.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

All three are English words you already own.

mögen is **maganq*, “to have power” — English **may**. The meaning slid from being able, to being inclined, to liking; the power sense survives in **might** and **die Macht**.

lieben is **leubaz*, “dear” — English **love** exactly, with **lief** and **believe** (to *hold dear*). **gern** is **gernaz*, “eager” — English **yearn**. So *Ich lese gern* is “I read yearningly.”

What you’ve built across these two chapters

- **vowel stays:** *denken, verstehen, fragen, schreiben* (strong only in its past).
- **vowel breaks:** *du liest, du nimmst, du hilfst*.
- **third pattern:** *ich mag, du magst, er mag*.
- **the traps:** **bekommen** is “receive,” never “become”; **also** is “therefore,” never “also.”

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ich mag, du magst, er mag”
- “Ich mag die Katze. Der Hund mag Wasser. Ich mag das Wetter.”
- *gern* on four — “Ich lese gern. Ich schreibe gern. Ich helfe gern. Ich frage gern.”
- the breakers, then not — “du liest, du nimmst, du hilfst”, “du fragst”
- all eight “I” forms — “ich denke, ich verstehe, ich lese, ich schreibe, ich nehme, ich frage, ich helfe, ich mag”
- the roll-call — “denken/think, verstehen/stand, lesen/gather, schreiben/scribere, nehmen/numb, fragen/pray, helfen/help, mögen/may, lieben/love, gern/yearn”

Before you move on

How does German say “I like reading,” literally? (***Ich lese gern*** — “I read gladly.”) Say: you like the cat; the dog likes water. (***Ich mag die Katze. Der Hund mag Wasser.***) Which three of the eight break their vowel? (***Lesen, nehmen, helfen.***) And the two traps — **bekommen**, also? (Receive; therefore.)

Chapter 37

Sitting, Standing, Sleeping, Hearing

Modes: 🗣️ voice (4) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say I sit, I stand, I sleep and I hear in German, tell the second shift's t-branch from its p-branch, break a verb's a to ä for du and er, and say which of the four changes German made alone and which it made alongside English.

The chapter closes on hören, the one verb of the four whose vowel cannot break because it was born umlauted: the reader produces all four ich forms and all four er forms, names schlafen as the only breaker, tells Grimm's law on the h of hören and Hund from the second shift on sitzen and schlafen, and hangs gern on the new verb. It reaches back past its own chapter to Chapter 17's Grimm's law, Chapter 22's Hund and Katze with the Hund etymology that had never been revisited, and Chapter 25's mögen, lieben and gern, all three of which were orphans until here.

37.1 sitzen — the same word as *sit*, respelt by one law

Helfen is **help**, split by the second sound shift: Germanic **p** became German **f**. That law has other branches. This verb rides one.

Sounds you'll need

- **tz-affricate** — **tz** is one squeezed sound, *ts*, as in English *cats*.
- **i-short** — a short, tight *i*: **sitzen** = *ZIT-sen*, buzzed at the front because German *s* before a vowel is voiced.

You'll want to know: sitzen

sitzen means “to sit.”

- **ich sitze** — I sit · **wir sitzen** — we sit
- **du sitzt** — you sit · **ihr sitzt** — you all sit
- **er sitzt** — he sits · **sie sitzen** — they sit

Ich sitze. — a whole sentence, two words.

Grammar Lens: strong does not mean it breaks

Sitzen is a **strong** verb — its past is *saß*, not *sitzte*. But its present never breaks its vowel: *du sitzt*, *er sitzt*. Beside it, *helfen* breaks to *du hilfst*.

So “strong” is a fact about a verb’s **past**; the *du/er* break is a separate habit only some strong verbs have.

The doing verbs gave two ways to say you like something: **ich mag** with a thing, **gern** hung on a verb. This verb takes the second.

Ich sitze gern. — “I like sitting.”

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

sitzen is Proto-Germanic **sitjaną*, and English **sit** is the same inherited word — Old English *sittan*, Old High German *sizzen*. The second, High German shift moved Germanic **p** to **f** in *helfen*. It moved Germanic **t** just as hard, to **z** (said *ts*) or **ss**: *sittan* → **sitzen**, *water* → **Wasser**, *eat* → **essen**, *ten* → **zehn**, *bite* → **beißen**. The food lesson handed you *Wasser* and the first numbers handed you *zehn* long before there was a name for what had happened to them. Under both lies PIE **sed-*, “to sit,” one of the family’s great providers. Latin *sedēre* gives **session**, **sedentary** and **preside**; Latin *sedēs*, “a seat,” gives the bishop’s **see**. Greek *hédra*, also “a seat,” gives

cathedral — the church with the bishop’s chair — and **polyhedron**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ich sitze, du sitzt, er sitzt” — the *i* never moves
- the contrast — “du sitzt” beside “du hilfst”
- “Ich sitze gern.”
- the *t* branch four times — “sitzen/sit, Wasser/water, essen/eat, zehn/ten”
- the *p* branch beside it — “helfen/help”
- the seat words — “sitzen, sedēre, hédra, cathedral”

Before you move on

Give the *du* and *er* forms of *sitzen*. (***Du sitzt, er sitzt*** — no break.) Which of the doing verbs does break, and how? (***Helfen*** — *du hilfst*.) Which sound did the second shift turn German’s **z** and **ss** out of? (An old **t**.) Name two pairs from that branch. (***Wasser/water, essen/eat, zehn/ten***.) Say you like sitting. (***Ich sitze gern***.)

37.2 stehen — the verb that was hiding inside *verstehen*

Verstehen was broken into *ver-* plus *stehen*, and named *stehen* as English **stand**. Here is that verb alone, and the letter the two languages disagree about.

Sounds you’ll need

- **st-initial-scht** — **st** at the start of a German word is said *sht*.
- **h-silent-lengthening** — the **h** is silent and marks the long vowel: **stehen** = *SHTAY-en*.

You'll want to know: **stehen**

stehen means “to stand.”

- **ich stehe** — I stand · **wir stehen** — we stand
- **du stehst** — you stand · **ihr steht** — you all stand
- **er steht** — he stands · **sie stehen** — they stand

Like *sitzen*, it keeps its vowel all the way through. Two postures, two sentences:

Ich sitze. Ich stehe.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Germanic ran two stems off one root here: a short **stānq* and a longer **standanq* with an **n** wedged inside. English generalised the long one and got **stand**; German took the short one and got **stehen**, Old High German *stān*.

German did not lose the *n*. It kept it in the past: **ich stand**, and the participle **gestanden**. German's past tense is spelt the way English's present is, out of the same drawer of stems.

The root is PIE **steh₂-*, the one *verstehen* named, and it is everywhere. Latin *stāre* gave **state**, **station**, **stable**, **constant**. Greek *hístēmi*, “I set up,” gave **static**, **system** and **ecstasy** — standing outside yourself. German built **die Stadt**, a city: a standing-place. English built **stead**, **steady** and **instead**.

Why it's said this way

Notice the shape of what has happened. *Sitzen* goes back to **sed-*, and so does Latin's *sedēre*. *Stehen* goes back to **steh₂-*, and so does Latin's *stāre*.

Nothing was borrowed in either direction. Two families inherited the same two roots and held them to the same two meanings for thousands of years, because sitting and standing are things everybody does.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ich stehe, du stehst, er steht” — *SHTAY*, not *STAY*
- both postures — “Ich sitze. Ich stehe.”
- the verb inside the verb — “stehen, verstehen”
- where the *n* went — “ich stehe, ich stand, gestanden”
- the Latin pair — “sitzen/sedēre, stehen/stāre”
- what stands in English — “state, station, stable, stead”

Before you move on

Give the *du* and *er* forms. (***Du stehst, er steht.***) Which letter does English’s *stand* carry that German’s *stehen* does not? (An **n**.) Where does German still keep it? (In the **past** — *ich stand, gestanden.*) Which longer verb already taught has *stehen* inside it? (***Verstehen.***) Say “I sit. I stand.” (***Ich sitze. Ich stehe.***)

37.3 schlafen — *sleep*, under two coats of paint

Sitzen and *stehen* held their vowels still. This one does not — and it does not break the way the mind verbs broke either.

Sounds you’ll need

- sch-sh — **sch** is English *sh*: **schlafen** = *SHLAH-fen*.
- vowel-ae — **ä** is a flat *eh*: **schläft** = *SHLEFT*.

You’ll want to know: schlafen

schlafen means “to sleep.”

- ich schlafe · wir schlafen
- du schläfst · ihr schlaft
- er schläft · sie schlafen

Die Katze schläft. — “The cat is sleeping.”

Grammar Lens: the second kind of break

Lesen gave you one break: long *e* goes to **i** for *du* and *er* — *du liest*, *er hilft*. Here is the other: **a** takes two dots and becomes **ä** — *du schläfst*, *er schläft*.

Those two dots are the umlaut, the mark that turns *Buch* into *Bücher*. The break lands in the same slot as before, **du** and **er** and nobody else, so only its raw material is new: *e* verbs brighten to **i**, *a* verbs to **ä**.

Es regnet. Die Katze schläft.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

schlafen is Proto-Germanic **slēpaną*, and English **sleep** is the same inherited word — Old English *slæpan*, Old High German *slāfan*.

Two German changes sit between them. The first you know: the second shift, Germanic **p** to German **f**, as in *helfen*. The second is new — German turned **s** into *sh* before *l*, *m*, *n* and *w*, and wrote it down: *sleep* → **schlafen**, *swim* → **schwimmen**, *snow* → **Schnee**, *smith* → **Schmied**. It did the same before *p* and *t* and never spelt it, which is why *stehen* is said *SHTAY-en*.

Now the honest part. The old Indo-European verb for sleeping was **swep-*, still in plain view: Latin *somnus* gives **insomnia** and **somnolent**, Latin *sopor* gives **soporific**, Greek *hýpnos* gives **hypnosis**, and Old Norse *sofa* is Swedish *sova* today. German and English both threw that verb away and built a new one on **sleb-*, “to be slack” — German still has **schlaff**, “limp.” They made that swap **together**, before they were two languages.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ich schlafe, du schläfst, er schläft” — the *a* brightens to **ä**
- the three verbs — “Ich sitze. Ich stehe. Ich schlafe.”
- “Es regnet. Die Katze schläft.”
- both breaks in the same slot — “du hilfst” beside “du schläfst”
- the *sch* row — “schlafen, schwimmen, Schnee, Schmied”

- the verb they both threw away — “somnus, hypnos, sova”

Before you move on

Give the *du* and *er* forms. (***Du schläfst, er schläft*** — two dots on the *a*.) Which two people does a German verb break for? (**Du** and **er**, always.) Name the two changes between *sleep* and *schlafen*. (**p** to **f**, and **s** to **sch**.) Why is *stehen* said *SHTAY-en*? (**Same change**, never spelt.) Say “the cat is sleeping.” (***Die Katze schläft***.)

37.4 hören — *hear*, and the end of a chapter that never moved

Ich sitze. Ich stehe. Ich schlafe. Three verbs that stay put.
Here is the fourth — the sense that works with your eyes shut.

Sounds you’ll need

- umlaut-oe — **ö** is the *e* of *bed* said with rounded lips.
- r-uvular — the **r** is a soft scrape at the back: **hören** = *HUR-en*.

You’ll want to know: hören

hören means “to hear.”

- **ich höre · wir hören**
- **du hörst · ihr hört**
- **er hört · sie hören**

The **ö** never moves. *Schlafen* grew its dots for *du* and *er*; *hören* was born with them, so nothing is left to break.

Der Hund hört. Die Katze hört.

Grammar Lens: liking it, the mögen way

gern hangs on this verb like any other:

Ich höre gern. — “I like listening.”

Gern is English **yearn**: underneath, “I hear yearningly.” Beside it is the other way of liking, **ich mag** — English **may**, with the power drained out.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

hören is Proto-Germanic **hauzijanq*, and English **hear** is the same inherited word.

This time the change is one they **share**. Gothic still says *hausjan*, with an **s**; Old English *hīeran* and Old High German *hōren* had both turned it to **r**. *Sitzen* shows where German left English; *hören* shows a road they walked together.

The **h** is Grimm’s law, the first shift: an old **k** became Germanic **h**. Greek kept the *k* — *akoúein*, “to hear,” which English borrowed back as **acoustic**. Same swap that made **kwon-* into **Hund** while Latin kept *canis*.

Some break the root up further, into “sharp” plus “ear” — which would make *hören* “sharp-eared” and put **das Ohr** inside it. Cited often, not settled.

Why it’s said this way

gehören means “**to belong**.” It is *ge-* welded onto *hören*, and began as “to hearken to”: what belongs to you answers when called.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- all four — “Ich sitze. Ich stehe. Ich schlafe. Ich höre.”
- the four *er* forms — “er sitzt, er steht, er schläft, er hört”
- “Der Hund hört. Die Katze schläft.”
- “Ich höre gern.”
- the shared change — “hausjan, hīeran, hören”
- the *h* row — “hören/akoúein, Hund/canis”
- “gehören is *belong*”

Before you move on

Give all four *ich* forms of this chapter. (***Ich sitze, ich stehe, ich schlafe, ich höre.***) Which breaks its vowel? (***Schlafen*** — *a* to *ä*.) Which letter did Gothic keep where German and English have *r*? (An *s*.) Which law put the *h* on *hören* and *Hund*? (**Grimm's law**.)

Chapter 38

Going, Running, Opening, Closing

Modes: ⇄ voice (4) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say I go, I run and I open and close my hand in German, split a separable verb so its prefix waits at the end of the sentence, and say why German's line between walking and running is not where English draws it.

The chapter closes on schließen, the second verb in these chapters that German kept and English lost: the reader produces all of Chapter 27's verbs, splits both aufmachen and zumachen around die Hand, names Schloss, Schlüssel and Schluss as the household built on the kept verb, and runs the eight-verb morning that closes Chapters 26 and 27 together. It reaches back to Chapter 25's nehmen and the second shift on helfen, to Chapter 17's Hand and its final-d devoicing, which had never been revisited, and to Chapter 26's sitzen, stehen and hören.

38.1 gehen — go, and the word German never needed for walk

Four verbs that stayed put — sitting, standing, sleeping, hearing. Now a chapter that moves, opening on the verb German uses where English has two.

Sounds you'll need

- **h-silent-lengthening** — the **h** is silent and lengthens: **gehen** = GAY-en, built exactly like *stehen*, *SHTAY-en*.
- **ge-prefix** — **ge-** at the front is said *guh*, never *jee*.

You'll want to know: gehen

gehen means “to go” — and also “to walk.” German does not split those.

- ich **gehe** · wir **gehen**
- du **gehst** · ihr **geht**
- er **geht** · sie **gehen**

Ich stehe. Ich gehe.

Two verbs cut to the same short shape, each with a silent *h* propping the vowel up. Say them together and you hear a matched pair: *SHTAY-en*, *GAY-en*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

gehen is Proto-Germanic **gānq* and English **go** is the same inherited word, Old English *gān*.

Both languages then hit the same problem: the verb had no usable past, and each went shopping. English took **went**, really the past of *wend*, and left *wend* stranded. German took **ging** and **gegangen** from another old verb, **ganganq*, “to walk” — which English still owns in **gangway**, **gangplank**, and Scots *gang*, “to go.”

Gegangen carries the same *ge-* you met on **gehören**: an old prefix German fastens to a past participle.

Beyond Germanic, be honest — the deeper root of *go* is **disputed**, with no agreed list of cousins. It is the one verb here that cannot be followed back.

Why it's said this way

Because **walk** is not an old word for travelling on foot. Old English *wealcan* meant “to roll, to toss,” and its German cousin **walken** still means what it always meant: **to full cloth**, to work wool by trampling it.

English promoted that trampling verb around 1200. German never did, so *gehen* covers both jobs.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ich gehe, du gehst, er geht”
- the matched pair — “Ich stehe. Ich gehe.”
- the borrowed pasts — “go/went” beside “gehen/ging/gegangen”
- where English kept the other verb — “gangway, gangplank”
- the *ge-* on both — “gehören, gegangen”
- what *walken* does — it fulls cloth, it does not travel

Before you move on

Give the *du* and *er* forms. (***Du gehst, er geht.***) Which English verb is *gehen*? (**Go**, and **walk** as well.) Where did *went* come from? (From ***wend.***) What does German’s cousin of *walk* mean? (**To full cloth.**) How far back can *gehen* be traced? (**Not past Germanic.**)

38.2 laufen — the verb that lies across English’s line

Ich gehe covers going and walking. German has two words for *run*, and one of them is not only about running.

Sounds you’ll need

- diphthong-au — **au** is the *ow* of *house*: **laufen** = *LOW-fen*.
- diphthong-eu — **äu** is the *oy* of *boy*: **läuft** = *LOYFT*.

You’ll want to know: **laufen**

laufen means “to run” — and often “to walk.”

- **ich laufe · wir laufen**
- **du läufst · ihr lauft**
- **er läuft · sie laufen**

The *schlafen* break is here too, in the same *du* and *er* slot: **au** brightens to **äu**.

Der Hund läuft.

Why it's said this way

English draws a hard line between *walk* and *run*. German draws it elsewhere, and leaves one verb lying across it.

- **gehen** — on foot, unhurried.
- **laufen** — on foot at any speed at all.
- **rennen** — flat out. *ich renne, du rennst, er rennt.*

So **Wir laufen** is “we’re walking” or “we’re running,” and only the situation tells you which. That holds across most of Germany. In **Austria** it does not: there *laufen* means *run*. This book teaches the German usage.

Der Hund rennt. — no ambiguity left.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

laufen is Proto-Germanic **hlaupaną*, and English kept it as **leap** — Old English *hlēapan*. One more **p** against **f**, the second shift, on the pattern of *helfen/help*, *offen/open* and *schlafen/sleep*.

English holds three more scraps: **lope**, and — through Dutch relatives of the same verb — **elope** and **interloper**, both people running off.

Outside Germanic there are **no secure cousins**.

Rennen is a sharper story. Germanic had **rinnaną*, “to run, to flow,” and beside it a causative **rannijaną*, “to make something run.”

German fused the two into **rennen** and kept *rinnen*, “to trickle,” alongside. English fused the same two into **run** — one merger, carried out separately in each language.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ich laufe, du läufst, er läuft” — *LOW-fuh, LOYFST, LOYFT*
- the three speeds — “Ich gehe. Ich laufe. Ich renne.”
- “Der Hund läuft. Der Hund rennt.”
- the *p/f* row now four long — “helfen/help, offen/open, schlafen/sleep, laufen/leap”

- the runaways — “lope, elope, interloper”
- the doubled merger — “rinnen, rennen” beside English’s one *run*

Before you move on

Give the *du* and *er* forms of *laufen*. (*Du läufst, er läuft* — *au* to *äu*.) Which English verb is *laufen*? (**Leap** — and it means *run*.) Which German verb means only “run fast”? (**Rennen**.) Does **Wir laufen** mean walking or running? (**Either** — except in Austria, where it is running.) Say “the dog runs.” (*Der Hund rennt*.)

38.3 öffnen — *open*, which was always the word *up*

Ich gehe. Ich laufe. Ich renne. Now something done with the hands, and the German habit that breaks a verb in two.

Sounds you’ll need

- umlaut-oe — **ö** is the *e* of *bed* with rounded lips.
- fn-cluster — **-fn-** runs straight together: **öffnen** = *UFF-nen*.

You’ll want to know: öffnen

öffnen means “to open.”

- **ich öffne · wir öffnen**
- **du öffnest · ihr öffnet**
- **er öffnet · sie öffnen**

An extra **e** slips in for *du*, *er* and *ihr*, because *öffnst* cannot be said. Now a noun you already have, whose **d** is spoken as a **t**:

Ich öffne die Hand. — “I open my hand.” (*dee Hant*)

Grammar Lens: a verb that comes apart

Öffnen is the neutral, slightly formal word. What people say out loud is **aufmachen**, and both halves are yours already: **auf** from *auf Wiedersehen*, **machen** from your first verbs.

Here is the German part. In an ordinary sentence, **the prefix leaves the verb and waits at the end**:

Ich mache die Hand auf. — literally “I make the hand up.”

Machen takes the slot after *ich*; *auf* goes to the back and sits there. German does this to hundreds of verbs, and calls them **separable**.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Behind the verb is the adjective **offen**, “open” — which the doing verbs already put beside **open** as a **p-to-f** pair from the second shift. The better secret is that **neither word is a root**. Old English *open* goes back to Proto-Germanic **upana-*, “put up,” formed on the word that is now English **up** — it has the shape of a past participle, though no such verb “to up” is attested. German ran the same sum and got *offen*, which is why *offen* and **auf** are relatives and not merely neighbours.

So *aufmachen* is not a quaint compound. It is the ancient recipe for “open,” rebuilt out loud — and German pulls it apart every time you use it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ich öffne, du öffnest, er öffnet” — the extra *e*
- “Ich öffne die Hand.” — *dee Hant*
- the split — “Ich mache die Hand auf.”
- the *p/f* pair — “offen/open”
- what it is made of — “auf, up, offen, open”
- the feet verbs before the hand one — “Ich gehe. Ich laufe. Ich renne.”

Before you move on

Give the *du* and *er* forms. (*Du öffnest, er öffnet.*) Which older word is *offen* built from? (**Auf** — English **up**.) Where does *auf* go in **Ich mache die Hand auf?** (**To the end.**) What is such a verb called? (**Separable.**) How is the *d* of *Hand* spoken? (As a **t**.)

38.4 schließen — the second verb English lost

You can open a hand two ways, **ich öffne** and **ich mache ... auf**. Closing works the same, and the closing verb has the stranger history.

Sounds you'll need

- **ie-long-ee** — **ie** is a long *ee*: **schließen** = *SHLEE-sen*.
- **eszett** — **ß** is a sharp *s*, and it appears here because the *ee* before it is long.

You'll want to know: schließen

schließen means “to close,” and also “to lock.”

- **ich schließe** · **wir schließen**
- **du schließt** · **ihr schließt**
- **er schließt** · **sie schließen**

Its everyday partner is **zumachen** — *zu* plus *machen* — splitting exactly as *aufmachen* did:

Ich schließe die Hand. Ich mache die Hand zu.

The vowel shortens in the past, and the moment it does the **ß** becomes **ss**: *schließen*, but *schloss*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

schließen is Proto-Germanic **sleutana*, “to shut, to bolt.” Dutch kept it as *sluiten*. **English has nothing** — no inherited cousin at all.

So English closes things with borrowed and unrelated words. **Close** is Latin *claudere*, by way of French. **Shut** is native but a different verb entirely: Old English *scyttan*, to **shoot** a bolt across a door. That makes two verbs here with the same shape of story. The doing verbs gave you *nehmen*, which English lost to Norse *take*. This is the second.

On the verb it kept, German built a household: **das Schloss**, a lock — and, because a castle is the locked place, a castle; **der Schlüssel**, a key; **der Schluss**, the end. English says **conclusion** for that last one, from *claudere* — the same idea out of the other family’s parts. A link between the Germanic verb and Latin *claudere* has been **proposed**. It is not established.

What you’ve built across these two chapters

Eight verbs, and a whole small morning:

**Ich schlafe. Ich höre. Ich stehe. Ich gehe. Ich laufe.
Ich renne. Ich sitze. Ich mache die Hand auf. Ich
mache die Hand zu.**

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ich schließe, du schließt, er schließt”
- the pair — “Ich mache die Hand auf. Ich mache die Hand zu.”
- the spelling swap — “schließen, schloss”
- the household — “Schloss, Schlüssel, Schluss”
- the two lost verbs — “nehmen, schließen; English took *take* and *close*”
- the four *p/f* pairs — “helfen/help, offen/open, schlafen/sleep, laufen/leap”
- the whole morning — “Ich schlafe. Ich höre. Ich stehe. Ich gehe. Ich laufe. Ich renne. Ich sitze.”

Before you move on

Give the *du* and *er* forms. (***Du schließt, er schließt.***) Which English verb is the cousin of *schließen*? (**None** — English lost it.) Where did *close* and *shut* come from? (**Latin**, and from **shoot**.) Name three words German hung on the verb. (**Schloss, Schlüssel, Schluss.**) Close your hand, both ways, then run the eight verbs.

Chapter 39

Coffee, Tea, and Milk

Modes: 🗣️ voice (3) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 3 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can politely ask for coffee, tea, or milk in German, and say which of the three words is native and which two are loans.

The chapter closes on Milch, the native word beside two loans: the reader produces all three drinks with der/die articles, extends Chapter 19's Wasser, bitte pattern to Kaffee, bitte and Tee, bitte, and states each word's route — Kaffee overland through Arabic, Turkish and Italian; Tee by sea from Hokkien Chinese by way of Dutch; Milch never borrowed at all. It reaches back to Chapter 19's bitte pattern and rescues Chapter 27's final atoms, GE-LEX-SCHLIESSEN-10 and GE-ETYMON-SCHLIESSEN-11, which no lesson had revisited.

39.1 der Kaffee — the drink that closes one chapter and opens another

The last chapter ended by closing a hand. Now open the day with something to drink — and a new use for a request pattern you already own.

You'll want to know: der Kaffee

der Kaffee — coffee. Masculine.

Bitte taught you a complete polite request out of two known words: **Wasser, bitte**. The same pattern takes any drink you can name:

Kaffee, bitte. — Coffee, please.

Sounds you'll need

Kaffee is said two ways, and both are standard: many speakers in the north stress the first syllable, **KAF**-fay; many in the south, and most international learners' material, stress the second, kaf-**FAY**. Unlike *gehen* and *laufen*'s Germany/Austria split, this one is not regional in any strict sense — you will hear both from native speakers in the same city.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Kaffee is a loanword, and a young one by this book's standard — nothing like *Wein*'s two-thousand-year-old borrowing from Latin *vīnum*. The word travelled **Arabic qahwa** → **Ottoman Turkish kahve** → **Italian caffè** → **German Kaffee**. English *coffee* and French *café* took the same Italian step, which is why the whole spread of European words for the drink still rhymes with each other despite crossing four language families to get here.

The last chapter closed on **schließen**, a verb Proto-Germanic built and English lost outright. *Kaffee* is the opposite kind of word: nothing here is inherited, and nothing needed to be — German simply took the whole word, sound and all, the way it took *Wein* centuries earlier.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “der Kaffee” — either stress, both correct
- “Kaffee, bitte.” — the *bitte* pattern, one word swapped
- the route — “qahwa, kahve, caffè, Kaffee”

Before you move on

Give “coffee” with its article. (**Der Kaffee**.) Ask for it politely. (**Kaffee, bitte**.) Name the three languages the word crossed before German. (**Arabic, Turkish, Italian**.) Is *Kaffee* inherited like *schließen*, or borrowed like *Wein*? (**Borrowed**.)

39.2 der Tee — the same loan as English, by the same ship

Kaffee came overland through Turkey and Italy. The next drink took a completely different road — by sea.

You'll want to know: der Tee

der Tee — tea. Masculine.

Tee, bitte. — Tea, please.

Sounds you'll need

Tee is spelled almost exactly like the English word it translates, and said nothing like it. German **ee** is a long, steady *ay*: **Tee** = *TAY*, not *tea*'s *ee*. Looking alike on the page and sounding different is its own small trap — worth naming so it doesn't catch you.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Tee is Hokkien Chinese *tê*, the word for the plant in the coastal Chinese dialect that Dutch traders dealt with directly. Dutch **thee** carried it into Europe by sea, and German took the word from Dutch — the same route English **tea** followed, which is why *Tee* and *tea* match as closely as they do.

That is not the only road this word took. Languages reached by the **overland** trade routes out of northern China took a different syllable of the same Chinese word: **Hindi *chai*, Russian *chai*, Turkish *çay***. One plant, one Chinese word, two pronunciations of it — split by whether a language got the word from a ship or a caravan. *Kaffee*'s three-hop route through Turkish and Italian was its own single path; tea forked into two.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “der Tee” — say it *TAY*, not *tea*
- “Tee, bitte.” — “Kaffee, bitte.” — same pattern, two drinks
- the fork — “tê, thee, Tee, tea” by sea; “chai, chai, çay” overland

Before you move on

Give “tea” with its article, and say it correctly. (**Der Tee** — *TAY*.) Which language gave German the word, and by what route? (**Hokkien Chinese *tê*, by way of Dutch sea trade.**) Name one language that got the same Chinese word overland instead. (**Hindi, Russian, or Turkish.**) Does *Tee* sound the way it’s spelled in English? (**No** — same letters, different vowel.)

39.3 die Milch — the one that was never borrowed

Kaffee came from Arabic by way of Turkish and Italian. *Tee* came from Chinese by way of Dutch. The third drink needed no ship and no caravan — German already had it.

You’ll want to know: die Milch

die Milch — milk. Feminine.

Milch, bitte. — Milk, please.

Sounds you’ll need

German’s **ch** is not one sound but two. After a back vowel like the *a* of *Nacht*, it is a rasp at the back of the throat. After a front vowel or consonant like the *i* of **Milch**, it is soft, made further forward — closer to a hissed *h*. Say *ich* (your own word for “I”) right before *Milch* and you are making the same sound twice.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Milch is native Germanic, from ***meluks**, and further back from Proto-Indo-European ***h₂melg-**, “to milk” — the action came first, and the word for the substance is simply that verb, frozen into a noun. English **milk** is the exact same word, inherited rather than borrowed, which makes it the cousin of German *Melker* (“milker”) the way *denken* is the cousin of *Dank*.

So the trio closes the way the food lesson did: **Wasser** was native beside the loanword **Wein**; here, **Milch** is native beside the loanwords

Kaffee and **Tee**. Two loans, one inherited word, in both chapters — but this time the loans arrived from opposite directions on the map, one overland and one by sea, and only the native word needed no journey at all.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “die Milch” — the soft *ch*, as in *ich*
- all three requests — “Kaffee, bitte. Tee, bitte. Milch, bitte.”
- the shape of the chapter — “Wasser native, Wein borrowed; Milch native, Kaffee and Tee borrowed”

Before you move on

Give “milk” with its article. (**Die Milch.**) Is it native or borrowed? (**Native** — inherited **meluks*, the twin of English *milk*.) Which two drinks in this chapter were borrowed, and from where? (**Kaffee** from Arabic/Turkish/Italian; **Tee** from Hokkien Chinese by way of Dutch.) Which earlier chapter set up the exact same native/borrowed shape? (**Chapter 11 — Wasser and Wein.**)

Chapter 40

Friend and Family

Modes: 🗣️ voice (3) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 3 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name a friend, male or female, and my family in German, build a feminine person-noun with -in, and say which of the three words is native and which is borrowed.

The chapter closes on Familie, the one Latin loan beside two native words: the reader produces der Freund, die Freundin and die Familie with articles, builds the feminine -in suffix on a masculine person-noun and names its one English fossil (vixen), and states that Familie gathers the very members Chapter 10 already named (Vater, Mutter, Bruder, Schwester, Geschwister). It reaches back to Chapter 2's freut mich, which shares Freund's root, and to Chapter 10's family words.

40.1 der Freund — a word that was already a compliment

You were taught **freut mich** — “pleased to meet you,” literally “it gladdens me.” The person doing the gladdening has a name of their own, and it is built from the very same root.

You'll want to know: der Freund

der Freund — friend (male, or a friend in general). Masculine.

Das ist der Freund. — “This/That is the friend.”

Sounds you'll need

eu is a diphthong said *oy*, exactly as in English *boy*: **Freund** = *FROYND*. It is the same sound spelled **äu** in *Häuser* and *läuft*, just without the umlaut in front of it.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Freund and English **friend** are not merely cousins — they are the exact same inherited word, Proto-Germanic **frijōnds*. That word was never a plain noun to begin with: it is a **frozen present participle** of the verb **frijōnā*, “to love,” so *Freund* literally means “the one who is loving.” *freut mich* is built on the same family: both trace to Proto-Indo-European **preyH-*, “to love, to please.” The goddess **Frigg** — whose day German keeps as *Freitag* and English as **Friday** — carries the same root one step further.

Milch needed no journey to reach German; *Freund* did not either — but where *Milch* is a noun that was always a noun, *Freund* is a verb that stopped moving and became one.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “der Freund” — *FROYND*
- “Das ist der Freund.”
- the family — “Freund, freut mich, Frigg, Friday — all one root”

Before you move on

Give “friend” with its article. (**Der Freund**.) What part of speech did *Freund* start out as? (**A verb** — a frozen present participle of “to love.”) Which greeting phrase shares its root? (**Freut mich**.) Which day of the week carries the same PIE root one step further? (**Freitag** / **Friday**, from the goddess **Frigg**.)

40.2 die Freundin — one suffix, and the fox that kept it in English

You have **der Freund**. German does not need a new word for the feminine — it needs one small, reusable ending.

You'll want to know: die Freundin

die Freundin — friend (female). Feminine.

Das ist die Freundin. — “This/That is the (female) friend.”

Grammar Lens: the ending that builds a whole class of nouns

Add **-in** to a masculine noun for a person and you get the feminine: **der Lehrer** → **die Lehrerin** (“teacher”), **der Student** → **die Studentin** (“student”), **der Freund** → **die Freundin**. It is entirely regular, and it works on almost any such noun you will ever meet — one rule, not a new word each time.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

-in is native Germanic, not a Latin import — English inherited the same suffix and mostly stopped using it. Almost mostly: one English word still carries it, fossilized, unrecognized as a suffix by most speakers who use it — **vixen**, “female fox,” built the same way *Freundin* is built. English did not lose this pattern by borrowing over it; it simply stopped reaching for it, and later borrowed French *-ess* (**princess**, **actress**) to do the same job instead. German never stopped.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “die Freundin” — Freund plus -in
- “Das ist die Freundin.”
- the pattern — “Lehrer/Lehrerin, Student/Studentin, Freund/Freundin”
- the English fossil — “fox, vixen — the same -in, once”

Before you move on

Give “friend (female)” with its article. (**Die Freundin.**) What suffix builds it from *Freund*, and what does that suffix do generally? (**-in** — it makes the feminine of a person-noun.) Is *-in* borrowed or native? (**Native** — English inherited it too.) Name the one English word that still shows it. (**Vixen.**)

40.3 die Familie — the word that gathers Eltern and Geschwister

You have **der Freund** and **die Freundin**, both native, both built on a verb meaning “to love.” The word for the group at home has a completely different history.

You’ll want to know: die Familie

die Familie — family. Feminine.

Das ist die Familie. — “This/That is the family.”

You already have the members: **Vater, Mutter, Bruder, Schwester** — and the collective **Geschwister**, “siblings.” *Familie* is the word that gathers all of them into one group.

Sounds you’ll need

Familie keeps all three vowels distinct: *fa-MEE-lee-eh*, four syllables in careful speech, with the stress on the second. It does not collapse the way English *family* does.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Familie is a Latin loan: **familia**, “household,” related to **famulus**, “servant” or “slave” — a Roman household word, not originally a word about blood relation at all. English **family** borrowed the very same Latin root, by way of Old French, well before German did; German took *Familie* directly from Latin later, in the early modern period, which is why the two loans look so close to identical without one having been copied from the other.

So this small chapter runs the same shape twice: **Freund** and

Freundin are native, built from a Germanic verb meaning “to love”; **Familie** is borrowed, from a Roman word that first meant “household staff.” The food lesson set up exactly this pattern with **Wasser** native beside **Wein** borrowed, and the drinks just ran it a third time with **Milch** beside **Kaffee** and **Tee**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “die Familie” — *fa-MEE-lee-eh*
- “Das ist die Familie.”
- the members inside it — “Vater, Mutter, Bruder, Schwester, Geschwister”
- native beside borrowed — “Freund, Freundin native; Familie borrowed”

Before you move on

Give “family” with its article. (**Die Familie**.) Is it native or borrowed? (**Borrowed** — Latin *familia*, “household.”) What did *familia* first mean, before “relatives”? (**Household** — kin to *famulus*, “servant.”) Which two words from this chapter are native instead? (**Freund** and **Freundin**.)

Chapter 41

Eyes, Ears, Mouth, Nose

Modes: ⇄ voice (4) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name the eye, ear, mouth, and nose in German, and say which of the four traces to a confirmed ancient root and which does not.

The chapter closes on Nase, cousin of both English nose and Latin nasus by separate descent: the reader produces all four face parts with articles and plurals, names Auge and Ohr as words with confirmed Proto-Indo-European roots, names Mund as inherited but not traced further, and completes Chapter 17's face by running Kopf, Auge, Ohr, Mund, Nase, Hand together. It reaches back to Chapter 17's Kopf and Hand and to Chapter 26's hören, rescuing the disputed 'sharp-eared' link between hören and Ohr.

41.1 das Auge — back to the head, one part at a time

You already have **der Kopf** and **die Hand**. The head has more in it than its own name — starting with what you see with.

You'll want to know: das Auge

das Auge — eye. Neuter.

Das ist das Auge. — “This/That is the eye.”

The plural is **die Augen** — both eyes together, the form you will hear far more often than the singular.

Sounds you'll need

au is a diphthong said *ow*, as in English *how*: **Auge** = *OW-geh*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Auge is Proto-Germanic **augô*, the direct cousin of English **eye** — both inherited, no loan in either direction, from Proto-Indo-European **h₃ek^w-*. That root did not stay hidden in only the Germanic family: Latin turned it into **oculus** (giving English **ocular**, **binoculars**), and Greek into **ophthalmós** (giving English **ophthalmology**). Three branches of one family tree, and English ended up borrowing back two Latin and Greek reflexes of the very root it had already inherited natively as *eye*.

Kopf was a container word that took over the everyday job. *Auge* needed no such replacement — it has meant “eye” the whole way down.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “das Auge” — *OW-geh*; “die Augen” — both eyes
- “Das ist das Auge.”
- the three-family root — “Auge/eye, Latin *oculus*, Greek *ophthalmós*”

Before you move on

Give “eye” with its article, and its plural. (**Das Auge, die Augen.**) Is it native or borrowed? (**Native** — cousin of English *eye*.) Name one English word borrowed from the *same* PIE root by way of Latin or Greek. (**Ocular, binoculars, or ophthalmology.**)

41.2 das Ohr — the part hören was named for

You have the eye. You already have the verb for what the next part does — **hören**, “to hear” — without ever naming the part itself.

You'll want to know: das Ohr

das Ohr — ear. Neuter.

Das ist das Ohr. — “This/That is the ear.”

Plural: **die Ohren**.

Sounds you'll need

Ohr is a single long *o*, said the way you'd say the letter itself in English: **Ohr** = *OHR*, no glide, no second vowel.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Ohr is Proto-Germanic **auzô*, the direct cousin of English **ear** — both from Proto-Indo-European **h₂ous-*. One disputed idea about **hören** was already flagged: some accounts break its root into “sharp” plus “ear,” which would put this very word, *Ohr*, hiding inside the verb for using it. That analysis was marked cited but unsettled there, and it stays unsettled here — a tidy story is not the same as a confirmed one. What is confirmed: *Ohr* and *ear* are not two words that happen to sound alike. They are one Germanic word, unbroken since before English and German were different languages.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “das Ohr” — a plain long *o*; “die Ohren”
- “Das ist das Ohr.”
- the maybe-link — “hören, Ohr — sharp-eared, unsettled”

Before you move on

Give “ear” with its article and plural. (**Das Ohr, die Ohren**.) Is it native or borrowed? (**Native** — cousin of English *ear*.) What disputed idea would put this word inside *hören*? (**The “sharp-eared” root analysis** — cited, not settled.)

41.3 der Mund — where the family tree runs out

Auge and *Ohr* both trace cleanly to Proto-Indo-European. This one does not go nearly as far back with any certainty — and saying so honestly is the lesson.

You'll want to know: der Mund

der Mund — mouth. Masculine.

Das ist der Mund. — “This/That is the mouth.”

Plural: **die Münder**.

Sounds you'll need

Mund takes a short, closed *u*, as in English *put*: **Mund** = *MOONT* (final *d* devoiced, as in *Hand*).

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Mund is Proto-Germanic **munþaz*, and English **mouth** is that same inherited word — no loan in either direction, exactly like *Ohr* and *ear*. Here the two words part company. *Ohr* and *Auge* both trace on to confirmed Proto-Indo-European roots. *Munþaz* does not: proposed deeper connections exist, but no single one is agreed upon by standard references. Rather than hand you a tidy-sounding root that is not actually settled, this lesson stops at Proto-Germanic. An honest “we don’t fully know” is worth more than an invented ancestor.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “der Mund” — *MOONT*; “die Münder”
- “Das ist der Mund.”
- the honest stop — “Mund and mouth, inherited — but no further-back root is agreed”

Before you move on

Give “mouth” with its article and plural. (**Der Mund, die M nder.**) Is it native or borrowed? (**Native** — cousin of English *mouth*.) Does its root trace to a confirmed PIE ancestor, the way *Auge* and *Ohr* do? (**No** — the trail goes cold at Proto-Germanic.)

41.4 die Nase — the face, complete

Auge. Ohr. Mund. One part of the face is left, and it closes what *Kopf* opened and never finished.

You’ll want to know: die Nase

die Nase — nose. Feminine.

Das ist die Nase. — “This/That is the nose.”

Plural: **die Nasen**.

Sounds you’ll need

Nase opens on a long, open *a*: **Nase** = *NAH-zeh*, with the *s* voiced to *z* between two vowels — the mirror image of *Hand*’s final *d* devoicing to *t*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Nase is Proto-Germanic **nasō*, the inherited cousin of English **nose** — and, further back, of Latin **nasus**, which gave English **nasal** and **nostril**. One Proto-Indo-European root, **nas-*, split into Germanic and into Latin independently; German *Nase* and the Latin-derived word are family by **descent**, exactly like *rot* and *rouge*, never by borrowing.

That gives this small face four parts with four different shapes of story: **Auge** and **Ohr** trace cleanly to confirmed PIE roots; **Mund** is inherited but its root before Proto-Germanic is not agreed upon; **Nase** traces to a root Latin also inherited, on its own branch. Four native words, four different depths of certainty — which is the honest way etymology actually looks, not four identical tidy stories.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “die Nase” — *NAH-zeh*; “die Nasen”
- “Das ist die Nase.”
- the whole face — “Kopf, Auge, Ohr, Mund, Nase, Hand”
- the cousin — “Nase, nose, nasus — one PIE root, two families”

Before you move on

Give “nose” with its article and plural. (**Die Nase, die Nasen.**) Which Latin word is its distant cousin, and what English word does that Latin word give? (**Nasus**, giving **nasal**.) Name all five face and head words from Chapters 17 and 30. (**Kopf, Auge, Ohr, Mund, Nase.**) Which of the four words of this chapter does not trace past Proto-Germanic? (**Mund.**)

Chapter 42

Arm, Finger, Foot, Heart

Modes: ⇄ voice (4) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name the arm, finger, foot, and heart in German, completing the Hand/Arm/Finger/Fuß/Herz table Chapter 17 named but did not finish teaching, and say which of the four shows Grimm's law and which sits outside it.

The chapter closes on Herz, the third word in the book to show Grimm's law's k-to-h swap: the reader produces all four words with articles, names Arm as a word outside Grimm's law's reach entirely, Fuß as a second p-to-f case beside Vater, and Finger's disputed link to fünf, and finally completes the five-word table Chapter 17 printed but only taught one-fifth of. It reaches back to Chapter 17's Hand and Grimm's law, Chapter 26's hören, and Chapter 22's Hund, all three of which supply the k-to-h comparison.

42.1 der Arm — the word Hand's own table already named

The *Hand* lesson ran a table — **Hand, Arm, Finger, Fuß, Herz** — to show how closely German and English match on the body. Only *Hand* was actually taught. Here is the second name from that table.

You'll want to know: der Arm

der Arm — arm. Masculine.

Das ist der Arm. — “This/That is the arm.”

Plural: **die Arme**.

Sounds you'll need

Arm is said almost exactly as it is spelled, with German's open *ah* vowel: **Arm** = *AHRM*. Of everything in this chapter, it is the smallest gap between the German word and its English cousin.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Arm is Proto-Germanic **armaz*, the direct cousin of English **arm**, from Proto-Indo-European **h₂er-*, “to fit together, to join.” That same root, by a separate Latin path, gave English **art** (a fitting-together of skill) and **harmony** by way of Greek. *Vater/father* and *Fuß/foot* both show Grimm's law loudly, because their starting consonants were exactly the ones the law changed. *Arm* shows why the law is a **rule about specific sounds**, not a blanket difference between German and English: the consonants in **armaz* were never in the law's path, so nothing had to move, and *Arm* and *arm* still look like the same word today for the same reason *Hand* and *hand* do.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “der Arm” — *AHRM*; “die Arme”
- “Das ist der Arm.”
- the point — “Grimm's law only moves the sounds in its path; Arm's sounds were never in it”

Before you move on

Give “arm” with its article and plural. (**Der Arm, die Arme**.) Which earlier table already named this word? (**Hand**'s table — *Hand, Arm, Finger, Fuß, Herz*.) Why does *Arm* look almost identical to English *arm*, when *Vater/father* do not? (**Its sounds were never in Grimm's law's path.**)

42.2 der Finger — maybe “one of the five”

The third name from the *Hand* table, and the first numbers come back for a cameo.

You’ll want to know: der Finger

der Finger — finger. Masculine, spelled and said almost exactly like English.

Das ist der Finger. — “This/That is the finger.”

Plural: **die Finger** — unchanged, one of the small set of German plurals that add nothing at all.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Finger is Proto-Germanic **fingraz*, inherited straight into English with no change of shape at all — the closest match of any word in this chapter.

Why it’s said this way

You were taught **fünf**, “five,” from Germanic **fimf*. One proposed account connects **fingraz* to that very number, as if a finger were once simply “one of the five.” It is a satisfying story, and it shows up often — but it is reported by standard references as **plausible, not proven**: the sound changes needed to get from **fimf* to **fingraz* are not fully regular, so the link stays a proposal rather than a settled fact. Held loosely, the way *hören* held “sharp-eared”.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “der Finger” — “die Finger”, unchanged plural
- “Das ist der Finger.”
- the maybe-link — “Finger, fünf — plausible, not proven”

Before you move on

Give “finger” with its article and plural. (**Der Finger, die Finger** — unchanged.) What number might *Finger* be built on, and how certain is that link? (**Fünf, “five”** — **plausible, not proven.**) Name one other word in this book that carries the same kind of unsettled-but-cited etymology. (**Hören’s** “sharp-eared” account.)

42.3 der Fuß — Grimm’s law, on a second word

One name left on the *Hand* table, and it turns out to run the very same sound-law you already learned on a completely different word.

You’ll want to know: der Fuß

der Fuß — foot. Masculine.

Das ist der Fuß. — “This/That is the foot.”

Plural: **die Füße** — the umlaut marking more than one, the same fronting pattern behind *Mann* → *Männer*.

Sounds you’ll need

Fuß = *FOOSS*, a long *u* followed by the sharp *s* spelled **ß**. The colour words already gave you the rule this word follows exactly: **ß** after a **long** vowel, **ss** after a short one — the same reason *weiß* keeps its **ß** while *Fluss* does not.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Fuß is Proto-Germanic **fōts*, cousin of English **foot**, from Proto-Indo-European **pōds*. That opening **p** → **f** is the very shift **Vater/father** showed you — Grimm’s law, run again here on an unrelated word, with the identical result: Latin kept the old *p* in **ped-** (giving English **pedal, pedestrian**), Germanic moved it to *f* in both *Fuß* and *foot*.

This chapter has now shown you two shapes of Grimm’s law and one word that never needed it at all: **Vater** and **Fuß** both shift *p* → *f*; **Arm** sits outside the law’s reach entirely, unchanged in both languages.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “der Fuß” — *FOOSS*; “die Füße”
- “Das ist der Fuß.”
- the shift, twice — “Vater/father, Fuß/foot — both p to f”

Before you move on

Give “foot” with its article and plural. (**Der Fuß, die Füße.**)
Which family word already showed this same sound-law step?
(**Vater/father**, both $p \rightarrow f$.) Why does *Fuß* keep its **ß** while *Fluss*
does not? (**Long vowel before it, by the eszett rule.**)

42.4 das Herz — the body list, complete at last

The *Hand* lesson printed a five-word table and taught you one of them. This lesson teaches the fifth and closes it.

You’ll want to know: das Herz

das Herz — heart. Neuter — the one organ word in this chapter that breaks the masculine pattern of *Arm*, *Finger* and *Fuß*.

Das ist das Herz. — “This/That is the heart.”

Plural: **die Herzen.**

Sounds you’ll need

Herz takes a short, open *e*, as in English *bed*: **Herz** = *HAIRTS*, the *z* said *ts*, exactly as in *Katze*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Herz is Proto-Germanic **hertan*, cousin of English **heart**, from Proto-Indo-European **kērd-*. The opening consonant is Grimm’s law again — old **k** became Germanic **h** — the identical step already heard on **hören** (against Greek *akoúein*, English *acoustic*) and on **Hund**

(against Latin *canis*). Three separate words, one law, heard a third time: *k* stays *k* in the languages that didn't shift, and softens to *h* in every Germanic one.

That five-word list is finally complete. **Hand** was taught that chapter; **Arm**, **Finger**, **Fuß** and now **Herz** waited fourteen chapters for their turn. All five are native Germanic, all five are direct cousins of their English translations, and not one of them was borrowed from anywhere.

Grammar Lens: the whole chapter, run once more

Run this chapter's four words back to back: **der Arm**, said almost exactly as spelled, sitting outside Grimm's law entirely; **der Finger**, identical to English and maybe — not certainly — built on **fünf**; **der Fuß**, the *p* → *f* Grimm's-law twin of *Vater*, its **ß** long-vowel-marked exactly as Chapter 13 taught; and **das Herz**, the *k* → *h* twin of *hören* and *Hund*. Four words, four different sound-law stories, and not one of them borrowed.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “das Herz” — *HAIRTS*; “die Herzen”
- “Das ist das Herz.”
- the whole list, complete — “Hand, Arm, Finger, Fuß, Herz”
- the k-to-h swap, three times — “Hund/canis, hören/akoúein, Herz/kardia”

Before you move on

Give “heart” with its article and plural. (**Das Herz, die Herzen.**) Which two earlier words showed the same Grimm's-law *k* → *h* swap? (**Hören** and **Hund.**) Name all five words from that original table, now that all five are taught. (**Hand, Arm, Finger, Fuß, Herz.**) Which one breaks the chapter's masculine pattern, and how? (**Herz** — it is **neuter.**)

Pronunciation — a reference, not a chapter

Not to be read before starting. German spelling is largely phonetic — mostly you say what you see — so this page is short. Each lesson names the sounds its word needs and points here for more.

Vowels

- **a** = open *ah*; **o** = *oh*; **u** = *oo* (*gut* = *goot*).
- Umlauts shift the vowel forward: **ä** ≈ *eh*, **ü** = the front-rounded *ee* (= French *u*).

Consonants that differ

- **ch** after *a/o/u* = a guttural *loch* sound (*Nacht* = *nahkht*); softer after *e/i*.
- **z** = *ts*; **s** before a vowel = *z*; **ß** = a sharp *ss*.
- **h** at word-start *is* pronounced (unlike Spanish/French).
- **w** = English *v*; **v** = English *f*; **j** = English *y*.
- **Final devoicing**: written *-d/-g/-b* are said *-t/-k/-p* (*Abend* = *AH-bent*, *Tag* = *tahk*).

Two habits

- **Every noun is Capitalized** — *Tag*, *Nacht* — not just names.
- **Final devoicing** (above).

The High German Consonant Shift

A decoding tool rather than a rule for *saying* words: German pushed certain consonants forward, so English and German cousins differ predictably.

English	→ German	example
d	t	good → gut, day → Tag
t	s / ss / z	water → Wasser, that → das
p	pf / f	apple → Apfel, ship → Schiff
k	ch	make → machen, book → Buch

(A *different* shift from Grimm's Law, the older PIE→Germanic change shared by both English and German — see the *Nacht* lesson.)

Glossary

This glossary collects every word and phrase taught in the book. Pronunciation appears when it differs from the written form; chapter numbers show where each entry is introduced.

Abend

evening (der Abend — masculine)

Introduced in Chapter 1.

acht

eight — the rasp you already own, on a number you already know

Introduced in Chapter 8.

alt

old — the adjective the German age sentence is built on

Introduced in Chapter 25.

auf

on, upon — the small word the formal goodbye is built on

Introduced in Chapter 4.

auf Wiedersehen

goodbye, formally — literally “on the seeing-again”

Introduced in Chapter 4.

bald

soon — and the same word as English bold

Introduced in Chapter 4.

bis

until, up to — the preposition every soft German goodbye is built from

Introduced in Chapter 4.

bis bald

see you soon — the first of the bis... family

Introduced in Chapter 4.

bis morgen

see you tomorrow — and the bis... family, complete

Introduced in Chapter 4.

bis später

see you later — the vaguest of the bis... family

Introduced in Chapter 4.

bitte

please — and also “you’re welcome,” “here you go,” and “pardon?”
Introduced in Chapter 3.

bitte

please — place the familiar courtesy word after a small request
Introduced in Chapter 30.

bleiben

to stay — a verb that takes *sein* while meaning the exact opposite of change
Introduced in Chapter 27.

danke

thank you — which is really “I think of you”
Introduced in Chapter 3.

das Auge

eye — the third gender back on a body part, and a direct Germanic cousin of English eye
Introduced in Chapter 41.

das Brot

bread — inherited Germanic, the twin of English bread
Introduced in Chapter 17.

das Herz

heart — the last name from the *Hand* table, closing it with the same k-to-h Grimm’s law swap already heard on *hören* and *Hund*
Introduced in Chapter 42.

das Jahr

the year — the span the twelve months add up to, and a word German never borrowed
Introduced in Chapter 15.

das Ohr

ear — another direct Germanic cousin of its English translation, and the sense *hören* already named
Introduced in Chapter 41.

das Wasser, der Wein

water and wine — one native Germanic, one ancient Latin loan
Introduced in Chapter 17.

das Wetter, es regnet

weather — a NATIVE Germanic word, unlike Romance’s shared Latin *tempus* family; *Wetter* is the SAME word as English “weather,” and *regnet* is the SAME word as English “rain”
Introduced in Chapter 32.

denken

to think — the verb you already met hiding inside *danke*, and the same inherited word as English *think*
Introduced in Chapter 35.

der / die / das

the (masculine / feminine / neuter)

Introduced in Chapter 1.

der April

April — the one month whose Roman name nobody can be sure about

Introduced in Chapter 13.

der Arm

arm — named on the *Hand* table and now finally taught, a word Grimm's law never had to touch

Introduced in Chapter 42.

der August

August — the second and last month named for a man, and the last name the calendar ever gave

Introduced in Chapter 14.

der Bruder, die Schwester

brother and sister — again Germanic twins of the English words

Introduced in Chapter 16.

der Dezember

December — decem, ten, the last month and the last of the four numbered ones

Introduced in Chapter 14.

der Donner

thunder — the noun, and the god's name hiding inside it

Introduced in Chapter 10.

der Februar

February — the one month named for a ritual rather than a person or a god

Introduced in Chapter 13.

der Finger

finger — identical to its English cousin, and possibly, though not certainly, built on the word for "five"

Introduced in Chapter 42.

der Freund

friend — a Germanic cousin of English friend, both frozen out of the same old verb meaning "to love"

Introduced in Chapter 40.

der Frühling

spring — früh plus -ling, "the early one", a season German named rather than borrowed

Introduced in Chapter 15.

der Fuß

foot — the fourth name from the *Hand* table, and the same p-to-f Grimm's law pattern Vater already taught

Introduced in Chapter 42.

der Herbst

autumn — and the word is one English still has, doing a different job
Introduced in Chapter 15.

der Januar

January — Janus, the god of doorways, which is what a first month is
Introduced in Chapter 13.

der Juli

July — the first month in the year named after a man, and he named it himself
Introduced in Chapter 14.

der Juni

June — Juno, queen of the gods, and a j that sounds like Januar's
Introduced in Chapter 13.

der Kaffee

coffee — a loanword that crossed from Arabic to German by way of Turkish and Italian, and the first word in a new polite request
Introduced in Chapter 39.

der Kopf

the head — masculine, capitalised, with final pf
Introduced in Chapter 28.

der Lenz

spring, the old poetic word — worth recognising, not worth saying
Introduced in Chapter 15.

der Mai

May — Maia, a goddess of growth, and the shortest month name German has
Introduced in Chapter 13.

der März

March — Mars's month, and once the first month of the whole Roman year
Introduced in Chapter 13.

der Mittag

noon — Mitte plus Tag, a compound you can read before you are told it
Introduced in Chapter 12.

der Monat

the month — and the word itself is the moon, before Rome supplied the names to put in it
Introduced in Chapter 13.

der Mond

the moon — the noun the first weekday is built on, and English's own word untouched
Introduced in Chapter 10.

der Mund

mouth — the same inherited word as English mouth, with a root the standard accounts do not agree on past Proto-Germanic
Introduced in Chapter 41.

der November

November — novem, nine, and a word German and English spell identically
Introduced in Chapter 14.

der Oktober

October — octo, eight, and German spells the Latin c as a k because German spells that sound with a k
Introduced in Chapter 14.

der Sabbat

the Sabbath — the only word in the week that is neither Germanic nor Latin
Introduced in Chapter 11.

der September

September — the seventh month, which is now the ninth, and the name never caught up
Introduced in Chapter 14.

der Sommer

summer — the season whose German and English names are the same word, barely disguised
Introduced in Chapter 15.

der Tee

tea — a word that looks like its English cousin and is not said like it, and travelled to Europe by sea rather than overland
Introduced in Chapter 39.

der Vater, die Mutter

father and mother — Grimm's law makes them twins of English father/mother
Introduced in Chapter 16.

der Winter

winter — spelled exactly as in English, and the fourth of the four
Introduced in Chapter 15.

Deutsch

German, the language — and it means “of the people”
Introduced in Chapter 5.

die (plural)

the — the one plural article German uses for every gender
Introduced in Chapter 1.

die Familie

family — the whole group the Eltern and Geschwister already named the members of, and this chapter's one Latin loan beside two native words
Introduced in Chapter 40.

die Freundin

friend (female) — built on Freund with the native feminine suffix -in, the same suffix English kept in exactly one fossil word, vixen
Introduced in Chapter 40.

die Hand

the hand — the same word as English, and unrelated to Romance manus
Introduced in Chapter 28.

die Jahre

the plural of das Jahr, which is the form the age sentence needs and the only form it uses
Introduced in Chapter 25.

die Jahreszeit

season — literally year-time, a compound you can now read without being told
Introduced in Chapter 15.

die Milch

milk — the native Germanic word that closes this trio, standing beside two loanwords the way Wasser once stood beside the loanword Wein
Introduced in Chapter 39.

die Mitte

the middle — the native piece both of the day's pivots are built from
Introduced in Chapter 12.

die Mitternacht

midnight — the second pivot, and the -cht/-ght pair paying off again
Introduced in Chapter 12.

die Nase

nose — the fourth face-part, cousin of English nose and of Latin nasus, and the payoff that completes the face *Kopf* only started
Introduced in Chapter 41.

die Sonne

the sun — the noun behind Sunday, and a die-word where English has no gender at all
Introduced in Chapter 11.

die Stunde

an hour's span — the native word that survived beside the borrowed one, with the jobs divided
Introduced in Chapter 12.

die Uhr

the clock, and o'clock — the first everyday German word in this book that Rome supplied
Introduced in Chapter 12.

die Zeit

time — a Germanic word with no Latin in it at all, and the second half of the word for season
Introduced in Chapter 15.

Dienstag

Tuesday — named for a war-god both languages kept, under two different names
Introduced in Chapter 10.

dir

to you — the informal partner of mir
Introduced in Chapter 3.

Donnerstag

Thursday — the thunder-god's day, and the same god-slot under three names
Introduced in Chapter 10.

drei

three — the same word, with th worn down to d
Introduced in Chapter 6.

dreizehn — zwanzig

13–20 — perfectly regular digit+zehn compounds, step for step with English
Introduced in Chapter 18.

du / Sie

you (familiar / formal)
Introduced in Chapter 2.

du bist

you are — bin plus the -st ending you already know, and the one place sein behaves
Introduced in Chapter 24.

du hast

you have — the first form where the b falls out and the rule stops working
Introduced in Chapter 20.

du hast gesagt

you said — the second slot, where haben drops its b exactly as English have does
Introduced in Chapter 22.

du warst

you were — the familiar -st ending again, now on the past stem
Introduced in Chapter 26.

einen

a, an — the form the word takes for a masculine thing you have, and the first sighting of a system taught later
Introduced in Chapter 20.

eins

one — and the ei that is always the English word “eye”
Introduced in Chapter 6.

elf, zwölf

11 and 12 — literally “one left over” and “two left over,” the exact twins of eleven and twelve
Introduced in Chapter 18.

Entschuldigung

sorry / excuse me (literally “un-guiling,” from Schuld “guilt/fault”)
Introduced in Chapter 31.

er hat

he has — the second and last form where the b falls out
Introduced in Chapter 20.

er hat das gemacht

he did that — the third slot, and the first Perfekt sentence with something in the middle
Introduced in Chapter 22.

er ist

he is — the form that also serves sie, es and das, and the one that matches Latin est
Introduced in Chapter 24.

er war

he was — the same word as ich war, because the German simple past gives its third person no ending
Introduced in Chapter 26.

er · sie · es

he, she, it — the three third-person pronouns, and the -t they share
Introduced in Chapter 5.

es

it — the placeholder German puts in front of a state
Introduced in Chapter 3.

es geht

“it goes” — the German shrug, and what saying nothing extra means
Introduced in Chapter 3.

Es ist zwei Uhr

telling the time — es ist, a number you own, and Uhr
Introduced in Chapter 12.

fahren

to travel, to drive — motion with a vehicle under it, and English fare hiding inside
Introduced in Chapter 27.

fragen

to ask — a weak verb whose vowel stays put, and whose closest English relatives came in from Latin as pray and precarious
Introduced in Chapter 36.

Freitag

Friday — the one day named for a goddess, and the Roman she replaced
Introduced in Chapter 10.

freut mich

pleased to meet you (literally “it gladdens me”)
Introduced in Chapter 2.

früh

early — the word the first season is built out of, and a cousin of English early
Introduced in Chapter 15.

fünf

five — and the p-to-f law caught in one word
Introduced in Chapter 7.

gehen

to go — and the verb German uses for “how are you?”
Introduced in Chapter 3.

gehen

to go, and to walk — because German has no separate word for walking, and English’s walk turns out to be a word about cloth
Introduced in Chapter 38.

gelernt

learned — the wrap on lernen, and the sentence you can finally say about yourself
Introduced in Chapter 21.

gemacht

made, done — the wrap applied to machen, and the one spelling surprise in it
Introduced in Chapter 21.

gesagt

said — the first past participle, and the first time a German ending arrives with a beginning attached
Introduced in Chapter 21.

gestern

yesterday — the word that fills the middle of a Perfekt sentence, and morgen’s opposite number
Introduced in Chapter 22.

gewohnt

lived, dwelt — the wrap on wohnen, and the English fossil that still means “accustomed”
Introduced in Chapter 21.

grün, gelb

green and yellow — grün is native Germanic, the direct cousin of English’s OWN “green” (a different root entirely from Latin’s viridis); gelb is native too, and is usually said to share its ultimate PIE root with French’s jaune, though that particular link is less secure than it first appears
Introduced in Chapter 34.

gut

good; well
Introduced in Chapter 1.

Gute Nacht

good night
Introduced in Chapter 1.

Guten Abend

good evening
Introduced in Chapter 1.

Guten Morgen

good morning

Introduced in Chapter 1.

Guten Tag

hello / good day (polite)

Introduced in Chapter 1.

haben

to have — the twin of English have, and the workhorse the rest of the book leans on

Introduced in Chapter 20.

hallo

hello (informal)

Introduced in Chapter 1.

heißen

to be called / to be named

Introduced in Chapter 2.

helfen

to help — the same word as English help, separated by one sound law, and still strong in German the way English's help once was

Introduced in Chapter 36.

hören

to hear — the same verb as English hear, and the closing of a chapter of four things you do without going anywhere

Introduced in Chapter 37.

Hund, Katze

dog and cat — Hund is native Germanic, cognate with English's OWN discarded word "hound"; Katze, surprisingly, is NOT native — it's the same borrowed Latin word behind French chat and Spanish gato (though not every European language shares it)

Introduced in Chapter 33.

ich

I

Introduced in Chapter 2.

ich bin

I am — the first form of sein, and it comes from a different verb than the infinitive does

Introduced in Chapter 24.

ich bin zwanzig Jahre alt

I am twenty years old — the answer, word for word the English sentence

Introduced in Chapter 25.

ich habe gesagt

I said — the first filled slot of the Perfekt, and a sentence you can use whole

Introduced in Chapter 22.

ich hatte

I had — haben's own Präteritum, and one of the handful that everybody says out loud

Introduced in Chapter 23.

ich heiße / du heißt / Sie heißen

one verb, three endings — the ending machine every German verb runs

Introduced in Chapter 2.

ich heiße...

my name is... (literally "I am called...")

Introduced in Chapter 2.

ich konnte

I could — a Präteritum that survives in ordinary speech everywhere, north and south alike

Introduced in Chapter 23.

Ich lerne Deutsch

your first sentence built from parts, not handed to you whole

Introduced in Chapter 5.

ich machte

I made, I did — the second verb through the -te ending

Introduced in Chapter 23.

ich sagte

I said, in one word — the Präteritum of sagen, beside the Perfekt that means exactly the same

Introduced in Chapter 23.

ich war

I was — the past of sein, and a third stem that shares nothing with the other two

Introduced in Chapter 26.

Ihnen

to you, formally — the capitalised to-whom that goes with Sie

Introduced in Chapter 3.

ihr

you all — the plural you English gave up

Introduced in Chapter 5.

ihr seid

you are, to more than one person — the form English lost when it dropped its plural you

Introduced in Chapter 24.

in

in — the same word as English in, and it needs no learning at all

Introduced in Chapter 5.

ja

yes

Introduced in Chapter 29.

kommen

to come — English come with one consonant shifted, and the second verb of the sein family

Introduced in Chapter 27.

laufen

to run — and to walk, because German draws the line in a different place from English, with rennen at the fast end

Introduced in Chapter 38.

lernen

to learn — and its noun is English lore

Introduced in Chapter 5.

lesen

to read — a verb that first meant “to gather”, and the first one in this book whose vowel changes in the du and er forms

Introduced in Chapter 35.

machen

to make, to do — and it is just English make

Introduced in Chapter 5.

mich

me — the object form of ich

Introduced in Chapter 2.

mir

to me, for me — the form German uses for the person a thing happens to

Introduced in Chapter 3.

Mittwoch

Wednesday — the first day that breaks the pattern, because the Church would not name one for Wodan

Introduced in Chapter 10.

mögen, lieben

to like and to love — plus gern, the adverb that lets any verb say “I like doing this” and has no English shape at all

Introduced in Chapter 36.

Montag

Monday — the pattern’s first instance, and the one weekday English and German name identically

Introduced in Chapter 10.

Morgen

morning (der Morgen — masculine)

Introduced in Chapter 1.

morgen

tomorrow — the second job of the Morgen you already know

Introduced in Chapter 4.

müde

tired — the first adjective that says something about a person, and it needs no ending here

Introduced in Chapter 24.

Nacht

night (die Nacht — feminine)

Introduced in Chapter 1.

nehmen

to take — the verb English lost, though it left numb and nimble behind as fossils

Introduced in Chapter 36.

nein

no

Introduced in Chapter 29.

neun

nine — the oy vowel from Deutsch, twice in one word

Introduced in Chapter 9.

nicht

not — German's plain negator

Introduced in Chapter 3.

öffnen

to open — built on *offen*, which is English *open*, which is really the word *up*; and the doorway into German's separable verbs

Introduced in Chapter 38.

rot, blau

red and blue — an ancient shared root, and a second word German lent to its neighbours

Introduced in Chapter 19.

sagen

to say — the verb this chapter builds its past tense on

Introduced in Chapter 21.

Samstag

Saturday — the second day that breaks the pattern, and the only one German bought rather than inherited

Introduced in Chapter 11.

schlafen

to sleep — the same word as English *sleep* under two coats of German paint, and a second way for a strong verb to break

Introduced in Chapter 37.

schließen

to close — the second verb in these chapters that German kept and English lost, and the one that locked up *Schloss*, *Schlüssel* and *Schluss*

Introduced in Chapter 38.

schön

beautiful, nice — and the word that upgrades a thank-you
Introduced in Chapter 3.

schreiben

to write — the one verb in this chapter German did not inherit but borrowed,
from Latin scribere
Introduced in Chapter 35.

schwarz, weiß

black and white — both native Germanic, and one of them German lent to half of
Europe
Introduced in Chapter 19.

sechs

six — where chs is simply an x
Introduced in Chapter 8.

sehen

to see — a straight cognate of English see
Introduced in Chapter 4.

sehr

very — the intensifier that turns gut into a real answer
Introduced in Chapter 3.

sein

to be — the partner of haben, and the most irregular verb German has
Introduced in Chapter 24.

sie sind / Sie sind

they are, and the polite you are — one form, and the capital letter is the only
difference
Introduced in Chapter 24.

sieben

seven — and the s that buzzes at the front of a word
Introduced in Chapter 8.

sitzen

to sit — the same inherited word as English sit, respelt by the other branch of the
shift that separated helfen from help
Introduced in Chapter 37.

so lala

so-so — the sing-song middle of the answer ladder
Introduced in Chapter 3.

Sonnabend

Saturday in the north — Sun-eve, built from two words you already own
Introduced in Chapter 11.

Sonntag

Sunday — the one day the Church left alone, where Romance renamed it entirely
Introduced in Chapter 11.

spät

late — and später, “later,” your first comparative
Introduced in Chapter 4.

stehen

to stand — the verb hiding inside verstehen, and the one place German keeps a
letter English put in the wrong tense
Introduced in Chapter 37.

Tag

day (der Tag — masculine)
Introduced in Chapter 1.

tschüss

bye, casually — and secretly the same blessing as adiós
Introduced in Chapter 4.

und

and — and the two-word move that returns a question
Introduced in Chapter 3.

verstehen

to understand — literally “to stand around a thing”, the same picture English
built independently in understand
Introduced in Chapter 35.

vielen Dank

many thanks — the noun behind danke, and the warmest everyday thank-you
Introduced in Chapter 3.

vier

four — spelt with a v, said with an f
Introduced in Chapter 7.

was

what — the fourth w-question, and the one you will use most
Introduced in Chapter 5.

werden

to become — the change-of-state half of the rule, in one word
Introduced in Chapter 27.

wie

how
Introduced in Chapter 2.

Wie alt bist du?

how old are you — word for word the English question, built from four words you
own
Introduced in Chapter 25.

Wie geht es dir?

how are you? — informal, and every piece already yours
Introduced in Chapter 3.

wie heißen Sie?

what's your name? (literally "how are you called?")

Introduced in Chapter 2.

wieder

again — the "back" hiding inside withdraw

Introduced in Chapter 4.

wir

we — and the ending that is the dictionary form again

Introduced in Chapter 5.

wir haben gesagt

we said — the fourth slot, where the helper is the infinitive itself

Introduced in Chapter 22.

wir sind

we are — the plural form, and the first one that looks like the infinitive

Introduced in Chapter 24.

wir waren

we were — the plural past, and the last form of sein you need

Introduced in Chapter 26.

wo

where — the third of German's w-questions

Introduced in Chapter 5.

wohnen

to live, to dwell — your first regular German verb

Introduced in Chapter 5.

zehn

ten — one consonant photographed three times

Introduced in Chapter 9.

zwei

two — English two with its t turned into the ts of z

Introduced in Chapter 6.

Review Questions

Try these without looking ahead. Every prompt comes from the same canonical lesson data as its chapter. Answers begin in the next section.

Chapter 28

28.1 *Kopf / Haupt — two head-words*

Which inherited German head-word survives in compounds such as Hauptstadt?

Answer Key

The first response is the canonical display answer. When a question accepts other authored forms, they appear underneath.

Chapter 28

28.1 *Kopf / Haupt — two head-words*

Answer: Haupt

Index

Look up an English meaning, a dedicated language topic, or a chapter topic. Each linked reference opens the chapter where the material is introduced; the focus labels name only explicitly typed lesson sections.

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11 and 12 — literally “one left over” and “two left over,” the exact twins of eleven and twelve *elf, zwölf*

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13–20 — perfectly regular digit+zehn compounds, step for step with English *dreizehn — zwanzig*

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A

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Chapter 20, p. 199

ä ö ü — the two dots that used to be an e

script and writing topic; explicit focus: writing, grammar, etymology; Chapter 4, p. 53

again — the “back” hiding inside withdraw *wieder*

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an hour’s span — the native word that survived beside the borrowed one, with the jobs divided *die Stunde*

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and — and the two-word move that returns a question *und*

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April — the one month whose Roman name nobody can be sure about *der April*

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Arm, Finger, Foot, Heart

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Grimm's law never had to touch *der Arm*

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 last name the calendar ever gave *der August*

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 job *der Herbst*

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 of Turkish and Italian, and the first word in a new polite

request *der Kaffee*

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Coffee, Tea, and Milk

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D

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December — decem, ten, the last month and the last of the four numbered ones *der Dezember*

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finger — identical to its English cousin, and possibly, though not certainly, built on the word for "five" *der Finger*

explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 42, p. 365

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foot — the fourth name from the *Hand* table, and the same p-to-f Grimm's law pattern Vater already taught *der Fuß*

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good night *Gute Nacht*

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he has — the second and last form where the b falls out *er hat*

Chapter 20, p. 199

he is — the form that also serves sie, es and das, and the one that matches Latin est *er ist*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 24, p. 245

he, she, it — the three third-person pronouns, and the -t they share *er · sie · es*

explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 5, p. 75

he was — the same word as ich war, because the German simple past gives its third person no ending *er war*

explicit focus: pronunciation; Chapter 26, p. 265

Head and Hand

chapter topic; Chapter 28, p. 289

heart — the last name from the *Hand* table, closing it with the same k-to-h Grimm's law swap already heard on hören and**Hund** *das Herz*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 42, p. 365

hello / good day (polite) *Guten Tag*

explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 1, p. 1

hello (informal) *hallo*

explicit focus: pronunciation, writing, etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 1, p. 1

Herbst and harvest

etymology topic; explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 15, p. 169

Homegrown numbers, imported months

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, usage and culture; Chapter 9, p. 109

how *wie*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 2, p. 19

How Are You?

chapter topic; Chapter 3, p. 31

how are you? — informal, and every piece already yours *Wie geht es dir?*

Chapter 3, p. 31

how old are you — word for word the English question, built from four words you own *Wie alt bist du?*

Chapter 25, p. 257

I

I *ich*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 2, p. 19

I am — the first form of sein, and it comes from a different verb than the infinitive does *ich bin*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 24, p. 245

I am twenty years old — the answer, word for word the English sentence *ich bin zwanzig Jahre alt*

Chapter 25, p. 257

I Am, You Are

chapter topic; Chapter 24, p. 245

I could — a Präteritum that survives in ordinary speech everywhere, north and south alike *ich konnte*

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 23, p. 231

I had — haben's own Präteritum, and one of the handful that everybody says out loud *ich hatte*

explicit focus: pronunciation; Chapter 23, p. 231

I made, I did — the second verb through the -te ending *ich machte*

Chapter 23, p. 231

I said, in one word — the Präteritum of sagen, beside the Perfekt that means exactly the same *ich sagte*

explicit focus: pronunciation; Chapter 23, p. 231

I said — the first filled slot of the Perfekt, and a sentence you can use whole *ich habe gesagt*

explicit focus: pronunciation; Chapter 22, p. 219

I was — the past of sein, and a third stem that shares nothing with the other two *ich war*

explicit focus: pronunciation; Chapter 26, p. 265

ich bin gegangen — the perfect built on sein

grammar topic; explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar; Chapter 27, p. 275

ich bin gewesen — and the rest of the learned list

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 27, p. 275

in — the same word as English in, and it needs no learning at all *in*

Chapter 5, p. 75

Introducing Yourself

chapter topic; Chapter 2, p. 19

“it goes” — the German shrug, and what saying nothing extra means *es geht*

explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 3, p. 31

It means “I said,” not only “I have said”

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 22, p. 219

it — the placeholder German puts in front of a state *es*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 3, p. 31

J

Jahr and alt, taken apart

etymology topic; explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 25, p. 257

January — Janus, the god of doorways, which is what a first month is *der Januar*

explicit focus: pronunciation; Chapter 13, p. 147

July — the first month in the year named after a man, and he named it himself *der Juli*

explicit focus: pronunciation; Chapter 14, p. 159

June — Juno, queen of the gods, and a j that sounds like Januar's *der Juni*

explicit focus: pronunciation; Chapter 13, p. 147

K

Kopf / Haupt — two head-words

etymology topic; explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 28, p. 289

L

late — and später, “later,” your first comparative *spät*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 4, p. 53

learned — the wrap on lernen, and the sentence you can finally say about yourself *gelernt*

explicit focus: pronunciation; Chapter 21, p. 209

lived, dwelt — the wrap on wohnen, and the English fossil that still means “accustomed” *gewohnt*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 21, p. 209

M

made, done — the wrap applied to machen, and the one spelling surprise in it *gemacht*

explicit focus: pronunciation; Chapter 21, p. 209

many thanks — the noun behind danke, and the warmest

everyday thank-you *vielen Dank*

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 3, p. 31

March — Mars’s month, and once the first month of the whole Roman year *der März*

explicit focus: pronunciation; Chapter 13, p. 147

März and Dienstag

etymology topic; explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 13, p. 147

May — Maia, a goddess of growth, and the shortest month name German has *der Mai*

explicit focus: pronunciation; Chapter 13, p. 147

me — the object form of ich *mich*

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 2, p. 19

midnight — the second pivot, and the -cht/-ght pair paying off again *die Mitternacht*

explicit focus: pronunciation; Chapter 12, p. 135

milk — the native Germanic word that closes this trio, standing beside two loanwords the way Wasser once stood beside the loanword Wein *die Milch*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 39, p. 347

Mittag and midi

etymology topic; explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 12, p. 135

Monday — the pattern’s first instance, and the one weekday

English and German name identically *Montag*

Chapter 10, p. 117

morning (der Morgen — masculine) *Morgen*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 1, p. 1

mouth — the same inherited word as English mouth, with a root the standard accounts do not agree on past Proto-Germanic *der Mund*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 41, p. 359

my name is... (literally “I am called...”) *ich heiße...*

explicit focus: usage and culture; Chapter 2, p. 19

N

night (die Nacht — feminine) *Nacht*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 1, p. 1

Nine, Ten, and the Months That Are Numbers

chapter topic; Chapter 9, p. 109

nine — the oy vowel from Deutsch, twice in one word *neun*

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 9, p. 109

no *nein*

explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 29, p. 295

noon — **Mitte plus Tag**, a compound you can read before you are told it *der Mittag*

Chapter 12, p. 135

nose — **the fourth face-part**, cousin of English nose and of Latin **nasus**, and the payoff that completes the face *Kopf* only

started *die Nase*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 41, p. 359

not — **German's plain negator** *nicht*

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 3, p. 31

November — **novem, nine**, and a word German and English spell identically *der November*

explicit focus: pronunciation; Chapter 14, p. 159

Numbers Eleven to Twenty

chapter topic; Chapter 18, p. 191

O

October — **octo, eight**, and German spells the Latin **c** as a **k** because German spells that sound with a **k** *der Oktober*

explicit focus: pronunciation; Chapter 14, p. 159

old — **the adjective the German age sentence is built on** *alt*

explicit focus: pronunciation; Chapter 25, p. 257

on, upon — **the small word the formal goodbye is built on** *auf*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 4, p. 53

one — **and the ei that is always the English word “eye”** *eins*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 6, p. 93

One, Two, Three

chapter topic; Chapter 6, p. 93

one verb, three endings — **the ending machine every German**

verb runs *ich heiße / du heißt / Sie heißen*

explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 2, p. 19

P

Please

chapter topic; Chapter 30, p. 299

please — **and also “you’re welcome,” “here you go,” and “pardon?”** *bitte*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 3, p. 31

please — **place the familiar courtesy word after a small**

request *bitte*

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 30, p. 299

pleased to meet you (literally “it gladdens me”) *freut mich*
 explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 2, p. 19

R

red and blue — an ancient shared root, and a second word
German lent to its neighbours *rot, blau*
 Chapter 19, p. 195

S

said — the first past participle, and the first time a German
ending arrives with a beginning attached *gesagt*
 explicit focus: pronunciation; Chapter 21, p. 209

Saturday in the north — Sun-eve, built from two words you
already own *Sonnabend*
 explicit focus: usage and culture; Chapter 11, p. 127

Saturday — the second day that breaks the pattern, and the
only one German bought rather than inherited *Samstag*
 explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 11, p. 127

season — literally year-time, a compound you can now read
without being told *die Jahreszeit*
 explicit focus: usage and culture; Chapter 15, p. 169

see you later — the vaguest of the bis... family *bis später*
 Chapter 4, p. 53

see you soon — the first of the bis... family *bis bald*
 Chapter 4, p. 53

see you tomorrow — and the bis... family, complete *bis morgen*
 explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 4, p. 53

sein, not haben
 grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, usage and culture; Chapter 25, p. 257

September — the seventh month, which is now the ninth, and
the name never caught up *der September*
 explicit focus: pronunciation; Chapter 14, p. 159

seven — and the s that buzzes at the front of a word *sieben*
 explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 8, p. 105

Siblings, not borrowings
 grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, usage and culture; Chapter 6, p. 93

Sitting, Standing, Sleeping, Hearing
 chapter topic; Chapter 37, p. 327

Six, Seven, Eight
 chapter topic; Chapter 8, p. 105

six — where chs is simply an x *sechs*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 8, p. 105

so-so — the sing-song middle of the answer ladder *so lala*

explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 3, p. 31

soon — and the same word as English bold *bald*

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 4, p. 53

Sorry

chapter topic; Chapter 31, p. 301

sorry / excuse me (literally “un-guiling,” from Schuld “guilt/fault”) *Entschuldigung*

explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 31, p. 301

spring — früh plus -ling, “the early one”, a season German named rather than borrowed *der Frühling*

explicit focus: pronunciation; Chapter 15, p. 169

spring, the old poetic word — worth recognising, not worth saying *der Lenz*

explicit focus: pronunciation; Chapter 15, p. 169

summer — the season whose German and English names are the same word, barely disguised *der Sommer*

explicit focus: pronunciation; Chapter 15, p. 169

Sunday — the one day the Church left alone, where Romance renamed it entirely *Sonntag*

explicit focus: usage and culture; Chapter 11, p. 127

Suppletion — filling a verb in from another verb

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 26, p. 265

T

Taking, Asking, Helping, Liking

chapter topic; Chapter 36, p. 317

-te — the one-word past

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 23, p. 231

tea — a word that looks like its English cousin and is not said like it, and travelled to Europe by sea rather than overland *der Tee*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 39, p. 347

Telling the Time

chapter topic; Chapter 12, p. 135

telling the time — es ist, a number you own, and Uhr *Es ist zwei Uhr*

explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 12, p. 135

ten — one consonant photographed three times *zehn*

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 9, p. 109

thank you — which is really “I think of you” *danke*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 3, p. 31

The b that fell out

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 20, p. 199

the clock, and o’clock — the first everyday German word in this

book that Rome supplied *die Uhr*

explicit focus: pronunciation; Chapter 12, p. 135

The dental preterite — a Germanic invention

etymology topic; explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 23, p. 231

The endings you can actually hear

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 5, p. 75

The First Verbs

chapter topic; Chapter 5, p. 75

The forms that stayed spoken

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 23, p. 231

The ge- that English lost

etymology topic; explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 21, p. 209

The German Weekend

chapter topic; Chapter 11, p. 127

The Gods of the Week

chapter topic; Chapter 10, p. 117

the hand — the same word as English, and unrelated to

Romance manus *die Hand*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 28, p. 289

the head — masculine, capitalised, with final pf *der Kopf*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 28, p. 289

the (masculine / feminine / neuter) *der / die / das*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 1, p. 1

the middle — the native piece both of the day’s pivots are built

from *die Mitte*

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 12, p. 135

the month — and the word itself is the moon, before Rome

supplied the names to put in it *der Monat*

explicit focus: usage and culture; Chapter 13, p. 147

the moon — the noun the first weekday is built on, and English’s

own word untouched *der Mond*

explicit focus: pronunciation; Chapter 10, p. 117

The participle waits at the back

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 22, p. 219

The Past Built From Have

chapter topic; Chapter 22, p. 219

The Past That Takes To Be

chapter topic; Chapter 27, p. 275

the plural of das Jahr, which is the form the age sentence needs and the only form it uses *die Jahre*

explicit focus: pronunciation; Chapter 25, p. 257

The Roman Calendar

chapter topic; Chapter 13, p. 147

the Sabbath — the only word in the week that is neither Germanic nor Latin *der Sabbat*

Chapter 11, p. 127

The same retreat, three times over

etymology topic; explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 23, p. 231

The Seasons Go Native

chapter topic; Chapter 15, p. 169

The Simple Past

chapter topic; Chapter 23, p. 231

the sun — the noun behind Sunday, and a die-word where English has no gender at all *die Sonne*

explicit focus: usage and culture; Chapter 11, p. 127

the — the one plural article German uses for every gender *die (plural)*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar; Chapter 1, p. 1

The Wrapped Participle

chapter topic; Chapter 21, p. 209

the year — the span the twelve months add up to, and a word German never borrowed *das Jahr*

explicit focus: pronunciation; Chapter 15, p. 169

they are, and the polite you are — one form, and the capital letter is the only difference *sie sind / Sie sind*

explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 24, p. 245

three — the same word, with th worn down to d *drei*

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 6, p. 93

Three Verbs Under One Roof

chapter topic; Chapter 26, p. 265

thunder — the noun, and the god's name hiding inside it *der Donner*

explicit focus: pronunciation; Chapter 10, p. 117

Thursday — the thunder-god's day, and the same god-slot under three names *Donnerstag*

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 10, p. 117

time — a Germanic word with no Latin in it at all, and the second half of the word for season *die Zeit*

explicit focus: pronunciation; Chapter 15, p. 169

tired — the first adjective that says something about a person, and it needs no ending here *müde*

explicit focus: pronunciation; Chapter 24, p. 245

to ask — a weak verb whose vowel stays put, and whose closest English relatives came in from Latin as pray and

precarious *fragen*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 36, p. 317

to be called / to be named *heißen*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 2, p. 19

to be — the partner of *haben*, and the most irregular verb

German has *sein*

explicit focus: pronunciation; Chapter 24, p. 245

to become — the change-of-state half of the rule, in one word *werden*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 27, p. 275

to close — the second verb in these chapters that German kept and English lost, and the one that locked up Schloss, Schlüssel and Schluss *schließen*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 38, p. 337

to come — English come with one consonant shifted, and the second verb of the *sein* family *kommen*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 27, p. 275

to go — and the verb German uses for “how are you?” *gehen*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 3, p. 31

to go, and to walk — because German has no separate word for walking, and English’s walk turns out to be a word about cloth *gehen*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 38, p. 337

To Have

chapter topic; Chapter 20, p. 199

to have — the twin of English have, and the workhorse the rest of the book leans on *haben*

explicit focus: pronunciation; Chapter 20, p. 199

to hear — the same verb as English hear, and the closing of a chapter of four things you do without going anywhere *hören*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 37, p. 327

to help — the same word as English help, separated by one sound law, and still strong in German the way English’s help once was *helfen*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 36, p. 317

to learn — and its noun is English lore *lernen*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 5, p. 75

to like and to love — plus *gern*, the adverb that lets any verb say “I like doing this” and has no English shape at all *mögen, lieben*

explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 36, p. 317

to live, to dwell — your first regular German verb *wohnen*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 5, p. 75

to make, to do — and it is just English make *machen*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 5, p. 75

to me, for me — the form German uses for the person a thing happens to *mir*

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 3, p. 31

to open — built on offen, which is English open, which is really the word up; and the doorway into German's separable verbs *öffnen*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 38, p. 337

to read — a verb that first meant “to gather”, and the first one in this book whose vowel changes in the du and er forms *lesen*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 35, p. 309

to run — and to walk, because German draws the line in a different place from English, with rennen at the fast end *laufen*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 38, p. 337

to say — the verb this chapter builds its past tense on *sagen*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 21, p. 209

to see — a straight cognate of English see *sehen*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 4, p. 53

to sit — the same inherited word as English sit, respelt by the other branch of the shift that separated helfen from help *sitzen*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 37, p. 327

to sleep — the same word as English sleep under two coats of German paint, and a second way for a strong verb to break *schlafen*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 37, p. 327

to stand — the verb hiding inside verstehen, and the one place German keeps a letter English put in the wrong tense *stehen*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 37, p. 327

to stay — a verb that takes sein while meaning the exact

opposite of change *bleiben*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 27, p. 275

to take — the verb English lost, though it left numb and nimble behind as fossils *nehmen*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 36, p. 317

to think — the verb you already met hiding inside danke, and the same inherited word as English think *denken*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 35, p. 309

to travel, to drive — motion with a vehicle under it, and English fare hiding inside *fahren*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 27, p. 275

to understand — literally “to stand around a thing”, the same picture English built independently in *understand* *verstehen*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 35, p. 309

to write — the one verb in this chapter German did not inherit but borrowed, from Latin *scribere* *schreiben*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 35, p. 309

to you, formally — the capitalised to-whom that goes with

Sie Ihnen

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 3, p. 31

to you — the informal partner of *mir* *dir*

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 3, p. 31

tomorrow — the second job of the Morgen you already

know *morgen*

explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 4, p. 53

Tuesday — named for a war-god both languages kept, under two different names *Dienstag*

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 10, p. 117

two — English two with its t turned into the ts of *z* *zwei*

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 6, p. 93

U

Uhr, taken apart

etymology topic; explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 12, p. 135

until, up to — the preposition every soft German goodbye is

built from *bis*

explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 4, p. 53

V

Verbs of the Mind

chapter topic; Chapter 35, p. 309

very — the intensifier that turns gut into a real answer *sehr*

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 3, p. 31

W

water and wine — one native Germanic, one ancient Latin

loan *das Wasser, der Wein*

Chapter 17, p. 187

we — and the ending that is the dictionary form again *wir*

explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 5, p. 75

we are — the plural form, and the first one that looks like the infinitive *wir sind*

explicit focus: pronunciation; Chapter 24, p. 245

we said — the fourth slot, where the helper is the infinitive itself *wir haben gesagt*

Chapter 22, p. 219

we were — the plural past, and the last form of sein you need *wir waren*

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 26, p. 265

Weather

chapter topic; Chapter 32, p. 303

weather — a NATIVE Germanic word, unlike Romance’s shared Latin tempus family; Wetter is the SAME word as English “weather,” and regnet is the SAME word as English “rain” *das Wetter, es regnet*

explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 32, p. 303

Wednesday — the first day that breaks the pattern, because the Church would not name one for Wodan *Mittwoch*

explicit focus: pronunciation, usage and culture; Chapter 10, p. 117

what’s your name? (literally “how are you called?”) *wie heißen Sie?*

explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 2, p. 19

what — the fourth w-question, and the one you will use most *was*
Chapter 5, p. 75

When the Calendar Stopped Naming

chapter topic; Chapter 14, p. 159

where — the third of German’s w-questions *wo*

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 5, p. 75

Which past, and where

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, usage and culture; Chapter 23, p. 231

Why German keeps the pronoun

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 5, p. 75

Why “to be” is the messiest word in every language

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, usage and culture; Chapter 26, p. 265

Wie geht es Ihnen? — the same question, at a distance

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 3, p. 31

winter — spelled exactly as in English, and the fourth of the four *der Winter*

explicit focus: pronunciation; Chapter 15, p. 169

Y

yes *ja*

explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 29, p. 295

Yes and No

chapter topic; Chapter 29, p. 295

yesterday — the word that fills the middle of a Perfekt sentence, and morgen’s opposite number *gestern*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 22, p. 219

you all — the plural you English gave up *ihr*

explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 5, p. 75

you are — bin plus the -st ending you already know, and the one place sein behaves *du bist*

explicit focus: pronunciation; Chapter 24, p. 245

you are, to more than one person — the form English lost when it dropped its plural you *ihr seid*

explicit focus: pronunciation; Chapter 24, p. 245

you (familiar / formal) *du / Sie*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 2, p. 19

you have — the first form where the b falls out and the rule stops working *du hast*

explicit focus: pronunciation; Chapter 20, p. 199

you said — the second slot, where haben drops its b exactly as English have does *du hast gesagt*

Chapter 22, p. 219

you were — the familiar -st ending again, now on the past stem *du warst*

explicit focus: pronunciation; Chapter 26, p. 265

your first sentence built from parts, not handed to you whole *Ich lerne Deutsch*

explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 5, p. 75

Z

zwei Uhr, not zwei Uhren

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 12, p. 135

Other

ß — the letter that is two s’s in a coat

script and writing topic; explicit focus: writing, grammar, usage and culture; Chapter 4, p. 53